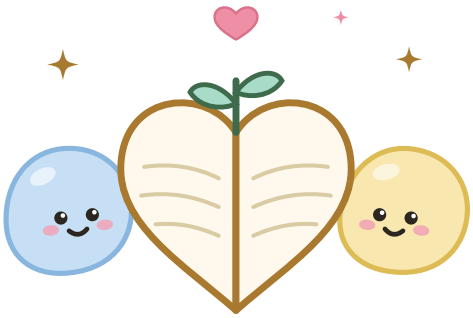
# Spread Love & Acceptance

UNDERSTANDING PEOPLE · SHORT VERSION

# Spread Love & Acceptance

*Understanding yourself and the people you share a life with*

UNDERSTANDING PEOPLE · SHORT VERSION



*by Christian*

Spread Love & Acceptance
spreadloveandacceptance.com

*Spread Love & Acceptance*: Understanding people, the short version.
By Christian. Published by Spread Love & Acceptance.

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**Not therapy.** This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counselor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

**The examples are made up.** The people in the scenes and examples are invented, built from common patterns. None of them is a real person or a testimonial.

Research mentioned in the chapters is listed, with links, in the research notes at the back and at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

# How to use this book

*This is a book about seeing what is really going on, in yourself and between people, without blaming anyone, and then changing one small thing. This copy holds 17 chapters in one part, in the short version. There is no wrong way in.*

### THE PARTS

> **Part Three: Understanding people.** How feelings, stress, trust, change, grief, groups and love work, for anyone, in any kind of relationship.

### TWO SIZES OF EVERY CHAPTER

Every chapter comes in a short version (about 10 to 15 minutes) and a full version with the research, more examples and more to try. This is the short version. The full version is free at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book.

### READ IN ORDER, OR BY NEED

Read it front to back like any book, or start with the chapter that fits what is going on. Each chapter ends with *What to remember*, *This connects to* (the chapters that explain it or put it to use, with page numbers) and *Put it to use*, with codes you can scan for the matching tool.

### IN EVERY CHAPTER

- A short scene: a made-up moment from everyday life.
- **Words you could use**: sentences to say out loud.
- **Try this**: one small thing to do this week.
- **Common mix-ups**: easy mistakes, and what is closer to true.

### THE SITE, THE PROGRAM AND PROFESSOR PUDDLES

The book has a free website with the workpapers (pages you fill in) and tools (helpers you use) that the chapters mention; the next page explains both. Nothing you type there leaves your device, and there is no account. The **six-week program** (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01) puts Part Two to work a week at a time, and the **self path** does the same for Part One. **Professor Puddles**, the site's friendly guide, answers questions about the book's ideas.

### GO GENTLY

Some chapters touch hard things: grief, shame, anger, worry, trauma. Skip anything that isn't right for today. Nothing here is a test, and nothing needs to be done all at once.

# Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-03 **Workpapers: pages you fill in**

A workpaper is a page you fill in, on your own or together: a one-week log, a list of who owns which job, a short check. Each one has a number, like **WP-03**, and it is always called a workpaper, for example “Workpaper WP-03: One owner per job”. The blank workpapers are also at the back of this book, one page each, to copy.

TOOL **Tools: helpers you use on the site**

A tool is an interactive helper on the website: a quiz, a calm-down timer, a card maker, or the Chat analyzer that reads a message with you. You use it and it gives you something back. It is always called a tool, for example “Tool: Chat analyzer”.

The book keeps the two apart: a workpaper and a tool never share a list. Both are free, need no account, and what you type stays on your device.

## Three friends who give hints



**Professor Puddles**, the site’s cheerful raindrop professor, gives most of the hints: a thought to take with you, and the workpaper or tool that fits.



**Tidbit**, the quick, curious pup with the big smile and the collar, bounds in now and then with a playful tip.



**Sugarfoot**, the steady, gentle pup with the long soft ears and the best hugs, turns up with a calm, slow tip.

They keep to the lighter pages. Where a chapter talks about crisis, deep grief or being hurt, the pages stay quiet and plain.

# Find it fast

*Start with what is going on, not with chapter one. Each line points to the place in the book that helps most, and one tool to try. You can read that part on its own and stop.*

### SHARING THE LOAD

| IF THIS IS GOING ON | READ | PAGE | TRY |
|---|---|---|---|
| **We each think we do more than our share.** | Part Three · Chapter 3 · Everyone feels like the one who sees clearly | 43 | WORKPAPER WP-01 Who did what |
| **We've just had a baby and we're both exhausted.** | Part Three · Chapter 2 · Rest isn't one thing | 28 | WORKPAPER WP-02 How much are you carrying? |
| **I'm caring for a parent or partner, and it's wearing me down.** | Part Three · Chapter 12 · Your limits make your help last | 175 | WORKPAPER WP-02 How much are you carrying? |

### TALKING IT THROUGH

| IF THIS IS GOING ON | READ | PAGE | TRY |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Small things turn into big fights.** | Part Three · Chapter 2 · When you're flooded | 28 | WORKPAPER WP-11 The Calm-Down Kit |
| **One of us goes quiet and the other pushes for an answer.** | Part Three · Chapter 5 · Feeling safe with someone | 74 | WORKPAPER WP-11 The Calm-Down Kit: our pause plan |
| **Texts and messages keep landing wrong.** | Part Three · Chapter 4 · Messages lose their tone | 57 | TOOL Chat analyzer |
| **We need to say sorry and mend things.** | Part Three · Chapter 11 · A real apology | 161 | WORKPAPER WP-09 Say it so it lands |
| **Conflict at work, with a colleague or in a team.** | Part Three · Chapter 4 · Saying hard things kindly | 68 | WORKPAPER WP-09 Say it so it lands |

### KNOWING YOURSELF

| IF THIS IS GOING ON | READ | PAGE | TRY |
|---|---|---|---|
| **I can't tell what I'm feeling.** | Part Three · Chapter 1 · Naming a feeling helps you hold it | 14 | TOOL My weather today |

| IF THIS IS GOING ON | READ | PAGE | TRY |
|---|---|---|---|
| **I'm wiped out and everything feels like too much.** | Part Three · Chapter 2 · Stress adds up, like a tank filling | 28 | WORKPAPER WP-02 How much are you carrying? |
| **ADHD: I'm overwhelmed and keep forgetting things.** | Part Three · Chapter 9 · ADHD, time and motivation | 129 | TOOL "How to talk to me" card |
| **I'm autistic, and people keep misreading me (or I misread them).** | Part Three · Chapter 9 · Autism and the double empathy problem | 129 | TOOL "How to talk to me" card |
| **My inner critic is loud.** | Part Three · Chapter 7 · The critic and the soothing system | 102 | WORKPAPER WP-11 The Calm-Down Kit |
| **I want to change a habit, but it keeps slipping.** | Part Three · Chapter 6 · Slips are part of change | 88 | The self path, step by step |

HARD SEASONS

| IF THIS IS GOING ON | READ | PAGE | TRY |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Someone I love has died.** | Part Three · Chapter 8 · Grief comes in waves | 124 | When you've lost someone |
| **I feel lonely, or I live on my own.** | Part Three · Chapter 5 · Building connection from where you are | 84 | Living on your own, living well |
| **A teenager's anger, or I'm a teenager and I'm angry.** | Part Three · Chapter 13 · The hot minutes | 198 | WORKPAPER WP-11 The Calm-Down Kit |
| **Left out of a group, a friend group or a group chat.** | Part Three · Chapter 17 · Groups online, and their pull | 253 | TOOL Chat analyzer |
| **Worry keeps me awake, or my mood is low.** | Part Three · Chapter 16 · Worry time; low mood | 235 | WORKPAPER WP-02 How much are you carrying? |

This copy holds only part of the book, so this map lists the problems it covers. The whole book's map has 15 more, and every chapter is free to read at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book. Each thing to try is marked as a workpaper (a page you fill in) or a tool (a helper you use on the site). All are free on the website, with nothing to sign up for; each chapter's end has a code you can scan for them. Looking for a word rather than a problem? The index at the back lists the main ideas.

# The book in two pictures

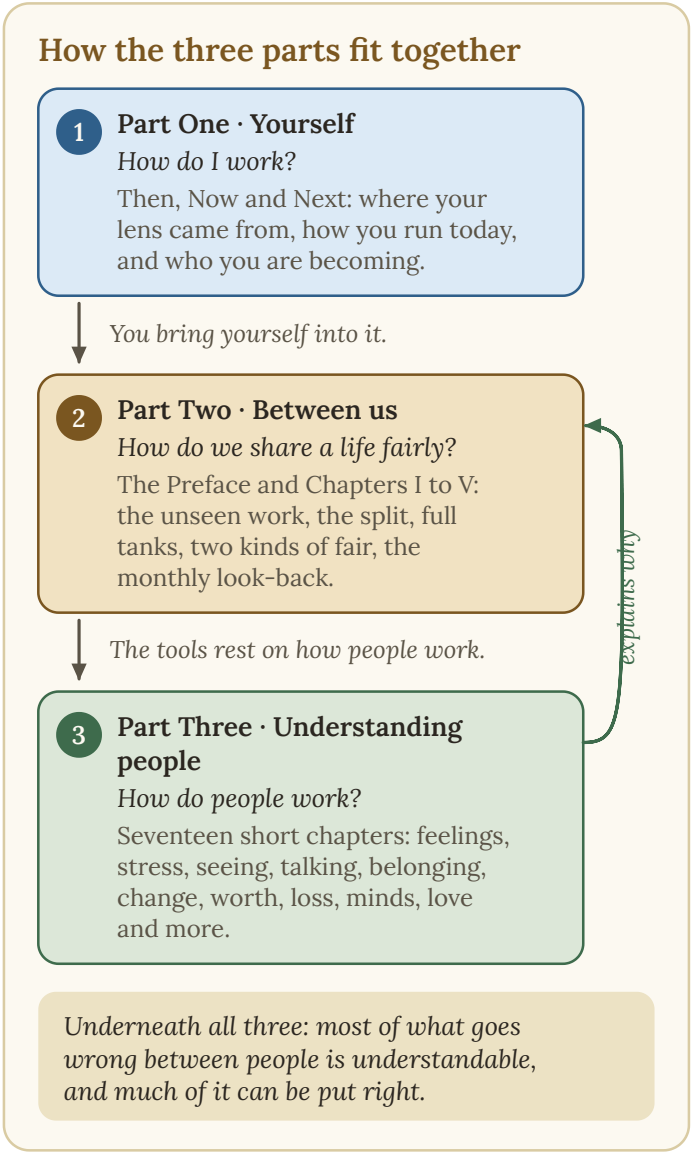



FIGURE 1 How the three parts fit together: you bring yourself into every shared life, and Part Three explains why the Part Two tools work.

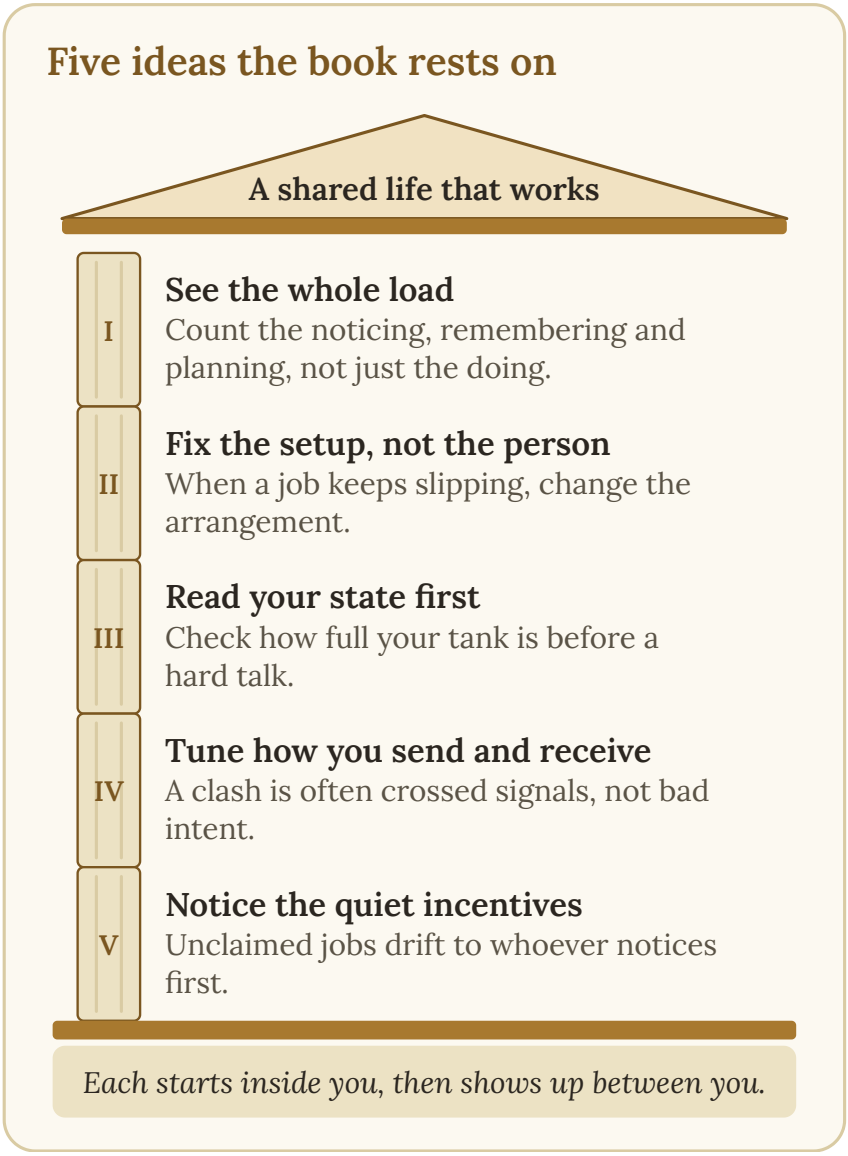



FIGURE 2 Five ideas the whole book rests on. Each one starts inside you, then shows up between you and the people you share a life with.

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PART THREE

# Understanding people

*How feelings, stress, trust, change, grief, groups and love work, for anyone, in any kind of relationship.*

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PROFESSOR PUDDLES

If a question pops up while you read, ask me. Nothing you type leaves your device.

TOOL **Ask Professor Puddles** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

# 1

PART THREE · CHAPTER 1

# How feelings work: signals, the body, and naming what you feel

*What feelings are for, where they start, and why putting a name to one can make it easier to carry, whether you're on your own, at home, with friends or at work.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. A feeling is a signal, not a verdict
2. Feelings start in the body
3. Naming a feeling helps you hold it
4. More words, better tools
5. Feelings come in layers
6. Feelings rise and pass like waves
7. Feelings spread between people
8. If you weren't brought up to talk about feelings
9. Feeling it isn't the same as doing it
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation


AT A GLANCE

- **A feeling is a signal** that something matters to you. It doesn't tell you what to do about it.
- **Feelings start in the body.** A tight chest or a hot face often arrives before the word for it.
- **Naming helps.** "I feel let down" is easier to hold than a big, nameless rush.
- **You can let a feeling be there** and still choose what you do next.

THURSDAY, 4:50PM

*A message from your manager. Have you got a minute tomorrow? No period, no smiley, nothing else at all.*

*By the time you get in you've snapped at the cat, decided you're not hungry, and gone back over every mistake of the past month, plus one from March that nobody else remembers. Nobody has said anything bad. You check the message again anyway, in case it's grown a period.*

Feelings sit underneath nearly everything else in this book, so they get looked at first. Two tools elsewhere lean on this chapter. My weather today and the daily check-in (Part One, Now, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now; Part Two, Chapter I, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-1) ask for one word about how you are, because naming a feeling turns its volume down a little and a daily word catches feelings while they're still small. And Say it so it lands (Part Two, Chapter IV, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4) asks you to describe a feeling, because "I felt let down" is a good deal easier to hear than "you never care."

Here is the knot in the stomach in quick strokes. On top, a short message from a manager. Under it, the body's alarm, which has already decided something is wrong. Under that, the meaning your mind gives the alarm. The roots are state and setting, and signal and noise. Then, slowly, each layer gets its own page or two.

01

## A feeling is a signal, not a verdict.

Feelings are fast messages about what matters to you. Fear says watch out. Anger says this seems unfair, or this is in my way. Sadness says something that mattered has gone. A signal is worth listening to. It can also be badly wrong about the details, the way a smoke alarm goes off for burned toast with exactly the same urgency it would give a house fire.

Hayley's best friend has a new best friend, or that's how it feels, and Hayley is jealous and a bit ashamed of being jealous at thirty-four. The jealousy proves nothing about her, and nothing about whether the friend is drifting off either; it just shows how much the friendship matters, which is worth

knowing, and possibly worth saying. "I'm being daft," she texts eventually, "but I miss you." The friend rings within the minute.

**Sunny days and big questions**

In a classic study, people phoned on sunny days rated their whole lives as more satisfying, and the bad-weather dip vanished once the interviewer mentioned the weather. Much bigger studies later found the weather effect itself is tiny. The useful part survives: spotting where a feeling comes from stops it coloring everything else.

**Schwarz and Clore (1983)** · *Moderate: a classic study of feelings as information; the weather effect proved very small*

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"This feeling is telling me something matters. What is it?" "Is this the fire, or the toast?"

02

## Feelings start in the body.

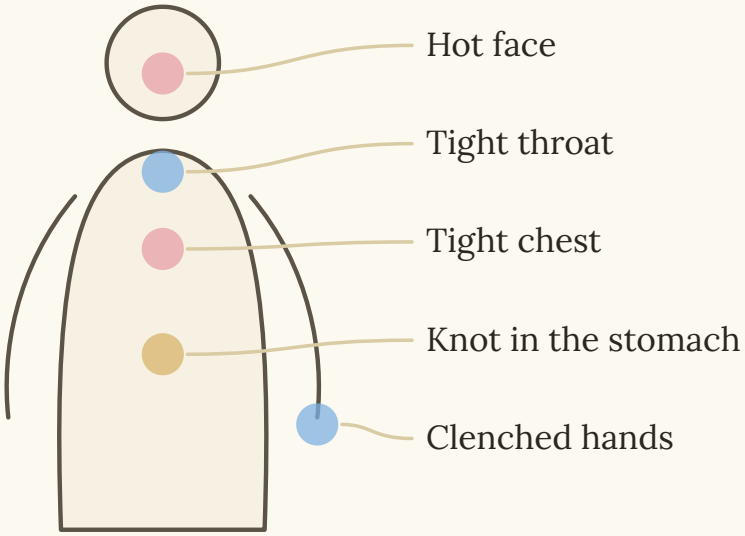
Often the body goes first. Racing heart, hot face, a weight on the chest, a knot in the stomach. Then the brain tries to work out what the signal means. It guesses, and it isn't always a good guesser. Which is why being hungry, or cold, or in pain, can feel so much like being upset.

Reece is fifteen and has come home in a fury about a towel. Specifically, about his mom asking where his gym towel was. There is a good deal of door involved. After a cheese toastie and twenty minutes on the couch with the dog's head on his knee, most of it has drained away, and he admits, through a mouthful, that he didn't have any lunch. "I wasn't hungry," he says. Then, "I was a bit hungry."

A few times today, stop and ask what your body feels like right now, and whether any of it is simply hunger, or cold, or a sore back.

## A feeling is a signal, not a verdict

*It often shows up in the body before it has a word.*




**Feel it**
*in the body*

→

**Name it**
*"I feel let down"*

→

**Choose**
*what you do next*

**It says: something here matters to me.**
*It doesn't say what to do.*

*Illustration. Everyone's body signals are a little different; these are common ones, not a medical map.*

FIGURE 3 A feeling is a signal, not a verdict. It often shows up in the body first. Naming it helps you choose what to do next.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 1

**My weather today**

*Esme, 29, at 4:50pm, after "Got a minute tomorrow?" from her manager*

---

## Check today's weather

### The sky

Clear: Calm and connected · *Gusty: Revved up* · Fogged in: Running on empty

### Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner · Family · A co-parent · Roommates · *Coworkers* · Someone I care for · Friends · Mostly on my own

### The pressure

Light · *Building* · Heavy

### Ground conditions

*Haven't eaten in a while* · Thirsty · In pain or unwell · Been still all day · Too much noise or light · *Running on caffeine* · Screens since I woke up

### Last night's sleep

Barely slept · Short night · *About enough* · Properly rested

### People load

Barely any · *A normal amount* · A lot · Nonstop, no gaps

### What's blowing in

Work · Money · Kids or caring · Health · Family · The house · *One conversation* · Something I can't name

### What would actually help in the next hour?

Space · Food or water · Rest · To move · *To be heard* · *A plan* · Company · Quiet · Someone to take something off me

YOUR FORECAST

**Gusty today**
Revved up · Some room today

**Talk window**
wait about 20 minutes

It's gusty. You're revved up. That energy is useful for doing something physical, but it is poor weather for deciding anything about another person.

The ground underneath: you haven't eaten in a while and you're running on caffeine. That isn't a side note. It's likely a big part of why today feels the way it does, and it's easier to change than character is.

Blowing in: one conversation. Weather from one front tends to land on whoever is nearest, often someone who had nothing to do with it. Worth saying out loud before it does.

You said what would help is a plan and to be heard. Arrange that before anything else.

If you want to send someone a line: "I don't need it solved. I just need you to hear this for a few minutes first."

*Made-up example. Esme ate something, then called her sister to be heard. She didn't reply to the message until the morning.*

Fill in your own: My weather today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks)

03

## Naming a feeling helps you hold it.

Putting a feeling into words can turn its volume down. In brain-scan research by Lieberman and colleagues (2007), simply putting a name to a feeling ("I feel scared") turned down the brain's alarm response. A name gives a big, cloudy rush some edges, so you can see it and talk about it and decide what to do.

Two roommates spent a whole evening passing each other in the hall without a word. Nobody had done anything, as far as either of them knew. At about ten, one of them stopped on the stairs. "I think I'm embarrassed about the noise complaint," she said, "and I've been taking it out on you by being weird." The other one, who had spent two hours going back over everything she'd said that week, laughed so hard she had to sit down. Then she made some tea.

**It works even when it doesn't feel like it**

A review by Torre and Lieberman found that naming a feeling can turn down its intensity even though, in the moment, it doesn't feel as if you're doing anything at all. So carry on with "something like sad" even when it seems pointless.

**Torre and Lieberman (2018)** · *Moderate: consistent lab evidence; how it works is still being worked out*

Once a day, name one feeling, out loud or on paper. A guess like "something like sad" counts.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

If the words won't come, weather words often will. "Foggy" or "stormy" is a perfectly good place to start.

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

04

## More words, better tools.

"Bad" is a blunt instrument. Disappointed is different from left out, and both are different from overwhelmed or ashamed. Each one needs something different. A review by Kashdan, Barrett and McKnight (2015) found that people who can tell their feelings apart more finely tend to cope with them in healthier ways. You don't need a big vocabulary. A number does the job. So does a color.

Stephen told his partner he felt bad about his mom and they went around in circles for half an hour. Bad how? Bad about what? Then, out of nowhere, staring at the fridge: "I feel guilty I haven't been up since Easter. And I'm scared she's getting worse." Within ten minutes they were looking at trains to Carlisle, and the cheapest one turned out to leave at 6.12 in the morning, which led to a whole different conversation about who was going to drive them to the station.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"On a scale of one to ten, I'm about a six." "It's less angry and more… let down." "It feels heavy, like a gray day."

05

## Feelings come in layers.

The feeling you show first isn't always the one you felt first. Anger very often sits on top of hurt or fear, because anger is a stronger place to stand. And we have feelings about our feelings (ashamed of being sad, mad about being scared) and that second layer can sting more than the first.

School break has been canceled again, for the second time. Brenda's daughter rings to say so, with a lot of reasons, all of them good ones, and Brenda says, "Fine. Well. Another time," in a voice like a closing door. Under that is hurt, and under the hurt, if she let herself look, there is a quieter worry that she isn't needed much anymore by anyone, which is the one she has spent the last two years carefully not looking at. She doesn't look. She puts the phone down and sits next to it for a while with her coat still on.

Next time you're angry, you might ask whether there's hurt or worry underneath. You don't have to tell anyone what you find.

06

## Feelings rise and pass like waves.

Most feelings, even big ones, rise and peak and settle, as long as you don't keep feeding them. Moods are something else. A mood is more like weather, a background feeling that hangs about for hours or days and colors everything without announcing itself.

By eleven o'clock on a Saturday morning Rachel had decided her whole life was going nowhere. In fairness it had been a morning. The water heater, a letter from the city, and a dream about her ex in which he was, for some reason, a dentist. By seven that evening, after a walk along

**Not every wave is the same length**

Of 27 emotions in one study, sadness lasted longest, and shame, fear and disgust were among the shortest. The long ones tended to follow events that mattered, and to be chewed over.

**Verduyn and Lavrijsen (2015)** · *Moderate: a single self-report study, in line with other research on how long feelings last*

the canal and an hour on the phone with her sister, the same life looked fairly ordinary and mostly all right, with an actual dentist on Tuesday and a library book she wanted to finish. Nothing in her life changed between eleven and seven.

So if you can, leave big decisions until the wave has gone past. Write it down. Look at it tomorrow.

07

## Feelings spread between people.

We catch each other's feelings from a tight voice, a sigh, a door shut slightly too hard, usually without noticing we've caught anything. It's part of how people bond. It also means stress can go around a house or a team like a cold in February.

Bryony came into the Monday meeting late and rattled, and within ten minutes six people who had been perfectly fine at nine o'clock felt behind on everything. The following Monday she stood outside the door for two slow breaths before going in. The meeting finished on time. In that office this was regarded as a minor miracle and nobody could work out why.

You can care about someone's feeling without catching the whole of it. Good moods are catching too, and Stay close (spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding) has small ideas for passing one on. Notice who you tend to catch things from, and give yourself a minute before you next talk to them.



TIDBIT

Good moods are catching too. If you'd like a small way to share one, there's a tool for it.

TOOL **Stay close: one small idea** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

08

## If you weren't brought up to talk about feelings.

Lots of people grew up in homes, generations or cultures where feelings were kept private. "Don't make a fuss." "Big boys don't cry." "We don't talk about that." It's especially common among men and older people, and in some cultures keeping your feelings to yourself is a sign of respect and strength.

It isn't a flaw, and it doesn't mean you don't feel. Many people who rarely put a feeling into words show it every day by doing things, fixing the faucet or driving someone to the ER at two in the morning and waiting in the parking lot till it's over. They turn up. Caring by doing is real caring. Words can be added slowly, a few at a time, if you want them.

Len was a builder for forty years and his wife died in the spring. He has never in his life said how he feels about anything, apart from Newcastle United. On the touchline at his grandson's match, during a long dull bit of the first half, he says to his son, "I wasn't brought up to say this. But I miss her. Every morning." His son puts a hand on his shoulder and leaves it there. Neither of them says anything else for the rest of the match. They watch the second half, which is also dull, and it's one of the better afternoons either of them has had all year.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> "I wasn't brought up to say this, but I miss her." "I'm not good with words for this. It's been a hard week." "I don't know what to call it. I just feel heavy." "I'm not one for talking, but I wanted you to know I'm proud of you."

If one of those fits, you could say it once this week, to one person, or just out loud in the car. A text counts.

09

## Feeling it isn't the same as doing it.

A feeling usually arrives with an urge attached, to shout or leave or hide or send the text you'll regret by dinnertime. You don't choose the feeling, but you get rather more say over the urge. Pushing a feeling down tends to bring it back bigger, and acting on every urge hurts people, so the middle way is to let the feeling be there and choose the action.

A crash from the yard. Through the kitchen window, Imran's son is standing very still beside the greenhouse with a soccer ball, and there is a lot less greenhouse than there was. Imran feels the heat go up his neck. He opens the back door, says, "I'm too cross to talk about this. Ten minutes," shuts it again,

and goes to find the dustpan. By the time he comes out his son has picked up most of the big bits, very carefully, in gardening gloves two sizes too large.

FRIDAY, 9:05AM

*The knot's back. This time you give it a name, which is scared, and then you do the thing you'd been avoiding and just ask. Your manager looks honestly baffled. "Oh God, no. It's the summer schedule." You go back to your desk and eat the breakfast you skipped, a banana that's been in your bag since Wednesday.*

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

### A feeling, sent and received

Some people feel first and find the words later, sometimes much later. Asked "What's wrong?" they honestly may not know yet. Others name a feeling almost as it arrives and expect everyone else to as well. If you name things fast, the quiet person may not be hiding anything. Their words are still on the way. If you need time, the quick namer may not be pushing. To them, saying it is how a feeling gets smaller.

**Where the fields meet.** Music has known for a long time that tone and tempo carry more than the words, and a feeling is often heard in the tune before the lyrics. Psychology adds that mood filters what we hear, so the same sentence lands differently on a bad day.

## In everyday life

If you live on your own, nobody is going to notice how you are, so a one-word check-in with yourself each day matters more (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). With a partner, "What are you

feeling?" can sound like an exam. "Do you want to tell me, or shall I just sit with you?" is much easier to answer. Children learn feeling words from the grown-ups near them, and hearing you say "I'm frustrated, so I'm going to take a breath" teaches more than any lesson. At work, "I'm a bit low today and I'm not upset with anyone" can stop a whole team guessing. And if someone close to you shows care by doing, like clearing the drive on your bad day, you can thank them for it in words. They may not know what to do with it the first time.

## Common mix-ups

Some feelings hurt and some actions do harm, but a feeling on its own isn't bad. It's information. Feeling stupid doesn't make you stupid, either, so treat a feeling as something to check before you obey it. People also expect to know right away what they feel, and plenty can't, some of them most days, which is why body words and numbers count as answers here. The most stubborn mix-up is the idea that a face tells you what someone feels. Faces are a poor guide. People show the same feeling in very different ways, and asking is kinder than guessing and a lot more accurate.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Ask before you name it for them. "You're angry" can land like a label. "You seem upset, am I reading that right?" leaves them room to put you straight. Then help the feeling make sense ("Of course you're upset, that was a lot"), which does more than advice and doesn't mean you agree with everything they did. Ask whether they want ideas or just company. A lot of people only want the second and are relieved to be asked. Take other ways of saying it, a number or a text or "I'm at a seven." And settle yourself first. If their sadness makes you anxious, calm down before you go in, or they'll end up looking after you.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "That sounds really hard." "Do you want to talk, or would company help more?" "You don't have to find the right word. A number is fine."

## Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

**Workpapers** **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11): a plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments.

**Tools** **helpers you use on the website**

- My weather today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks): a short, private daily check of your mood and state.
- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now): steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.

**Reading** **pages to read on the website**

- Know your own wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself): how you tend to feel and react, and why.
- The library: what emotions are (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), naming feelings (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#affect-labeling), emotional granularity (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#emotional-granularity), when feelings are hard to name (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#alexithymia), emotional contagion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#emotional-contagion) and sensing your body (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress).

## More for your situation

- Next in Part Three: Stress and the nervous system (page 28)
- Part One, Now: your wiring, your weather and your words
- Wired differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently) and Neurodivergent relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- For teens: when feelings get loud (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- For caregivers: resentment and guilt (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers)
- Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)

- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words**
*Reading your own weather day to day* — read online

**Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles**
*Feelings when a stress tank is full* — read online

**Part Three · Chapter 2 · Stress and the nervous system**
*What the body does under pressure* — page 28

**Part Three · Chapter 13 · Anger**
*One feeling up close* — page 188

PUT IT TO USE

**The Calm-Down Kit**
A plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11

**My weather today**
A short, private daily check of your mood and state
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

# 2

PART THREE · CHAPTER 2

# Stress and the nervous system: the ladder, flooding, rest and recovery

*What stress does to your body and your mind, why kind people say things they don't mean when they're flooded, and which kinds of rest actually put something back.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Stress is your body getting ready
2. Stress depends on what you have to meet it
3. The ladder: three everyday states
4. When you're flooded, thinking goes offline
5. Stress adds up, like a tank filling
6. Settle the body first
7. Rest isn't one thing
8. Sleep and stress feed each other
9. Stress is easier to carry when it's shared
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation


MONDAY, 7:52AM

*The bus is late. One school shoe is missing, last seen under the sofa on Saturday. Your phone buzzes with a message from work that begins "Quick one," which it never is. From the hall your partner calls, "Have you seen my keys?" and you hear yourself shout, "I'm not your secretary!"*

*A second later you're standing there wondering where that came from. It wasn't the keys. You were behind before anyone had said a word, before the shoe went missing, probably before you were even out of bed.*

Feelings got their own chapter (Chapter 1, page 14). This one goes a layer down, to the nervous system underneath them, and what it does when the

pressure's on. Knowing how stress works won't make Monday any quieter. It does make your own reactions, and other people's, a lot less mysterious.

It also explains why some of the tools elsewhere work at all. The stress tank in Part Two, Chapter III (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3) asks how full you are before you judge the moment, because stress piles up from small loads. The Calm-Down Kit in Part One, Now (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now) settles the body before any words, and it asks you to name a time to come back, so a pause doesn't look like walking out. And the setup score in Part Two, Chapter II (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2) counts stress as well as hours, since a split can look fair on paper and still leave one person running on empty.

In quick strokes: the surface is a missing shoe. Underneath it, a body already in alarm before anyone spoke. Underneath that, a week with no recovery in it. The roots are limited capacity and state and setting. Now one at a time, starting with the body.

01

## Stress is your body getting ready.

Something needs dealing with, and your body gears up before you've decided anything. Heart faster, breath quicker, muscles tight, stress hormones up. Which is exactly what you want when a glass is sliding off the table. The trouble starts when the body stays geared up for hours and never gets the message to stand down.

Morag is a nurse. She handles a cardiac arrest on the ward calmly and well. She gets home at nine, eats half a sandwich standing up at the counter, and at 10:30 finds herself sobbing at an ad for car insurance. Car insurance has never moved her to anything before. Her body is still running the emergency it thinks she's in.

So after something stressful, give your body a clear sign that it's over, whether that's a walk around the block or a hot shower or one song played much too loud in the car on the way home. The body takes its cue from what you do far more than from what you tell it.

02

## Stress depends on what you have to meet it.

The same deadline lands on two colleagues on a Thursday afternoon, and one of them has a quiet evening ahead and a takeout menu. The other has a seven-year-old at home with a temperature and a partner away in Chicago till Saturday. On paper it's one task. Guess which of them is awake at 3am.

Stress grows when a demand looks bigger than what you've got to meet it with, whether that's time or energy or money or help or sleep. That's why a small thing tips you over on a bad day. It's also why giving someone more support can shrink their stress without changing the job at all. When something feels huge, I'd write two lists side by side, one for what it asks of you and one for what you've got. Then ignore the first list for a minute and ask what would make the second one a line longer.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "It's less the task than how little I've got left today." "What would make this feel more doable?"

03

## The ladder: three everyday states.

The ladder is a picture of the states your body moves between in a day. Near the bottom you're **calm and connected**, breathing easily, able to hear something difficult without bristling. Higher up you're **revved up**, tense, and small things start to feel urgent or personal. Then there's **running on empty**, which is low and slow, with the words just out of reach.

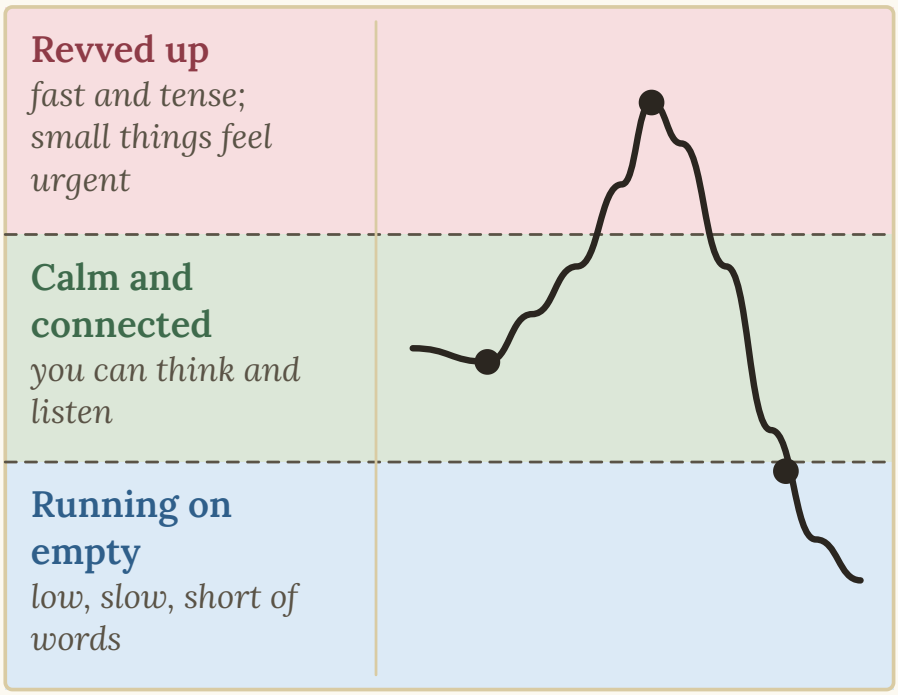
Most people go up and down it many times a day. Derek minds his granddaughter on Wednesdays, and at two o'clock he's calm and connected and they're doing a jigsaw. By four she has found the felt-tips and the wall, and he's revved up. By six, when her mom comes, he is sitting on the kitchen floor eating a fish stick off her plate and can't remember the word for colander. Neither of them had changed, only the hour, and how much afternoon was left in him.

The Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks) is a thirty-second check that gives you a best guess at where you are. If you'd rather not use a screen, set three reminders on your phone for today, and

each time one goes off, notice which called you're on. Don't do anything about it, just notice.

## The ladder: three everyday states

*You move up and down it all day.*




*Same grandfather, same toddler. The state changed.*

**Hard talks go best from the middle band.**

*Everyday words, not a medical model. A related map is the "window of tolerance" (Siegel, 1999): inside it, you can feel strongly and still think.*

FIGURE 4 The ladder: three everyday states. You move up and down it all day. Hard talks go best from the middle band.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 2

**The ladder (the sky, in My weather today)**

*Mike, who cares for his wife, Ann*

## The sky

Pick the one closest to true right now. This is a reading of you, never of anyone else.

The sky

Clear: Calm and connected  Gusty: Revved up  *Fogged in: Running on empty*

Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner  Family  A co-parent  Roommates  Coworkers  *Someone I care for*  Friends  Mostly on my own

The pressure

Light  Building  *Heavy*

Last night's sleep

*Barely slept*  Short night  About enough  Properly rested

What's blowing in

Work  Money  *Kids or caring*  *Health*  Family  The house  One conversation  Something I can't name

What would actually help in the next hour?

Space  Food or water  *Rest*  To move  To be heard  A plan  Company  Quiet  *Someone to take something off me*

YOUR FORECAST

**Fogged in today**
Running on empty · Very little room today

**Talk window**
another day is kinder

You were already carrying a heavy day before this. Treat the size of your reaction as a reading on the day, not on whoever is in front of you.

Between you and the person you care for today: do the essentials kindly and let the rest go. If anyone can cover one thing today, ask them.

If you need to say something now: "I'm at the end of what I can carry today. Could you take [one thing] off me?"

*Made-up example. A heavy reading is information about a day, not a failing in a person.*

Fill in your own: My weather today: the sky (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks)

04

## When you're flooded, thinking goes offline.

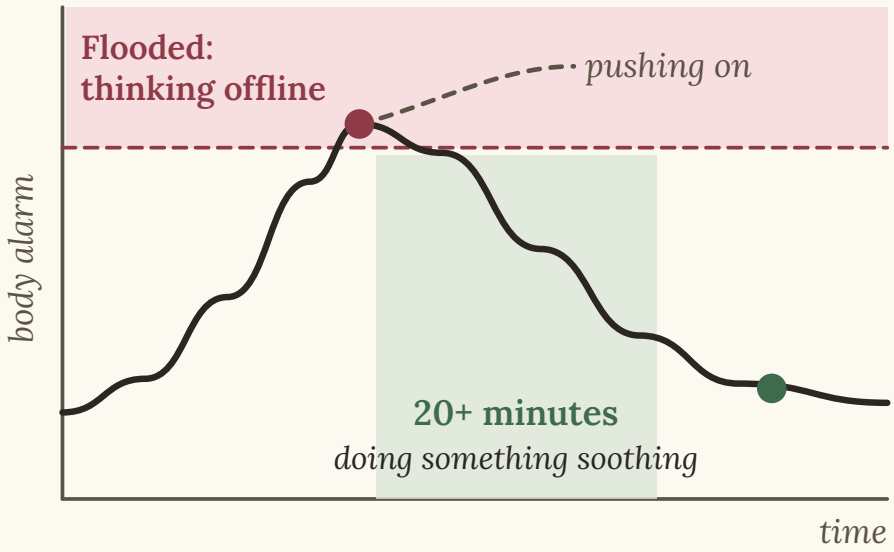
At the top of the stress curve your body is in full alarm, and the things a hard conversation needs most (careful thinking, listening, seeing the other side) get much harder to reach. Lots of people call this being **flooded**. You might say something you don't mean, or freeze, or want nothing in the world except to be out of the room.

Two brothers start clearing their dad's house one wet Saturday in March. Within twenty minutes they are shouting at each other about a standard lamp. Neither of them likes the lamp. Neither of them wants it. One of them says "Fine, take it then!" and the other says "I don't *want* it!" and they stand there either side of it, breathing hard, while the actual subject sits in the boxes all around them and nobody says it.

A flooded person is still a decent person whose body has to come down before the talk can go anywhere. Know your own flood signs in advance. Heat in the face is a common one. So is a racing heart, or the room going narrow, or a voice in your head that has gone very loud and very certain. Two at once is your cue to stop. Then say so in plain words, something like "I'm too flooded to listen well. Can we stop for twenty minutes and come back at four?"

## Flooded means offline

*Pause, settle, then come back.*




- Pause, and name a time to come back.
- Settle the body. Don't rehearse the argument.
- Come back and talk, once you can listen.

*Illustrative curve. John Gottman's work on couples suggests a real break of at least about twenty minutes when flooded.*

FIGURE 5 Flooded means offline. Pause and name a time to come back, settle the body for at least twenty minutes, then talk. Illustrative curve.

05

### Stress adds up, like a tank filling.

Picture a tank holding everything you're already carrying today. The traffic goes in. So does the meeting that overran, and the noisy shop, and the text from your mom that just says "Call me when you can." It's all one tank, and by

the evening something tiny makes it overflow and gets the blame for the whole lot.

Asked to empty the dishwasher, Kyle, who is fifteen, explodes. Really explodes, a whole speech about how he does everything in this house. It's days later, from a friend's mom at school pickup, that his own mom finds out his closest friendship fell apart at lunchtime that Monday, over something said in a group chat. The dishwasher was just the next thing anyone asked of him.

**Hassles beat headlines**

In a classic study, everyday hassles predicted how people were doing better than major life events did, even once the big events were taken into account. Which is why a missing shoe can be the thing that tips you over.

**Kanner and colleagues (1981)** · *Moderate: a classic study; many later studies agree*

Small daily hassles count as much as big events here, which surprises people. Before you react to a small thing in the evening, ask how full you were before it happened. How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying) is five quick questions, and Part Two, Chapter III uses it to tell old stress from new.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Stress fills up a little at a time, like a puddle in a long spell of rain. Five quick questions tell you how full yours is today.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02

06

## Settle the body first.

You can't think your way out of a body in alarm. You can help the body come down, though, and the thinking usually follows. Slow breathing with long out-breaths works for a lot of people. So does moving, or humming something you know by heart, or steady pressure like a heavy blanket, or simply leaving the noisy room. What works is personal, which is why it's worth finding your own short list on a calm day and not in the middle of a fight.

Before she has to give some difficult feedback, Bridie feels her heart going. She walks once around the staff parking lot, breathing out slowly past the

dumpsters and the smokers' shelter, and goes in a little steadier, if not exactly calm. Put your list on your phone. The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11) helps you build it. If you only keep one line from this section, keep "body first, words second."

07

## Rest isn't one thing.

An hour on the couch scrolling can leave you more tired than when you sat down. That's because recovery comes in different kinds, and sleep is only one of them, alongside switching off from work in your head, real relaxation, doing something absorbing that you enjoy, and the plain feeling of being in charge of your own time for once. None of them stands in for the others.

Two roommates have friends over on a Saturday for a takeout and a game show on TV. One wakes up on Sunday buzzing. The other spends the whole of Sunday in her room with a library book and the door shut, and comes out at dinnertime feeling human again. Company fills some people up and drains others, and neither of them is doing rest wrong.

**Four kinds of recovery**

Researchers who study unwinding after work separate four things: switching off in your head, relaxing, doing something absorbing that stretches you a little, and being in charge of your own time. An evening that gives you none of the four isn't much of a rest, however long you sit down.

**Sonnentag and Fritz (2007)** · *Strong: a widely used measure; recovery research is large and consistent*

Ask yourself which kind of tired you are, whether it's your body or your brain, or people, or feelings, then pick a rest that matches rather than the one you always go for. Calm sounds and music (spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes) is one kind, if you like that sort of thing.



SUGARFOOT

Rest can be a nap, a walk or ten minutes of quiet music. Find the kind that suits you, and keep it somewhere you can reach it.

TOOL **Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes`

08

## Sleep and stress feed each other.

Stress makes sleep harder, and poor sleep makes stress land harder. After a short or broken night small things feel bigger, tempers are shorter, and people pull away from each other. This one is well studied. In a brain-scan study by Yoo and colleagues (2007), one night without sleep made the brain's alarm center react more strongly to upsetting pictures.

In a daily study by Gordon and Chen (2014), couples reported more conflict after nights of poor sleep. In experiments by Ben Simon and Walker (2018), people who had missed a night's sleep kept others at a greater distance and felt lonelier.

Saoirse comes off her third night shift at the nursing home and bursts into tears in the parking lot over a parking ticket. Her sister, on speakerphone, says, "You've had no sleep, leave it, we'll deal with it Thursday." By Thursday it is a parking ticket again, annoying and payable, and she pays it online on her lunch break between a granola bar and a yogurt.

You can't always fix sleep, but you can notice when it's part of the story. Before a hard conversation, ask whether you've both slept, and if not, pick another time. At night, do the same few calm things before bed in the same order, so your body learns the signal.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I slept badly, so if I'm short with you today, that's why." "Can we talk about this after we've both slept?"

09

## Stress is easier to carry when it's shared.

People calm each other down. A steady voice, a hand on the shoulder, or just a quiet person in the same room can help a nervous system settle. Saying your state out loud helps too, because "I'm stressed about work" stops your partner wondering if it's about them.

Fish sticks again, Tuesday. Kwasi says to his ten-year-old, without quite looking at him, "I'm a bit stressed about money this month. Sorting it is my grown-up job, and you're not in trouble." His son nods and carries on eating.

Nothing else is said. Over the next few days the boy stops tiptoeing around him, and on Friday he brings his math homework to the table again and asks for help with it, which he hasn't done since school break.

MONDAY, 7:58AM

*Six minutes later your partner is by the front door, still patting their pockets. "Sorry," you say. "I was full up before you opened your mouth." And then, after a moment, "Bathroom shelf, next to the toothpaste." They laugh, and ask if it's been a bad start. The bus is still late and the shoe is still missing.*

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

### A full tank, two ways

For some people, stress shows up loudly: a sharp voice, a slammed cupboard. For others it goes inward and quiet, and the first sign anyone sees is a person who has stopped answering. If you get loud, the quiet one may be just as full, only less visible. If you go quiet, the loud one is probably not angry with you. They are usually full, and it's coming out sideways.

**Where the fields meet.** Neurobiology's idea is that your state sets the volume, and stress left over from earlier still counts. Economics says the same thing in money terms: a household or a person running at full stretch has no margin left for an ordinary bad day.

## In everyday life

Living on your own means nobody's there to notice when you're running on empty, so build rest into the week before you need it. With a partner, agree a pause word on a calm day, plus the rule that whoever pauses names a time to

come back (One of you wants to talk now, the other needs space, spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw, has more on this). A child can't settle until the nearest grown-up does. Your calm is something they borrow for years before they can make their own. At work, a flooded colleague can't take in feedback, and waiting an hour usually beats pushing on.

Some people run on empty for reasons built into their lives, like shift work, a long-term illness or caring for someone. What that needs is a different setup. More effort won't do it (see Different hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours, and Caregivers, spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers). If you have ADHD, just keeping track of everything can fill the tank before breakfast. Get the remembering out of your head and into the world, with labeled alarms and one hook for the keys, and plan hard talks for your better time of day. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-2-stress-in-depth).

## Common mix-ups

People often think all stress is bad, and it isn't. Short bursts help you rise to something, and the harm comes from stress that never gets a recovery. Being calm doesn't mean not being upset, either. You can be calm and sad, or calm and extremely firm. Pausing gets mistaken for avoiding, but a pause with a time to come back is how you finish a talk well. Avoiding is the pause that never comes back. Rest gets called lazy, though bodies and minds that never recover tend to break. And short replies with a flat face get read as not caring, when far more often they mean someone is worn out.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Nobody in the history of the world has calmed down because they were told to. A lower voice, slower words and a steady presence do far more. Taking one job off someone's list beats any pep talk. Ask what kind of help they'd like (practical help, company, distraction, some space) instead of guessing. Don't argue with someone who's flooded. Offer a break and a time to come back, because the facts will still be there in twenty minutes. And if someone has been running on empty for weeks, say so kindly and help them find support.

YOU COULD SAY

"You seem really stretched. Is there one thing I could take off your plate?" "We don't have to sort this now. Shall we pick it up after dinner?"

## Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

**Workpapers** **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit: your plan for heated moments.

**Tools** **helpers you use on the website**

- The Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks#ladder): a thirty-second self-check.
- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now): steps to calm down, alone or together.
- Drift (spreadloveandacceptance.com/calm-visualizer), Brain Breakers and calm games (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pause-and-play): gentle ways to come down.

**Reading** **pages to read on the website**

- The library: the stress response (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress), appraisal (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress#appraisal), the window of tolerance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress#window-of-tolerance), flooding (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships), burnout (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress#burnout) and slow breathing (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/calm).

## More for your situation

- Back: How feelings work (page 14) · Next: How we see each other (page 43) · All chapters in the contents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/contents)
- Part Two, Chapter III: full tanks and different angles
- How to stop fighting: calm steps (spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-to-stop-fighting-with-your-partner)

- New baby, sharing the load (spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent) and Coming home after time apart (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home)
- For teens: big feelings and stress (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- Sensory overload at home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Stress is your body getting ready.
- ✓ The ladder: three everyday states.
- ✓ Stress adds up, like a tank filling.
- ✓ Rest isn't one thing.
- ✓ Stress is easier to carry when it's shared.

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles** — read online
*The stress tank in a shared home*

**Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words** — read online
*Your weather before you speak*

**Part Two · Chapter I · Why we get out of tune** — read online
*How stress knocks two people out of tune*

**Part Three · Chapter 16 · Worry, low mood and trauma** — page 231
*When stress turns into worry or low mood*

PUT IT TO USE

**The Calm-Down Kit**
Your plan for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11

**The Nervous System Ladder**
A thirty-second self-check
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

# 3

PART THREE · CHAPTER 3

# How we see each other: perception, bias, and the stories we tell

*Why two people can watch the same moment and come away with two different stories, and how to see others, and yourself, a little more fairly.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Seeing is a best guess
2. You see what you're looking for
3. We fill the gaps with stories
4. We judge ourselves by our reasons, and others by their actions
5. Quick shortcuts can lead us astray
6. Everyone feels like the one who sees clearly
7. "Us" and "them" changes what we see
8. Ask, don't guess
9. In everyday life
10. Two memories of one evening, or gaslighting?
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation


AT A GLANCE

- **Seeing is a best guess.** Your brain fills in a lot of what you think you see and hear.
- **We fill gaps with stories**, and the story often feels like a fact.
- **We judge ourselves by our reasons and others by their actions**, and that gap causes a lot of hurt.
- **Asking is kinder and more accurate** than trying to read someone's mind.

WEDNESDAY, 12:15PM

*You wave at a colleague across the canteen, tray in one hand, soup slopping. She looks straight through you and walks out.*

*All afternoon. All afternoon you go back through Monday's meeting, that thing you said about the budget, the email you didn't reply to. At four o'clock she messages. Sorry I didn't stop earlier, I'd just had a call about my dad. She hadn't seen you at all.*

How feelings work (page 14) and Stress and the nervous system (page 28) look inward. This chapter looks outward, at how we see other people, and why misunderstandings are so common even between kind and clever people. Before I built any of this I spent my career as a government auditor, walking into situations where nobody could tell me straight what had happened. Almost everyone, it turned out, was doing their best with the piece of the picture they could actually see. This chapter is more or less about that.

Some of the tools elsewhere depend on it. Who did what (the Preface to Part Two, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/preface) exists because everyone sees their own effort more clearly than other people's, so two honest guesses of "I do about 60%" can add up to well over 100%, and one shared page settles it. Rewind the talk (Part Two, Chapter III, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3) slows down the habit of judging ourselves by our reasons and others by their actions. And the Chat analyzer follows this chapter's last idea, that asking beats guessing.

A wave that wasn't returned, quickly. The surface is a colleague who walked past. Underneath, a story your mind wrote in a second. Underneath that, a brain saving effort with a shortcut. The roots are signal and noise, and limited capacity. Then slowly, shortcut by shortcut.

01

## Seeing is a best guess.

Your eyes and ears take in far less than you think, and your brain fills in the rest from what it expects. Most of the time this works well, and fast. It also means what you see is partly what you expected, so two people can watch the same moment and honestly see different things.

Under-12 soccer, a freezing Sunday morning, a field that is mostly mud. Archie's mom sees him giving up, and says so, quietly, into her scarf. His dad, beside her with the flask, sees him being careful with the ankle he went over on last week. They argue about it all the way home and Archie, in the back, says nothing, because he was actually thinking about dinner.

**They saw a game**

Students from two rival universities, Princeton and Dartmouth, watched the same rough American football game and saw it very differently, right down to how many fouls each side committed. Same match, two games.

**Hastorf and Cantril (1954)** · *Moderate: a classic single case study, widely cited*

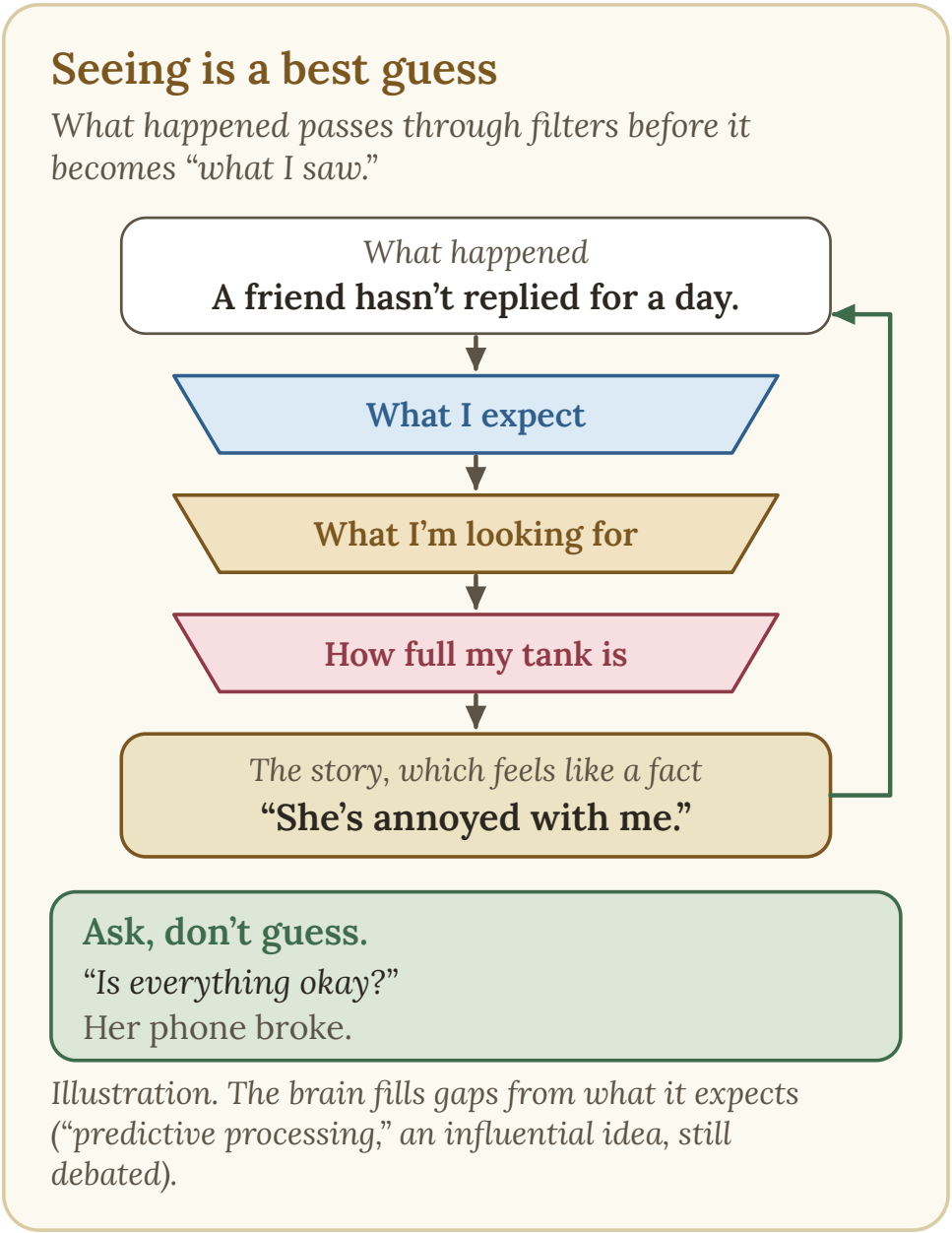



FIGURE 6 Seeing is a best guess. The story that comes out feels like a fact. Asking is kinder and more accurate than reading minds.

02

## You see what you're looking for.

Attention is like a flashlight in a dark room. You see what it lights up and can miss what it doesn't, even when it's right in front of you. If you're looking for proof that someone doesn't care, you will notice every missed call and none of the little kindnesses.

In her first week Rosie decided her new manager didn't like her. For a month she noticed every short email he sent, and there were a lot. He sends short emails to everyone, including, as it turned out, his wife. What Rosie somehow didn't clock was that he'd given her the best project on the team. A colleague pointed it out at the bar after somebody's going-away party, and Rosie said, "Oh." Then, "Oh no."

If there's someone you're struggling with, try writing down one kind thing they do each day for a week. It's an odd exercise, and it tends to move the flashlight.

03

## We fill the gaps with stories.

When we don't know why someone did something, the mind makes up a reason, fast. A late reply becomes anger, and a closed door becomes rejection. And the story arrives feeling like a fact. Memory works the same way, because every time we remember something we rebuild it a little, so two people can honestly remember the same evening differently.

Two days without a reply. By Sunday evening you have decided she's fed up with you, and you've drafted, then deleted, a message saying you're sorry for whatever it was. On Monday morning she sends seventeen photographs from a campsite in Snowdonia with no signal, most of them of the same sheep. One message, "The story I'm telling myself is that you're upset with me. Is that right?" would have saved two days of it.

04

## We judge ourselves by our reasons, and others by their actions.

When you're late, you know why, because it was the traffic or a phone call or a child who lost a shoe. When someone else is late you only see the lateness, and it's very easy to decide they're careless. We all tend to blame other people's character for things that are really about their situation.

A driver cuts in front of you on the beltway and you call him an idiot, not quite under your breath. The next week your mom has a fall and you're racing to the hospital, and you cut someone off yourself, badly, at the intersection. You know exactly why you did it. You'd quite like them to know too. They don't, and in their car, right now, you are an idiot.

**The fundamental attribution error**

Lee Ross gave this habit its name: when we explain what someone else did, we tend to underrate the situation and overrate their character. It's well replicated, though weaker in some cultures than in others.

**Ross (1977)** · *Strong: foundational and widely replicated*

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY

"What might be going on for them that I can't see?" "If I did this, what would my reason be?"



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

We know our own reasons and only see other people's actions. Try writing out their side, in their words. It's irritatingly effective.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder`

05

## Quick shortcuts can lead us astray.

The brain uses shortcuts to save time, and plenty are useful. Some lead to unfair judgments, like a first impression that colors everything after it, or one bad moment that outweighs ten good ones, or a quick guess about someone from their age or accent or looks or group. Everyone has these, and the trouble only starts when nobody notices them.

On day one, the new tenant left a box in the hall, just the one, for an afternoon. Tash decided there and then that he was messy, and every bit of mess after that was proof. Her own mug collection on the landing, eleven mugs at the last count, went entirely unseen, by her, though he saw it. He didn't say anything for months, which, when it finally came out, was its own small argument.

**Bad is stronger than good**

That's the real title of a wide review, which found that bad events, feedback and behavior usually hit harder and last longer than equally good ones. There are exceptions, but it explains how one box in the hall can outweigh months of tidiness.

**Baumeister and colleagues (2001)** · *Strong: a widely cited review; the pattern is accepted, with known exceptions*

06

## Everyone feels like the one who sees clearly.

Most of us feel we see things as they really are, and anyone who disagrees must be missing something. The other person feels exactly the same about you. Each of you can see the other's lens much more easily than your own.

Two brothers in their fifties argued, at their mom's eightieth, about how they'd been brought up. "I'm just being realistic," said one. "So am I," said the other. They were both right. Each was being entirely realistic about the childhood he had lived through, which turned out, when they finally compared notes in the parking lot, to have been quite a different childhood, in the same house, four years apart.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I think we're both seeing this from where we stand. Can you tell me how it looks from yours?"

07

## "Us" and "them" changes what we see.

People split into groups quickly, even over tiny things. We tend to see our own group as varied and full of individuals and other groups as all the same, and we give our own side the benefit of the doubt. Spending real time with people from the other group, as equals, is one of the best ways to soften this.

At one depot the night shift calls the day shift lazy and the day shift calls the night shift sloppy, and has done since before anyone can remember. Then there was a joint training day, with a bad buffet and a fire drill in the rain. By the afternoon people were using each other's names. It didn't fix everything, though the notes on the kettle stopped.

Have one real conversation this month with someone from a group you tend to see as "other," and ask about their day before you ask about their views.

08

## Ask, don't guess.

Imagining yourself in someone's shoes is a kind start, though research suggests it doesn't make us much more accurate about what they think, while asking does. A plain, curious question like "What was that like for you?" beats the cleverest guess.

Every Sunday Moira's grandson sat at her kitchen table glued to his phone, and every Sunday she decided a bit more firmly that he hated coming. One week she just asked. "Don't you like coming here, sweetie?" He looked up, horrified, with his thumb still on the screen. He'd been messaging a friend who was having a terrible time. He liked her house because it was calm, he said, and for the crumble. He wouldn't have mentioned the crumble if she hadn't asked. She makes two now, and sends one home with him in a tin she never gets back.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 3

**Chat analyzer**

*Zoe, texting her oldest friend, who moved abroad*

### Chat analyzer

Mode

*I'm about to send this* Someone sent me this

Type your sentence

*You always cancel on me last minute. Can we pick a time for a call on Sunday?*

Relationship

*Friends*

Channel

*Text / chat*

THE READ

**How it may land for most listeners**
Some words may hurt. How it may sound: sharp in places.

**What stands out**
The word “always” (words like “always” and “never” leave no room for the times it went fine).

**A clearer way to say it**
Lately it’s felt like you cancel on me last minute. Can we pick a time for a call on Sunday?

**What changed, and why**
“always” became “lately it’s felt like.” “Always” and “never” erase every exception, so the listener argues the exception.

*Made-up example. The ask stayed; only the word that would start an argument changed.*

Fill in your own: Chat analyzer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator)

THURSDAY, 12:20PM

*She’s in the canteen again. This time you go over and ask how her dad is. She tells you about the hospital and the waiting and the parking lot charges, which seem to be the thing she’s angriest about. You end up sharing a table until the end of the break. Your soup goes cold. You don’t mind.*

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

## Blunt feedback, two ways

Some people hear softening as part of the message and take a bare comment as a sign that something’s wrong between you. Others hear the softening as noise and want the point first, because a clear point is quicker to fix. If you like softening, “The

second half doesn't work" may be the most helpful thing that person can say, with no judgment of you in it. If you like it plain, adding one warm line for the other person costs very little and lets the point land.

**Where the fields meet.** Philosophy's habit of separating the fact from the guess is most of this chapter. Economics explains why the guess comes so fast: attention is a budget, and the brain saves it with shortcuts that are usually right and sometimes badly wrong.

## In everyday life

We tell stories about ourselves too, and "I always mess things up" is usually built from a few bright memories that leave a lot out. After years together, partners stop checking and start assuming. And "I know what you meant" can do a lot of quiet damage in a long relationship. Children get labeled early, the difficult one, the easy one, and the label becomes a lens that only sees what fits. With ADHD, attention gets pulled by whatever is new or urgent and can lock on hard, so someone may genuinely not have seen or heard. Get their attention first and put requests in writing. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-3-seeing-in-depth).

## Two memories of one evening, or gaslighting?

Two people often remember the same evening differently. Memory isn't a recording. Each person noticed and kept different parts, and stress, tiredness and strong feelings blur it further, so most "That's not what happened!" arguments are two honest memories. Gaslighting describes something much rarer, and the word does real harm when it's used for an ordinary disagreement.

For something to be gaslighting, these are usually all present:

- the same person denies, again and again, things the other person saw, heard or knows happened,
- they know it happened, so the denial is deliberate,
- the aim is to make the other person doubt their own memory or judgment in general,
- it usually gains them something, such as winning, avoiding blame or getting their way.

Not enough on its own:

- two people remembering it differently,
- someone misremembering, especially when tired, stressed or upset,
- disagreeing about what something meant,
- one heated "That never happened!" in the middle of a fight,
- "I don't think I meant it like that."

Ask whether it happens in both directions, and whether the conversation settles when you look at a message or a calendar. Then talk about what each of you remembers rather than the word itself. "I remember you saying Saturday. You remember Sunday. Can we check the message and plan from there?" keeps both memories in the room.

## Common mix-ups

Nobody sees things exactly as they are. Everyone sees through a lens, and knowing that is where fairness starts. Memory isn't a recording, either, since it gets rebuilt each time, so two honest people can remember the same evening differently and both be telling the truth. Giving someone the benefit of the doubt doesn't mean ignoring what happened. It means checking the story before you decide, and if something hurtful keeps happening, that matters. And a face or a tone is a clue to what someone meant. Faces and tones vary a lot between people and between cultures, so a face is a weaker clue than it feels.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Start with how they feel, and make sense of the feeling first, and only then wonder aloud whether there might be another way to see it. Offer information instead of verdicts. “I know she had a hard week” helps more than “You’re being unfair to her.” Check your own guesses out loud (“I assumed he was annoyed, I’ll ask”), which shows how it’s done. Be careful with labels for children and colleagues, because they stick and then shape what everyone sees. And believe people about their own experience. Seeing other angles never means telling someone that what happened to them didn’t happen.

> WORDS TO TRY
> “That sounds really hurtful. Do you know what was going on for them?”
> “It might be worth asking. Want to plan what to say?”

## Tools and reading on the website

**Tools** **helpers you use on the website**

- Rewind the talk: see their side (spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder): a free perspective-taking tool.
- Chat analyzer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator): how a sentence might land before you say it.

**Reading** **pages to read on the website**

- Wired differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently): how different minds hear the same words.
- Philosophy stories on seeing the other person (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth): the cave, the elephant, the fish and the empty boat.
- The library: the fundamental attribution error (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking), confirmation bias (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking#confirmation-bias), negativity bias (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking#negativity-bias), naive realism (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking#naive-realism), mind-reading (spreadloveandacceptance.com/

library/thinking#mind-reading) and how memory is rebuilt (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking#memory-reconstruction).

## More for your situation

- Back: Stress and the nervous system (page 28) · Next: How communication works (page 57)
- Part One, Then: where your lens came from (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-1-then)
- Part Two, Chapter III: full tanks and different angles
- Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts), Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting) and For grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children)
- Communication between different minds (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) and For parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents)
- Everything on the site (spreadloveandacceptance.com/contents) · Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part One · Then · Where your lens came from**
*Where your lens came from*
read online

**Preface to Part Two · The work nobody sees**
*Why the other person doesn't see the work*
read online

**Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles**
*Seven angles on the same moment*
read online

**Part Three · Chapter 17 · Groups, influence and culture**
*Us and them, and the stories groups tell*
page 245

PUT IT TO USE

**Rewind the talk: see their side**
A free perspective-taking tool
spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

**Chat analyzer**
How a sentence might land before you say it
spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

# 4

PART THREE · CHAPTER 4

# How communication works: meaning, listening, repair and messages

*Talking feels simple because we do it all day, yet every message has to travel from one mind to another, and a lot can change on the way. This chapter follows that journey and looks at what helps a message arrive the way you meant it.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Meaning is made between two people
2. Every message says two things
3. Listening is something you do
4. Check, don't guess
5. Hard things land better when they start soft
6. Mix-ups are normal. Repair is the skill
7. Messages lose their tone on the way
8. Different styles aren't wrong styles
9. Small talk has a job, and it can be short
10. In everyday life
11. Going quiet can mean very different things
12. When the past joins the conversation
13. Common mix-ups
14. If you want to help someone else with this
15. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
16. More for your situation


AT A GLANCE

- **Meaning is made between two people.** What you say and what they hear can differ without either of you being wrong.
- **Every message says two things**, the words themselves and what they seem to say about the two of you.
- **A short question saves a long misunderstanding**, so check before you guess.

- **Mix-ups are normal, and repairing them is the skill.** Small talk is allowed to be short.

THURSDAY, 8:15AM

*Ana texts her brother. Can you call me when you're free?*

*She means no rush, small question about the weekend. He reads it at the back of the 8:10 bus, and for eleven stops, past the hospital, which doesn't help, he works out who is ill.*

Small habits help a message arrive. Listening, checking, starting softly, mending quickly. A few ready-made lines make small talk easier for anyone who dreads it. And three tools elsewhere lean on this chapter. Say it so it lands (Part Two, Chapter IV, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4) asks for what happened, how you feel and one clear request, because every message carries a second message about the relationship. The 90-second daily check-in (Part Two, Chapter I, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-1) keeps repairs small and frequent. And the Chat analyzer's whole-conversation view shows where a written conversation lost its tone.

A text with no kisses, in quick strokes. On the surface, three words. Underneath, the tone the reader added. Underneath that, what it seemed to say about the two of you. The roots are signal and noise, and feedback loops, since every reply changes the next one. The chapter slows down from here.

01

## Meaning is made between two people.

Words don't carry meaning on their own. The speaker has a meaning in mind, and the listener builds their own from the words, the tone, the timing and everything they already expect. Most of the time the two match well enough. Sometimes they don't, and neither person can see the gap from where they're standing.

"Let's chat tomorrow," the manager wrote to the new starter at ten to five, meaning a friendly catch-up and possibly a cookie. The new starter went home and reread his last three emails looking for the mistake. He found two, neither of which existed. In the morning there was a cookie, which he

couldn't face. The sentence that would have saved him an evening is a dull one, "I think what you meant and what I heard might be two different things. Can we check?"

02

## Every message says two things.

There is *what* you say, and there is what it says about the two of you. "You're late" is a fact about time, though it can also mean "I was worried" or "I don't matter to you." People argue about the fact when the hurt is in the second layer.

I take one eight-word sentence apart on the website's About page: "don't worry about it, I'll sort it out." Said kindly, in passing, it's reassurance. Said for the third time that month about the same job, it also says a job has no owner and a decision has been put off again, and both of those are in the same eight words.

Or take Tomasz, who wants to know whether his roommate used his good pan. On the surface it's a question about a pan. Underneath, it's a question about whether his things are respected in this house, and no amount of talk about the pan is going to settle that. "Honestly," he said in the end, "I don't care about the pan." His roommate, who had in fact used the pan, washed it and put it back in the wrong cupboard, looked baffled. "Then why have we been talking about it for ten minutes?"

**Content and relationship**

Watzlawick and colleagues made this one of their axioms of communication: every message has a content level and a relationship level, and the relationship level often decides how the content is heard. It's a framework rather than an experiment, and a remarkably durable one.

**Watzlawick, Beavin and Jackson (1967)** · *Theory: influential in communication and family therapy*

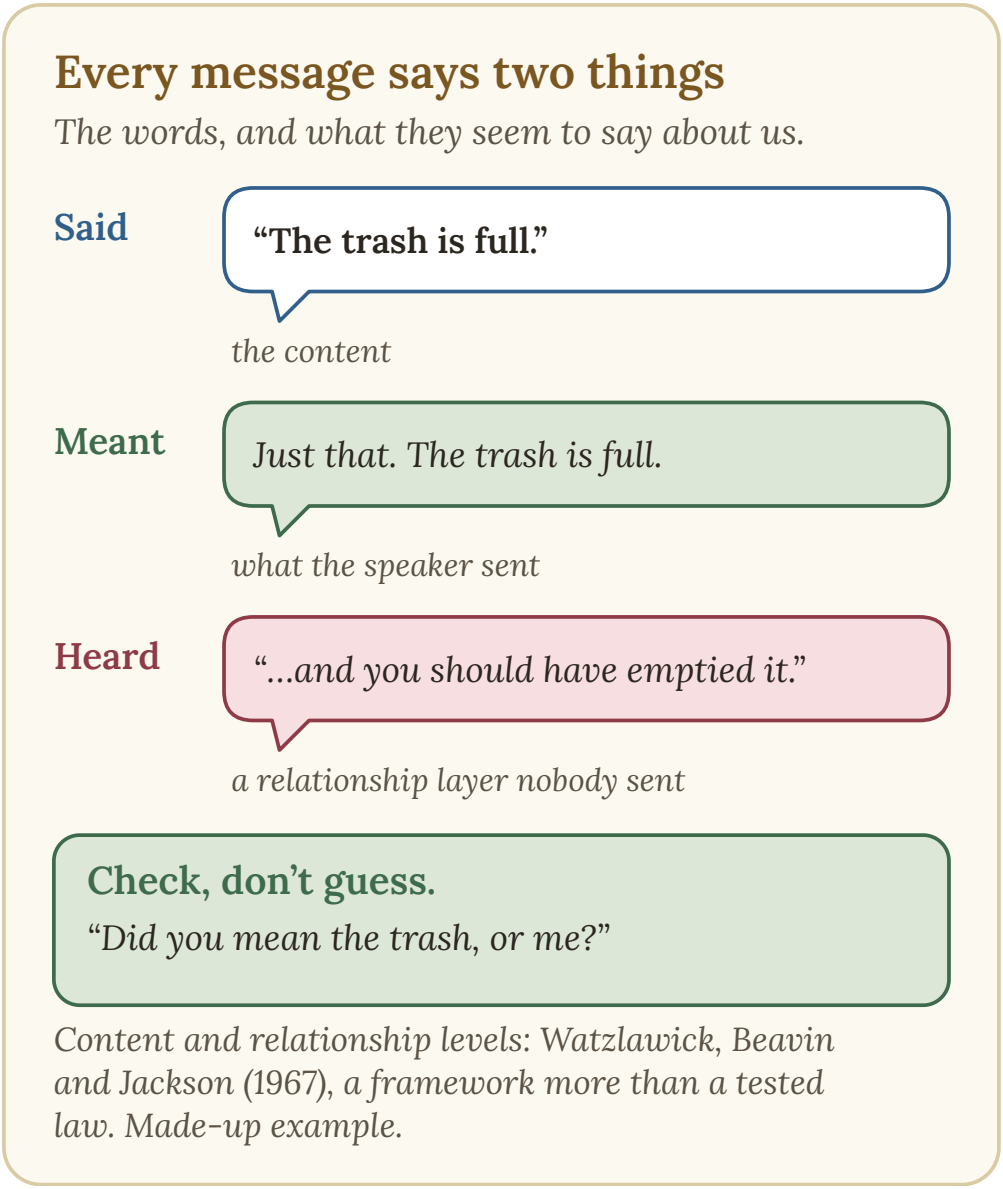



FIGURE 7 Every message says two things: the words, and what they seem to say about the two of you. Check, don’t guess.

03

## Listening is something you do.

Hearing happens by itself. Listening is a choice, and most of us do a lot of it partly in order to reply. To fix, or defend, or advise, or tell our own story. Real listening means following what the other person is trying to say, and letting them know you got it, before you add anything of yours.

"School is pointless," Mollie announced, thirteen, coat still on. Her dad started explaining, at some length and with examples, why it wasn't. She stopped talking and went upstairs, and the door shut harder than it strictly needed to. The next time she said it, a week later, he bit his tongue, hard. "Pointless how?" he said. "Tell me about today." She talked for twenty minutes, mostly about a supply teacher and a seating plan, and he said almost nothing, which nearly killed him.

04

## Check, don't guess.

Once we know something it's very hard to imagine not knowing it, so we leave out steps, assume the other person can tell what we mean, and guess what they meant instead of asking. We do it most with the people we know best, which is unfortunate, because they're the ones we most want to get it right with. A short check costs you a sentence, whereas a wrong guess can cost a whole evening.

"Something low-key," they agreed, for Fliss's fortieth. Fliss pictured a Chinese takeout on the couch, in pajamas, with the good crackers. Her best friend booked a quiet table at the Italian, ironed a shirt, and turned up at seven with flowers. Fliss opened the door in her pajamas, and for a second they just looked at each other, both disappointed, both having thought it was obvious. They ate the takeout in the end, the friend in her ironed shirt, and it was a good night, eventually.

**Closeness makes us lazy listeners**

In three small experiments, people overestimated how well they got through to friends and spouses even more than to strangers. Closeness seemed to switch off the checking we do without thinking with people we don't know.

**Savitsky and colleagues (2011)** · *Moderate: three small experiments, extended in later work*



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Checking what someone meant takes ten seconds and can save a whole evening. When you're ready to reply, this workpaper helps.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09

05

## Hard things land better when they start soft.

How a hard conversation starts often decides how it ends. A complaint about one thing ("The trash wasn't taken out") is easier to hear than a criticism of the person ("You never help"). A simple shape works for most hard things, which is to say what happened, how you feel and what you would like.

A woman wants her eighty-one-year-old father to stop driving at night. She has "You're not safe anymore" on the tip of her tongue. She leaves it there and says, "You had two near-misses last month and I lie awake worrying. Could I drive us in the evenings?" He says he'll think about it, which in his language is nearly a yes.

## Say it so it lands

*A simple shape for most hard things.*

**What happened**
One specific fact, not a verdict.
*"The trash didn't go out on Tuesday."*

**How I feel**
Your feeling, in a word or two.
*"I felt let down, because I'd asked."*

**What I'd like**
A small, doable ask.
*"Could you set a reminder for next week?"*

✕ **Not: "You never help."**
*That's about the person, so it starts a defense.*

*This book's plain-language shape, a cousin of I-messages and Nonviolent Communication; research on such scripts is mixed, and tone matters most.*

FIGURE 8 Say it so it lands: what happened, how I feel, what I'd like. A complaint about an action can be heard. A criticism of the person starts a defense.

06

## Mix-ups are normal. Repair is the skill.

Even close, kind people misunderstand each other constantly, several times a day if you're counting, and what keeps a relationship steady is noticing it and fixing it rather than never doing it. "That came out wrong." "Can we start again?" Small repairs made often build trust much faster than big apologies made rarely.

"Excuse *me*!" a woman snaps in the supermarket, because your cart is blocking the cans. "I'm *moving*," you snap back. A second later you hear yourself add, "Sorry. Long day." And she sags a bit and says hers has been too, and somehow you end up talking about the price of coffee for five minutes by the chopped tomatoes.



SUGARFOOT

A mix-up isn't the end of anything. Come back, sit close, and go through it a step at a time.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

07

## Messages lose their tone on the way.

A text or email carries the words without your face or your voice, so the reader fills in the tone with however *they* feel right now. A tired reader hears a tired, cross message. Short replies, missing greetings and late-night timing all get read as meaning something.

In the group chat for the school summer fair, somebody proposes the tombola goes by the gate. One parent replies, "Fine." Period and everything. Within four minutes two other parents have privately decided she's furious and started composing careful messages. She was stirring a pan of soup, typing with one thumb, and genuinely thought it was fine.

**The period problem**

In one study with students, short text replies ending in a period were rated less sincere than the same replies without one, while handwritten notes showed no such effect. Later work suggests it fades with longer messages, so this one is early days.

**Gunraj and colleagues (2016)** · *Early: one study with students*

Before you send your next tricky message, read it out loud in the grumpiest voice you can manage. If it sounds harsh, add a warm word. This is my favorite test in the whole book, and it takes four seconds.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 4

**Chat analyzer: a whole conversation**

*Dana and Raj, coworkers on the same project*

### Chat analyzer: paste a conversation

#### 01 Paste the conversation

*Dana: Did the slides go to the client?*
*Raj: Not yet, still waiting on the numbers from finance*
*Dana: I needed them by 10. This always happens.*
*Raj: I can't make finance go faster.*
*Dana: Forget it. I'll do it myself.*

02 Which one is you?

*Dana (3 messages)* Raj (2 messages)

03 THE READ

**What happened**

Ends shut down. 5 messages: 3 from you, 2 from Raj. The words don't make it clear what it's mostly about, so the Reader won't guess. It starts calm. There's no one big turn, but some tension creeps in. By the end someone has pulled back. That isn't the same as calm: it can mean they're overwhelmed, or hurt.

**Your part · always / never**

I said "This always happens," and that isn't fair: it isn't every time. What I meant was: [one recent time, and how it felt].

### 04 Check your reply before you send it

Your reply

*Sorry, that last line wasn't fair. When the numbers weren't in by 10, I felt worried about the client. Could you ask finance for them by 9 next time? I'll chase them with you.*

THE CHECK

✓ Says what you need or how it landed · ✓ Makes one clear ask · ✓ No verdicts, always/never, dismissals, sarcasm, shots, comparisons or shutting the door · ✓ Stays on one topic

Nothing in the wording is likely to add heat. Read it once more as if you were them, then send it when you're calm.

*Made-up example. The Reader looks at one side's part without blaming anyone.*

Fill in your own: Chat analyzer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator)

08

## Different styles aren't wrong styles.

Some people say exactly what they mean. Others hint, and expect you to read between the lines. Some talk fast and overlap, and others need a pause to think. Families and cultures and different kinds of mind all shape this, and a clash between two styles is usually a translation problem, with nobody being difficult on purpose.

"Is the report ready?" "No. I need two more days." Her manager heard that as rude, for about a month, until he decided to ask what she meant, over a coffee he didn't want. She said she'd rather tell him the truth plainly than make him guess, and that where she grew up a straight answer was the polite one. After that he started finding her clarity a relief, and then, slightly to his surprise, a model.

WORDS TO TRY

"I'm quite direct, so if I sound blunt, it doesn't mean I'm upset." "It helps me if you say exactly what you need."

09

## Small talk has a job, and it can be short.

Small talk ("Cold today, isn't it?" "Busy weekend?") isn't really about the weather. Its job is to say that you see the other person and that the two of you are okay. In 1923 the anthropologist Bronisław Malinowski called this "phatic communion," talk whose main purpose is bonding more than information. Small moments like this matter more than people expect. Sandstrom and Dunn (2014) found that people who had a short, friendly exchange with a coffee-shop barista felt more belonging and a better mood than people who kept it purely efficient.

Small talk is hard work for many people, though, including many autistic people, shy or anxious people and people speaking a second language. The rules are unwritten, and it uses energy that some people would rather keep. A few ready-made lines, sometimes called social scripts, take the guesswork out, and keeping it short is allowed. For what it's worth, this is the part I had to learn on purpose.

Phil dreads school pickup. He has three lines ready, a "Morning! How's your week going?" an "Oh, nice" and a "Right, I'd better get going, see you Friday." Some mornings he still sits in the car with the radio on until the bell rings. Most days he gets through it. One of the other dads now saves him a spot by the fence, and has never once asked him how his week is going, which Phil appreciates more than he can say.

YOU COULD SAY

"Morning! How's your week been?" "How do you know Nico?" "Oh, how was that?" "Great to see you. I'd better get going." And to opt out kindly, "I'm not great at chit-chat, but it's really nice to see you."

THURSDAY, 9:02AM

*He calls the second he's off the bus. "Who's ill?"*

*"Nobody! I wanted to know if you're free Saturday. Dresser."*

*He laughs, a bit shakily, and says he'll bring the van. The week after, her text says, No rush and nothing's wrong!! Quick q about Sat, call when free.*

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

### A message, two ways

For some people, “Fine.” with a period is just fine. For others it reads as a door being shut. Some people say exactly what they mean and hear exactly what’s said. Others wrap a request in a hint and expect it to be found. If you’re literal, the hint is a real request in soft packaging. If you hint, the literal person isn’t ignoring you. They need the ask said out loud.

**Where the fields meet.** Psychology’s short version is that intent isn’t impact. The art of debating adds a habit that works at a kitchen table as well as in a debate: say the strongest version of their point back before you answer, and the disagreement turns into a shared problem.

## In everyday life

### On your own: how you talk to yourself

You send yourself messages all day, from “Typical, I always mess this up” to “That was hard and I handled it.” The same things apply. Notice the tone, check whether it’s fair, and mend it when it’s harsh. Catch one harsh sentence you say to yourself today and rewrite it the way you’d say it to someone you like.

### With other people

Between partners, “We never go out anymore” sounds like a complaint about evenings, and underneath it may mean “I miss you,” so answering that layer goes further than defending the calendar. “Stop that!” tells a child what not to do without saying what to do instead. “Feet on the floor, please” is easier to follow. In meetings, silence gets taken as agreement until a quieter colleague says afterward that she never agreed, and a round of “Anyone see it

differently?" catches that early. "Are you eating properly?" is care in one generation's language and checking up in another's.

- **Feedback at work.** Talk about the work rather than the person, with one recent example of what good looks like. Then ask, "What's been getting in the way?" When you're the one receiving it, "Thanks. Can I think about it and come back tomorrow?" is a fine first answer. The full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-4-communication-in-depth) walks through a whole performance conversation.

## Going quiet can mean very different things.

When someone stops talking in an argument, it might be a shutdown, a need for space or the silent treatment, and from outside they can look the same. A shutdown happens when a person is flooded or overloaded and words go offline for a while. Autistic young people in Phung and colleagues (2021) described shutdowns as something that happens to them, separate from choosing to withdraw. Needing space is a choice to pause so the talk can go better later.

For something to be the silent treatment, sometimes called stonewalling, these are usually all present:

- the silence is used as a message or a penalty,
- it lasts well beyond the argument, often for days,
- it ends only when the other person gives in or apologizes,
- there's no offer of a time to come back, and it's often aimed at one person while everyone else gets warmth.

Not enough on its own:

- going quiet when flooded or overloaded,
- asking for a break, even an abrupt one,
- needing time to think before speaking,
- a quieter person's normal pace.

One pattern is very common and nobody's villainy. One person pushes to talk and the other pulls back, and each move makes the other stronger. A large review by Schrodt and colleagues (2014) linked this push-and-pull pattern with less satisfaction for both people, whichever role they played. If you're the quiet one, a short line keeps the door open: "I can't talk yet. I'm not punishing you. Give me an hour." If you're waiting, "Take your time. Can you tell me when?" asks for a time without putting a label on the pause.

## When the past joins the conversation

Sometimes the size of a reaction belongs to an older moment. A raised voice can sound like a parent's, and a closed door can feel like being shut out again. From outside you can't know someone's history, and guessing out loud ("This is about your dad") usually makes things worse. What you can notice is the shape. The reaction is much bigger than the moment, the voice or face changes suddenly, or the person wants to leave or freezes.

You can't calm someone down by telling them to calm down. You can change what you bring to the moment, and all of these are within your control:

- Your pace. Slow down and use fewer words.
- Your tone. Lower your voice and soften the volume.
- Your body. Sit down if you're standing, unclench your hands, and breathe out slowly. Slow breathing tends to calm the body (Zaccaro and colleagues, 2018 · Moderate evidence).
- Space. Give the other person room, and don't block a doorway or follow them.
- Your words. Name what you see without blame ("This feels big. Let's slow down."). Putting feelings into words can turn them down a notch (Lieberman and colleagues, 2007 · Moderate evidence).
- Timing. Agree to come back at a set time rather than pushing on.
- Stepping away and coming back. "I'm going to step out for twenty minutes, and I'll come back to this at seven." Then come back at seven.

The same list works when the big reaction is yours.

## Common mix-ups

"If they loved me, they'd just know" is the big one. Closeness makes us check *less* without making us understand any more, so saying it clearly is a kindness, and no test of love. Listening isn't agreeing, either, because you can understand someone completely and still see it differently, and the understanding comes first. A repair doesn't mean you're confessing to being the bad one. It just says that didn't go the way you wanted, and either person can make one. And texts feel safer for hard things because they're easier to send. They're also much easier to misread, so for anything tender, add warmth, or call.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Maybe a friend keeps having the same argument with their partner, or your teenager feels nobody listens. You can't talk for them. You can be the one person who really hears them, without fixing, which is often the most useful thing anyone does all week. You can help them pull the two layers apart, by asking what it was about and then what it seemed to say about the two of them. You can offer the simple shape (what happened, how they feel, what they'd like) and let them find their own words. And stay out of judging the other person's character, since you only hear one side and they may make up next week. **Notice if it's more than a mix-up.**

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "Do you want me to just listen, or help you think about what to say?"

## Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Try one of these this week with one real conversation. Say it so it lands (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-09-say-it-so-it-lands) helps you shape a hard sentence, Rewind the talk (spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder) walks you back through a talk that went wrong, and the wiring card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card) puts how you communicate on one page.

**Tools** **helpers you use on the website**

- Chat analyzer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator): calm replies after a fight.
- Communication style quiz (spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz): a playful look at your own style.

**Reading** **pages to read on the website**

- Effective communication (spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication): the site's complete, plain guide, from listening and timing to hard talks, repair and each kind of relationship.
- Check-ins (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins): how to hold a hard conversation kindly.
- Why we get out of tune looks at the same ideas at home.

## More for your situation

- At work: messages and meetings (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) and for parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents)
- Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting)
- Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)
- Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance)
- Two faiths or cultures, one family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths)
- Neurodivergent relationships: communication (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- Find it by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part Two · Chapter I · Why we get out of tune**
*Pace, tone and getting back in tune*
read online

**Part Two · Chapter IV · Two kinds of fair**
*Letting a comment land*
read online

**Part Three · Chapter 11 · Healing after hurt**
*Repair after it goes wrong*
page 161

**Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words**
*How you like to be spoken to*
read online

PUT IT TO USE

**Chat analyzer**
Calm replies after a fight
spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

**Communication style quiz**
A playful look at your own style
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

5

PART THREE · CHAPTER 5

# Attachment, trust and belonging

*Why we need each other, how the bonds we had early on shape what we expect today, and how trust and belonging are built and lost and built again, one small moment at a time.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Belonging is a basic need
2. Early bonds teach us what to expect
3. Patterns, not boxes
4. Trust is built in small moments
5. Feeling safe with someone calms the body
6. Fitting in isn't the same as belonging
7. When trust breaks, rebuilding takes time
8. You can start building connection from wherever you are
9. If you're a teenager
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. Reading on this site
14. More for your situation


AT A GLANCE

- **Belonging is a basic need.** Feeling lonely or left out is a signal, like hunger.
- **Early bonds set expectations that can change.** What we learned about being cared for can soften over time.
- **Trust grows in small moments.** Doing what you said, again and again, matters more than big gestures.
- **You can start small**, with one friendly exchange or one kept promise.

SUNDAY, 9:30PM

*Kai sent his friend a long message at lunchtime. Four paragraphs about the new job, and a question at the end. It says Read 12:47, and there's nothing after that.*

*By dinnertime he's gone from "she's busy" to "she's annoyed." By nine thirty he's wondering whether anybody really likes him at all. The friend, meanwhile, is at her nephew's sixth birthday at an indoor play place in Columbus, and her phone is in her coat pocket under nineteen other coats.*

Two tools elsewhere rest on this chapter. One owner per job (Part Two, Chapter II, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2) works because trust is built from small promises kept, and a named owner turns "someone will probably do it" into a promise people can rely on. The monthly look-back (Part Two, Chapter V, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-5) looks at the month and keeps both people out of the dock, because feeling safe is what lets anyone say what went wrong.

Quickly, then slowly. On the surface, a message that hasn't been answered. Underneath, an old expectation about whether people come back. Underneath that, a body that has been on its own too much. The roots are state and setting, and feedback loops, since trust grows in small repeated moments. The chapter takes them in order.

01

## Belonging is a basic need.

People need to feel connected, the way we need food and sleep. When we feel left out it can hurt in a way that feels almost physical (Naomi Eisenberger and colleagues, 2003). That hurt works like hunger, pushing you to reach for someone.

Rhea moved to Pittsburgh for work. She's busy and doing well and likes the job. And by the third month she's low and teary every Sunday afternoon, when the office is shut and nobody in the whole city knows her well enough to call. She found this embarrassing for a while, and told her mom on the phone that she was "just tired." Then she joined a running club, which she hated, and a bar trivia team, which she loved.

**Friendship takes hours**

Studies of adults who had recently moved found that more time together, especially relaxed time, went with moving from acquaintance to friend. The hour counts are rough. The message isn't: friendship is mostly built out of time spent.

**Hall (2019)** · *Moderate: survey studies; the hour estimates are rough*

02

## Early bonds teach us what to expect.

As children we learn, from the people who looked after us, whether others will come when we need them. If help usually came, we tend to expect it. If it came sometimes, or rarely, we may learn to cling harder, or stop asking. These lessons are a starting point that later relationships can change. This is the idea of attachment, first described by John Bowlby (1969) and studied by Mary Ainsworth and colleagues (1978).

Watch a toddler at the park. He runs off toward the ducks, then runs back to check his grandma is still on the bench, then off again, a bit further, and back, and further still, right to the edge of the pond, where he stands and shouts at a goose. He gets braver every time, because he knows exactly where she is. If you're the one on the bench, "I'm right here, go and look, come back whenever you want" is more or less the whole job.

03

## Patterns, not boxes.

As adults, some of us worry a lot about being left, and reach out more when we feel unsure. Some of us pull back when things get close and need more room. Many of us feel mostly secure. Most of us mix all three, depending on the day and the person.

These are patterns that can soften and change, especially in steady, kind relationships. Cindy Hazan and Phillip Shaver (1987) first described them in adults, and later work, such as R. Chris Fraley and colleagues (2015), suggests they work as sliding scales.

When things get tense, Ronan wants to talk it through, now, immediately. His wife Clara needs to go quiet first, usually in the yard, usually with the pruning shears. He reads her quiet as her leaving, and she reads his questions through the back door as pressure. It took them nine years to see it. Now she says "I need an hour, and I'm coming back," and he waits, which for about the first month he found almost unbearable.

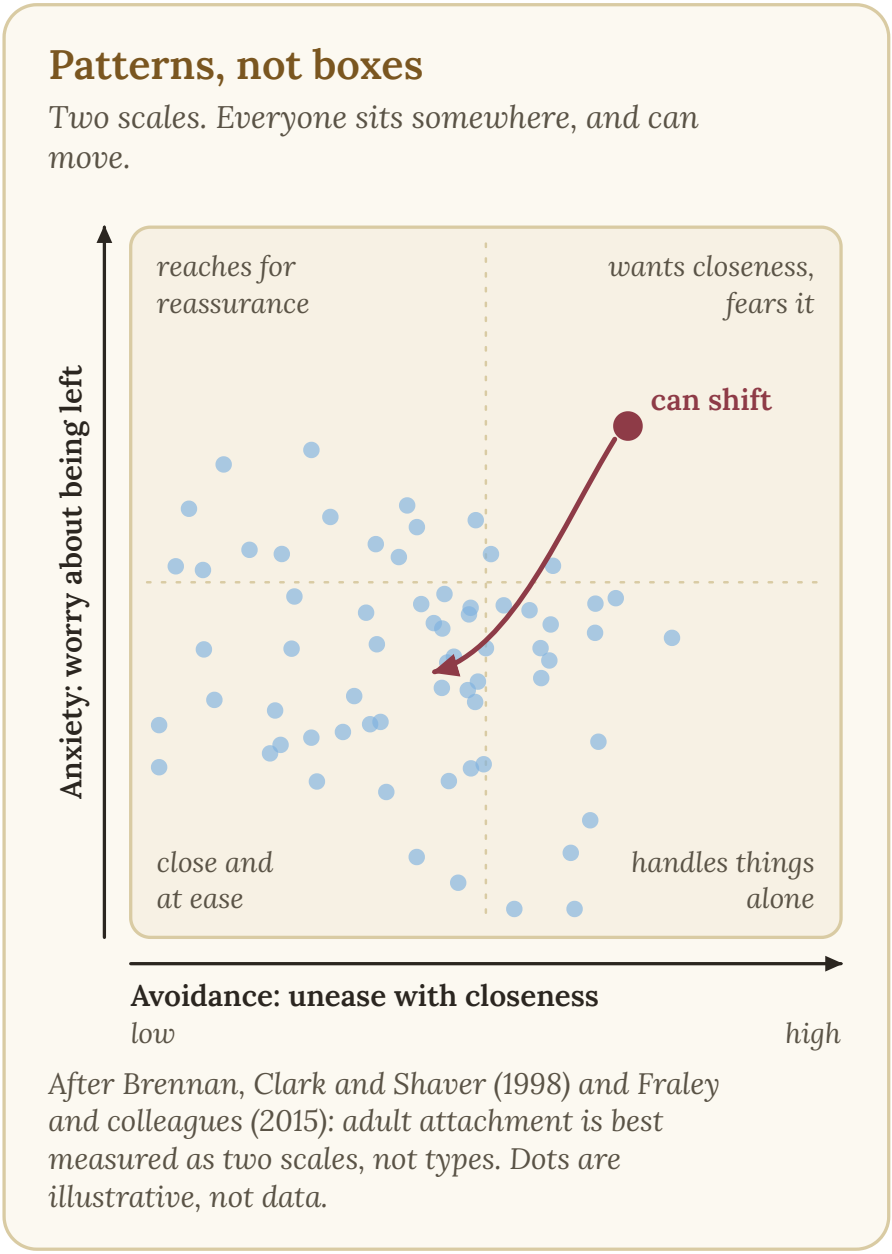



FIGURE 9 Attachment as two scales, not four boxes: worry about being left, and unease with closeness. Everyone sits somewhere, and can move. Dots are illustrative.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 5

**Our pause plan**

*Imani and Kwame, married ten years*

## Our pause plan

Fill this out together on a calm day, or fill it out yourself and send it to your partner to change.

Our pause word or sentence

*"Pause. I'll be back at ...," with a hand on the heart*

Shortest break, so our bodies can settle

*30 minutes*

Whoever pauses names a clock time to come back, no later than

*the same evening*

If one of us can't come back on time

*Send one text with a new time. No silence.*

The first sentence when we come back

*"I'm back. You first: what do you most want me to hear?"*

YOUR PLAN, READY TO SEND

Our pause plan

Pause word: “Pause. I’ll be back at …,” with a hand on the heart

Shortest break: 30 minutes

Return time: whoever pauses names a clock time, no later than the same evening

If one of us can’t come back on time: Send one text with a new time. No silence.

When we come back, we start with: “I’m back. You first: what do you most want me to hear?”

*Made-up example. For relationships where everyone feels safe.*

Fill in your own: Our pause plan (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw)

04

## Trust is built in small moments.

Trust rarely comes from big gestures. It grows from small, ordinary things done again and again, like doing what you said, and being the same person on a hard day as on a good one. Honestly, it’s a bit boring, which is probably why it works.

The new starter said she’d send the figures by Thursday, and she did. The following week she warned on Monday that something would be late on Friday. By the third month her manager trusted her completely, and if you’d asked him when that happened he couldn’t have told you. It hadn’t happened at any one moment, more like in forty small ones.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Trust grows in small moments that repeat. This workpaper helps you notice the little rituals you already have, and keep them going.

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-15

05

## Feeling safe with someone calms the body.

Being with someone we trust can settle the nervous system. In one study, holding a trusted partner's hand calmed the brain's response to threat (James Coan and colleagues, 2006). A calm voice, a hand to hold, or just someone nearby can make a hard moment easier to bear. It works both ways, so we can be that for other people, often without saying much.

After his panic attack, Kieran's friend didn't try to fix anything. He sat down next to him on the cold step outside the apartments. "Take your time. I'm here." Then nothing else, for about twenty minutes, while a man walked past twice with a very small dog. Eventually Kieran's breathing slowed, and he noticed how cold the step was. "Thanks," he said. "Any time," said his friend, and meant it.

Notice who helps you feel calmer, and tell them. "I always feel better after seeing you" is a lovely thing to hear, and almost nobody says it.

06

## Fitting in isn't the same as belonging.

Fitting in means changing yourself to be accepted. Belonging means being accepted as you are. Teams, families, clubs and communities can offer either. Being left out of a group hurts even when the group doesn't matter much to us, and real belonging grows where people feel safe to be themselves and to speak up.

At her new job Ola laughs at jokes she doesn't find funny. She orders a club soda with lime "for the drive," every Friday, so nobody asks why she doesn't drink. She goes home wiped out. At her book club, in the back room of the library on alternate Tuesdays, she says exactly what she thought of the book, which last month was "I hated every single character," and someone said, "Oh, thank God," and they talked till the caretaker turned the lights off.

> YOU COULD SAY
> (in a group) "I see it a bit differently. Is it okay if I say why?" "Has everyone had a chance to say something?"

07

## When trust breaks, rebuilding takes time.

When someone lets us down badly, trust doesn't come back with one apology. It comes back slowly, as words are matched by actions over time. The person who broke trust can own what happened and be patient. The person who was hurt can decide, at their own pace, whether and how much to trust again.

At Sunday dinner, for a laugh, Jen told the whole table a story her sister had told her in confidence. Nobody else at the table thought it was a big deal, but her sister left before dessert. The apology, two days later, was a start. What actually rebuilt things was the months after, when the story never came up again, and Jen started checking before she told anyone anything. "Can I mention the thing about work?" "No." "Okay."

08

## You can start building connection from wherever you are.

If you feel alone right now, big friendships can seem a long way off. Belonging can start far smaller than that. A chat with a neighbor. A regular class. An online group about something you love. Even small, light contact with people we barely know can lift our mood (Gillian Sandstrom and Elizabeth Dunn, 2014).

After his divorce, Martin started saying more than "thanks" to the man at the coffee stall outside the station. It was the weather, at first. A few weeks later they were talking football every morning, mostly about the Eagles' defense, which they agree about entirely. It's a small friendship, and it makes Mondays bearable. Small rituals like that are worth keeping going on purpose, and Keep your little rituals alive (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-15-keep-your-little-rituals-alive) helps you notice the ones you already have.

**We underestimate strangers**

Commuters asked to talk to a stranger on their train or bus had a better journey than those told to keep to themselves, even though most people predicted the opposite. Misjudging how pleasant it will be is part of what keeps people apart.

**Epley and Schroeder (2014)** · *Moderate: field and lab experiments, replicated since*



TIDBIT

One small hello is a fine start. If you can't think of one, there's a tool that picks one for you.

TOOL **Stay close: one small idea** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

MONDAY, 8:10AM

*SO sorry, phone was in my coat all day, soft play hell. LOVED your message. Coffee Thursday?*

*Kai reads it twice. He thinks about how far last night's story got, all on its own, with no help from anybody. Next time a reply is slow, he decides, he'll send something light, no rush, just thinking of you, and leave it at that.*

## If you're a teenager

Ezra is sixteen when he sees a photo of his three closest friends at the movies and finds out there's a group chat he isn't in. It hurts like being punched, because being left out really does register a bit like pain. He drafts something sharp, deletes it, and messages one friend instead, saying he's a little hurt not to be asked and was it something he did. It turns out they thought he'd be at football. One of the friendships really is drifting, though, and that's allowed to hurt too.

WORDS TO TRY

"Kind of bummed not to be asked. Did something happen?" "I'd like to come next time, even if I can't always make it." "I miss how we used to be. Are we okay?"

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

### Going quiet, two ways

In an argument, some people need to keep talking until it feels settled, and silence feels like being shut out. Others flood fast, and going quiet is how they stop words they'd regret. If you need

to talk it through, their silence is usually a brake, not a punishment. If you go quiet, a short line ("I need ten minutes, then I'll come back") tells the other person the door is still open.

**Where the fields meet.** Holistic therapies start with the body, and belonging is felt there first: a calmer breath beside someone safe. Some of these practices are well studied and some are debated. Laughter belongs here too, since a shared laugh tells the body it's among friends. The research on laughter is still growing, so it's offered as a small thing.

## In everyday life

When one partner texts a lot while apart and the other forgets, agreeing on one goodnight message can keep both feeling connected. A child who acts up at pick-up may simply be letting go of a long day with the safest person they know. A friend who keeps canceling may be overwhelmed, and "Is it easier if we do something short?" keeps the door open. At work, a team where mistakes can be owned without blame builds trust faster than one where everyone hides them. And in a shared house, one simple weekly meal can turn people who share a kitchen into people who look out for each other. Stay close (spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding) has small ideas if you're stuck for one.

### On your own: belonging with yourself

Belonging includes how you treat yourself. If you're kind to yourself on a bad day, you carry a small safe base wherever you go, and people who can comfort themselves often find it easier to let others in, because they're less afraid of being let down. You're allowed to need people. A lonely day is hard. It isn't a forecast. On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own) has more for people living alone.

## Common mix-ups

"Needing people means I'm needy" is the one people say most quietly. Everyone needs connection, including the people who hide it well. Attachment style isn't fixed for life, either, and patterns can change, especially through steady, kind relationships and a bit of reflection. And forgiving isn't the same as trusting again right away. Trust can return slowly, or not at all, and that's your call.

- **"Jealousy and checking up show how much they love me."** Jealousy is a common feeling, and asking for reassurance ("Are we okay?") is ordinary, especially for people who feel rejection keenly, which Downey and Feldman (1996) called rejection sensitivity. A worried text is a feeling looking for comfort. Checking someone's phone without asking, needing to know where they are all day, or deciding who they can see is a different thing, whatever feeling sits underneath it. The question to ask is whether the request leaves the other person free to say no.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Be steady, and turn up when you said you would, which matters more than any big gesture. If someone says they feel alone, listen before you remind them how many friends they have. Invite, and keep inviting. People who feel left out may say no a few times, and a warm invitation with no pressure still counts every time. In groups, notice who's on the edge and ask what they think. And leave the labels out. Telling someone they're "so avoidant" or "so clingy" has never helped anyone, as far as I can tell. "What would help?" often does.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I'm here, and I'm not going anywhere." "We're having a few people over on Friday. No pressure, but I'd love you to come."

## Reading on the website

Pick one small way to turn toward someone this week. Turning toward (spreadloveandacceptance.com/turning-toward), When one talks and one goes quiet (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw) and How to apologize so it counts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages) have more ideas.

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Bonding: how closeness grows: what research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family, coworkers and you.
- Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends): when a friendship drifts, and how to reach out.
- The languages of connection (spreadloveandacceptance.com/languages-of-connection): the different ways people show care.
- Complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency): why good things fade, and how to keep them alive.

## More for your situation

- On my own after a breakup
- Friends
- Parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) and foster, adoptive and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship)
- Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance)
- Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts)
- Coming out as an adult (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out)
- At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- Find it by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part One · Then · Where your lens came from**
*Early trust and the rules from home*
read online

**Part Three · Chapter 15 · Closeness and love**
*Being known, at every age*
page 218

**Part Three · Chapter 17 · Groups, influence and culture**
*Belonging to groups, and their pull*
page 245

**Part Three · Chapter 8 · Loss, grief and big life changes**
*When a bond is lost*
page 116

PUT IT TO USE



**Bonding: how closeness grows**
What research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family, coworkers and you
spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding



**Friends**
When a friendship drifts, and how to reach out
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends

# 6

PART THREE · CHAPTER 6

# Habits and change: why change is hard and how small steps work

*Why it's so hard to change, even when we really want to, and what actually helps: small steps, a kinder setup, patience with slips, and remembering that other people's change belongs to them.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Change is hard for good reasons
2. Habits run on cues
3. Start smaller than feels useful
4. Change the setup, not just your willpower
5. Being in two minds is normal
6. Slips are part of change
7. Change sticks when it fits who you want to be
8. You can support change, but not force it
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
13. More for your situation


AT A GLANCE

- **Change is hard for good reasons.** Habits save effort, so the old way is always the easy way.
- **A small step and a kind setup outlast willpower.** Make the first step tiny and change what is around you.
- **Slips are part of change.** A missed day tells you something about the plan and nothing about your character.
- **Other people's change is theirs.** You can support it, though you can't force it.

MONDAY, 7:05AM

*The plan was a walk before work. The sneakers are by the door. Somehow the phone is in your hand instead, and at 7:40 you are watching a man in Finland restore a rusty axe, next to a coffee that went cold twenty minutes ago. You don't even like axes.*

*By the evening a quiet voice is telling you that you never stick to anything. What you actually ran into this morning was a habit with about six years of practice behind it. It won, as it usually does for the first few rounds.*

This chapter is why several tools in these books are so small. One small step a week (Part One, Next, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next) starts smaller than feels useful and decides ahead of time. The setup score and One owner per job (Part Two, Chapter II, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2) change the setup instead of asking anyone for more willpower. And What keeps coming back? (Part Two, Chapter V, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-5) treats a repeat as information about the plan, because slips are an ordinary part of changing anything.

Quickly: a phone in your hand at 7:40 is the surface. Underneath, a habit with years of practice behind it. Underneath that, a setup that quietly makes the old way easier. The roots are feedback loops and quiet incentives. Then the chapter slows down and takes them one by one.

01

## Change is hard for good reasons.

A lot of what we do each day runs on autopilot. That saves energy, and it's the whole point of a habit. The catch is that the old way is always quicker and easier than the new one, so changing asks your brain to do something effortful again and again, for weeks, until the new way becomes the easy one.

Every night Jodie decides she will not snap at the children in the morning, and she means it. Every morning, somewhere between the lost reading book and the toast going cold and Lily's hair, she snaps. The morning has worn a groove deeper than her good intentions, which says something about mornings and not much about her as a mother.

Pick one thing you'd like to change, and write down when it usually happens, where, and what's going on just before.

02

## Habits run on cues.

Most habits have a trigger, which might be a time or a place or a feeling or a person, or simply the thing you've just done. The cue starts the routine, and some kind of reward (relief, comfort, a small buzz) keeps it going. Once you know the cue, you can plan for it.

Nigel noticed, eventually, that he reached for the cookie jar the moment he opened his laptop after dinner, hungry or not, every night, and the laptop was the cue. So now he makes tea before he opens it and makes a pot. By the time the tea's brewed the urge has mostly wandered off. On Fridays it doesn't wander anywhere and he has a custard cream, and that seems fair.

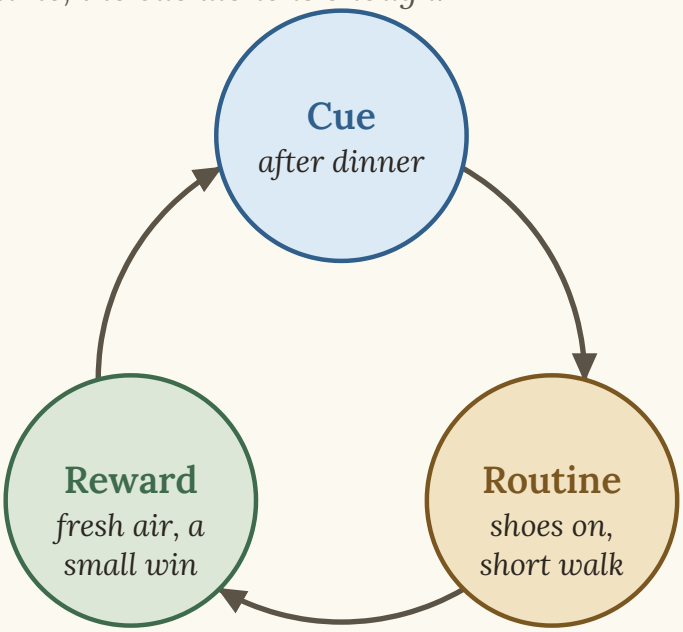
**Stale popcorn**

In one field experiment, people with a strong movie-popcorn habit ate stale popcorn about as much as fresh, but only in a movie theater. Somewhere else, they didn't. The setting drove the habit more than taste or good intentions did, rather like Nigel's laptop.

**Neal and colleagues (2011)** · *Moderate: two field experiments, in line with wider habit research*

## Habits run on cues

*Over time, the cue alone is enough.*




**Change the setup, not just your willpower:**
*move the cue, make the step tiny.*

*The cue, routine and reward loop is a popular simplification; the core idea, that context triggers habits, is well supported (for example Neal, Wood and colleagues, 2011).*

FIGURE 10 Habits run on cues. Over time the cue alone is enough, so change the setup, not just your willpower.

03

## Start smaller than feels useful.

Big goals are inspiring and easy to drop. Tiny steps feel almost silly, and they work precisely because they're easy enough to manage on a bad day. Tie the new step to something you already do ("After I make my coffee, I'll…"), and only grow it once it's stuck.

Two roommates had been promising each other a big Sunday clean of the kitchen since March. It had happened once, so they agreed something smaller. After dinner, each of them wipes one surface, which takes two minutes. By the second week the stove had stopped being a source of tension. By the fourth, someone had descaled the kettle without being asked, which caused a small sensation.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "Let's start with something tiny, and see if it sticks." "After I …, I will …"

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 6

**Your done list**

*Bernie, 71, living on his own*

### Your done list

Write down one small thing that went right, however small.

A small win

*Went to the Thursday quiz with Rita and Joe*

Who it was with

*With a friend*

THIS WEEK: 4 SMALL WINS

Went to the Thursday quiz with Rita and Joe · Thu, Oct 8 · With a friend

Cleared one shelf in the spare room · Wed, Oct 7

Called my brother back · Tue, Oct 6 · With family

Walked to the mailroom instead of driving · Mon, Oct 5

*Made-up example. A done list is for encouragement, not proving who does more.*

Fill in your own: Your done list (spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins)

04

## Change the setup, not just your willpower.

Willpower runs low when you're tired or hungry. Your surroundings stay the same all day. So make the new habit easier, by putting it in sight or getting things ready the night before, and make the old one a little harder, by moving it out of reach. I'd back a small change to the setup over a big push of effort almost every time. At home that can be as simple as one owner for each job (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job).

Callan is seventeen and wants to sleep better, and for weeks he tried to stop scrolling in bed by sheer force of will. It didn't work once. Then his mom suggested charging his phone in the kitchen overnight, next to the bread box. He said this was ridiculous, and did it anyway, mainly to prove her wrong, and within a week he was asleep before midnight most nights. Every few weeks he tells her it's ridiculous, without much conviction.

**Willpower isn't a fuel tank, probably**

A popular idea says self-control runs out like fuel. When 23 labs tried to repeat the classic experiment together, they found an effect close to zero. The argument isn't over, but it's one more reason to change the setup rather than lean harder on yourself.

**Hagger and colleagues (2016)** · *Strong: a large pre-registered replication; the debate continues*



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Changing the setup is often easier than changing a person. At home, that can be as simple as one owner for each job.

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03

05

## Being in two minds is normal.

Part of you wants to change and part of you doesn't, and the reluctant part usually has its reasons. The old habit may give comfort, or protect you from something. Pushing harder against it rarely works, and listening to it often does.

Asif wanted to drink less, and he also loved Friday nights at the bar with his team. When he finally asked himself what Friday actually gave him, the answer wasn't really the beer. It was the people, the laughing, the end of the week. So he kept the Friday and switched to alcohol-free after the first pint. If anyone at the table noticed, they didn't say, which is its own sort of kindness.

Try two lists, one of what you like about how things are, one of what you'd like about changing. You're allowed both, and I suspect the first one will be the more honest of the two.

06

## Slips are part of change.

Nearly everyone who changes something slips back sometimes, and one slip doesn't undo the progress. What does the damage is usually the thought that follows. "I've blown it, so why bother?" Being kind to yourself after a slip makes it a good deal more likely you'll start again.

Three calm weeks, and then Lewis shouted at his son over spellings. Really shouted, the old way. That night he sat on the end of the bed in the dark. "I shouted, and I'm sorry. I'm working on it." A small voice from under the duvet said "Okay." The next evening they did the spellings at the kitchen table with the radio on. Nobody raised their voice. The word was "necessary," which neither of them could spell.

**There's a name for "why bother?"**
Relapse-prevention research calls it the abstinence violation effect: after one slip, guilt and a sense of total failure make a full slide back more likely. It comes from addiction treatment, but the shape is the same for cookies and evening runs.

**Marlatt and Gordon (1985)** · *Moderate: a foundational clinical model, widely used in addiction treatment*

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"A slip is one moment out of many." "What made today harder, and what can I plan for next time?"

Decide now, while things are going well, what you'll do after a slip. Have one kind sentence to say to yourself and one small step to start again. A game can help some people practice, and the Re-check Drive (spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive) turns small kind steps into calm football.



TIDBIT

A slip is a stumble, not a fall. Try the tiny step again tomorrow. A game for small kind acts can make the practicing easier.

TOOL **Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

07

## Change sticks when it fits who you want to be.

Change made only to please someone, or out of shame, is hard to keep up. Change that connects to what you care about has deeper roots, and each small action becomes a vote for the person you're turning into.

Rania kept meaning to be better at keeping in touch, and kept not being. What shifted it was a different sentence in her head. She stopped telling herself she must message people and started thinking of herself as someone who shows up for her friends. A voice note on Sunday evenings became part of that. Some weeks it's thirty seconds of nonsense and some weeks it turns into an hour on the phone.

08

## You can support change, but not force it.

It's natural to want the people we love to change, to drink less, or look after themselves better. Their change belongs to them, though, and pressure tends to make people dig in. It helps more to say clearly what you need, ask what would help, and notice their small steps out loud.

Grant kept missing deadlines, and his teammate had the lecture about being organized all ready, she'd been polishing it for two weeks, and at the last minute she didn't give it. She asked what would make the handover easier, and he looked surprised. Between them they set up a shared checklist, and he fills it in every Friday before lunch, mostly. She has kept the lecture, though, in a note on her phone.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"I can't change this for you, but I'd love to help if you want me to." "I noticed you did that this week. That really helped."

TWO WEEKS LATER, 7:05AM

*The sneakers are still by the door. The phone sleeps in the kitchen now, and the plan has shrunk to shoes on, out to the end of the road. Some mornings that's all. Most mornings it turns into a loop past the community gardens and back. On the Thursday you miss, the voice starts up again, and you tell it you'll get to the end of the road tomorrow. It says you won't. You do.*

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

### Change, two ways

Some people love a fresh start and throw themselves at a new plan. Others need to change one small thing and see it hold first. If you're a fresh-starter, the slow one isn't lacking willpower. They're protecting what already works. If you're slow and steady,

the fresh-starter isn't being reckless. Novelty is part of what keeps them going.

**Where the fields meet.** Behavioral science says habits beat good intentions, and business adds the simple check: one owner for a change and one small look each week at whether it held. The root is feedback loops, small things repeated with a check each time.

## In everyday life

Take a couple who want to spend less of the evening on their phones. Earlier attempts failed because each of them watched the other. This time they put a basket by the door, both phones go in at nine, and there's one exception for whoever's on call for an elderly parent. The first week is awkward. On the Wednesday one of them sneaks a look at the football. By the third week the basket is part of the furniture and the evenings have a shape again, a movie or a crossword or an early night.

Big life changes, a move or a new baby, break old routines, which is disruptive and also a good moment to start new habits. If you have ADHD, make the cue impossible to miss, do the step the moment it appears, and make the reward come right away. Expect the novelty to wear off, and swap the method when it does instead of blaming yourself. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-6-change-in-depth).

### On your own: a kind plan for change

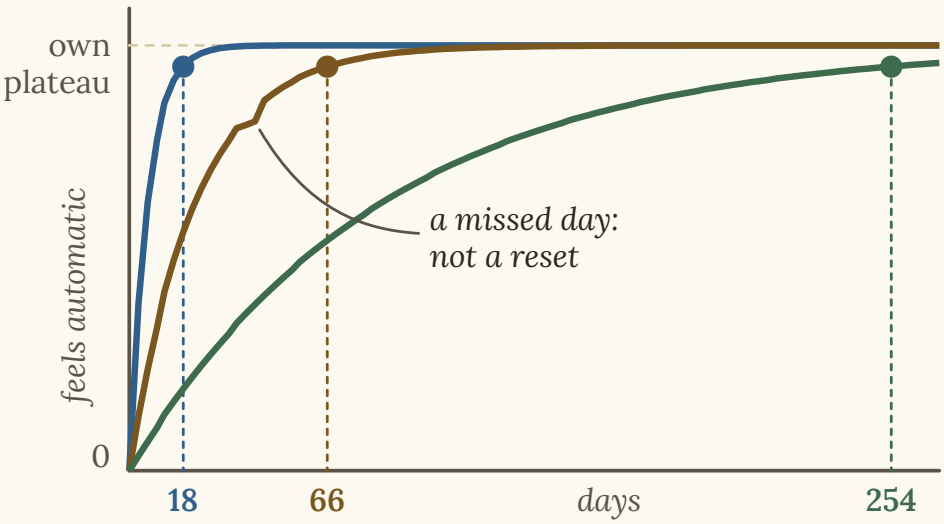
If you're working on something alone, the whole chapter fits into one small plan. Choose one change, the one that would make the most difference or the one that feels most doable. Give it a cue, written as "After I ___, I will ___." Make one tweak to your surroundings so it's easier to start. Decide on the smallest version you could still manage on a tired day. And write down one kind sentence to use after a slip. The self path (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) and Know yourself, next walk through it step by step.

## Common mix-ups

"If I really wanted it, I'd just do it" is the cruelest of these, and it's wrong. Wanting is only the start. Habits, setup, tiredness and stress all get a vote. Then there's the famous 21 days. There's no magic number. In one study, led by Phillippa Lally (2010), it took about two months on average, with a very wide range. Being hard on yourself doesn't keep you on track, either. Harshness makes people give up, and kindness makes it easier to try again. And routines don't have to mean being rigid. For a lot of people, autistic people especially, routines are what make life manageable, and change can respect that.

## About two months, give or take a lot

*How automatic a new daily habit feels, over time.*




- Fastest in the study: about 18 days
- Middle (median): about 66 days
- Slowest: about 254 days

*Illustrative shapes, not the raw data. Lally and colleagues (2010) followed 96 volunteers; reaching 95% of each person's own plateau took 18 to 254 days, median 66. Simpler habits formed faster.*

FIGURE 11 How long a new habit takes to feel automatic: about two months on average, with a very wide range. Illustrative shapes based on Lally and colleagues (2010).

### If you want to help someone else with this

Ask before you advise ("Would ideas help, or would you rather just talk it through?"), and help them find their own reasons by asking what would be

different for them if this changed. Practical help with the setup, like a ride to the gym, often does more than encouragement. Notice small steps out loud and be kind about slips. Look after yourself too. You can care a great deal and still have limits on what you'll put up with.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I'm on your side with this. What would help?" "You've done this three days in a row. That's not nothing."

## Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Pick one tiny change and try it for a week. The 90-second daily check-in (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-13-daily-check-in), the quick checks (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks) and the self path can help you keep track.

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Know yourself, next: values, one small goal, tiny steps and if-then plans.
- Complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency): why good habits fade, and how to keep them alive.

## More for your situation

- On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own)
- New parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent)
- When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids)
- Neurodivergent relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- Gaming, phones and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together)
- At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Coming home after time apart (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home)
- Find it by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part One · Next · Who you are becoming**
*One small goal and tiny steps* — read online

**Part Two · Chapter V · The monthly look-back**
*The monthly look-back* — read online

**Part Two · Chapter II · Is the split working?**
*Changing the setup, not the person* — read online

**Part Three · Chapter 14 · Personality, temperament and change**
*How much people really change* — page 203

PUT IT TO USE



**Know yourself, next**
Values, one small goal, tiny steps and if-then plans
spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next



**Complacency**
Why good habits fade, and how to keep them alive
spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency

7

PART THREE · CHAPTER 7

# Self-worth, shame and self-compassion

*Why your worth isn't a score you keep earning, how shame differs from guilt, and why being kind to yourself makes it easier to grow.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Your worth isn't a score
2. Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad."
3. Shame makes you want to hide
4. The inner critic is trying to protect you
5. Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off
6. Comparing yourself pulls your worth outside you
7. You can own a mistake without drowning in it
8. Worth is learned between people, and we can give it
9. In everyday life
10. Feedback, criticism and put-downs are three different things
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation


THURSDAY, 11:20PM

*You sent the wrong spreadsheet to the whole team. Last quarter's, not this one's. Priyanka spotted it in four minutes, sent the right one and added "no worries!!" with two exclamation marks, which somehow made it worse.*

*It's nearly midnight. The file stopped being the point some time around ten. The voice has moved on to bigger things now, like how you've always been a bit useless, really, and now they all know.*

This chapter is about how self-worth and shame work, and then about what you can actually do with them. None of it is a diagnosis. Take what helps.

A wrong spreadsheet, read quickly, has layers. On the surface, a file sent to the whole team. Underneath, guilt about the file, which is useful. Underneath that, shame about yourself, which isn't. The roots are signal and noise, what the mistake really says, and balance. The chapter slows down on the second and third layers.

01

## Your worth isn't a score.

A lot of us carry a quiet scoreboard, on which we're worth something when we're useful, or liked, or slim, or busy, or top of the class, or never any bother to anybody. Psychologists call these "conditions of worth," and the trouble with a score is that it can drop. If your worth goes up and down with each day's results, then every bad day is a verdict.

Pam taught third grade for forty years. In the September after she retired she found herself in the supermarket at ten on a Tuesday morning, holding a basket with nothing in it, feeling lost in a way she couldn't have explained to anyone. Nothing was wrong. But for four decades being needed was how she knew she mattered, and the bell had stopped ringing.

Try finishing "I feel okay about myself when I…" three times, then look at what you wrote. Those are your scores. Just noticing them is enough for now.

02

## Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad."

Guilt is about something you did, so it points somewhere useful. Say sorry. Put it right. Shame is about who you are, which feels impossible to fix, and so it makes people hide, or freeze, or blame someone else, or lash out. Research on the two feelings, such as June Tangney and Ronda Dearing's (2002), suggests guilt is the one more likely to lead to repair.

Rhys is twelve and he has just knocked his mom's favorite mug off the counter, the one with the hare on it that she bought on the seafront in Whitby years ago and drinks her first tea of the day from, and there are two ways this can go. Guilt says go and tell her, and maybe offer some birthday money. Shame says you ruin everything, and this time shame wins. He wraps the pieces in yesterday's paper and pushes them right down to the bottom of

the trash can, under the potato peelings, where his mom finds them on Sunday.

It was the hiding that upset her. She told him so. It took him a while to see what she meant.

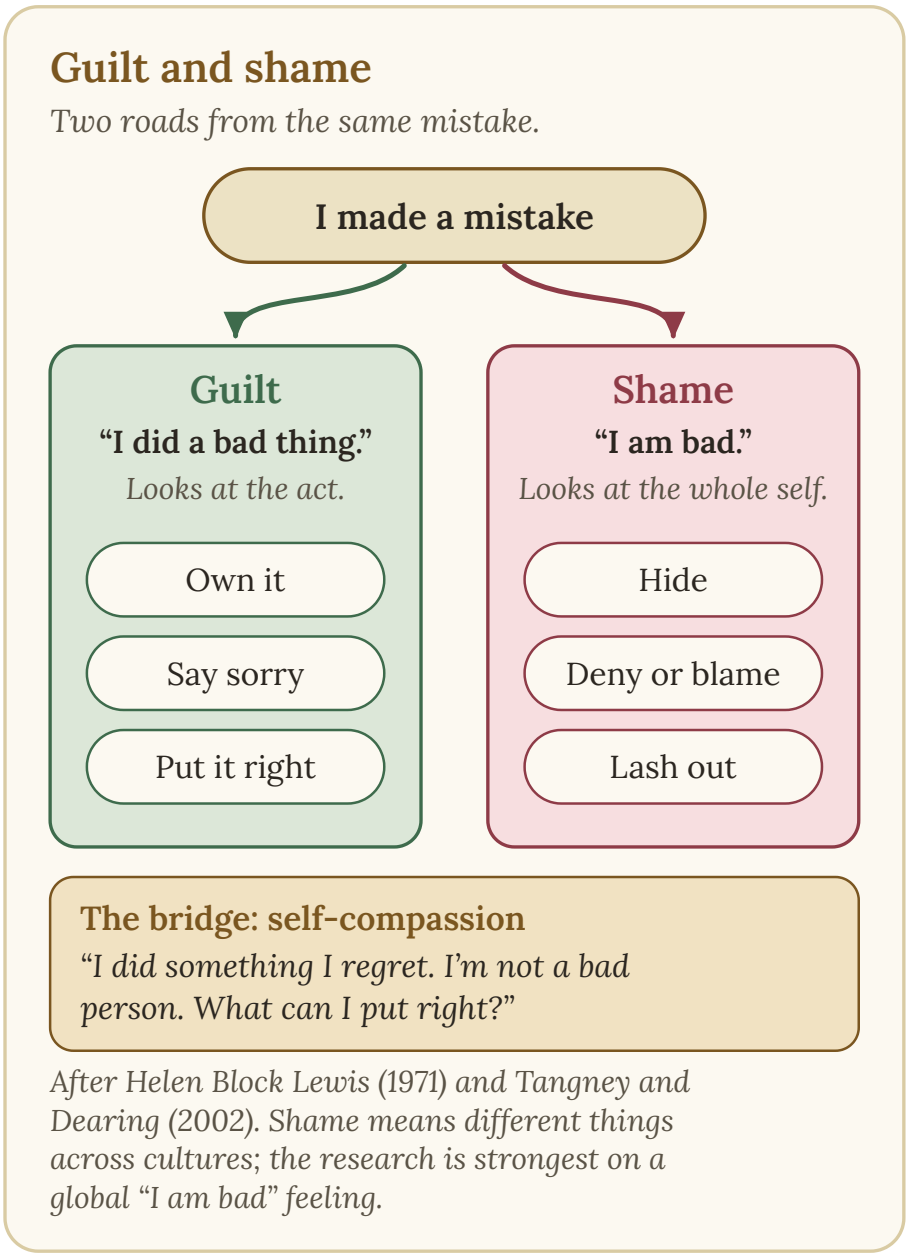



FIGURE 12 Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad." Guilt is easier to put right, and self-compassion helps you cross over.

03

## Shame makes you want to hide.

You feel shame in the body before you think it. Hot face, eyes down, stomach dropping, a strong wish for the floor to open. It also comes out sideways, as sudden anger or a closed, cold face, which is how a small comment turns into a big fight.

"Didn't we already cover this?" It was a mild question, asked in a Tuesday meeting by a man who genuinely couldn't remember. Becky snapped at him, properly, in front of nine people. That evening, scraping a plate into the trash, she worked out that it had nothing to do with him. She'd felt stupid in front of everyone, and stupid had come out as sharp.

Learn your own signs, if you can. Next time you suddenly want to vanish, or bite, you can name it quietly to yourself, and now and then out loud. "Sorry, I think I felt embarrassed and it came out sharp. Can I try that again?"

04

## The inner critic is trying to protect you.

That harsh inner voice usually started as protection. If you criticize yourself first, perhaps nobody else gets the chance. If you're hard enough on yourself, perhaps you'll never fail again. It meant well, in its way. But a voice that only threatens keeps your body on alert, and it's exhausting to share a head with.

Every time Craig forgets something for the baby he calls himself an idiot. Out loud, sometimes. The wipes. The rabbit she won't sleep without. It's the word his own dad used about him, all through his childhood. Patting his pockets in the daycare parking lot for a rabbit that's on the kitchen table, he hears it in his dad's voice, exactly, and it strikes him as odd that he's still using it.

**Perfectionism has been creeping up**

Students' perfectionism scores rose between 1989 and 2016, according to a meta-analysis by Curran and Hill, with the sharpest rise in the feeling that other people expect you to be perfect. It's questionnaire data from Western countries and it can't say why, but if that feeling is loud for you, you have company.

**Curran and Hill (2019)** · *Moderate: questionnaire data from Western countries; does not explain the cause*

Write down one thing your critic says a lot. Would you say it to a friend you loved? Some people find it helps to answer the critic directly. "Thanks. I

know you're trying to protect me. I can take it from here."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 7

**Flip it**

*Hamish, 44, after a mistake at work*

## Flip it

What's on your mind?

*I got the figures wrong in the client report and my manager had to fix it. I'm hopeless at this job.*

What kind is it?

A complaint about someone  A worry  *Being hard on myself*  Anger

THE FLIP

**What a good friend might say**

"That sounds like a hard moment. One mistake is not the whole of you. You're not hopeless. You're a person having a hard day."

**Kinder words for yourself**

"I had a hard moment. I'm human. Next time I'll [one thing]."

**One next step**

[one small thing, like a short sorry, a reminder on your phone, or some rest]

Talking to yourself the way you'd talk to a friend is a simple form of self-compassion. Being harsh rarely makes the next try easier. This is a starting point. Change any words you like.

Hamish's own words, after changing the flip

*I got two figures wrong and it was caught before the client saw it. I'm human. Next time I'll ask a colleague to check the numbers before it goes out.*

His next step

*Send my manager a two-line sorry and the checking plan, today, then go home on time.*

*Made-up example. The flip is a starting point: Hamish changed the words until they were true and sounded like him.*

Fill in your own: Flip it (spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins)

05

## Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off.

Self-compassion means treating yourself the way you'd treat a good friend who's having a rotten time. One well-known model has three parts. Kindness instead of attack. Remembering that everyone struggles. Noticing the pain without drowning in it. Studies, such as one by Juliana Breines and Serena Chen (2012), suggest that people who are kind to themselves after a failure are often *more* likely to try to improve.

Lindy failed her driving test for the third time, on the reverse around a corner again, clipping the same curb she had clipped in March, and afterward she sat in the DMV parking lot for a while with the engine off. Then she told herself what she'd have told her sister, more or less. This is hard. Lots of people need more tries. You're fine everywhere except that one corner. On Sunday morning she was on the empty industrial estate by the beltway with her dad in the passenger seat, reversing around the same lamp post eleven times.

If it feels all right, try putting a hand on your arm once today and saying, slowly, "This is a hard moment. Other people feel this too. What do I need?" It will feel daft the first time, and probably the second.



SUGARFOOT

Speak to yourself the way you'd speak to a friend having a hard day, slowly and kindly. Writing it down first helps.

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

06

## Comparing yourself pulls your worth outside you.

Everyone measures themselves against other people. It's how we work out where we stand. But a feed full of other people's best moments makes the measuring wildly unfair, and self-esteem that depends on being better than others swings about all over the place.

Two old friends met for a curry, one of them having just bought a house. The other rents a room in a shared apartment in Queens where the shower only works if you hold it. The renter spent the whole evening quietly ranking herself, and she missed what was right in front of her. Her friend was lonely in the new house, and had wanted to say so all evening, and kept waiting for a gap in the conversation that never came because the renter was so busy ranking herself. You're comparing your inside with somebody's outside. When you catch yourself at it, try a question instead. "How are you, really?"

**Why we compare at all**

Leon Festinger proposed in 1954 that people judge their opinions and abilities by comparing themselves with others, especially when there's no objective standard to go by. Worth has no objective standard, which may be exactly why comparing goes so badly there.

**Festinger (1954)** · *Strong: a foundational theory with a large body of later research*

07

## You can own a mistake without drowning in it.

Owning a mistake gets a lot easier once it doesn't mean you're worthless. Say what you did. Say what it did to the other person. Say what you'll do now. Then stop. Beating yourself up afterward proves nothing about how sorry you are, it just pulls everyone's attention back onto you.

Jess forgot to pay her share of the broadband and it got cut off for the whole long weekend. On the Tuesday, after a weekend of the others tethering their laptops to their phones and one of them going to the library to finish an essay, she put her head around the living-room door. "I forgot to pay, and it left you all without internet for three days. I've paid it and set a reminder for the 28th." Someone said "Thanks," and that was more or less the end of it.

If it went wrong in a conversation, Rewind the talk (spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder) helps you find the words. Then decide whether to

send them or let it rest.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Owning a mistake can be short and plain: what happened, that it was yours, what you'll do. If it went wrong in a talk, Rewind the talk helps you find the words.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

08

## Worth is learned between people, and we can give it.

Children learn their worth from how they're treated, and adults never entirely stop. The words matter, because "You did a careless thing" leaves room to change, while "You're so careless" shuts the door. Notice effort, and who someone is, as well as results, and people feel they matter on bad days too.

Gill took over a team that hid its problems until week ten, and from her first month she started every project review with the same question, "What did we learn?" and refused, politely and repeatedly, to discuss who had got what wrong. Within six months people were bringing problems to her in week two, which saved everyone a great many Friday evenings, and the sappy question stayed.

Today you could say one thing to someone that has nothing to do with how well they've done. Even just "I'm glad I know you."

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't control how other people judge you, or what you were taught about your worth growing up. You can control how you speak to yourself now, whether you repair what you can, and where you spend your time. Give your energy to people who treat you as someone who matters. More in Your wiring, weather and words (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

FRIDAY, 9:15AM

*You send one line. Sorry about the mix-up with yesterday's file, right one attached. When the voice starts up again you try answering it the way you would a friend. You got it wrong and you fixed it, which is what a decent colleague does. The voice is not convinced. Priyanka sends a thumbs-up, and by lunch you've mostly stopped thinking about it.*

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

### A mistake, read two ways

For some people a correction is just information: "slide four has a typo" means slide four has a typo. For others, the same sentence lands as a verdict on them, often because a lot of earlier corrections were. If you're the first kind, it can help to say the plain part plainly and add one warm line. If you're the second, it can help to ask, "Is this about the slide, or about me?" Usually it really is the slide.

**Where the fields meet.** The art of debating has a rule that fits this chapter well: separate the claim from the person. "I did a bad thing" is a claim about an act. Laughter, used gently, can help too, laughing with yourself and never at yourself. The research on laughter is young and modest, so treat that as a small help.

## In everyday life

Shame turns up in very ordinary places. Between partners, "You forgot to call" can land as "You're a terrible partner," so what comes back is a defense instead of a sorry. A child who hears "You're so naughty" learns something about who they are, while "That was a naughty thing to do" leaves a way back. A friend who says yes to everything may be quietly burning out, because no

feels like risking being dropped. At work, someone may sit on a small error for weeks because owning it feels like proof they never belonged there.

**On your own: a kinder voice to keep**

You don't need anyone else for this. Notice how you talk to yourself and practice one gentler sentence. Catch the critic's favorite words ("always," "useless," "pathetic," "should") and swap one for a plain fact. "I'm hopeless" becomes "I was late twice this week." On bad days, keep a short list of what you did, and let getting up count. You're allowed to be disappointed in what you did and still be on your own side.

## Feedback, criticism and put-downs are three different things.

Feedback is about something you did and what would work better, and it usually comes with a reason. Criticism aims at you as a person ("You always…," "You never…"). It's common in tired, stressed moments. In couples studied by Gottman (1994), criticism went with more unhappiness later, while a plain complaint about one specific thing did not. A put-down is something else again, and it's worth being exact about it, because the label hurts if it's wrong.

For something to be a put-down, these are usually all present:

- it's about who you are, not one thing you did,
- it keeps happening over weeks or months,
- it carries on after the thing is fixed or explained,
- it often lands in front of other people or on what you care about most.

Not enough on its own:

- one sharp comment on a bad day,
- plain words without padding, or a family where everyone talks bluntly,
- a fair complaint that came out badly,
- teasing that both of you enjoy and either of you can stop.

If you raise it, describe what was said and how it landed, and leave the label out. “When you called me useless in front of your sister, I felt small. What was really bothering you?” gives the other person something to answer.

## Common mix-ups

People worry that self-compassion is just self-pity. They feel quite different from the inside. Self-pity says “only me, poor me.” Self-compassion says “this is hard, and other people go through it too,” which joins you to other people instead of shutting you away from them. Others fear that being kind to themselves will make them lazy. The research leans the other way, because it’s fear of your own attack that makes people stop trying and hide their mistakes. And self-worth doesn’t mean thinking you’re great, only that you go on mattering on the days when you plainly aren’t.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Talk about what happened, never about what sort of person they are. Arguing with someone’s shame (“You’re not useless!”) can feel like being told they’re wrong to feel it, so you might try “It sounds like you feel really low about it. I don’t see you that way.” Helping them find one small thing they can do gives the feeling somewhere to go. And kindness on ordinary days, when nothing has gone wrong, teaches worth far better than anything said in a crisis.

> YOU COULD SAY
> “That sounds like it’s weighing on you. Want to work out one thing that would help?” “You don’t have to earn being cared about.”

## Tools and reading on the website

**Tools helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now) for a feeling that is too big to think through
- Ask Professor Puddles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask), the site’s chat host, to help you find a kinder sentence

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Shame and guilt (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), in the site's library of research notes
- Self-compassion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection) and self-esteem (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/motivation)
- Perfectionism (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/motivation#perfectionism) and social comparison (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life)
- Masking (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring), for anyone who has spent years trying to seem "normal"
- Where your lens came from (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up), for where an old inner voice might have started

## More for your situation

- **On your own:** Part One: where you came from (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-1-then) · Your self-discovery path (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · On my own after a breakup (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own)
- **Teens:** For teens: feelings (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- **Neurodivergent:** Wired differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently) · Neurodivergent relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- **At work:** At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- **Coming out:** Coming out as an adult (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out)
- **Caregivers and parents:** Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers) · When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids)
- **Related chapters:** Loss, grief and big life changes (page 116) · Minds that work differently (page 129)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Your worth isn't a score.
- ✓ Shame makes you want to hide.
- ✓ Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off.
- ✓ Comparing yourself pulls your worth outside you.
- ✓ Worth is learned between people, and we can give it.

THIS CONNECTS TO


**Part One · Then · Where your lens came from**
*Old rules that taught you your worth* — read online

**Part One · Next · Who you are becoming**
*Kindness when a goal slips* — read online

**Part Three · Chapter 11 · Healing after hurt**
*Guilt, apology and forgiveness* — page 161

**Part Three · Chapter 16 · Worry, low mood and trauma**
*When the inner critic gets loud* — page 231


PUT IT TO USE



**Upset right now?**
For a feeling that is too big to think through
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now



**Ask Professor Puddles**
The site's chat host, to help you find a kinder sentence
spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

# 8

PART THREE · CHAPTER 8

# Loss, grief and big life changes

*What grief is, why it comes in waves, how it shows up in the body, and how to carry a loss, or a big change, without having to "get over it."*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Grief is love with nowhere to go
2. Grief comes in waves, not neat stages
3. Grief lives in the body, too
4. Some losses nobody sees
5. People grieve in different ways
6. You don't have to let go
7. Big changes are losses too, even the good ones
8. Most people find a way through, and support helps
9. Losing a partner in later life
10. In everyday life
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. Tools and reading on this site
13. More for your situation


AT A GLANCE

- **Grief is love with nowhere to go.** It hurts because the person, place or life mattered.
- **It comes in waves.** A good week followed by a bad day is part of grieving, and it doesn't send you back to the start.
- **You don't have to let go.** Many people keep a bond with the person they lost, and that is healthy.
- **Most people find a way through.** Support helps, and some losses need more help than friends can give.

SATURDAY, 9:05AM

*Six months on, you're doing fine, or that's what you tell people, and on most days it's even true.*

*Then, in aisle seven, there's the cereal, his cereal, the faded blue box he always said tasted of cardboard and ate every single morning for thirty years. You leave the cart where it is, next to the oatmeal, and walk out to the car and sit in it with the engine off. A woman loading her trunk two spaces down glances over and then, kindly, doesn't.*

This chapter is for anyone who has lost someone or something. It might be a person, or a pet, or a marriage or a friendship, their health or a home or a job, a country they had to leave or a future they'd pictured. It looks at how grief works and then at what can help. There's no right way to grieve. Nothing here is a schedule, and if any of it doesn't fit you, leave it.

Aisle seven, in quick strokes. On the surface, a box of cereal. Underneath, six months of being fine. Underneath that, love with nowhere to go. The roots are balance and state and setting, what was given and is now missing, and where the wave happens to land. The chapter goes through them slowly.

01

## Grief is love with nowhere to go.

Grief is what we feel when something we were attached to is gone, and it isn't only for deaths. A divorce, a miscarriage, a diagnosis, a move, a friend who drifted off, children leaving home. Its size usually matches the size of the bond, whatever anyone else thinks the loss ought to mean.

When Bramble died, his owner was shaken by how hard he took it, and his friends at the bar told him, kindly enough, that it was only a dog. That dog walked beside him along the same stretch of river every morning for twelve years, through two jobs and a divorce. The lead is still on its hook by the back door, and he can't move it yet.

It can help to say a loss out loud to yourself, especially one you've never called grief. "I'm grieving the friendship." "I'm grieving the life we planned." They're small sentences, and they can bring a surprising amount of relief.

02

## Grief comes in waves, not neat stages.

You may have heard of five stages of grief, running from denial through anger, bargaining and depression to acceptance. They came from listening to people who were dying, and they were never meant as steps that everyone goes through in order. Most people swing back and forth, some hours deep in the loss and some hours getting on with life, and researchers who study grief see that swing as healthy.

Three months after Gerald died, Val laughed properly at lunch. Her sister had told a story about a man at the bowls club and a wasp, and Val laughed till she had to put her fork down. On the bus home she felt terrible about it. That evening she cried for two hours. The lunch was grief too, and so was the bus.

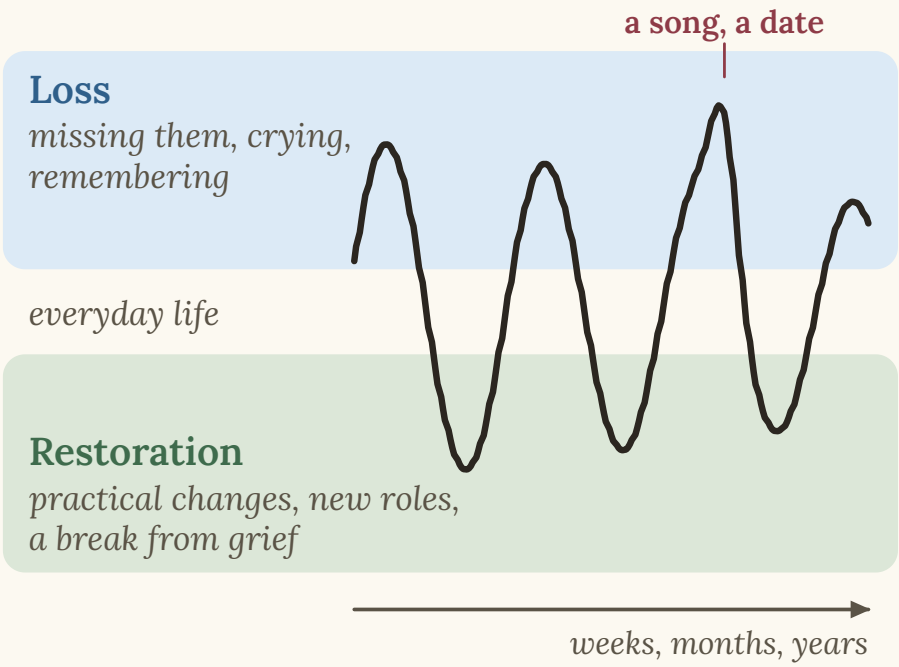
**Back and forth is normal**

The dual process model describes healthy grief as moving back and forth between facing the loss and getting on with life, with breaks from grief included. In this model Val's laugh at lunch isn't a lapse. It's part of the grieving.

**Stroebe and Schut (1999)** · *Moderate: a widely used framework with partial support*

## Grief comes in waves

*Moving back and forth between loss and life is part of it.*




*Waves, not neat stages. A good week, then a bad day, is normal, not going backward.*

*After Stroebe and Schut's dual process model (1999), a widely used framework rather than a precise prediction. Illustrative line.*

FIGURE 13 Grief comes in waves, not neat stages. Moving back and forth between loss and everyday life is part of healthy grieving.

03

## Grief lives in the body, too.

Grief can bring tiredness, bad sleep, no appetite or too much, aches, a tight chest, forgetfulness and a foggy head. Your brain is slowly learning that someone or something it expected to be there has gone, and the learning takes time and uses a lot of energy.

An assistant principal whose mother has just died loses her car keys three times in one week. She drives to school on a Saturday, and walks into a school board meeting that is happening on Thursday when it is in fact Tuesday. She starts to wonder, quietly, if something is wrong with her memory. It's grief fog. It lifts as the months go on, though nobody can tell her when, and she'd really like somebody to.

While it lasts, look after a few basics, like one real meal a day and a regular bedtime and a short walk outside, and it's fine to tell people, "I'm grieving, so I'm slower than usual. Could you send me a reminder?"

04

## Some losses nobody sees.

Some losses are hard to explain to anyone else. Someone may still be alive but changed by dementia or illness, or gone without having died, like an estranged parent or a missing relative. Other losses go unrecognized, such as the death of an ex-partner, a pregnancy loss or a friend you only ever knew online.

Every Sunday at two, Teresa visits her dad at the nursing home. He's always pleased to see her. He thinks she's his sister, Connie, and asks after their mother, who died in 1987. Teresa has stopped correcting him, and they talk about Connie's life, which Teresa now knows a surprising amount about. She is grieving someone who hasn't died. There's no funeral for that, no cards, and at work nobody thinks to ask.

**A loss without an ending**

Pauline Boss named this ambiguous loss: someone gone but still present in the mind, or present but changed, as with dementia. Part of what makes it so hard is that there's no clear ending to grieve.

**Boss (1999)** · *Moderate: a widely used framework, backed by clinical and interview research*

If a loss of yours had no ceremony, you can make a small one, a candle or a letter or a bulb in the yard, or just going to stand for a while somewhere that mattered.

05

## People grieve in different ways.

Some people grieve by talking and crying. Others grieve by doing, fixing things, organizing, working, building. Neither is more loving. Families often clash because one person thinks another isn't grieving, when they're grieving differently, and culture and faith and age and how your mind works all shape how it comes out.

After their son died, Janet wanted to talk about him every evening. Steve went into the garage every weekend and worked on the old Raleigh that Ryan had never got around to fixing. She thought he was hiding. He thought she was making it worse. It took a bereavement counselor about forty minutes to point out, gently, that they were both doing exactly the same thing. In March Steve brought the bike out, finished. Janet cried and he let her. Then she asked him what was wrong with the gears, and he told her, for some time.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 8

**Write it through**

*Edith, 74, seven months after her husband died, writing to her son and daughter*

**Write it, wait, then send**

Who is it to?

Partner · Co-parent or ex · *Family* · Friend · Roommate · Coworker · More than one person · Someone else

Their name (optional)
*Malcolm and Fiona*

Your name (optional)
*Mom*

What kind of message?

Raise something · Reply to something · *Make a plan* · Say sorry · I need a pause

What we need to plan (one thing)

*How often we ring and visit. Since your dad died in March, I've had a call every evening at seven and a visit every Sunday.*

How I feel about it

*tired* · rushed · frustrated · unseen · taken for granted · overwhelmed · stretched thin · worried · hurt · disappointed · left out · alone with it · confused · embarrassed · annoyed · sad · on edge · hopeful · *grateful*

What I suggest (one clear suggestion)

*Could we change to a call on Wednesdays and Sundays, and I'll call you if I need you in between?*

What I'm NOT saying (optional, but it helps)

*I'm not pushing you away. I love hearing from you, and I miss your dad too.*

When I'd like a reply

Today · Tomorrow · *By the weekend* · No rush

**A GENTLE CHECK**

House rules: ✓ One topic · ✓ Facts, not verdicts · ✓ No always or never · ✓ No sarcasm or ALL CAPS · ✓ No "you" accusations · ✓ Says what you're asking for · ✓ A reply-by time

No sharp words found. It reads as calm and clear.

*Made-up example. Fiona called the same evening: "Of course. Will you still tell us on a bad day?" Edith said she would.*

Fill in your own: Write it through (spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through)

06

## You don't have to let go.

An older idea said healthy grief meant moving on and cutting ties. Many grief researchers now see it differently. People often keep a bond with the person they lost, in memories, rituals, conversations in their head and the values they carry on, so the relationship changes shape without having to end.

Ama wears her grandpa's watch to every exam. It's far too big. She has to push it up her arm to write. She doesn't believe in luck, and if you asked her

why she does it she would probably shrug and say "dunno," but the honest answer is that it feels as if he's in the room.

You could pick one way of keeping a bond, cooking their recipe, or telling one of their stories at Christmas, or keeping one of their habits going. Some people find it helps, in a hard moment, to ask what the person would have said. Often it's something rude.

**Continuing bonds**

This is the book that challenged the cut-the-ties view of mourning, showing that inner bonds with someone who has died are common across many groups and often healthy. Later research adds a fair caveat: for some people the bond comforts, and for others it hurts.

**Klass, Silverman and Nickman (1996)** · *Moderate: influential; effects differ from person to person*

07

## Big changes are losses too, even the good ones.

A new baby, a promotion, retiring, moving country, a child starting school, coming out, getting well after a long illness. All of them can bring grief for the old life. Change often has three parts, an ending, a confusing middle bit, and a new beginning. The middle is the hardest part and also the easiest to rush.

Ifeoma and Olu moved to Denver for a job they both wanted. They toasted it with fizz in the empty apartment. Six months in, Olu felt low, and then guilty for feeling low, since this was the plan. What nobody had toasted was what they'd left behind, a circle of friends, a café where nobody had to ask what they wanted, and a whole Saturday that used to run itself. You can be glad about a change and still miss what came before.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When a loss is hard to talk about, writing can come first. Put the words down at your own pace. You never have to send them.

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

08

## Most people find a way through, and support helps.

Research suggests that over time many people find they can live with a loss and still feel joy, though they never forget. Being around people who let you talk, or let you stay quiet, helps. For some people, though, grief stays at full

strength for a long time and makes daily life very hard.

Doctors call this **prolonged grief**. It means a strong longing for the person, or being taken over by the loss, most days, still going many months after the death (6 to 12 months or more, depending on the guideline) and getting in the way of life. It has nothing to do with weakness, and there is specific help for it.

A year after his wife died, Dennis still couldn't go into their bedroom. He slept on the couch and had stopped answering his friends' calls. His doctor referred him to a grief counselor and he went, mainly so his daughter would stop asking. Things moved, slowly, starting with one evening a week at his brother's, watching the snooker and not saying much. He's back in the bedroom now, on his own side of the bed.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't control the loss, how long grief lasts, or how other people react to it. You can control small things: eating something, resting, telling one person how you are, and saying no to what you can't manage right now. That is enough for a hard season. More in Your wiring, weather and words (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

SATURDAY, 9:40AM

*You let it come, for ten minutes maybe, and then you blow your nose on a napkin from the glove box and go back in. The cart is still there by the oatmeal, and you put the cereal in it, without knowing why.*

*At home you text your sister. Saw Dad's cereal. Cried in the parking lot. She's typing right away. Same thing happened to me with his aftershave in the drugstore. Call tonight?*

## Losing a partner in later life

After a long marriage the loss is in everything, in the empty chair and the jobs that were always theirs and the paperwork, done alone, and in the first

birthday and the first anniversary without them. Do one small thing at a time, and let one drawer count as a day's work. It's fine to ask someone to sit with you while you fill out the forms.

Your grown-up children have lost a parent while you've lost a partner, and you may grieve on different clocks. If they start calling every day, that comes from love and worry. It isn't control, and you can still say what helps. "I love that you call. Could we make it two evenings a week, and I'll call you if I need you?"

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

### Grief, read two ways

Some people grieve by talking, crying and remembering out loud. Others grieve by doing, mending, fixing the bike. If you talk, the doer may look as if they've moved on. Usually they haven't, and the doing is the grief. If you do, the talker isn't wallowing. Telling the story again is how they carry it.

**Where the fields meet.** Philosophy has asked for a long time what makes a life go well, and part of its answer is that the people we lose stay part of it. Laughter, oddly, belongs here too: a shared laugh can tell a grieving body it's safe for a minute. The research on laughter is still young, so read that as a small comfort.

## In everyday life

After a miscarriage one partner may want to talk while the other goes quiet, and each can end up worrying the other doesn't care. A child may laugh and play the day after a funeral and cry at bedtime, and both are grief. A friend who stops calling after your diagnosis is usually stuck for words more than cold. Colleagues who avoid the subject when someone comes back after a

death can leave that person feeling as if the loss has been rubbed out. And a whole town can grieve together, when it loses its library or its factory.

### On your own: carrying it gently

Grief can be lonely even with people around you. When you're carrying it on your own, give the day a small shape, with a meal and a walk in it and one person you message. Expect harder days around birthdays and anniversaries, and plan something gentle for them. Writing to the person you lost, or about what you lost, can help, and nobody ever needs to read it. Some days the only goal is to get to tonight, and that is enough of a goal.

IF SOMEONE CLOSE TO YOU HAS DIED. Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief) goes further, with family after a loss, coming back to people, and a new chapter on your own. On a heavy night, the page called For a hard evening (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief#hard-evening) may help.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Show up, and then keep showing up. Support floods in for about two weeks and then stops, so a text at three months, or on a birthday, can mean a great deal. Offer something specific, because "Can I drop dinner round on Thursday?" is far easier to say yes to than "Let me know if you need anything." Say the name, too. Many grieving people find it a comfort to hear it, and a memory with it, and if you're not sure, ask. Leave out the explanations, since "Everything happens for a reason" and "At least…" tend to hurt. "I'm so sorry. I'm here" rarely does. And if you're upset too, lean on people further from the loss, not the ones closest to it. Comfort goes in toward the middle and venting goes out.

YOU COULD SAY

"I don't know what to say, but I'm here." "I was thinking about your mom today. I remember her laugh." "I'm going to the shop. What can I bring you?"

## Tools and reading on the website

**Tools helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now) for a wave that feels too big

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Calm sounds (spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes) for a quiet few minutes
- Grief and later life: loss, family and a new chapter, with a page for a hard evening
- Grief and change (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions) and ambiguous loss (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life), in the site's library of research notes
- Moving and life transitions (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life#moving-and-transitions) and writing about hard things (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#expressive-writing)
- After a loss (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path), in your self-discovery path

## More for your situation

- **After a breakup or divorce:** On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own)
- **Families after a loss:** Grief and family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief#family) · Family rifts after a loss or a will (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts)
- **Children and teens:** Helping children grieve (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief#children) · For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- **Big changes:** Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest) · Retired together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/retired-together) · Coming home after time apart (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · New parent (spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent)

- **Illness and caring:** When one of you is sick (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers)
- **Friendships:** When a friendship drifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- **Related chapters:** Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 102) · Minds that work differently (page 129)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

THIS CONNECTS TO


**Part Three · Chapter 5 · Attachment, trust and belonging** page 74
*Why losing a bond hurts so much*

**Part Three · Chapter 12 · Helping others well** page 175
*Supporting someone who is grieving*

**Part Three · Chapter 16 · Worry, low mood and trauma** page 231
*When grief turns into low mood*

**Part One · Then · Where your lens came from** read online
*Losses that shaped your lens*


PUT IT TO USE



**Upset right now?**
For a wave that feels too big
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now



**Calm sounds**
For a quiet few minutes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

# 9

PART THREE · CHAPTER 9

# Minds that work differently

*How autistic, ADHD, sensory and learning differences work, why none of them is a character flaw, and how people with different minds can meet in the middle.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Brains vary, like bodies do
2. Autism is a different way of sensing and connecting
3. ADHD is about steering attention, not lacking it
4. Everyone has a sensory profile
5. Learning differences aren't about intelligence
6. Masking costs energy
7. Autistic burnout is more than being tired
8. Meltdowns and shutdowns aren't choices
9. Stimming helps, so let it be
10. Deep focus makes switching hard
11. Deep interests are a source of joy and rest
12. Meet in the middle, out loud
13. Labels are tools, and they belong to the person
14. Finding out later in life
15. Getting things started and finished is a skill of its own
16. When demands feel like a threat
17. Not recognizing faces isn't rudeness
18. Not speaking isn't the same as having nothing to say
19. Telling friends and dates is your choice
20. Finding your people
21. In everyday life
22. Common mix-ups
23. If you want to help someone else with this
24. Tools and reading on this site
25. More for your situation


AT A GLANCE

- **Brains vary, like bodies do.** A different mind is not a broken one, though differences can still be disabling in a world built for one kind of mind.
- **Nobody chooses overload.** Meltdowns, shutdowns and burnout are what happens when a nervous system has had too much.

- **Less masking, room to stim, time for deep interests and real rest** help a great deal.
- **Meet in the middle, out loud.** Ask what helps, say what helps you, and use the words each person chooses.

MONDAY, 8:15AM

*"Shoes, please, just put them on," you say, for the third time.*

*Your son is lying on the hall floor with his hands over his ears. The new socks are wrong. From where you're standing, they are socks. From where he is, the seam across his toes is sandpaper, and the alarm clock upstairs that nobody has switched off is going straight through the middle of his head. You are already late. So is he, in a way you can't see.*

This chapter is for neurodivergent people, diagnosed or not, and for the people who live and work with them. It can't diagnose anyone, and only you get to choose the words you use for yourself.

Two tools elsewhere rest on it. The "How to talk to me" card (Part One, Now, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now) works because different minds need different input, and saying things plainly helps almost everyone. One owner per job and the written job list (Part Two, Chapter II, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2) move memory out of anyone's head and onto paper, which helps ADHD and autistic minds most and everybody a bit.

In quick strokes, a child on the hall floor with his hands over his ears is three things at once. On the surface, a fuss about socks. Underneath, a sensory system turned up high. Underneath that, a morning with no room left in it. The roots are state and setting, and quiet incentives, what the setup rewards. The chapter then takes the ways minds differ one at a time.

01

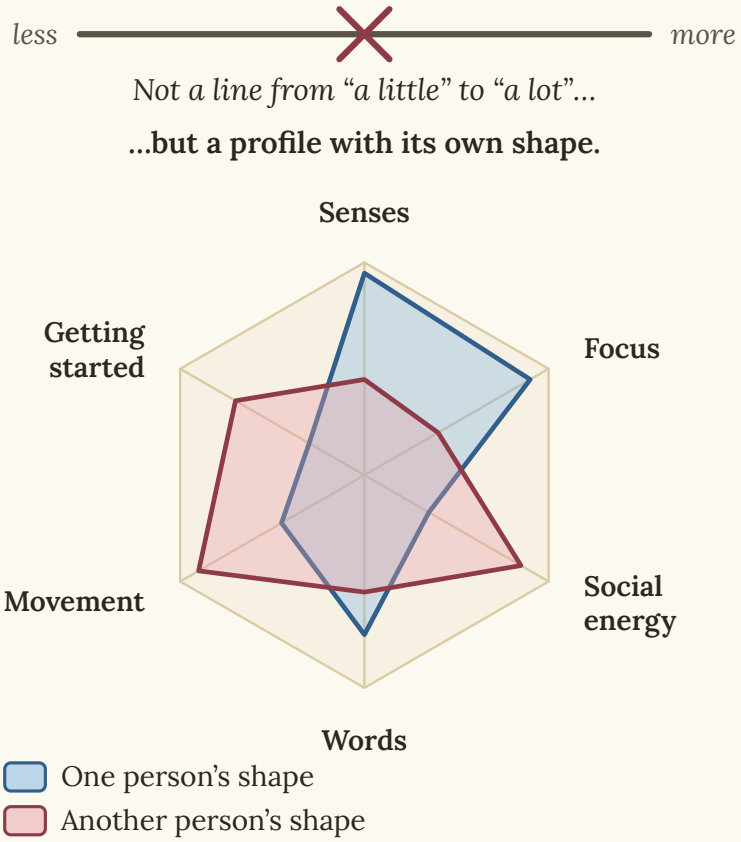
## Brains vary, like bodies do.

Brains differ in how they take in the world, focus, move, read, remember and connect with people. “Neurodiversity” is the idea that this variety is natural. “Neurodivergent” describes people whose minds work differently from what gets treated as typical. A different mind isn’t a broken one. Differences can still be disabling, though, especially in a world built for one kind of mind, and that is just as true.

Gary found out he was dyslexic at forty, and he sat in the car outside the assessment center for twenty minutes afterward with the report on the passenger seat, not reading it, obviously. What he mostly felt was relief. For thirty years he had half believed the teachers who wrote “lazy” in red pen.

## Brains vary, like bodies do

*Different, not broken.*




*Strong in some places, stretched in others.*
*Ask what helps, and say what helps you.*

*Illustration, not a test. "Spiky profile" is a common way to describe uneven strengths and needs.*

FIGURE 14 Brains vary, like bodies do. A mind has a profile with its own shape, not a place on a line from "a little" to "a lot." Different, not broken.

02

## Autism is a different way of sensing and connecting.

Autistic people often communicate more directly and literally. Many have deep, focused interests, feel senses more (or less) intensely than others do, and find predictability calming. Autism doesn't run along one line from "mild" to "severe." Each autistic person has their own mix of strengths and needs, which can change from day to day, and the misunderstandings between autistic and non-autistic people usually run both ways.

"Your slides have three typos," Kate told her colleague, kindly. "One on slide four and two on the summary." It was exactly what she would have wanted to be told. He went quiet for the rest of the afternoon and she had no idea why until a mutual friend explained it to her at a bar. They were using two different sets of rules for what kindness sounds like, and neither set is wrong, though it would help if they came with subtitles. If you're the direct one, it can help to say so up front, something like "I like it when people say exactly what they mean, so you can be direct with me."

**The story that got lost in the middle**

In an experiment, a story was passed along chains of eight people. All-autistic chains kept as much detail as all-non-autistic ones, while mixed chains lost detail faster and reported less rapport, which supports the idea that the difficulty sits between two styles rather than inside one of them.

**Crompton and colleagues (2020)** · *Moderate: a careful experiment; modest sample, one task*

03

## ADHD is about steering attention, not lacking it.

People with ADHD usually have plenty of attention, and the hard bit is pointing it. Boring tasks feel like pushing a car uphill, interesting ones swallow whole evenings, and time is slippery (there's "now" and there's "not now" and not much in between). Feelings arrive fast and big. It's a real difference in how the brain manages itself. Effort and caring don't come into it.

Saffy forgot her best friend's birthday. Completely. Not a text. Then she spent six hours making a card with pressed flowers from the yard, glued on one at a time with tweezers, and posted it four days late with a note that said "I KNOW." The forgetting and the six hours came out of the same brain. If

something keeps falling out of yours, move it into the world. A labeled alarm. A note on the door. A basket by the front door for the keys.

04

## Everyone has a sensory profile.

We all take in sound, light, touch, smell, taste, movement and signals from inside the body. Some people feel these strongly and get overloaded by noise, or a label in a sweater. Others need more input, like movement or strong flavors or firm pressure. Overload is a body at its limit, which is a very different thing from being fussy.

Two roommates fell out over the kitchen radio, because one found silence creepy and the other found Radio 2 at breakfast physically painful. They settled on the radio until nine and headphones after, which has lasted two years.

Notice one sound, light or texture that drains you and one that calms you, and change one small thing today.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Knowing your own sensory profile is information, not a complaint. Write it down once and hand it over, and you don't have to explain it every time.

TOOL **How you connect: how I like to be spoken to** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

05

## Learning differences aren't about intelligence.

Dyslexia (reading and spelling), dyscalculia (numbers), dyspraxia (coordination and planning movement) and language disorders are specific differences, and none of them measures how clever someone is. Plenty of people have a "spiky" profile, very strong in some areas and struggling in others. The right tools, audiobooks or extra time in exams or a reader for the long letters, can level things a good deal.

Every Wednesday afternoon on the football field, fourteen-year-old Ewan is called clumsy, usually by a PE teacher who should know better. The same term he wrote and directed the school play, which had a revolving set made

out of a bike wheel. Ask the people you live or work with how they find it easiest to take things in, and then actually use it.

06

## Masking costs energy.

Many neurodivergent people learn to hide their differences. They copy other people, force eye contact, hold back movements, rehearse small talk in the car. This is called masking. It can get someone through a day. It also uses a great deal of energy, and over years it can wear a person down into exhaustion and burnout. For a long time the cost can be invisible even to the person paying it, which is rather the point of a mask.

Mia seems completely fine at college, chatty in the canteen and helpful in class and laughing in all the right places. She gets home at four fifteen, goes straight up to her room, and can't say a word to anyone for an hour. Her dad used to knock and ask what was wrong, and now he leaves a cup of tea outside the door and goes away.

**Style, not substance**

Across three studies, non-autistic people formed poorer first impressions of autistic people from a few seconds of video and were less keen to talk to them. Given only a transcript of what was said, the bias disappeared. That goes a long way to explaining why people mask.

**Sasson and colleagues (2017)** · *Moderate: three studies with consistent results*

Notice one place where you could drop the mask a little, and one person you can be fully yourself with. Spend a bit more time there.

07

## Autistic burnout is more than being tired.

Autistic burnout is a deep, long-lasting exhaustion. Working with autistic adults, Raymaker and colleagues (2020) described it as long-term exhaustion, loss of skills (like speech, planning or self-care) and lower tolerance of noise, light and other input. It comes from long stress without enough support, and it often lasts months. Rest helps, and so do fewer demands and less masking. Pushing harder usually makes it worse. If you think you might be there, list three demands you could drop or hand to someone else for a month.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I'm in burnout. What I need for a while is fewer demands." "I can't do phone calls at the moment. Can we message instead?"

08

## Meltdowns and shutdowns aren't choices.

A **meltdown** is an involuntary loss of control when overwhelm gets too much, and it can look like crying, shouting, running off or lashing out. A **shutdown** is the quiet version: going still, losing speech, not being able to respond. Neither is a tantrum. In interviews by Phung and colleagues (2021), autistic young people described meltdowns and shutdowns as separate experiences, both linked to overload.

For a lot of people words go first. What helps is less of everything. Less noise, fewer words, no questions, more space. Talking can wait, sometimes until the next day. On a calm day, agree a simple signal for "I'm overloaded" and a quiet place to go.

WAYS TO SAY IT

(to someone else) "You're safe. I'm right here. No need to talk." (for yourself) "I'm overloaded. I need quiet for twenty minutes."

09

## Stimming helps, so let it be.

**Stimming** means repeated movements or sounds. Rocking, flapping, tapping, humming, pacing, fiddling with something. Most people stim a little. (Watch any meeting and count the jiggling feet.) For many autistic people it matters a lot. In interviews by Kapp and colleagues (2019), autistic adults described stimming as a way to cope with overwhelming emotions and sensations, and objected to efforts to stop harmless stimming. If it isn't hurting anyone, it doesn't need stopping. It's worth noticing what your own hands do when you're stressed or focused or happy, because that's yours, and nobody needs to train it out of you.

10

## Deep focus makes switching hard.

Some minds go deep into one thing at a time, often autistic and ADHD ones. That focus can be a real strength, because it builds expertise and brings a great deal of joy, and it also makes switching hard. Being interrupted can feel like being yanked out of water.

"Dinner!" Nothing. "Tilly, dinner!" Still nothing. Third time, louder. The fish sticks are going cold and Dominic is getting really frustrated. His daughter is upstairs building a castle and has reached a delicate stage with the drawbridge. The next night he tries a ten-minute warning, then a five. She comes down on time, still talking about the drawbridge, and tells him at length what the problem with it is. He doesn't entirely follow, but he eats his fish sticks while they're still warm, which is the main thing. The warning, for the record, goes "Dinner in ten minutes, I'll come and get you in five minutes," shouted up the stairs, and it works about four nights out of five.

11

## Deep interests are a source of joy and rest.

Many autistic people have deep, intense interests, often called special interests. The theory of monotropism (Murray, Lesser and Lawson, 2005) describes autistic attention as pulled strongly into a few things at a time. In a survey of autistic adults by Grove and colleagues (2018), people who were more motivated by and engaged with their special interests reported higher wellbeing, though very intense engagement went with lower wellbeing.

Ask someone about their favorite subject and let them talk for five minutes without steering. It costs you five minutes. It's one of the warmest things you can do for anyone.

**Interests and wellbeing**

In a large Dutch survey of autistic adults, about two in three had a special interest, and being more motivated by it went with higher wellbeing. Very intense engagement went the other way. The joy is real, and so, some weeks, is the need for an off switch.

**Grove and colleagues (2018)** · *Moderate: a large survey, self-report, at one point in time*



TIDBIT

The website can change to fit your mind too, with bigger text, calmer pages and fewer surprises. The settings are worth a look.

TOOL **Read your way** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-you-take-things-in

12

## Meet in the middle, out loud.

When two kinds of mind live or work together, neither should have to do all the adjusting. Clear, plain words help everyone. Say what you mean, give times, write things down, ask what helps. And changes made for one person (a quiet space, an agenda, flexible hours) usually help plenty of other people too.

A team started sending meeting agendas a day early, for one autistic colleague. Within a month most of them said meetings had got shorter. Two people who had never said a word in a meeting started saying things.

Today, swap one "how I work best" fact with someone. Tell them one thing that helps you and ask for one that helps them. The website can bend a bit to your mind too, with Read your way (spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-you-take-things-in) (bigger text, calmer pages, fewer surprises).

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 9

**"How to talk to me" card, for work**

*Tom, autistic, for his new manager*

### Your card

Who it's for

A partner  Family  A friend  *Work (a manager or coworker)*

Name on the card, optional

*Tom*

WIRING CARD · NOT A DIAGNOSIS

**How I receive things best**
A written list.

**I take words**
Literally.

**Give me time to answer**
Write it down so I can answer later.

**Please avoid**
A hard topic with no warning. Correcting me in public.

**A request lands best as**
"Could you ___ by ___?"

**Also good to know about me**
If I go quiet, I'm processing, not upset. Tell me the plan, and tell me if it changes. Noise, light or touch can wear me out.

**Sensory needs**
Short breaks in long talks.

Sent with one line: "Here's a short card about how I work best. It's not a request for anything big; it just helps us avoid crossed wires."

*Made-up example. Sharing a card is always the person's own choice.*

Fill in your own: "How to talk to me" card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card)

13

## Labels are tools, and they belong to the person.

A diagnosis can bring understanding, and sometimes support and a community too. Some people find their way to a label through self-discovery first. Many autistic adults prefer "autistic person" and others prefer "person with autism." The kindest rule is to ask, use the words the person chooses, and never try to diagnose somebody else, least of all in an argument.

The fight was about the dishes. It was going badly. "You're so autistic," Danny said, and the conversation ended right there, as it deserved to. In the morning, over toast that neither of them was eating, he said sorry, properly,

and then asked what his partner actually needed from him when the kitchen was a mess. It was the conversation they should have had the night before.

If you've wondered about yourself, write down what you've noticed and pick one small next step, like talking it over with someone you trust.

14

## Finding out later in life.

More and more adults are finding out they're autistic, or have ADHD, in their thirties or fifties or seventies. Many were missed as children, especially women. In interviews by Leedham and colleagues (2020), women diagnosed at forty or older described how exhausting it had been to go so long without an explanation, and how much the diagnosis changed the way they understood their own lives. Relief and grief and something like joy can all turn up together, on the same afternoon. If that's you, look for one autistic-led group or online space, and give yourself time.

15

## Getting things started and finished is a skill of its own.

Planning, starting, switching, remembering what you were doing and keeping track of time are called **executive function**. Many autistic and ADHD people find some of these harder, and harder on some days than others. A review of 235 studies by Demetriou and colleagues (2018) found differences in executive function in autism on average, with a lot of variation between people. The brain's self-management system is working differently. Laziness doesn't come into it.

Siân wrote a forty-page report for her board in a week, and it was brilliant. The same three weeks, she could not mail one package. It sat on the hall table while she walked past it forty times. Then she put it by the front door with a yellow sticky note on top ("MAIL ME") and set an alarm for Tuesday at 8:10, and on Tuesday at 8:11 it went. See routines that help (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids) and Wired differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently).

16

## When demands feel like a threat.

Some people, often autistic, feel strong anxiety when asked or expected to do things, even things they want to do. Avoiding the demand can look like refusing, joking, changing the subject or a meltdown. The profile was first described as "pathological demand avoidance," or PDA, by Newson and colleagues (2003).

It isn't in the main diagnostic manuals, and researchers disagree about it. A review by Kildahl and colleagues (2021) found the evidence limited and mostly based on parent reports. Many people who identify with it prefer the phrase "persistent drive for autonomy." Honestly, I'd hold this one loosely until the research settles. What helps tends to be the same whatever it's called. Less pressure. Requests that feel like invitations. "Put your coat on now" gets a flat no from Reuben every morning. "It's cold out. Coat or sweater, your choice?" gets the coat, usually.

17

## Not recognizing faces isn't rudeness.

**Prosopagnosia**, or face blindness, means finding it hard to recognize faces, sometimes even close friends seen out of context. It can be something you're born with. Many autistic people also find remembering faces harder, as a review by Weigelt and colleagues (2012) found. People who don't recognize you may be relying on your voice, your hair, your coat or where they usually see you.

Clive walked straight past his neighbor in the supermarket without a flicker, and she went home feeling snubbed and told her sister about it on the phone. When he explained, a week later and very embarrassed, that he hadn't known her without her spaniel, she laughed. Now she says "Hi Clive, it's Jo from number twelve" every time, even when the spaniel is right there.

> WORDS TO TRY
>
> "I'm bad with faces, so please say who you are when you say hi." (to someone else) "Hi, it's Jo from next door."

18

## Not speaking isn't the same as having nothing to say.

Some autistic people speak rarely, sometimes or not at all, and some lose speech when stressed. Many communicate through **AAC** (augmentative and alternative communication), which can mean typing, letter boards, picture cards, apps or sign. Using AAC doesn't stop speech developing: a review by Millar, Light and Schlosser (2006) found it did not hold speech back, and may help it. The safest place to start is to presume competence, which means assuming the person understands and has something to say, and giving them the time and the tools to say it.

At Sunday lunch at her grandma's, fifteen-year-old Ruby types on her tablet. Her uncle used to talk about her across the table as if she wasn't there ("Does she want gravy?"). Now he asks her, and waits, a bit longer than he'd like, while she types. Her answer was "Yes. Obviously." Wait longer than feels natural, which will feel very long and isn't.

19

## Telling friends and dates is your choice.

Whether to tell someone you're autistic or ADHD, and when, is up to you. Telling can bring understanding. In a study by Sasson and Morrison (2019), people formed better first impressions of autistic adults when they knew they were autistic, especially if they knew more about autism.

People don't always respond well, though, and interviews by Au-Yeung and colleagues (2025) describe autistic adults weighing hope for support against fear of not being believed. Many share a little at a time, starting with what helps and leaving the label for later. Second date, outside a bar with a line. "I'm autistic," Nina said, "so I'm quite direct, and I'd rather walk than sit in there." Her date looked at the bar, then the line, then back at her. "Oh, thank God," he said. They walked along the canal as far as the lock and back.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
>
> "I'm autistic. For me that means…" "I won't always pick up hints, so please just tell me." (if someone shares with you) "Thanks for telling me. What helps?"

20

## Finding your people.

Lots of autistic people describe meeting other autistic people as a turning point, because at last they don't have to translate or explain or mask. The research backs this up. Cooper, Smith and Russell (2017) found that autistic people who felt more connected to other autistic people had higher self-esteem, and through that, less anxiety and depression. Being autistic can be an identity and a community as well as a diagnosis.

After his diagnosis at fifty-three, Bernard joined an online group of autistic adults who love old maps, specifically the Ordnance Survey kind with hand-drawn hachures. The first evening he talked to them for three hours about contour lines. When he logged off he had more energy than when he'd started, which hadn't happened after a conversation in years.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't change how your brain, or anyone else's, is wired. You can learn how yours works and say what helps, and ask others what helps them. Meeting in the middle means both people move a little. If you're always the one adjusting, it's fair to say so. More in Your wiring, weather and words

MONDAY, 8:30AM

*You stop asking. You sit down on the hall floor next to him, which is cold, and say, "Socks feel wrong?" He nods without opening his eyes. You go upstairs, switch the alarm clock off, dig the old seamless pair out of the laundry basket. Two minutes later his shoes are on. You're ten minutes late and nobody has shouted, which on a Monday is about as good as it gets. That night you order three more pairs and let him pick the colors.*

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

### Headphones at dinner, two ways

Some brains filter background sound without trying, so a busy kitchen is just company. Others take in every clatter, voice and

hum at once, and filtering it by hand uses up the attention they wanted for the people. If you filter easily, headphones at the table can look like shutting everyone out, and for the other person they're how they stay at the table at all. If you hear everything, it may help to say so: "The headphones mean I can stay. Talk to me and I'll take one out."

**Where the fields meet.** Holistic therapies start with the body before the argument, which fits overload well: less noise, fewer words, settle first and talk later. Some of these practices are well studied and some are debated, so only the plain everyday parts are used here. The root underneath is quiet incentives, because a setup that only rewards masking will get a lot of masking.

## In everyday life

### On your own

Knowing how your mind works helps you build a life that fits it, and spot burnout before it's on top of you (see Get to know your wiring, spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path). Partners can swap "how I work best" notes about plans, messages, touch and time alone. With children, behavior very often has a sensory or overload reason, so "What's too much right now?" is worth asking before "Why are you doing this?" A friend who cancels at the last minute may just be out of energy, and offering something easier, like a walk, keeps the door open. At work, written agendas, clear deadlines and quiet spaces help far more people than the ones they were made for.

**If you have ADHD and share a home,** make the chore tools lighter. Log three days instead of seven, with a tally on the fridge. Own a few jobs completely, each with a labeled alarm, instead of helping a bit with everything. Forgetting is a setup problem to fix together. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-9-minds-in-depth).

## Common mix-ups

"Everyone's a bit autistic" is probably the commonest, and it makes real needs sound small. Everyone shares some traits, but autism is a whole pattern, present across life. ADHD doesn't just mean not sitting still. Many people with it, girls and women especially, are mostly inattentive or restless on the inside. "They seem fine to me" overlooks how much masking can hide, and seeming fine can cost someone their whole evening. Adjustments aren't special treatment; they remove a barrier, the way glasses do. And the idea that autistic people lack empathy is simply out of date. Many feel other people's feelings very strongly, and the differences in how empathy is shown run both ways.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Believe them about what's hard and what helps, even when it's different for you. Be clear, which means saying what you mean, giving times and writing down anything important. Ask what helps, because every neurodivergent person is different and their answer will beat any list, this one included. Protect their energy. Quiet time, warnings before changes and a way out of loud places matter more than they look. And enjoy their interests with them, if you can.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> "Is there anything about this place, or this plan, that would make it hard for you?" "You don't have to explain. Just tell me what you need."

## Tools and reading on the website

**Tools** **helpers you use on the website**

- Communication style quiz (spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz) for a friendly look at how you send and receive words

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- The wiring card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card): a one-page "how I communicate" card to share
- Wired differently: neurodiversity and communication, including the double empathy problem (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently#double-empathy)
- Know your own wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself)
- Research notes: autism (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring), ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#adhd-basics), monotropism (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#monotropism), masking (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#masking), sensory profiles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#sensory-profiles) and sensory load (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress)

## More for your situation

- **Couples:** Neurodivergent relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- **Parents and grandparents:** When a child has ADHD · Neurodivergent families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships#families)
- **At work:** Neurodiversity at work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work) · Autistic at work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work#autistic-at-work)
- **Teens:** For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- **Sharing a home:** Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)
- **On your own:** Get to know your wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path#wiring) · Your wiring, weather and words
- **More in Part Three:** Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 102) · Loss, grief and big life changes (page 116)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

FOR AUTISTIC READERS. If you are autistic, or wondering, several pieces were written with you in mind. Masking and autistic burnout are covered earlier in this chapter, and When feelings are hard to name (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now#hard-to-name) looks at alexithymia. The double empathy problem explains why misunderstandings run both ways, the wiring card gives you a one-page "how I work best" card to share, and Autistic at work has words for asking for what you need.

## THIS CONNECTS TO


**Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words**
*Getting to know your own wiring* — read online

**Part Two · Chapter I · Why we get out of tune**
*Pace, tone and meeting in the middle* — read online

**Part Three · Chapter 14 · Personality, temperament and change**
*Dials, not boxes* — page 203

**Part Three · Chapter 4 · How communication works**
*Saying it so it lands for different minds* — page 57


## PUT IT TO USE



**Communication style quiz**
For a friendly look at how you send and receive words
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz



**The wiring card**
A one-page "how I communicate" card to share
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

# 10

PART THREE · CHAPTER 10

# Values, meaning and a good life: what philosophy offers everyday life

*What matters to you, how to find it, what to do when two good things pull against each other, and what a few very old ideas can offer an ordinary, busy week.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Values are directions you keep walking in
2. Your strong feelings point to what you value
3. Two good things can pull in different directions
4. Put your effort where it can land
5. A good life is more than a good mood
6. Meaning comes from ordinary places
7. Different values aren't wrong values
8. Values live in small, everyday acts
9. In everyday life
10. If you want to help someone else with this
11. Tools and reading on this site
12. More for your situation


AT A GLANCE

- **Values are directions you keep turning toward.** You never finish being kind, and that is why values still work on days when goals fall apart.
- **Strong feelings point to what you value.** Anger often guards fairness, and hurt often guards closeness.
- **Meaning comes from ordinary places.** People, care and everyday work give most of us most of our meaning.
- **Values live in small acts.** One small thing this week, done because it matters, counts.

SUNDAY, 9PM

*The week ahead has the car inspection on Tuesday, a dentist, two late meetings and your turn for the school drop-off, twice, and none of it feels like yours, somehow. You're not sad, exactly. You just can't remember the last time you did something because it mattered to you, and not because it was next on the list.*

This chapter is about values, the things you care about and the direction you want your life to face, and about what makes a life feel worth living. It borrows from psychology, and from philosophy, which has been asking how we ought to live for more than two thousand years. You don't need to have read any of it. I've tried to keep the old names to a minimum and the words plain.

In quick strokes, a full week looks like a diary problem. Underneath, it is a values problem, two good things wanting the same evening. Underneath that, what quietly gets rewarded at home. The roots are ownership and structure, and quiet incentives. The chapter then slows down on each.

01

## Values are directions you keep walking in.

A goal is something you can tick off, like painting the hall or passing the test. A value is a direction you keep walking in, like looking after your health, or making home feel cared for, or being a fair friend. Nobody ever finishes being kind. That's exactly why a value still works on a day when a goal falls apart.

Bethan was going to go to the gym three times this week. She went once, on the Monday. On Thursday evening she was on the couch in her gym clothes eating a family bag of fries and feeling like a failure. So she asked herself what the gym was for. Looking after her body, was the answer, and when she asked what that was for, it was so she'd have energy for the kids. On Friday she walked twenty minutes at lunchtime, around the little park behind the office, past the man who feeds the pigeons, and as far as she was concerned it counted.

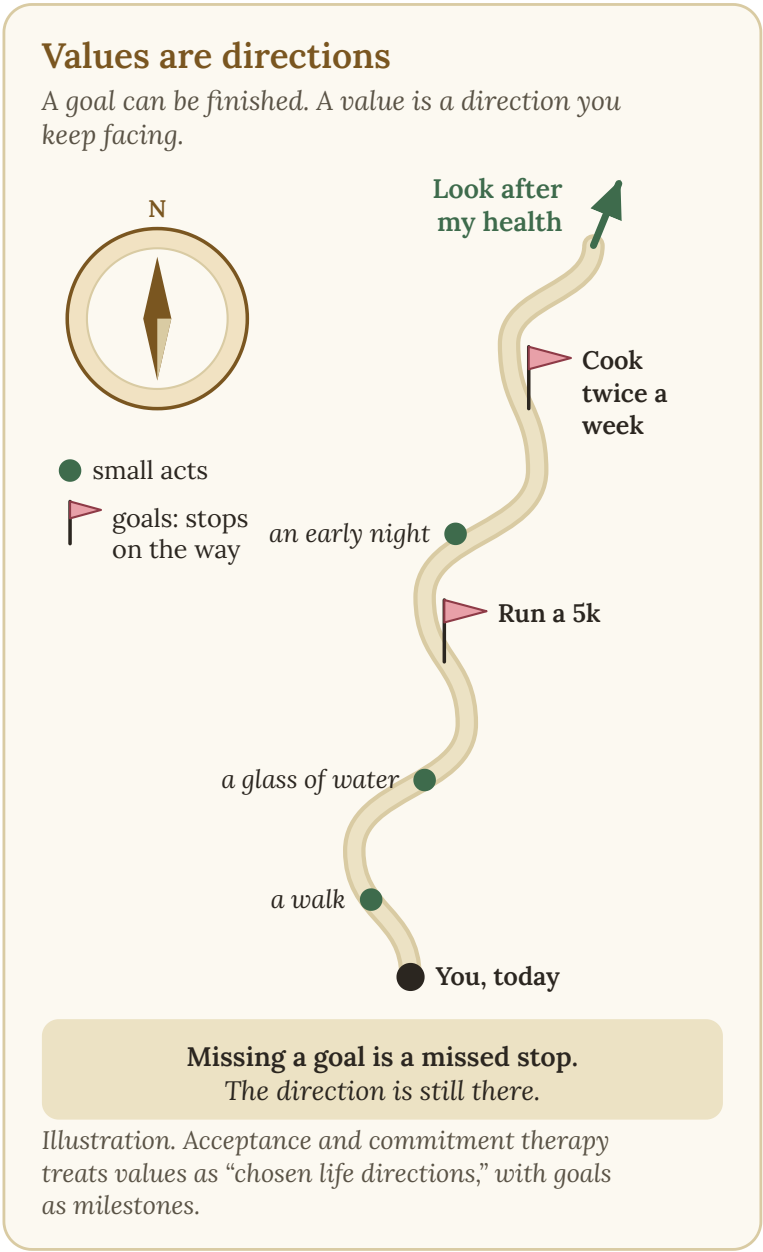



FIGURE 15 Values are directions, not finish lines. Goals are stops on the way. Missing one doesn't change the direction.

02

## Your strong feelings point to what you value.

You don't have to invent your values from scratch. They show up in your strongest reactions. Anger often means something you care about has been stepped on. Envy can point to something you want for yourself. Sadness tends to show what you love.

A colleague stood up in the quarterly review and took credit for a whole team's work, and Sacha was so angry he couldn't eat his lunch. He spent the afternoon drafting emails he didn't send. On the train home it dawned on him that it wasn't really about the colleague. It was fairness. Seeing people's effort. That was what had been stepped on. At the next team meeting he raised it as a fairness thing ("Can we agree how we credit joint work?") instead of seething at one person for a month, and it went better than any of the emails would have.

03

## Two good things can pull in different directions.

Most hard choices aren't between something good and something bad. They're between two good things, honesty and kindness, say, or family and rest. Feeling torn just means you care about more than one thing. Even when you choose well, it's normal to feel a bit sad about the side you didn't pick.

Pickles, the family Labrador, was very ill, and Megan's eight-year-old kept asking. Megan cares about being honest, and she also cares about protecting her son. She sat on the kitchen floor next to the dog's bed with him and tried to do both. "Pickles is very sick. The vet is helping. We'll look after him together." Her son thought about it for a long time, picking at the edge of the dog blanket. "Is he going to die?" "He might," she said. "We don't know yet." He put his hand on Pickles's side, very carefully, and left it there.

If you're stuck on a choice, write down the good thing on each side. You may be able to honor some of both, even if you can't have all of either.

04

## Put your effort where it can land.

About two thousand years ago a teacher called Epictetus, who had been born into slavery, taught that some things are up to us and some aren't. It's one of the oldest ideas in this book and still one of the most useful. Your own choices and how you treat people are up to you. Other people's choices, and the weather, and the past, are not. Worry tends to pile up in the second heap. Values do their work in the first.

Ingrid wants her partner to enjoy Christmas at her mom's, and she can't make him. She has tried, for six years, mainly by telling him it'll be fun. What she can do is plan a shorter visit, put a long muddy walk on the day after Christmas into it, which he'll like, and be warm herself. That's her part, and it turns out to be quite a lot.

05

## A good life is more than a good mood.

Feeling good matters. But many thinkers, from the Greek philosopher Aristotle to psychologists now, also describe a second kind of wellbeing. It comes from growing, using your strengths, being a decent friend, and doing things that matter even when they're hard. Aristotle called it flourishing, and he thought you build it the way you build any skill, by practice, a little at a time.

Jade spent a whole month of evenings helping a friend move out of a damp, miserable apartment. She scrubbed black mold off a bathroom ceiling with a toothbrush. She carried boxes down three flights of stairs while the friend cried on the landing. It was tiring and not much fun, and at the end of the year, when she thinks back over it, she counts it as one of the best months she had.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

If you enjoy big questions, put philosophy next to psychology and see what they share. It's one of my favorite rainy-day pastimes.

06

## Meaning comes from ordinary places.

Researchers who study meaning often describe three parts to it: your life makes some sense to you, you're heading somewhere, and your life matters to someone. Most meaning comes from people, from work done with care and from small roles other people count on, far more than from big moments.

Walter has lived alone since his wife died, and for a long time his days went very quiet. Now he reads to the under-fives at the library on Wednesday mornings. He irons a shirt for it on Tuesday nights. He does the voices, badly. When he had a cold in February and missed two weeks, a four-year-old called Albie asked the librarian every single day where the man was.

**Three meanings of meaning**

The three parts above come from Martela and Steger, who split meaning into coherence (life makes sense), purpose (a direction) and significance (your life matters). It's a way of thinking that has shaped later research rather than a finding in itself.

**Martela and Steger (2016)** · *Theory: a conceptual paper that has shaped later measurement*

Try listing the roles you play, big or small (neighbor, sister, the one who waters the office plants), and next to each one write who it matters to.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 10

**Keep your little rituals alive**

*Lachlan and Sunita, who lead a hybrid team of nine together*

## Keep your little rituals alive

Person A
*Lachlan*

Person B
*Sunita*

Date
*October 2, 2026*

### Part A: Our rituals, big and small

| Ritual or habit | How often | How it's doing | What it gives us, or what got in the way |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Monday coffee call, cameras optional* | *Weekly* | *Fading* | *Half the team stopped coming when it moved to 8:30* |
| *Friday "one good thing" round in the team chat* | *Weekly* | *Alive* | *Five minutes; people notice each other's work* |
| *A card and lunch when someone leaves* | *Now and then* | *Alive* | *People leave feeling thanked* |
| *Office day with lunch together* | *Monthly* | *Stopped* | *Stopped when the office moved; the three who work from home felt like guests* |
| *Hello and goodbye in the chat, start and end of day* | *Daily* | *New idea* | *So nobody wonders who's around* |

PART B: WHERE YOUR RITUALS STAND

**Your rituals**
5 rituals listed. Alive: 2 · Fading: 1 · Stopped: 1 · New idea: 1.

**Fading or stopped**
Monday coffee call, cameras optional, Office day with lunch together.

**New ideas**
Hello and goodbye in the chat, start and end of day.

Rituals lapse for ordinary reasons: a new job, a baby, a move, an illness, a hard year. A stopped one isn't a failure. Pick one to restart below, or let it go on purpose.

### Part C: One to restart, or start

The ritual
*Monday coffee call*

The smallest version that still counts
*Ten minutes at 9:15, no work talk, cameras optional*

The first time: when, and who will suggest it
*Next Monday; Sunita sends the invite*

What would make it easy to skip, and how we'll protect it (optional)
*A busy week. We keep it then too, just shorter.*

### Part D (optional): One to let go, with thanks

The ritual
*Office day with lunch together*

What it gave us
*A day all together, back when we all lived near the office*

*Made-up example. The sheet is written for couples and families, and it works for a team: the rituals are what make a group feel like one.*

Fill in your own: Keep your little rituals alive (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-15)

07

## Different values aren't wrong values.

Two people can share a home, a family or a team and still put the same good things in a different order, one putting safety first and another adventure. The philosopher Isaiah Berlin argued that there are many real goods in life and they can't all be ranked on one scale, which leaves room to disagree without either person being bad.

People who love you will sometimes try to change your mind, and that's ordinary influence. They tell you why, they listen to your reasons, and the choice stays yours. It becomes pressure when it keeps coming after you've said no, when saying no costs you something, such as days of coldness, money or being left out, or when it's aimed at the people and things that matter most to you. A good test is whether you can say "I see it differently" and still be treated warmly the next day.

Jasper likes a calm, tidy house. His roommate Darnell likes an open door and people dropping in. For months each of them privately thought the other was a bit much, uptight in one direction, messy in the other. It came out one night over takeout. "I just like knowing who's going to be in the kitchen," Jasper said. Darnell said, "I just like it when *anyone* is." Fridays are open house now, and Sundays are quiet, or as quiet as Darnell can manage.

In your next disagreement, you might ask, "What matters to you about this?" and listen for the value under the position.

08

## Values live in small, everyday acts.

A good life is built mostly from small things done again and again. How you say hello. Whether you keep small promises. How you talk about someone who isn't in the room. The Chinese teacher Confucius taught that small, everyday courtesies shape who we become, and later thinkers who wrote about care said that being good starts with paying attention to the person in front of you.

An older man at the self-checkout can't get the card machine to take his card. The line behind him is growing and somebody near the back tuts, loudly. You're next, and you don't sigh. You say, "No rush." He says, "It's always

this one, isn't it," and you agree that it is. The whole thing costs you about forty seconds.

Pick one value, choose one tiny act that shows it, and do it every day this week. You'll drift, as everyone does, and turning back is the practice.

**Kindness does something for the giver**

A meta-analysis of 27 experiments found that acts of kindness gave the person doing them a small-to-medium lift in wellbeing. The authors flagged worries about study quality, so take the size with a pinch of salt and the direction with rather less.

**Curry and colleagues (2018)** · *Moderate: the authors noted concerns about study quality and possible publication bias*



SUGARFOOT

A value can be as small as a cup of tea made just the way someone likes it. A "What feels like care" card helps you learn what that is for each of you.

TOOL **How you connect: what feels like care** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages`

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can choose your direction. When you notice you've drifted, you can turn back without shame. You can't choose other people's values for them, and you don't have to adopt theirs to love them. You can share what matters to you, listen to what matters to them, and look for the places where your directions overlap.

SUNDAY, 9:20PM

*On the back of an envelope you write people, health and making things, and under each one, a small thing for this week. Call Grandma, walk on Wednesday, finish the shelf in the spare room, the one that has been "nearly done" since Easter. The week is just as full as it was. You prop the envelope against the kettle, where it'll be the first thing you see.*

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

## Values, two ways

Some people hold a value as a rule: honesty means saying the true thing, every time. Others hold it as a direction, adjusted to the moment. If you hold rules, the direction person isn't being slippery. They're weighing two good things at once. If you hold directions, the rule person isn't being harsh. A clear rule is how they stay steady.

**Where the fields meet.** Politics has a lot to say about two people with different values under one roof: a fair way to decide, and a say for everyone, and a way to change the rule later. The root is ownership and structure, plus quiet incentives, because a home drifts toward whatever it rewards.

## In everyday life

Partners may rank the same values differently, security and adventure, say, and it helps to say what each of you is protecting before you argue about the plan. Two generations of a family can both value family and mean very different things by it, from living around the corner to being free to go, so it's worth asking what the word means to each of you. When a job keeps asking you to act against a value, the strain often shows up as tiredness or cynicism, and naming the clash is a first step. A club, a faith group or some volunteering can give you a place to act on a value alongside other people.

## If you want to help someone else with this

"What matters most to you about this?" helps more than telling someone what they ought to care about. People often see their values for the first time in someone else's words, so it can help to notice them out loud. "You stayed late to help your friend. Loyalty really matters to you, doesn't it?" With children, naming the value when you see it teaches more than any lecture. Try not to use values as a weapon, because "I thought you valued family" lands as a guilt trip. You can disagree with someone's choice and still see the good thing they were reaching for.

YOU COULD SAY

"What would a good outcome look like to you?" "What do you want to be able to say about how you handled this, a year from now?"

## Tools and reading on the website

**Tools helpers you use on the website**

- Your self-discovery path (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path), step by step, and Professor Puddles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask), the site's chat host, if you want to think out loud.

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Part One, Next: start with what matters (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next), a short values step from the self-discovery part of the book.
- Library: values, what matters most (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/motivation) and self-determination theory (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/motivation#self-determination-theory).
- Library: why new things stop feeling new (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life) and comparing yourself to others (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life#social-comparison).
- Stories from philosophy: What is up to us (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth), Three kinds of friendship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth#friendship) and The circles of Hierocles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth#circles).

**A limit to keep in mind:** This chapter shares ideas to think with, not answers to follow. Your values are yours to find, and it's fine if they change as your life does.

## More for your situation

- **On your own after a big change:** On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own) · Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest) · A new chapter after loss (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)

- **Couples with different priorities:** Money together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together)
- **Families with different beliefs:** Two faiths, one family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths) · Coming out as an adult (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out)
- **Friends and work:** Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- **Teens working out who they are:** For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) · Growing up (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up)
- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

THIS CONNECTS TO


**Part One · Next · Who you are becoming**
*Turning values into one small goal* — read online

**Part Two · Chapter IV · Two kinds of fair**
*Two kinds of fair* — read online

**Part Three · Chapter 17 · Groups, influence and culture**
*Whose values a group rewards* — page 245

**Part Three · Chapter 7 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion**
*Worth that is not a score* — page 102


PUT IT TO USE

**Your self-discovery path**
Step by step, and Professor Puddles, the site's chat host, if you want to think out loud
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

**Part One, Next: start with what matters**
A short values step from the self-discovery part of the book
spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next

# 11

PART THREE · CHAPTER 11

# Healing after hurt: repair, forgiveness and old hurts

*How hurt heals, why it lingers, how small breaks get mended, what a real apology sounds like, and what forgiveness is and isn't.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Hurt is real, and healing takes time
2. Every close relationship has breaks. Repair is what counts
3. Telling someone they hurt you
4. A real apology names it, owns it, and mends it
5. Forgiveness isn't forgetting, excusing or going back
6. You can heal even if they never say sorry
7. Trust comes back in small, kept promises
8. Going back is a choice
9. Look after the hurt part of you
10. How old hurts shape new reactions
11. In everyday life
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation


AT A GLANCE

- **Hurt is real, and healing takes time.** Replaying a hurt says more about how much it mattered than about any weakness in you.
- **Repair is what counts.** Every close relationship has breaks, and a real apology names what happened, owns it and offers to mend it.
- **Forgiving and going back are separate choices.** You can forgive without forgetting, excusing or letting someone back in.
- **Going back is a choice.** You can heal even if they never say sorry.

THURSDAY, 2AM

*It was one sentence, three weeks ago, said over your shoulder in somebody's kitchen at a party on the way to the fridge, and they have almost certainly forgotten it.*

*You haven't. It plays again, word for word, tone and all, followed by every clever thing you could have said back and didn't. You're very tired of carrying it about, and you honestly don't know where you'd put it down if you could.*

Everyone gets hurt, and everyone hurts other people, mostly without meaning to. This chapter looks at how hurt works and how relationships mend, and at how you can heal with or without the other person, for small hurts and bigger ones.

Seen fast, a sentence from three weeks ago is three things. On top, the words, which you can still quote. Under them, what they seemed to say about you. Under that, the question of whether it will happen again. The roots are balance and signal and noise. The chapter slows down on repair.

01

## Hurt is real, and healing takes time.

Being hurt by someone shows that something mattered, whether it was the person, or your trust in them, or your sense of being respected. The mind replays hurts because it's trying to understand them and keep you safe from the next one. Healing rarely goes in a straight line. The hurt can come back on an anniversary, or out of nowhere, which doesn't mean you've failed.

Months after a friend said something cruel to him at a party, Kwesi still feels a jolt whenever the song that was playing comes on the radio. It happened again on Sunday, chopping onions. He said, out loud, to nobody, "Oh, that," turned the radio down, and carried on with the onions.

**What a hurt is about**

When Leary and colleagues asked people about times their feelings were hurt, the common thread was feeling less valued by someone, usually someone they knew well. A stranger's remark stings for an afternoon. A friend's can stay for months.

**Leary and colleagues (1998)** · *Moderate: based on people's recollections; the idea is widely supported*

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY

"This hurts because it mattered." "A feeling coming back doesn't mean I'm back at the start."

02

## Every close relationship has breaks. Repair is what counts.

No relationship is smooth all the time, because people snap, forget, misread each other and let each other down. Research on parents and babies, on couples and on therapy all points the same way. Breaks are normal, and what matters most is whether they get mended. A small repair, made soon, often leaves a relationship feeling safer than before the break.

Orange juice, a full glass, right across the breakfast table and into the toast rack. Toby's dad shouted, not a huge shout, but enough. Twenty minutes later he sat down next to him on the couch. "I was grumpy and I shouted. That wasn't fair, spills happen. Want to help me make a new one?" They went and did it together. Toby poured, very slowly, with his tongue out, and slopped some, and they both pretended he hadn't.

**Even therapy has ruptures**

Across 11 studies, repairing breaks in the relationship between therapist and client went with better results. Training therapists in repair didn't show a clear effect on outcomes in the six studies that tested it, which is a useful bit of honesty.

**Eubanks, Muran and Safran (2018)** · *Strong: a meta-analysis, though the main finding is correlational*

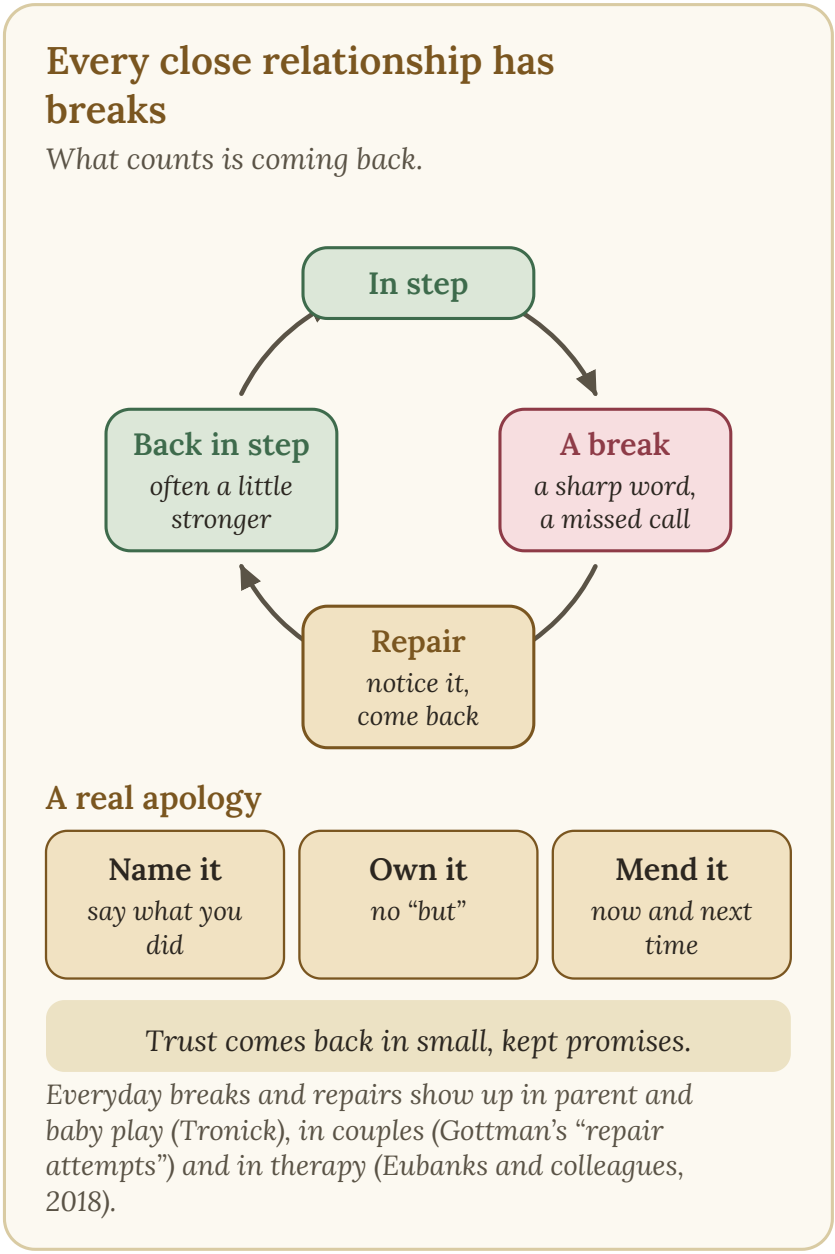



FIGURE 16 Every close relationship has breaks. What counts is the repair. A real apology names it, owns it and mends it.

03

## Telling someone they hurt you.

People can't mend what they don't know about. Saying "that hurt" is a risk, but it gives the relationship a chance. It works best when you describe what happened and how it felt, and leave out what kind of person they are. Pick a calm moment, well away from the middle of a fight.

Amara had a stronger word ready, one she'd been working on for days. On a walk with her friend, not over the phone, she said this instead. "When you told the group about my breakup before I was ready, I felt exposed. I'd like to be the one who shares my news." Her friend, who had honestly thought she was helping, went bright red. There was a long, awful pause next to a bench with a brass plaque on it for somebody called Maud. Then the friend said, "God. Yes. Sorry," and they walked on. It was a bit stiff for the rest of the walk and fine by the following week.

Before you say it, try writing it down in three short lines, one for what happened, one for how you felt and one for what you'd like.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 11

**Write it through**

*Carys, writing to her brother Owen*

### Write it, wait, then send

Who is it to?

Partner · Co-parent or ex · *Family* · Friend · Roommate · Coworker · More than one person · Someone else

Their name (optional)

*Owen*

Your name (optional)

*Carys*

What kind of message?

*Raise something* · Reply to something · Make a plan · Say sorry · I need a pause

What happened (facts only, one thing)

*At Dad's 70th on Saturday, you said to everyone at the table that I don't visit. I visited three times in September.*

How it landed for me

tired · rushed · frustrated · unseen · taken for granted · overwhelmed · stretched thin · worried · *hurt* · disappointed · left out · alone with it · confused · *embarrassed* · annoyed · sad · on edge · hopeful · grateful

What I'm asking for (one clear ask)

*Could we talk on the phone this week about how we share the visits?*

What I'm NOT saying (optional, but it helps)

*I'm not angry with you as a person.*

When I'd like a reply

Today · Tomorrow · *By the weekend* · No rush

A GENTLE CHECK

House rules: ✓ One topic · ✓ Facts, not verdicts · ✓ No always or never · ✓ No sarcasm or ALL CAPS · ✓ No "you" accusations · ✓ Says what you're asking for · ✓ A reply-by time

No sharp words found. It reads as calm and clear.

*Made-up example. Then the tool asks her to wait before she sends it.*

Fill in your own: Write it through (spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through)

04

## A real apology names it, owns it, and mends it.

"Sorry if you were upset" doesn't heal much. A real apology says what you did, takes responsibility without excuses, shows you understand what it did to the other person, and offers to put it right or do things differently. Research, such as a study led by Roy Lewicki (2016), suggests owning it and offering repair are the parts that matter most.

At the Tuesday meeting, Leila presented an idea she'd worked out with a colleague as if it were all hers. She saw his face. She spent the evening telling herself it didn't matter, then the next morning went and found him at the coffee machine. "I presented our idea as mine. That wasn't fair to you. I'll

email the team today and say it was joint work." He said, "Okay," and then, after a moment, "Thanks." She sent the email at 9.40 and copied him in.

Next time you say sorry, check it has each of the four parts. If it went wrong in a conversation, Rewind the talk (spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder) helps you find the words, and Apology languages (spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages) has more.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

An apology lands best when it's plain: what happened, that it was yours, and what you'll do now. Rewind the talk can help you find those words.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

05

## Forgiveness isn't forgetting, excusing or going back.

Forgiveness is usually described as letting go of resentment and the wish to get even, and it happens inside you. Forgiving someone doesn't mean saying what happened was okay. It doesn't mean forgetting, or trusting them again, or keeping them in your life. It's a choice, often a slow one, and you never owe it on anyone else's schedule.

Danielle forgave her father for missing most of her childhood, though it took her well into her thirties. She keeps his visits to an hour and won't leave the children with him if he's been drinking. He knows why. They don't discuss it. For her the forgiving and the protecting sit side by side without much strain.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"I can let go of wanting to get even, and still keep my limits." "I don't have to forgive today. I can just stop feeding the anger today."

06

## You can heal even if they never say sorry.

Waiting for an apology that never comes can keep you stuck for years, because the person may be gone, or unwilling, or unable to understand. Your healing doesn't have to depend on them. You can make sense of what happened, tell your story to someone safe, and decide what it means for you now.

After the breakup, Martha wrote a letter she never sent. Four pages in pen, both sides, about what hurt and what she'd hoped for and what she was taking with her, which was mostly the good saucepans. She folded it into the back of a notebook and for a while she read it most nights, then less, and then one day in April she realized she hadn't looked at it for a month.

**Writing helps, a bit**

Pooling 146 randomized studies, Frattaroli found that writing about something painful had a small but real benefit on average. Small is the honest word, and it varies a good deal from person to person.

**Frattaroli (2006)** · *Moderate: a real but small effect that varies by person*

Writing works for a lot of people. Write about the hurt for fifteen minutes on three or four days in a row, the facts and the feelings both. If it ever makes you feel much worse, stop and talk to someone instead.

07

## Trust comes back in small, kept promises.

After trust is broken, one big apology rarely rebuilds it. Trust grows back slowly, in lots of small moments where someone does what they said they'd do. If you broke trust, being patient and consistent matters more than a grand gesture. If you were let down, it's fair to watch what someone does as well as what they say.

Declan hid a credit card debt from his partner for most of a year. When it came out it was very bad for a while. After that, on the first of every month, he left his bank statement on the kitchen table without being asked, with no speech, just the statement left by the fruit bowl. About a year in, one ordinary evening, his partner said she could breathe again. He went into the yard so she wouldn't see his face.

08

## Going back is a choice.

After a hurt, you can mend the relationship or change its shape. You can also step away. All three can be healthy.

Ellie's roommate borrowed money twice and didn't pay it back. Ellie let the first time go, because it was only ten dollars and she'd been broke herself. The second time it was fifty dollars for a train ticket to Chicago, and she said,

"I won't lend money again. I still want us to get along in the house." The roommate went quiet for two days and left a slightly pointed note about the recycling. They still do Sunday dinner together most weeks, and nobody mentions Chicago.

Three questions can guide what comes next. Has the hurt stopped? Has it been owned? Do you want this relationship in your life?

It also helps to tell one hurt from a pattern of hurt. A single hurt, owned and repaired, is something most relationships survive, and many come out closer. A pattern looks different. The same hurt keeps happening after you've named it, apologies arrive without any change, and you notice yourself saying less to avoid the next one. One bad month isn't a pattern, and neither is a partner who is slow to apologize but changes what they do.

09

## Look after the hurt part of you.

Hurt lives in the body as well as the mind, as poor sleep or a jumpy feeling that won't settle. Healing goes better with basic care, which means rest and food and moving about, people who are kind to you, and talking to yourself the way you'd talk to a hurting friend. Some people find they grow after something painful and some don't, and neither is a test you can fail.

A man at the back of the 38 bus shouted at Idris and called him names, the whole way from Angel to Dalston, and nobody else said a word. For days afterward Idris felt shaky. He told a friend. He went for long walks after work. He kept reminding himself it was about the man, and that he was safe now. Over a couple of weeks the shakiness faded, though he sat downstairs on the 38 until well into the spring.

Pick one small act of care for today, an early night or a call to someone kind. Calm tools are in Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now)

**YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART.** You can say what hurt, apologize for what you did, and look after your own healing. You can't make someone apologize or change, and you don't have to wait for them to start feeling better. Forgiveness, trust and going back are all yours to choose, in your own time.

SATURDAY, 11AM

*You wrote it all down last night, every word of it, two pages. This morning you wrote a much shorter version. When you said that, I felt small. I just wanted you to know.*

*You haven't sent it. It's sitting in your drafts between a half-finished email to the city about trash pickup and a shopping list that just says "eggs??" But the two o'clock replays have gone a bit quieter since it went onto paper.*

## How old hurts shape new reactions

What happened earlier in life can make some reactions more likely now. In surveys of tens of thousands of adults in 24 countries, most had lived through at least one traumatic event (Kessler and colleagues, 2017 · Strong evidence), and many studies have linked hard childhood experiences with health and relationship problems decades later (Felitti and colleagues, 1998 · Strong evidence). That is an association across large groups, not a forecast for any one person. A mark can be left at any age.

- In early childhood, a child who learned to watch a parent's mood may grow into an adult who scans every face in a meeting.
- In the school years, being shamed in front of a class can make any public correction sting.
- In the teens, months of being left out can make a group chat that goes quiet feel like a verdict.
- In early adulthood, a first job or first home that went badly can make the next change feel dangerous.

- In a partnership, a betrayal can make an innocent late text feel like the start of another one.
- As a parent, a frightening birth or a child's illness can leave you braced for the next emergency.
- In midlife, a layoff, a divorce or caring for a parent can wear down the reserves that used to absorb a bad day.
- In later life, losses and illness can arrive close together, with less time to recover between them.

Most people who go through something terrible recover without lasting problems (Bonanno, 2004 · Strong evidence). For some, especially after repeated or very severe events, the body's alarm stays switched on. Post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) is the clinical name for one form of this. It follows exposure to actual or threatened death, serious injury or sexual violence, and most people who go through such events don't develop it (Koenen and colleagues, 2017 · Strong evidence). Trauma responses can look like being on edge, startling easily, avoiding reminders, going numb, or meeting a small thing with the force of the old one. Those responses once helped someone get through. In a conversation they usually make things harder, because the person is answering the past as well as the present.

You might recognize it in yourself when a reaction feels older than the moment, arrives in your body before you can think, follows the same kind of trigger each time, or is hard to explain afterward. You might notice it in someone else when their reaction is far bigger than what just happened. These signs are for understanding. They are not a diagnosis, and you can't diagnose yourself or anyone else from them.

Having lived through something hard is never the person's fault. The aim is to take back control, so the old event stops running today's reaction. That usually starts small: noticing "this feels older than today," naming it, steadying your body, and then choosing what to do next. Trauma-focused therapies have the strongest evidence for PTSD (NICE, 2018 · Strong evidence).

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

**Fine all day, two ways**

Some people show how they feel as they go, so a hard day shows during the day. Others hold it together for hours, at work or school, and let go only once they're somewhere safe, which is often home. If you show it as you go, the person who falls apart at home isn't saving their worst for you. Home is where it's safe to stop holding on. If you're the one who holds it in, saying "I've used it all up today" helps the people at home read the crash for what it is.

**Where the fields meet.** Finance gives repair a plain picture: a real apology tops up a reserve of goodwill that small hurts draw down. Psychology adds the reason repairs are needed even between kind people, that intent isn't impact.

## In everyday life

Between partners, small breaks happen most days, and a quick "That came out wrong, can I try again?" mends most of them (see How to apologize so it counts). Old family hurts often need a different kind of talk from new ones, and sometimes more time apart. A friend may not know they hurt you, and "Can I tell you something that stung? I'd rather say it than drift" keeps the door open. You can even heal a hurt with someone who has died, by writing to them or talking it through with someone you trust.

- **After an affair.** The shock is real for both people. Couples can recover, and some decide to part; both can be done with care. Trust returns through kept promises over months. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-11-healing-in-depth).
- **If you decide to separate.** Part as kindly as you can. Tell children together, without blame, and never ask them to choose. Write decisions down, and consider family mediation. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-11-healing-in-depth#separating).

## If you want to help someone else with this

Listen before you advise. “That sounds really painful” helps far more than “You should just let it go.” Don’t rush them toward forgiveness, which can feel like being told their hurt doesn’t matter. Don’t push them to cut someone off, either; it’s their relationship and their choice. If you were the one who caused the hurt, give a real apology and then give them time, and don’t ask them to make you feel better about it.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
>
> “Do you want to talk it through, or would it help more to take your mind off it?” “Whatever you decide about them, I’m on your side.”

## Tools and reading on the website

**Tools** **helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now? for calming down in the moment, and the Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks) for checking your state.

**Reading** **pages to read on the website**

- Apology languages: how to say sorry so it lands, and asking for forgiveness (spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages#forgive).
- Library: forgiveness (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/conflict), what research says about apologies (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/conflict#apology-research) and repair attempts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships).
- Library: rumination (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), expressive writing (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#expressive-writing) and self-compassion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection).
- Stories from philosophy: the Second Arrow (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth).

## More for your situation

- **Families:** Adult siblings and family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · For grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children)
- **After a breakup:** On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own) · Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting)
- **Friends:** When a friendship drifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- **Children who have been hurt:** Foster, adoptive and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship)
- **After a loss:** Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

**A limit to keep in mind:** This chapter is for everyday hurts and for thinking about bigger ones. It isn't therapy.

THIS CONNECTS TO


**Part Two · Chapter IV · Two kinds of fair** — read online
*Covering kindly and saying it out loud*

**Part Three · Chapter 4 · How communication works** — page 57
*Repair in everyday talk*

**Part Three · Chapter 13 · Anger** — page 188
*When anger did the damage*

**Part Three · Chapter 7 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion** — page 102
*Guilt without shame*


PUT IT TO USE

**Upset right now?**
For calming down in the moment, and the Nervous System Ladder for checking your state
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

**Apology languages**
How to say sorry so it lands, and asking for forgiveness
spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages

# 12

PART THREE · CHAPTER 12

# Helping others well: support without fixing, boundaries, and not burning out

*How to help someone without taking over, by asking what they need, listening first, caring without drowning and keeping kind limits, and how to keep going without burning out.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Ask what kind of help they want
2. Listening is a kind of help
3. Fixing it for them can take away their power
4. Care without drowning in their feelings
5. Your limits make your help last
6. Notice when you're running on empty
7. Don't wait for someone else to step in
8. Let other people help you too
9. In everyday life
10. Caring a lot, or losing yourself?
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation


AT A GLANCE

- **Ask what kind of help they want.** "Ideas, or just someone to listen?" saves a lot of misfires.
- **Listening is help.** Fixing a problem for someone can take away their power.
- **Your limits make your help last**, and caring from a steady place helps more than drowning in their feelings.

WEDNESDAY, 7:15PM

*Your friend is telling you about her awful week. Before she's finished her first sentence you have five good ideas. You give her all five, in order, with reasons.*

*"Yeah," she says. "Maybe."*

*You both hang up feeling slightly worse, and neither of you could say why.*

Most of us want to help the people around us, and helping well is a skill, because good intentions don't always land. This chapter looks at how support works, why fixing can backfire, and how to care for people in a way you can keep up. Two tools elsewhere grew out of it. One owner per job (Part Two, Chapter II, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2), because caregivers burn out when everything counts as "just helping" and nobody else owns a job. And How much are you carrying? (Part Two, Chapter III, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3), which helps you notice you're running on empty before you snap or stop.

A friend's awful week, in quick strokes. The surface is a phone call. Underneath, two kinds of help on offer and only one wanted. Underneath that, how much each of you has left. The roots are ownership and structure, and limited capacity. The chapter slows down on both.

01

## Ask what kind of help they want.

Help comes in kinds. Some people want ideas. Some want someone to listen. Some want a practical hand, a meal or a ride, and some just want company on the couch, and giving the wrong kind, however kindly, can leave someone feeling unheard.

That phone call could have gone differently. "That sounds like a rotten week. Do you want ideas, or do you just want to have a rant?" It feels a bit formal the first few times you say it, like reading off a card, but people tend to love being asked.

## Ask what kind of help they want

*The wrong kind of help can feel like not being heard.*

**"Ideas, or just someone to listen?"**

**Listening**
*comfort, company*

**Practical**
*a ride, a meal*

**Ideas**
*advice, if asked*

**Making sense**
*thinking it through*

- Fixing it for them can take away their power.
- Care from a steady place. Your limits make your help last.
- Accepting help is part of the same circle.

*Kinds of support after House (1981). Support helps most when it fits what the person needs (Cutrona and Russell, 1990), though the evidence for exact matching is mixed.*

FIGURE 17 Ask what kind of help they want. Fixing it for them can take away their power, and your limits make your help last.

02

## Listening is a kind of help.

Being properly heard helps people calm down and think, and quite often they find their own answer. Good listening means paying attention, letting them finish, checking you understood, and showing that their feelings make sense even if you'd feel differently.

Ravi came home furious about his boss. His partner had "Just quit" ready on her tongue and kept it there. "So he had a go at you in front of everyone," she said, "after you'd stayed late all week. No wonder you're livid." Ravi's shoulders came down about two inches. Ten minutes later he was sketching out a plan on the back of a takeout menu. It was a better plan than "just quit," which he'd have hated being told anyway.

**Matching the help to the problem**

Cutrona and Russell proposed that support works best when it fits the problem: practical help for things that can be changed, comfort for things that can't. Later studies back this in part.

**Cutrona and Russell (1990)** · *Moderate: widely cited; later studies support it in part*

In one conversation today, listen for two whole minutes without giving advice, then sum up what you heard. Two minutes is longer than you think.



SUGARFOOT

Sometimes the best help is sitting close and listening, with no fixing. Listening takes energy too, so check your own tank now and then.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02

03

## Fixing it for them can take away their power.

When we love someone we want the problem gone. But doing things for people that they could do themselves can leave them feeling less capable, so helping well often means helping someone do it themselves. It's their life, and their choice.

Rosalind's son is twenty-four and struggling with a job application for the city, and she is itching to rewrite it. She can see three things wrong with the first paragraph alone. She sits on her hands. "Would you like me to read it and say what stands out?" He makes the changes himself, some of them, not

the ones she'd have made. When he gets the interview he's quietly, enormously proud, and so is she, and she doesn't mention the paragraph.

04

## Care without drowning in their feelings.

Feeling someone's pain as if it were yours can wear you out fast. Researchers separate this "empathic distress" from compassion, which is warm concern from a steadier place, still caring deeply without sinking alongside the other person. A steady helper is more use than a second person drowning.

When Abi's roommate went through a breakup, Abi cried with her every night, stopped sleeping, and was a wreck by the end of the first week. So she changed tack. Still kind, still there. But a run in the mornings, and Friday evening with her own friends, and a quiet reminder to herself, roughly hourly, that this was her roommate's pain to feel and hers to keep company with.

05

## Your limits make your help last.

Saying yes to everything leads, eventually, to resentment, exhaustion and not being able to help at all. Limits tell people what you can actually give, so your yes means something. And a kind no that comes with an offer of what you can do is still help.

Kojo's sister keeps asking to borrow money, fifty here and eighty there, and none of it comes back. He loves her and he's running out, of money and of something else. On the phone one evening, with the TV on mute, he says it. "I can't lend money anymore. I can help you go through your bills on Sunday, if you want." There's a silence long enough for him to hear her kettle click off. "Fine," she says, not fine. On Sunday she turns up with a carrier bag full of envelopes.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> "I can't do that, but I can do this." "I want to help, and I need to stop at nine tonight."

If you need words for a "not this time," Say no kindly (spreadloveandacceptance.com/refusals) helps you make your own, with something to offer instead.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Your limits keep your help going for longer. When you need to say "not this time," Say no kindly helps you find the words, with something to offer instead.

TOOL **Say no kindly: make your scripts** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/refusals

06

## Notice when you're running on empty.

People who help a lot can burn out: caregivers, parents, nurses, teachers, the friend everyone calls. The signs include feeling exhausted most of the time, or numb and cynical about the people you help, or dreading the next call, and any of them means you need some help too.

Gwen has looked after her husband since his stroke two years ago. Last month she snapped at him over the remote control, properly snapped, and felt terrible for the rest of the day. She mentioned it to her doctor almost in passing, on the way out of an appointment about her knee. The doctor sat her back down. "That sounds like caregiver strain." There's a caregivers' group on Tuesday mornings now and a few hours of respite a week. She has, she says, about a third of herself back.

Rate your energy from 1 to 10 each evening for a week. If it's often 3 or lower, ask someone for one specific kind of help. See Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers).

07

## Don't wait for someone else to step in.

When lots of people see something going wrong, each one can assume someone else will deal with it. Psychologists call this the bystander effect, and knowing about it helps you break it. Small, safe actions count. "Are you okay?" Getting a staff member.

On a train out of Philadelphia, a man was making a young woman uncomfortable, leaning in and asking where she was getting off. Yvonne didn't confront him. She sat down in the seat next to the woman and said brightly, "Hi! Is this the train to Chicago?" The woman grabbed the conversation with both hands. They talked about Chicago, which neither of

them knew much about, until the next stop, when the man got up and moved down the car.

It helps to decide in advance what your safe move would be, distracting or getting help or checking in afterward. People with a plan act. People without one tend to freeze.

Sometimes the person in trouble is someone you know well. If someone tells you they're thinking of ending their life, or you're worried they might be, it's okay to ask them plainly. A review led by Dazzi and colleagues (2014) found that asking doesn't put the idea in someone's head, and it can bring relief. You don't need perfect words, and you don't have to fix anything. Listen, stay with them, and help them tell someone else they trust.

08

## Let other people help you too.

Helping goes both ways, and people who are good at giving help are often hopeless at receiving it. Letting someone help is a gift to them as well, because most people like being useful to someone they care about. And relationships where only one person ever helps start to feel lopsided.

After the baby came, Nkechi said "We're fine, thanks" to every single offer, including several when she very much wasn't. When she finally said yes to the woman next door, who had offered a lasagna four times, the neighbor was so pleased she nearly dropped it. They walk their strollers around the park together on Thursday mornings now. Say yes to the next small offer of help you get, even if you could manage.

**People say yes more than we think**

In a set of experiments and field studies, people asking for help underestimated, by as much as half, how many others would agree, mainly because they forgot how awkward it is to say no. It has been repeated many times since.

**Flynn and Lake (2008)** · *Strong: several experiments and field studies, widely replicated*

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"Yes, thank you. That would really help." "Could you do one thing for me this week?"

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 12

**One owner per job: sharing the care**

*Margaret and Alan, with their daughter Sue*

## One owner per job: sharing the care

Person A
*Margaret*

Person B
*Alan*

Person C
*Sue*

Date of this list
*October 6, 2026*

### Who owns each job

| Job | How often | Roughly how long? | Owner | Helper or backup | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Medicines and the pill box (as the care team directs)* | *Weekly* | 0.5 | *Margaret* | *Sue* | *Sue checks it on Sundays* |
| *Book and go along to medical appointments* | *As needed* | 3 | *Sue* | *Margaret* | *Sue drives; Mom comes too* |
| *Insurance and paperwork* | *Monthly* | 1 | *Alan* | *Sue* | *Dad can do this from his chair* |
| *Night care and nighttime calls* | *Daily* | 1 | *Margaret* | | *Ask the nurse about a night sitter* |
| *Sunday call with the family* | *Weekly* | 0.5 | *Alan* | | |
| *Book respite: a break for the main caregiver* | *Monthly* | 0.5 | *Sue* | | *Mom's Thursday afternoon off* |
| *Groceries and meals* | *Weekly* | 2 | *Sue* | *Margaret* | *Online shop, Sue orders* |

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

**Jobs with an owner**
7 of 7. Every job has an owner.

**Who's carrying more right now**
Margaret 63% · Alan 9% · Sue 28%. Does this match what you agreed? If it doesn't match, ask which job could move first. It's a starting point for a talk, not a scorecard.

### Changes to the list

| Date | What changed | Who |
|---|---|---|
| *6 Oct 2026* | *Sue takes Tuesday nights from next week, so Margaret gets one full night's sleep.* | *Margaret, Alan and Sue* |

*Made-up example. This is about who owns each job, not medical advice.*

Fill in your own: One owner per job (sharing the care)
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can offer help and listen well, and be honest about your limits. You can't make someone accept help or get better on your schedule. Their life and their choices are theirs.

THE NEXT WEDNESDAY, 7:15PM

*She rings again. This time, before she gets going, you ask. "Ideas, or do you just need to vent?"*

*She laughs. "Vent."*

*So you listen, through her manager, and her landlord, and the cat's vet bill ($260, for a sock). At the end she says she thinks she knows what she's going to do. You realize you haven't offered a single idea, and you had at least four.*

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

### Help, two ways

Some people want ideas the moment they share a problem. Others want to be heard and nothing more, and an idea offered too soon feels like being corrected. If you fix, the listener isn't ungrateful. They wanted company first. If you need to be heard, the fixer isn't dismissing you. Ideas are how they show they care. Asking "Ideas, or just listening?" saves both of you an evening.

**Where the fields meet.** Business explains the bystander moment exactly: work that belongs to everyone belongs to no one, so one person has to own it. Holistic therapies add the other half, which is to start with the body, because a helper who never rests stops being able to help. Some of these practices are well studied and some are debated.

## In everyday life

Helping yourself counts too, and you can ask yourself the same question, ideas or rest. Caring for a parent, or a child with extra needs, is long-haul help, so share the load early (see Caring for someone you love). The friend everyone calls needs someone to call too. Covering for a struggling coworker is kind for a week, and after that it needs a real conversation with the team. In an emergency, point to one person ("You in the blue coat, please call for help"), because a crowd tends to wait. If you have ADHD, helping can feel interesting and urgent, so a fast yes comes easily, and "I'd like to help. Let me check my week and come back to you tonight" buys you time. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-12-helping-in-depth).

## Caring a lot, or losing yourself?

People sometimes call a devoted helper "codependent." Codependency is not a diagnosis, and researchers debate how to define it, so it's worth being careful with it.

For something to be caring that has tipped into losing yourself, these are usually all present:

- your mood rises and falls with the other person's, most days,
- you can't say no to them, even when you want to,
- you keep covering for choices that hurt them or you,
- your own needs, friends and rest have quietly disappeared for months.

Not enough on its own:

- caring a lot about someone,
- helping a partner or parent through a hard year,
- being the person who organizes the family,
- a culture or family where people come first and look after each other.

If you recognize yourself in the first list, the aim is to take some of yourself back, not to care less. One protected evening a week is a start.

## Common mix-ups

People think helping means solving the problem. Often it means listening, or being there, or helping someone find their own answer. People think good helpers never say no, when it's knowing their limits that lets good helpers last. And "I'll make it worse if I step in" stops a lot of people. There are small, safe ways to help, and doing nothing often feels worse to the person in trouble.

## If you want to help someone else with this

The helpers around you need looking after too. Notice them, the caregiver, the friend everyone calls, the coworker who always covers, and ask how they are as if you mean it. Offer something specific, because "Can I take the kids on Saturday morning?" is far easier to accept than "Let me know if you need anything." Give them permission to rest ("You're allowed a night off. I've got this"). And if a helper seems burned out, share Caring for someone you love.

Sometimes it's as simple as asking them, "You look after everyone. Who looks after you?"

## Tools and reading on the website

**Tools helpers you use on the website**

- Check-ins (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins), for tender conversations, and Professor Puddles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask) if you want help finding words.

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Library: active listening (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/communication), advice or support? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/communication#advice-vs-support) and validation (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/communication#validation-in-conversation).
- Library: empathic distress and compassion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection) and social support (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection#social-support).
- Library: burnout (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress) and caregiver strain (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress#caregiver-strain).
- Library: saying no (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/communication#saying-no) and boundaries (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/communication#boundaries).
- Stories from philosophy: the circles of Hierocles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth).

## More for your situation

- **Caregivers:** Caring for someone you love · When one of you is sick (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill)
- **Friends:** Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- **Parents and grandparents:** For parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) · For grandparents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents) · When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids)

- **At work:** At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work) · For counselors, coaches and group leaders (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)
- **After a loss:** Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

**A limit to keep in mind:** This chapter is about everyday helping. It isn't therapy.

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THIS CONNECTS TO


**Preface to Part Two · The work nobody sees** read online
*The care work nobody sees*

**Part Two · Chapter II · Is the split working?** read online
*Sharing the load so it lasts*

**Part Three · Chapter 8 · Loss, grief and big life changes** page 116
*Helping someone through grief*

**Part Three · Chapter 2 · Stress and the nervous system** page 28
*Noticing your own stress first*


PUT IT TO USE

**Check-ins**
For tender conversations, and Professor Puddles if you want help finding words
spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins

**Stories from philosophy: the circles of Hierocles**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth

# 13

PART THREE · CHAPTER 13

# Anger: what it's for and what to do with it

*What anger is for, what to do in the hot minutes, how to repair afterward, and how to tell when anger has turned into harm. For anyone, in any kind of relationship, or on your own.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Anger is a signal about something that matters
2. Anger often guards a softer feeling
3. Anger rises in the body fast
4. In the hot minutes: slow the body first
5. Letting rip doesn't empty it
6. Step back and look from the outside
7. Say it, don't throw it
8. After anger, repair
9. When anger becomes harm
10. If you're a teenager
11. In everyday life
12. Common mix-ups
13. If you want to help someone else with this
14. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation


AT A GLANCE

- **Anger is a signal** that something seems unfair, blocked or threatening. The feeling is allowed, and what you do with it is the part you choose.
- **The first minutes are about the body.** Slow down, breathe out long, and step away with a time to come back.
- **Letting rip doesn't empty anger.** Shouting tends to feed it, while calming the body, putting it into words and repairing any sharp moments help more.

- **Anger that hurts someone has become harm.** The feeling is yours to own, and so is what you do with it.

TUESDAY, 6:10PM

*Your brother. Cant do thurs after all sorry!! work thing*

*Thursday is Mom's hospital appointment. The one with the specialist, the one you've been going on about for three weeks, and it's the third time this month he's done this. Your jaw goes and your face goes hot. Your thumbs are already moving, TYPICAL. You never, and the message is one tap from sent.*

Plenty of us were taught that anger was rude, or dangerous, or grew up around anger that was frightening. Anger itself is an ordinary human feeling, though, and it very often points at something real. It also sits under two tools elsewhere. The Calm-Down Kit (Part One, Now, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now) works because anger rises in the body first and slowing the body is what makes words possible. And letting a comment land before you react (Part Two, Chapter IV, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4) is the stepping back described further on.

The canceled appointment, seen quickly. The surface is a sibling who let you down again. Underneath, anger, fast and hot. Underneath that, fear about Mom and tiredness. The roots are signal and noise, and state and setting. The chapter goes back through those layers slowly.

01

## Anger is a signal about something that matters.

Anger usually says something is unfair, or something's in your way, or a line has been crossed. It pushes you *toward* a problem so you'll change it. It can also land on the wrong person, or come out far bigger than the thing in front of it.

Somebody keeps eating Shabnam's lunch from the office fridge. Week one, she assumes a mistake. Week two, she writes her name on the box in marker pen. Week three, the box is empty again and has been put back in the fridge, neatly, with the lid on, which is the bit that does it. Her anger has now told

her very clearly that a line has been crossed, and it's the anger, frankly, that gets her to raise it at the Monday meeting. (It was the new starter. He thought the fridge was communal. He bought her a meal deal and looked like he wanted to die.)

Next time you're angry, finish this privately. "I'm angry because something I care about, which is ___, seems ___."

**Anger moves you toward things**

Most unpleasant feelings make us back away. A review by Carver and Harmon-Jones argued that anger usually does the opposite: like eagerness, it pushes you toward the goal or the obstacle. That's what makes it good at showing what matters, and risky to act on at full heat.

**Carver and Harmon-Jones (2009)** · *Moderate: an influential review; the approach view is still debated*

02

## Anger often guards a softer feeling.

Anger can arrive first because it feels stronger and safer than whatever is under it, which is often hurt, or fear, or shame, or plain exhaustion. Chapter 1 (page 14) calls this layers, and the layer underneath usually tells you what you actually need.

Frankie was an hour late home. She is sixteen. Her dad was waiting in the hall when the key went in the door and what came out of him was mostly about curfews and rules and respect, at volume. She gave as good as she got. It was only later, sitting on the stairs, that he told her about the hour itself. Standing at the front window. Phone in his hand. Checking the bus app over and over. Working out which ER. She went quiet then. "Sorry," she said, and this time she meant it.

YOU COULD SAY

"I'm angry, and I think underneath I was really scared." "I came across as angry, but I think I'm actually hurt."

03

## Anger rises in the body fast.

A hot face, a tight jaw, a pounding heart and a voice going up are the body getting ready for a fight, and it takes seconds. When anger is high, careful thinking gets a lot harder, and listening harder still. Chapter 2 (page 28) calls

this being flooded.

Halfway through an argument about the trash (whose turn, and also, it emerged, whose turn for the last four years) Meera noticed that her hands were shaking. She also realized she hadn't heard a single thing her roommate had said for at least a minute. She'd been composing, and that was her sign. Learn your own early signs, if you can, whether it's a tight jaw or talking faster or being very, very reasonable in a slightly high voice.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Anger moves faster than words. The Calm-Down Kit is a plan you make on a calm day, for the hot minutes.

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11

04

## In the hot minutes: slow the body first.

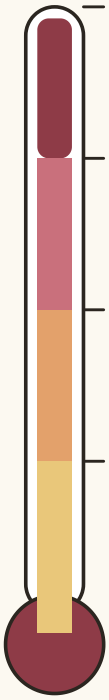
When anger is high, settle your body before you try to sort anything out. Stop talking. Stop typing. Breathe out slowly, so the out-breath is longer than the in-breath. Unclench your hands. If you can, get out of the room for a bit. A large review of 154 studies by Kjærvik and Bushman (2024) found that activities which calm the body, like slow breathing, relaxation and mindfulness, reduced anger, while ones that rev you up showed little or no benefit.

Fractions, at the kitchen table, 7:30, question four. Ben could feel his voice getting tighter with every "But *why* is it a half?" "I'm getting frustrated," he said in the end, "and that's not your fault. I'm getting a glass of water. Five minutes." He stood at the sink, looking out at the dark backyard, and drank the whole glass. When he came back they did the rest of the sheet together, and both of them got number six wrong, confidently.

Make the plan on a calm day. Your early sign, the words you'll say, where you'll go for ten minutes. Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now) has steps for the very worst moments.

## Anger rises fast

*What helps depends on how hot it is.*



**Hot minutes**
Slow the body first: long out-breaths. Step away, with a time to come back.

**Angry**
Don't solve it now. Problems can wait; sharp words are hard to take back.

**Annoyed**
Notice the body: hot face, tight jaw, clenched hands.

**Irritated**
Say it early, plainly and kindly.

✕ **Letting rip doesn't empty it. It feeds it.**

**Once cooler: say it, don't throw it.**
Then repair any sharp moments.

*In a review of 154 studies (Kjærvik and Bushman, 2024), activities that calm the body reduced anger; revving it up did not help.*

FIGURE 18 Anger rises fast, and what helps depends on how hot it is. In the hot minutes, slow the body first. Letting rip feeds it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 13

**The Calm-Down Kit**

*Pat, a grandmother raising her grandson Jay, 13*

## The Calm-Down Kit

Whose kit is this? (your name)
*Pat (Grandma)*

Date
*October 4, 2026*

### Part A: What tends to start it

| What tends to start it | How it shows up in my body first |
|---|---|
| *Door slammed after a call with his mom* | *Shoulders up by my ears* |
| *Being shouted at in front of the neighbors* | *Hot face, can't find words* |

### Part A: My two defaults

First default
*Gating (lower the lights, step out)*

Second, if the first isn't available
*Low, steady sound*

### Part A: My pause line

In my words
*I'm too wound up to listen well. I'm making tea for twenty minutes. I'll come and find you in half an hour.*

### Our pause plan (agree it together, and share it)

Our pause word or signal
*"Coffee break"*

The shortest break we take
*20 minutes*

How we set the time to come back
*Whoever pauses says a time before they go*

The first sentence when we come back
*"I'm back. Let's start again, slower."*

### Part B: In the moment

Say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step. Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

### Part C: Coming back

| Time | What I did | How I feel now |
|---|---|---|
| 5:10pm | *Gating (lower the lights, step out)* | *Settled enough* |

WHERE THAT LEAVES YOU

**Next**
Settled enough: go back to the conversation, at the time you named. When you come back, start with one small, simple task, like putting the dishes away.

Next small action
*Sit with Jay and agree one screen-time rule*

If you put the conversation off: when you'll pick it back up
*After tea, at 6*

☑ I'm going with this

*Made-up example. Jay agreed the pause plan with her on a calm Sunday. "Gating," one of the kit's calming steps, means cutting down what comes in through the senses: lower the lights, turn the sound down, or step out of the room.*

Fill in your own: The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11)

05

## Letting rip doesn't empty it.

A lot of people believe anger works like steam. Shout, slam a door, hit a pillow, and it's out, and you're calmer. It's a lovely tidy idea. The research doesn't support it. In a well-known study by Bushman (2002), angry people who hit a punching bag while thinking about the person who annoyed them ended up angrier than before.

Going over what happened again and again in your head has a similar effect. In studies by Bushman and colleagues (2005), people who dwelt on a provocation were later more aggressive, even toward someone who only mildly annoyed them. Anger fades faster when the body is calmed and the mind has something else to do for a while.

After a fight with a colleague, Neville spent his lunch break telling three separate people how awful she was. Each telling got a bit better. By two o'clock he was angrier than he'd been at noon, and had a headache. The next time it happened he walked to the river and back instead and didn't tell anyone anything, which nearly killed him. By two he could think about the actual problem. He still thinks she was out of order, and says so, but at a normal volume and to fewer people.

06

## Step back and look from the outside.

Once your body has come down a bit, try looking at the moment as if you were watching from the other side of the room. What actually happened? What might the other person have been dealing with? In experiments by Mischkowski, Kross and Bushman (2012), people who looked back on an annoying moment "like a fly on the wall," instead of reliving it, felt less angry and acted less aggressively. Rethinking what happened, which psychologists call reappraisal (Gross, 1998), helps too.

One way in is to write two lines about it in the third person, with your own name. "Wes got angry because…" It feels a bit mad. It works annoyingly well. Wes himself, canceled on by a friend for the third time, got as far as "Wes got angry because Matt canceled again, and Matt is…" and stopped, because Matt is looking after his dad, who has been in and out of the hospital since June. The anger didn't go. It turned, slowly, into worry, which was at least pointing the right way.

07

## Say it, don't throw it.

Anger is often a fair message sent in a hurtful way. Once you're calmer you can still say you were angry, and why, without going for anyone, by keeping to what happened and how you felt and what you're asking for.

"You always let me down" was what Carol wanted to say to her sister. What she actually sent, after two drafts and a cup of tea, was this. "When you canceled Mom's appointment again I felt really angry, and on my own with it. Can we sort out who takes her for the next three months?" It's longer, and it

is also the only version that gets anyone to the hospital. Chapter 4 (page 57) has more on saying hard things.

**Two versions of the same fight**
When people wrote about a time they angered someone and a time someone angered them, the two kinds of story differed in how serious the harm seemed, how understandable it was and whether it was over. Same sort of event, told from two different places.

**Baumeister, Stillwell and Wotman (1990)** · *Moderate: a classic study of people's own written memories*

YOU COULD SAY

"I was angry about what happened on Monday. Can I tell you why?"
"When ___ happened, I felt ___, and what I'm asking for is ___."



SUGARFOOT

Say it slowly, in one plain sentence. A soft start makes it far easier for the other person to hear you.

TOOL **Cool-down corner: soften a tense moment** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/soften-a-tense-moment

08

## After anger, repair.

Everyone gets angry, and most of us say something sharp now and then. What happens next matters a lot, because a short, real repair rebuilds trust. Name what you did, with no "but" on the end, and say what you'll do differently.

The blue vase from the hall table is on the floor in about nine pieces and Grandma Jean has just shouted, really shouted, and Jayden is crying. An hour later she finds him on the stairs. She sits down next to him, which takes her a while with her knees. "I shouted, and that was scary," she says. "You matter to me far more than any vase. I'm sorry." He leans on her shoulder for a bit, and then he asks if they can glue it, so they try. It now has a very visible crack and lives on the landing, where she says it reminds her of something. Chapter 11 (page 161) has more on apologies that land.

YOU COULD SAY

"I was sharp with you earlier. That wasn't fair, and I'm sorry." "I'm still upset about what happened, and I also shouldn't have spoken to you that way."

09

## When anger becomes harm.

Feeling angry is human. But some things done in anger are harm, whatever the feeling behind them: hitting, pushing, throwing things at or near someone, breaking their things, threatening, or shouting so someone is scared. Anger is never a reason someone deserves to be hurt.

Being angry, even loudly, is different from intimidation. Anger becomes intimidation when these are present together: it happens again and again, it arrives when the other person disagrees or says no, it decides what happens next, and people start changing what they say and do to avoid it. A raised voice in one hard conversation that gets repaired isn't that. Neither is being loud by nature, saying a strong feeling plainly, or crying and shouting during a meltdown. Ask yourself whether your anger passes and gets repaired, and whether the other person can still say no to you.

For example, a man realizes his partner and children go quiet when he comes home in a bad mood. He doesn't hit anyone, but they have started keeping out of his way, and he decides to do something about it.

YOU COULD SAY

"I think my anger is scaring people I love. I want help with it."

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can learn your early signs, settle your body, say what made you angry in words, and repair when you get it wrong. You can't make someone else calm down.

TUESDAY, 6:40PM

*You put the phone face down on the arm of the sofa and walk around the block, breathing out long and feeling slightly silly about it, and somewhere near the postbox on the corner you notice what's underneath, which is that you're tired and you're frightened about Mom. Back home you delete the capitals and write, "I'm really frustrated. This is the third time and I feel on my own with Mom's care. Can we talk tonight and make a plan?"*

*He reads it at 6:52. By ten there's still no reply, and you go to bed not knowing who's driving her on Thursday.*

## If you're a teenager

Ten o'clock, and Maisie's dad has taken her phone. Right in the middle of a group chat about Saturday. She shouts and slams her bedroom door hard enough to rattle the picture on the landing, and then lies on her bed composing speeches. The next morning, calmer and also starving, she tells him it felt like he didn't trust her, says sorry about the door, and asks for ten minutes' warning next time. He says fine. He also says he'd much rather hear this over breakfast than through a door, which she thinks is a bit much, but lets go.

Being angry with a parent is normal, and the fights often feel most intense in the middle teens. A rule given out of care is not control, even when it feels unfair, and a calm request the next day works more often than a slammed door.

YOU COULD SAY

"I'm too angry to talk properly. Can we talk tomorrow?" "I don't mind the rule so much as how it happened." "Could we try it for two weeks and then check?"

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

**Anger, sent and heard**

Some people say anger fast and plainly and are over it within minutes. Others go very quiet and very polite, and it can last for days. If you're quick, the quiet person may still be furious long after you've moved on, so check. If you're slow and quiet, the quick one's outburst may be bigger in sound than in meaning. Both versions carry the same message: something mattered.

**Where the fields meet.** The art of debating offers a useful rule for the hot minutes: separate the claim from the person, and say the strongest version of their point first. Music explains why it so often goes wrong anyway, because tone and tempo carry more than the words, and a rising voice is heard before any sentence is.

## In everyday life

Anger at yourself counts. "I'm so stupid" is anger turned inward, and it helps to talk to yourself the way you would to a friend who'd done the same thing (Chapter 7, page 102, goes further). With a partner, agree a pause word on a calm day, and a time you'll always come back. Children copy what we do with anger far more than anything we say about it. At work anger is common and rarely spoken, and "I'm frustrated about the deadline change, can we talk about what's realistic?" keeps it useful.

If you have ADHD, anger can come fast and big and go just as fast, so plan for the speed. A three-word pause line ("Back in ten") and a rule to wait before you send anything. If you're managing a clash between two other people, hear each of them on their own first and then together, always about what happened and never about each other. Quite often the fight is about the setup, two people who both believe they own the same job. The full chapter has a worked example (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-13-anger-in-depth).

## Common mix-ups

Anger itself isn't a bad feeling. It's normal and it carries information, and it's some of the things done in anger that cause harm. Letting it out isn't the healthy option it sounds like, because shouting and hitting things tend to keep anger going. "They made me angry, so it's their fault I shouted" mixes up two separate things. Someone can do something unfair, and what you do next is still yours. And holding it in isn't as safe as it looks. Anger swallowed for years comes out sideways, as coldness or sarcasm or a sudden explosion over a teaspoon, so saying it calmly and early is the safer road.

## If you want to help someone else with this

You don't have to stay and calm someone down. If you do stay, speak lower and slower and leave the argument until they've come down. Then listen for the message underneath. There's often something fair in it, and you can take that part seriously while still saying the way it came out wasn't okay. Something like "I want to hear this, and I can't while we're both shouting. Can we try again at seven?" keeps hold of both halves.

## Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

**Workpapers** **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11): a plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments.

**Tools** **helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now?: steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.

**Reading** **pages to read on the website**

- When we keep having the same fight (spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-to-stop-fighting-with-your-partner) and When one talks and one goes quiet (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw).
- How to apologize so it counts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages).

- The library: anger (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), going over and over things (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#rumination), rethinking versus holding it in (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#reappraisal-suppression), time-outs (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/conflict) and managing flooding (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/conflict#managing-flooding).

## More for your situation

- For parents: help with your own anger (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) · Repair after you've scared a child (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents#repair-scared)
- For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers)
- At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles**
*Leftover stress behind a reaction* — read online

**Part Three · Chapter 1 · How feelings work**
*Feelings as signals* — page 14

**Part Three · Chapter 11 · Healing after hurt**
*Repair after the hot minutes* — page 161

**Part One · Next · Who you are becoming**
*A Calm-Down Kit made on a calm day* — read online

PUT IT TO USE



**The Calm-Down Kit**
A plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11



**Upset right now?**
Steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

# 14

PART THREE · CHAPTER 14

# Personality, temperament and change across life

*What personality is, where temperament comes in, how people change across their lives, and how to live and work with people who are made differently from you, without putting anyone in a box.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Traits work like dials
2. Temperament is the starting point
3. Situations matter too
4. Introvert and extravert is about energy, not liking people
5. People change across life
6. You can change on purpose, a little at a time
7. Every trait has gifts and costs
8. Differences are usually about fit
9. In everyday life
10. Narcissistic, toxic and other labels people reach for
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation


AT A GLANCE

- **Traits work like dials.** Everyone sits somewhere along each one, and most people are near the middle.
- **Temperament is a starting point.** Babies already differ in how active, cautious or easily upset they are, and what happens next matters too.
- **People keep changing.** On average people grow steadier and more organized as they get older, and you can change on purpose, slowly.
- **Most clashes between personalities are about fit**, and nobody has to be at fault.

SATURDAY, 3:00PM

*Your aunt's seventieth, in the function room above the golf club. You're standing by the cake, minding your own business, when she tells the whole room, "Oh, she was always the shy one!"*

*Everybody laughs, and you laugh along with them, and something stings.*

*You're forty-two. Every weekday at twenty to nine you stand in front of thirty eight-year-olds and get them to sit down, which takes some doing. So are you still the shy one? Were you ever?*

We describe each other by personality all the time, as laid-back, or a worrier, or the organized one, and descriptions like those have a way of setting hard. This chapter is about how personality actually works, what stays put and what moves. Two tools elsewhere build on it. The "How to talk to me" card and the style quiz (Part One, Now, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now) describe how you lean on a few dials, which is more use than knowing which box somebody once put you in. And One owner per job (Part Two, Chapter II, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2) arranges the jobs round people's differences, so nobody has to turn into someone else to share a house.

Quickly, one "difficult" colleague has three layers. On the surface, behavior you don't like. Underneath, a trait, a dial set differently from yours. Underneath that, a situation that suits one setting and not the other. The roots are limited capacity and ownership and structure. Slowly now, dial by dial.

01

## Traits work like dials.

Personality is the usual pattern in how you think and feel and act. Many psychologists describe it with five broad traits, often called the "Big Five": **openness** (curious about new ideas and experiences), **conscientiousness** (organized and careful), **extraversion** (drawn to people and busy places), **agreeableness** (warm and cooperative) and **emotional stability** (how steady your moods are).

The same five turned up in work such as McCrae and Costa (1987), whether people rated themselves or were rated by people who knew them well. Each runs from low to high, and most people sit near the middle of most of them. That's the bit online quizzes leave out. Two friends did one on the train to Santa Cruz and were told, very confidently, that one was an introvert and the other an extravert. Then they looked at the actual numbers. Four points apart, both bang in the middle. They spent the rest of the journey arguing about which of them was more middle.

If you're curious, mark where you think you sit on each dial from one to ten, and ask a close friend where they'd put you. The gap is often the interesting bit.

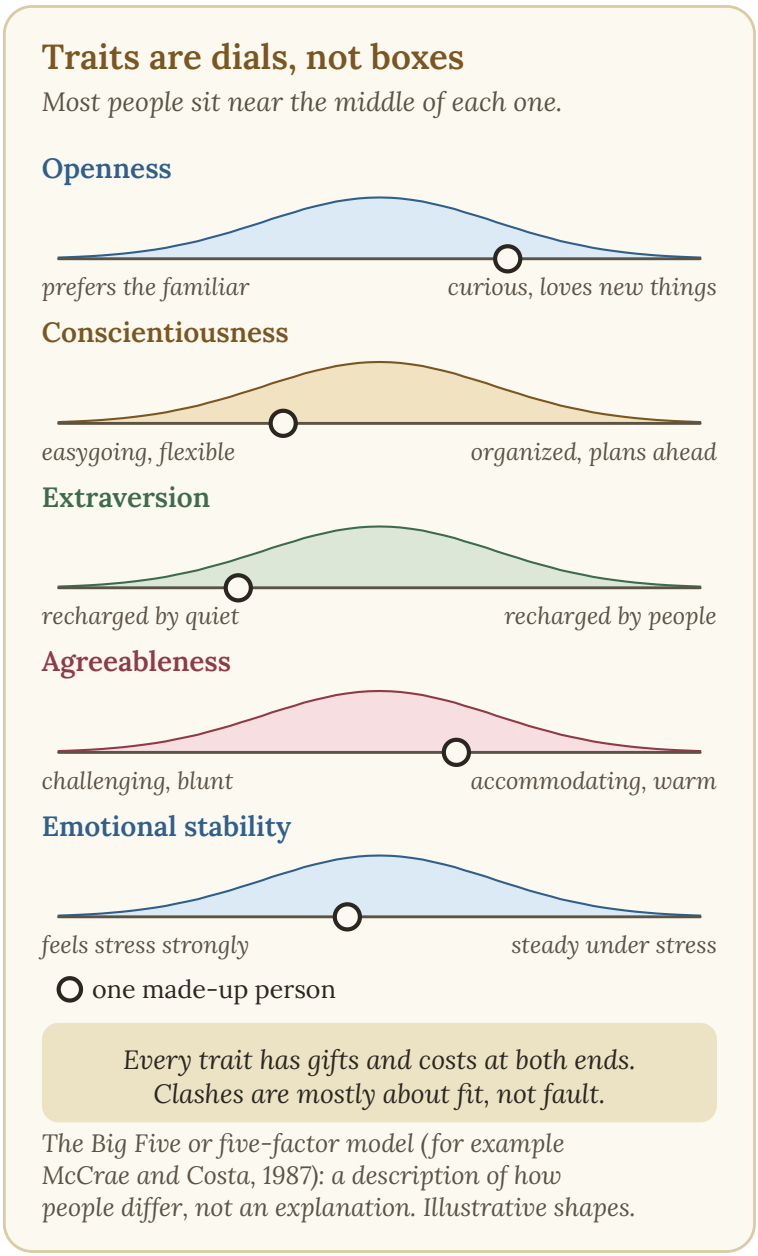



FIGURE 19 Traits work like dials, and most people sit near the middle of each. Illustrative shapes.

02

## Temperament is the starting point.

Temperament is the part of personality you can see very early on. Some babies are on the go from the moment they wake. Some are calm. Some take to a new routine right away and some need a week. Some flinch at every loud noise. In their long-running study, Thomas and Chess (1977) described these early differences and the idea of "goodness of fit," meaning how well a child's temperament suits what the people and places around them expect.

Isla is two and cried at every new playgroup. Her mom tried coaxing her into the circle, then bribing her, then (once, quietly) begging. In the end she just sat at the edge of the church hall with Isla on her lap, feeling a bit silly, while everyone else did "The Wheels on the Bus." It smelled of orange drink and floor polish. Week three, Isla climbed down on her own, walked to the sand table, and didn't look back. Her mom, slightly put out, had a cookie.

**Sensitive isn't the same as shy**

Elaine and Arthur Aron described a trait they called sensory-processing sensitivity, taking things in deeply, and found it was partly separate from introversion. Researchers still argue about its exact shape. Still, the child hanging back may be taking everything in rather than shrinking from it.

**Aron and Aron (1997)** · *Moderate: a widely used measure; the trait's structure is still debated*

YOU COULD SAY

"You like to watch first. That's fine. Join in when you're ready." (to yourself) "I need time to warm up. That's how I'm made."

03

## Situations matter too.

Personality describes a pattern, and patterns have exceptions. The same person can be loud with family and quiet at work, endlessly patient with toddlers and very short with call centers. A trait tells you what someone tends to do across lots of situations and a good deal less about the one in front of you.

Anita had decided her new colleague was cold. Polite, competent, cold. Then came the fundraiser soccer game, and there he was in a borrowed bib two sizes too small, shouting encouragement at a goalkeeper who was letting in

everything. On Monday Anita sat looking around the open-plan office with its gray partitions and humming lights and wondered how much of what she'd seen was the room.

04

## Introvert and extravert is about energy, not liking people.

People who are more introverted often like people a lot. What they find is that busy, noisy company uses energy up, and they need quiet afterward to get it back. People who are more extraverted tend to be topped up by company. Most of us are a mix (sometimes called an ambivert), and every point on the dial just needs different things to be at its best.

> **Happy now, tired later**
> Forty-eight people tracked for twelve days felt better while acting outgoing and more tired about three hours later, introverts and extraverts alike. It's a small study, and the authors say so.
>
> **Leikas and Ilmarinen (2017)** · *Early: a small study (48 people); the authors asked for it to be repeated*

Eleven o'clock at a wedding in a barn outside Hexham. Fraser wants the after-party in the local bar. Luke wants bed and silence and possibly never to hear "Mr. Brightside" again. They've had this exact standoff at four previous weddings. This time Fraser goes for an hour and Luke walks back to the hotel along the lane with his shoes in his hand, and they meet at breakfast, one of them hoarse and the other one smug, both of them happy. What Luke said, for once, was "I loved tonight, and I'm out of social energy," which he'd practiced on the walk from the car.



TIDBIT

Some people recharge in a busy park and some under a quiet blanket. Both are fine. A short quiz can show you your own style.

TOOL **How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength`

05

## People change across life.

Personality is fairly stable. It also moves. A large review by Roberts, Walton and Viechtbauer (2006) found that, on average, people become more organized, more emotionally steady and more confident with others as they

move through adult life, with much of the change between 20 and 40. A later review by Bleidorn and colleagues (2022) found that emotional steadiness went on growing right across the lifespan. Big life events play a part, and so do the roles people take on and who they love.

At school Tunde lost his keys about once every two weeks and once turned up to a math exam on the wrong day. He's a charge nurse now, forty-six, the calm one people look for when it goes wrong at three in the morning. At the reunion his old friends kept staring at him across the room in the function suite, and eventually one of them came over with two pints and said, "What happened to you?" He thought about it. "Life kept asking me to cope," he said, "and eventually I learned how."

06

## You can change on purpose, a little at a time.

If you want to change a trait you can, slowly, mostly by acting differently in small ways over and over. In a study by Hudson and Fraley (2015), people who set goals to change one of their traits tended to move in the direction they wanted over sixteen weeks. A review by Roberts and colleagues (2017) found that therapy was often linked to lasting change too, especially toward more emotional steadiness.

Noor wanted to be less quiet at work. She made a rule. One thing in every team meeting, even if it was only "I agree with Neil." The first two weeks her heart thudded so hard she was sure people could see it through her sweater. By the end of the second month it had become ordinary, and somewhere in the third month she forgot it had ever been a rule. Pick one small thing that fits who you'd like to be more of, and do it three times this week. Chapter 6 (page 88) has more on habits.

07

## Every trait has gifts and costs.

There's no good personality. Every trait helps in some places and gets in the way in others. Very agreeable people are lovely to be around and may find "no" almost impossible to say. Very conscientious people are the ones you'd leave your keys with, and they can't always stop. People high in openness love anything new and can be bored to tears by routine.

For most of a year Alys was irritated by her roommate. His sneakers in the hall. His "it'll be fine." Then the water heater died on the coldest night in January, and while Alys stood in the kitchen in her coat reading the manual, he called around until he found a plumber who'd come out at ten o'clock, and then he filled everybody's hot water bottles from the kettle. "It'll be fine," he said, and it was, apart from the hot water bottle that leaked.

A one-page card, "How to talk to me," (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card) turns a trait people complain about into plain information about what helps.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Every trait has gifts and costs. Writing down what helps you on a one-page card turns a "flaw" into useful information.

TOOL **How you connect: how I like to be spoken to** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

08

## Differences are usually about fit.

When two people with different personalities share a home or a family or a job, friction is normal. A tidy person and a relaxed one can both be right in their own way, and so can a planner and someone spontaneous, or a talker and someone who needs quiet. What helps is naming the difference and agreeing how to live with it, without either of you being the problem. Personality is also different from neurodivergence and from mental health conditions. If something feels bigger than personality, Chapter 9 (page 129) may help.

A couple argue about every single vacation, because one wants every hour planned and the other wants to wander about and see what happens. This year they plan the mornings and leave the afternoons free, and they still argue about the mornings. I'd count that as progress.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 14

**How you connect: the style quiz**

*Mo, before moving in with his friend Callum*

## The style quiz: just my Wave Code

Twelve quick either/or taps, about two minutes.

Your first name (optional)

*Mo*

Someone asks you a big question. You…

Answer right away and figure it out as I talk — *Need a moment, or a day, to think first*

A sudden change of plans feels…

*Fine, maybe even fun* — Jarring. I need a heads-up or a transition

Starting something new, you want…

*The why and the big vision* — The first concrete step

When something bothers you, you usually…

Say it plainly so we can fix it — *Hint at it, or wait for the right moment*

Someone says "I'm fine." You…

Believe them. Fine means fine — *Check their tone to see if they really are*

…and seven more like these.

MO'S FOUR LEANINGS (HIS WAVE CODE: S F N A)

**What each letter means**

Pace: leans Slow Simmer (S, not Quick Spark) · Lens: leans Forest (F, not Trees) · Sending: leans Nuanced (N, not Direct) · Receiving: strongly Attuned (A, not Explicit)

**The nickname the tool gives it: the Willow**

Reflective and soft-spoken. Feels the undercurrents of every room.

**Watch for**

agreeing in the moment just to fill the silence; your real needs getting lost in the cushioning.

Mo's style-quiz statement: "About how I'm wired: I think first and talk second, I tend to hint rather than say it straight, I see the big picture first, and I like to take my time."

*Made-up example. A Wave Code is shorthand for four preferences, each a lean along a dial, not a type or a box. "Leans" means near the middle. Answers can change with the day, the setting and the person you're with.*

Fill in your own: How you connect (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can get to know your own mix, look after what you need, and practice one small change if you want to. You can't change someone else's personality, and you don't have to change yours to be loved. If you're always the one bending to fit, it's fair to say so. More in Know your own wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself), free online.

SATURDAY, 5:30PM

*People are drifting off with slices of cake in paper towels. You think about sitting down next to your aunt and telling her about the thirty eight-year-olds. You don't. You help stack the plates. On the drive home you're still turning it over, half annoyed with her and half with yourself, and somewhere around the beltway you start drafting what you'll say at Christmas if she does it again. It's quite a good line.*

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

### The same lunch, two ways

For some people a new lunch is a small pleasure, and the same sandwich every day sounds dull. For others every new food is a small gamble on taste, texture and how it sits, and a known lunch is one decision they never have to make. If you like variety, the same-lunch person isn't stuck. They're saving their energy for the rest of the day. If you like sameness, the variety person isn't restless. Trying something new is part of what makes lunch a break for them.

**Where the fields meet.** Economics treats attention as a budget, and personality is partly about where the budget goes and how fast it runs out. Business has a related habit: match each job to the person whose strengths suit it, and give it one owner, so nobody has to pretend to be someone else to get it done.

## In everyday life

### On your own

Knowing your own mix helps you build a life that suits you, with about the right amount of company and quiet. "I'm just not a people person" might be

true. It might also be an old label that deserves testing at least once. With a partner, a shared plan (one does the bills, the other does vacations) usually goes better than trying to change each other. A quiet friend who hardly texts may still care a great deal, so ask what kind of contact suits them. A child's temperament says nothing about good or bad parenting, and adjusting to fit them is a skill you pick up. And family roles like "the clever one" or "the difficult one" can hang on long after they stop fitting. You're allowed to grow out of them, whether or not your aunt has noticed.

## Narcissistic, toxic and other labels people reach for.

Words from clinics have drifted into everyday arguments. Narcissistic personality disorder is a clinical diagnosis that only a qualified professional can make, after a full assessment. It describes a long-lasting pattern across most of a person's life, not a bad week or a bad breakup. "Toxic" isn't a clinical word at all.

For something to be a personality pattern of this kind, these are usually all present:

- it shows up across many years and most settings, at home, at work and with friends,
- it includes a constant need for admiration and very little room for other people's feelings,
- it doesn't change when the person is calm, rested and happy,
- it causes real, lasting harm to the person or to the people around them.

Not enough on its own:

- confidence, ambition or self-promotion at work,
- one selfish choice, or a defensive reaction to criticism,
- talking about yourself a lot when you're nervous,
- someone you've fallen out with.

Describing what happened helps more than a label. "You talked over me three times tonight" can be answered. A diagnosis thrown at someone in an argument usually ends the conversation, and it's often wrong. "Toxic" works

the same way. It names no specific behavior and no effect over time, and a hard week, a single conflict or a bad day isn't enough to earn it.

## Common mix-ups

You aren't simply an introvert or an extravert. Most people are somewhere in the middle, and where you sit shifts with the setting and your mood. Personality isn't set in stone by thirty, either. It keeps moving slowly all through life. Online type quizzes are good for fun and for starting a conversation, and that includes the website's own Wave Code, which shows four leanings on four dials, but they sort people into a handful of types when real people are spread along each dial. "They're just difficult" often means "they're different from me," and it can hide stress or illness or a need nobody has asked about. And practicing something new isn't being fake. It feels odd at first, like new shoes, and then it's yours.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Drop the old labels, and notice if you still describe someone the way they were twenty years ago. Ask instead of guessing. "What helps you recharge?" or "How do you like to plan things?" will tell you more than any theory. Say it when you see someone grow, because "You handled that so calmly" can show a person a change they hadn't spotted. And describe what happened, not who someone is. "You're so uptight" shuts doors that a plain description would leave open.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I used to think of you as the shy one. I don't think that fits anymore."
> "What do you need to be at your best this week?"

## Tools and reading on the website

**Tools** **helpers you use on the website**

- How you connect (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength): four quick dials for how you think, talk and listen. Its four-letter Wave Code is shorthand

for four preferences, not a type.

- Communication style quiz (spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz).

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Know your own wiring: how you tend to feel, react and recharge.
- The library: the Big Five (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring), introversion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#introversion), morning and evening people (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#chronotypes) and highly sensitive people (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#sensory-processing-sensitivity).

## More for your situation

- Part One, Now: your wiring, your weather and your words
- Part Three, Chapter 6: Habits and change (page 88)
- Part Three, Chapter 9: Minds that work differently (page 129)
- For parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) · For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) · For grandparents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents)
- Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room) · At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words**
*Your wiring today* read online

**Part One · Then · Where your lens came from**
*Temperament and how you grew up* read online

**Part Three · Chapter 9 · Minds that work differently**
*Minds that work differently* page 129

**Part Three · Chapter 6 · Habits and change**
*How change really happens* page 88

PUT IT TO USE

**How you connect**
Four quick dials for how you think, talk and listen. Its four-letter Wave Code is shorthand for four preferences, not a type
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

**Communication style quiz**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

# 15

PART THREE · CHAPTER 15

# Closeness and love: being known, at every age

*How closeness grows, what it means to feel truly known, how love changes over the years, and how it looks in every kind of relationship, at every age, including for people on their own.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Love comes in many forms
2. Closeness grows from being known
3. Closeness is built a step at a time
4. Feeling understood matters most
5. Old maps show up in love
6. Love changes over time
7. Love at every age
8. Love is something you do
9. If you're a teenager
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. Reading on this site
14. More for your situation


FRIDAY, 10:30PM

*Eleven years in this house with Charlie. Tonight you're both on the couch, both on your phones, with a cooking show on in the background that neither of you is watching. Someone on it is crying about a soufflé.*

*You try to remember the last time the two of you talked about something that wasn't bills, or the water heater, or whose turn it is to cook. You can't. You love Charlie, which isn't in question. You feel oddly on your own, a foot away from them.*

This chapter is about closeness in all its forms, far beyond romance. It looks at what helps people feel near to each other, and why closeness fades and

how it grows back, and it builds on Chapter 5 (page 74), on attachment and trust.

Two people on a sofa, scrolling, in quick strokes. The surface is a quiet evening. Underneath, a closeness that has thinned without anyone deciding it should. Underneath that, months of small bids missed on both sides. The roots are balance and feedback loops. The chapter goes back over them slowly.

01

## Love comes in many forms.

The ancient Greeks had several words for love, for friends, family, romantic partners and strangers. People love in many ways now too, through lifelong friendships, partners of any gender, more than one partner, chosen family, and among people who are asexual or aromantic and build deep closeness without romance or sex. Some people on their own pour love into friends, family, pets, work and community. A life can be full of love without a partner in it.

Frances is fifty-six and has never wanted a partner. Ask her about her great love story and she'll tell you about Denise, her best friend of thirty years. Between them there have been two house moves, one cancer scare, a camping trip in Cape Cod that they still can't discuss without one of them leaving the room, and more Sunday phone calls than either of them could count. "People feel sorry for me," she says. "I feel quite sorry for them."

02

## Closeness grows from being known.

Intimacy is about much more than touch or romance. At its heart is being known. The psychologists Reis and Shaver described it as a back-and-forth, in which one person shares something real about themselves and the other responds in a way that leaves them feeling understood and cared for. In a diary study by Laurenceau, Barrett and Pietromonaco (1998), feeling that the other person really responded was a big part of what made everyday conversations feel intimate.

Two brothers who mostly talk about football were driving to their dad's nursing home. Somewhere on the highway, staring straight ahead, one of

them said, “I find these visits really hard.” There was a long pause before the other said, “Yeah. Me too. I always feel guilty on the way home.” It was the longest conversation they’d had in years. It lasted all the way to the parking lot, where they sat with the engine off for another ten minutes. Then they went in and talked about football.

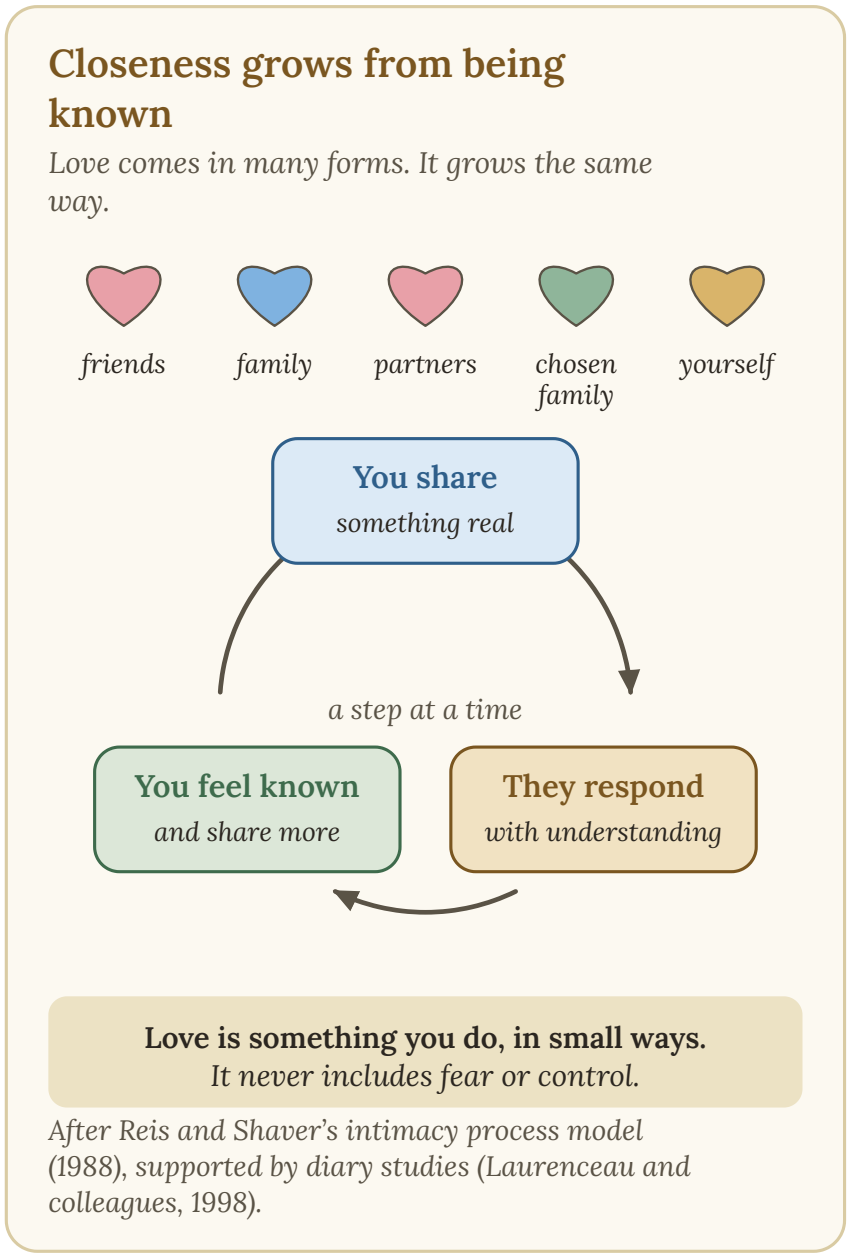



FIGURE 20 Closeness grows from being known: you share something real, the other person responds with understanding, and you share a little more.

03

## Closeness is built a step at a time.

People usually get close by sharing a little more, then a little more, when it feels safe. In a well-known study by Aron and colleagues (1997), pairs of strangers who took turns asking gradually more personal questions, now known as the "36 questions," felt closer after forty-five minutes than pairs who made small talk. The same idea works in friendships and long relationships, where closeness grows when both people take small, matched steps.

Two new neighbors start with the weather, and the parking, which on their street is a serious subject. A few months later one asks how the other's mom is getting on. Some time after that, over the fence, with a hosepipe running, one of them says, "Can I tell you what's actually been going on?"



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Closeness grows when you know what feels like care to the other person, not just to you. A "What feels like care" card is a gentle way to find out.

TOOL **How you connect: what feels like care** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

04

## Feeling understood matters most.

What makes someone feel loved is often less about grand gestures and more about feeling understood. Researchers call this *responsiveness*, meaning noticing, understanding and caring about what matters to the other person, and it shows in small moments such as how you react to good news. Gable and colleagues (2004) found that people whose partners usually met their good news with real interest and warmth felt closer and more satisfied together.

"I got into the band." She's fourteen, coat still on, trying to sound casual about it. Her grandpa put the paper down, properly down, folded, and said, "Which instrument? When's the first concert?" She talked for twenty minutes, mostly about the trombone section and a boy called Luca who can't count. Next time someone shares good news with you, put your phone face down and ask two follow-up questions.

05

## Old maps show up in love.

The patterns from Chapter 5 (page 74) often come out strongest with the people we love most. Hazan and Shaver (1987) suggested that adult love uses the same attachment system as childhood bonds. When closeness feels shaky, some people reach harder for reassurance and others pull back to feel safe. Both are ways of protecting something precious.

When his partner goes quiet, Leo texts, and once it was five times in an hour. His partner goes quiet to calm down, and five texts feels like being chased around the house. What they agreed, eventually, was that his partner would say, "I need an hour, and I'll message you at eight." Leo found, somewhat to his surprise, that he could wait quite happily for a known time, and that the waiting had never really been the problem.

06

## Love changes over time.

Early love is often intense, with racing thoughts and a lot of longing, and over the years it usually settles into something calmer and deeper. A review by Acevedo and Aron (2009) found that some people in long relationships still report strong romantic love, without the anxious, all-consuming edge of early love, and that this was linked to being happier together.

In experiments by Aron and colleagues (2000), couples who tried a new, mildly challenging activity together felt better about their relationship afterward than couples given a dull task. After twenty-five years together, Howard and Lynne signed up for a pottery class at the community center. They were both dreadful. Lynne's bowl collapsed twice and Howard got clay in his ear. They laughed most of the evening and brought home a bowl that won't stand up, and on the walk back Howard said, "That felt like a date." Something new matters more than something big. A new walk. A new recipe. A café in the next town.

**Thank-yous as a booster**

In a daily diary study of couples living together, feeling grateful for a partner's thoughtful act predicted feeling more connected and more satisfied the next day, for both of them. Correlational, but cheap to test at home.

**Algoe, Gable and Maisel (2010)** · *Moderate: a daily diary study; correlational*



SUGARFOOT

Little rituals, a Sunday walk, a goodnight text, keep love warm through the years. Most couples have more of them than they think.

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-15

07

## Love at every age.

Love looks different across a life. Teenagers' first loves can be huge and real. Adults juggle love with work and children and, often, aging parents. Many older people choose to spend their time with fewer, closer people, which Carstensen and colleagues (1999) linked to feeling that time is more limited, so that the most meaningful relationships matter more. People find new love at seventy and eighty, and people lose great loves and carry them always.

Arthur is seventy-eight, and he met Irene at his walking group, in the drizzle, arguing about a stile. When his children looked surprised, and then worried, and then started asking careful questions about wills, he said, "I loved your mother for fifty years. I still do. And I'm allowed to be happy now." His daughter cried. His son changed the subject to the car. Irene is coming for Christmas, with a trifle.

08

## Love is something you do.

Feelings of love come and go. The actions of love can be steady. Turning toward someone when they speak. Keeping small promises. Saying thank you, and sorry. Making room for who they are. Physical closeness, like a hug or holding hands, matters a lot to some people and less to others, and sex is part of closeness in some relationships and not in others. What matters is that both people feel comfortable and free to say yes or no.

Her friend had gone quiet after his divorce. Paula has never once told him she loves him and would be mortified to. Every Thursday she texts one word, *Walk*?, and turns up at his door at six in her old wax jacket, whatever the weather. Some weeks they talk and some weeks they just walk. A "What feels like care" card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages) is a gentle way to find out what the small thing is for someone you love.

**Bids, and turning toward them**

Watching 49 newlywed couples over dinner, Driver and Gottman found that partners who turned toward each other's small bids, a comment or a question or a look, showed more humor and affection later, even in a disagreement. It's a small, correlational study, so it can't say which causes which.

**Driver and Gottman (2004)** · *Moderate: observational, small sample; direction of cause not established*

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 15

**Our time-together deal**

*Jamal and Tess, a couple; Jamal games most evenings*

## Our time-together deal

Your name
*Jamal*

Their name
*Tess*

Game nights (or long phone time)
*Tuesday and Friday evenings, plus Sunday afternoon*

Heads-up rule
*Say before a session over an hour, and roughly when it ends.*

When one of us asks for time
*Finish this match, then I'm yours. No new one.*

Our protected evening
*Wednesday, from 7: we cook together*

Phone-free times
*Dinner, and the first 20 minutes in bed*

Chores before the session
*Dishes and our own jobs for the day are done first.*

YOUR DEAL, READY TO SEND

Our time-together deal (Jamal and Tess), with each line above. A link holds the deal as it is right now: if either of you changes something, send a new link.

*Made-up example.*

Fill in your own: Our time-together deal (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can share a little of yourself, listen well, turn toward the people you love and keep small promises. You can't make someone love you, or love you in the way you want.

THE NEXT FRIDAY, 10:30PM

*The phones go on the kitchen counter and you make two cups of tea. You ask Charlie, feeling a bit silly, what they've been thinking about lately that they haven't told you. Charlie looks at you for a moment as if you might be ill. Then they talk about their dad getting older, and how they dread the phone ringing late at night. You didn't know that, and you listen. Then you tell them about the restructure at work, which you hadn't mentioned either. The tea goes cold, and it's midnight before either of you looks at the clock.*

## If you're a teenager

First love can be huge and real, and so can a first breakup. Ines is sixteen when she's dumped by message on a Tuesday night, and she cries until two in the morning. Being told by adults that she'll get over it does not help, at all. Telling her cousin, who just listens, does. So does muting the chat instead of rereading it, and a rule of no checking his profile after ten, which she breaks twice. A few weeks later she notices a whole day has gone by without her thinking about him, and is slightly offended.

YOU COULD SAY

"I don't need advice, I just need to tell someone." "Can we reply when we can, rather than all day?" And if you are the one ending it, "I don't want to go out anymore. I'm sorry. It isn't about something you did wrong."

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

### Love, two ways

Some people show love by saying it. Others show it by doing: the lunch from home, the bike fixed, the car filled up. If love reaches you through words, the doer may be saying it all day in a language you don't hear yet. If it reaches you through deeds, the talker isn't being cheap with words. For them, the words are the deed.

**Where the fields meet.** Finance has a neat picture for the small moments: turning toward someone's little bid is a deposit, turning away is a small withdrawal. Aromatherapy, read modestly, adds touchstones, a familiar place or scent that brings a shared memory back. The claims for particular oils are debated, so it's the familiarity that counts.

## In everyday life

### On your own

Being single, widowed, divorced or happily alone doesn't mean a life without love. Friendships, family, community and the way you treat yourself are all places where love lives. If you want a partner and don't have one, that longing is real and worth being gentle with (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). Most partners drift into talking only about jobs and bills, and one real question a week can bring them back. Friendship needs tending like any other love. And families often love each other enormously and say so

about once a decade, so a short "I'm glad you're my sister" can land like a brick, in a good way.

- **Different levels of desire.** This is very common in long relationships and is nobody's fault. Talk at a calm time, keep some affection that doesn't have to lead anywhere, and remember that a kind "no" is a no to the moment and never a rejection of the person. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-15-love-in-depth).

## Common mix-ups

The spark fading doesn't mean love is over. Early intensity usually settles, and many long relationships stay warm and close and lively for decades. Nobody reads minds, either, however much they love you, so saying what helps is a gift rather than a failure of romance.

- **"A boundary is just an ultimatum with a nicer name."** A boundary says what you will do. "If the shouting starts, I'll leave the room and we can try again later." An ultimatum tries to decide what the other person does, with a threat attached. "Stop seeing your friends or I'm leaving." Both can be said calmly and both can be said in anger. Ask whether it's about your own actions or theirs, and whether you'd accept the same rule turned around.
- **"Jealousy proves love."** Feeling jealous is human, and saying so ("I felt left out when you went without me") is honest. Jealousy turns into something else when it becomes checking up, rules about who someone can see, or coldness as a penalty for time spent apart.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Respect their kind of love, without assuming that everyone wants a partner or children. Be a safe person to tell things to, which means listening without judging and keeping what they share to yourself. After a loss or a breakup, keep showing up, because most people get plenty of support for two weeks and very little after that.

- **If you're worried about someone's relationship,** stay close and kind rather than criticizing their partner.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I'm always glad to hear from you." "You don't have to explain your relationship to me. I just want you to be happy and safe."

## Reading on the website

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Bonding: how closeness grows (spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding), what research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family and you.
- Turning toward (spreadloveandacceptance.com/turning-toward), on small daily moments of connection.
- The languages of connection (spreadloveandacceptance.com/languages-of-connection), on the different ways people show care.
- Complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency), on why good things fade and how to keep them alive.
- The library: responsiveness (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships), love maps (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships#love-maps), self-expansion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships#self-expansion), adult attachment (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships#adult-attachment) and sharing good news (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection).

## More for your situation

- Attachment, trust and belonging (page 74)
- Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · More than two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two) · Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance)
- Coming out as an adult (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out)
- On my own · Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- Retired together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/retired-together) · Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest)

- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

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WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Love comes in many forms.
- ✓ Closeness is built a step at a time.
- ✓ Old maps show up in love.
- ✓ Love changes over time.
- ✓ Love is something you do.

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part Three · Chapter 5 · Attachment, trust and belonging**
*Attachment and trust*
page 74

**Part Two · Chapter I · Why we get out of tune**
*Staying in tune day to day*
read online

**Preface to Part Two · The work nobody sees**
*Noticing the work love does*
read online

**Part One · Next · Who you are becoming**
*Growing as a person inside a relationship*
read online

PUT IT TO USE



**Bonding: how closeness grows**
What research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family and you
spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding



**Turning toward**
On small daily moments of connection
spreadloveandacceptance.com/turning-toward

# 16

PART THREE · CHAPTER 16

# Worry, low mood and trauma

*How worry and anxiety work, the difference between a low patch and depression, what trauma is and isn't, what helps day to day, and how to support someone. For anyone, in any kind of relationship, or on your own.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Worry and anxiety are the body's alarm
2. Avoiding keeps fear going
3. Give worry a time and a place
4. Low mood is common. Depression is more than a bad week
5. Doing often comes before feeling better
6. Sleep, moving and people do a lot of the work
7. Trauma is about what happened, and what it left behind
8. After something frightening: safety, choice and no pressure
9. Therapy helps many people, and medicines can too
10. If you're a teenager
11. In everyday life
12. Common mix-ups
13. If you want to help someone else with this
14. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation


AT A GLANCE

- **Worry, low mood and the after-effects of trauma are common, human and treatable.** They are not weakness, and they are not your fault.
- **They all run through the stress system** from Chapter 2 (page 28). Small, steady things that settle the body and reconnect you with life help more than big pushes.
- **Avoiding and withdrawing feel safer but keep things going.** Small steps back in, a little at a time, help most.

- **Therapy works for many people, and so can medicines.**

SUNDAY, 10:50PM

*The house is quiet. You've checked the front door twice and the back door once, and you're thinking about the front door again. Tomorrow is the hospital, ten o'clock, and it goes round and round. What if it's bad. What if I can't cope. Who would I even tell.*

*And if you're honest, it isn't only tonight. You haven't really wanted to see anyone for a few weeks. Even replying to a text has started to feel like lifting something.*

Almost everyone worries, feels low or goes through something frightening at some point. For some people it settles by itself, and for others it sticks, and grows, until it shapes every day. This chapter is about how these things work, what tends to help, and when it's time to ask for more. It can't diagnose anyone. If any of this is about you right now, you aren't alone in it, and it can get better.

Some tools elsewhere lean on this chapter. The daily check-in's "low, medium or high" (Part Two, Chapter I, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-1) lets people adjust when worry or low mood has shrunk the room you have. "A full tank means later, not never" (Part Two, Chapter III, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3) names a time to come back, because avoiding a thing keeps fear going. And picking one small goal (Part One, Next, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next) suits low mood, since doing very often comes before feeling better.

Quickly, then slowly. On the surface, checking the door twice. Underneath, an alarm that keeps going off with nothing to point at. Underneath that, sleep, people and days that have narrowed. The roots are state and setting, and feedback loops, since avoiding keeps the alarm going. The rest of the chapter takes each part in turn.

01

## Worry and anxiety are the body's alarm.

Fear is the body's alarm for danger that's here now. Anxiety is the same alarm ringing about something that might happen. Worry is the thinking part, the "What if…?" going round. All three run through the stress system from Chapter 2 (page 28), which is why they come with a racing heart and a tight chest and a churning stomach and nights of bad sleep. The alarm is trying to protect you. The trouble is it can be set far too sensitive, and it can't tell a tiger from an email.

Before every presentation in class, Leah's heart hammers so hard her hands shake her notes. She is fifteen, and nothing bad has ever happened to her in a presentation. Her alarm still treats a room full of people she's known since first grade, one of whom once ate a worm for 50 cents, as somewhere dangerous.

**Fear of not knowing**

One review argues that fear of the unknown, the not-knowing itself, may sit underneath a lot of anxiety. It's a proposal rather than a settled finding, but it fits the night before a hospital appointment better than most explanations do.

**Carleton (2016)** · *Theory: an influential review; the central claim is a proposal*

When it rises, try breathing out slowly five times, each breath out longer than the breath in. Then name three things you can see. It tells the body the danger isn't here right now, and while it won't switch the alarm off, it can usually turn it down a notch.

02

## Avoiding keeps fear going.

When something makes us anxious, stepping away brings quick relief, and the relief teaches the brain that escaping was clever. So next time the fear is a little bigger and the world a little smaller. What helps is going back toward the feared thing in small, chosen steps, and staying long enough to find out you can cope. Psychologists call this exposure. Craske and colleagues (2014) describe how it works best when each step tests what you expect to happen.

After a panic attack on the 42, Graham started walking everywhere, in the rain, three miles to work and three miles back. His sister didn't argue. One Saturday she just stood at the bus stop with him and they got on, and off again, after one stop. A week later, two stops. It took most of the spring

before he did the whole run into town, sitting by the doors, feeling sick, reading the same ad for a lawyer over and over. But he did it, and his brain had slowly learned that buses are survivable.

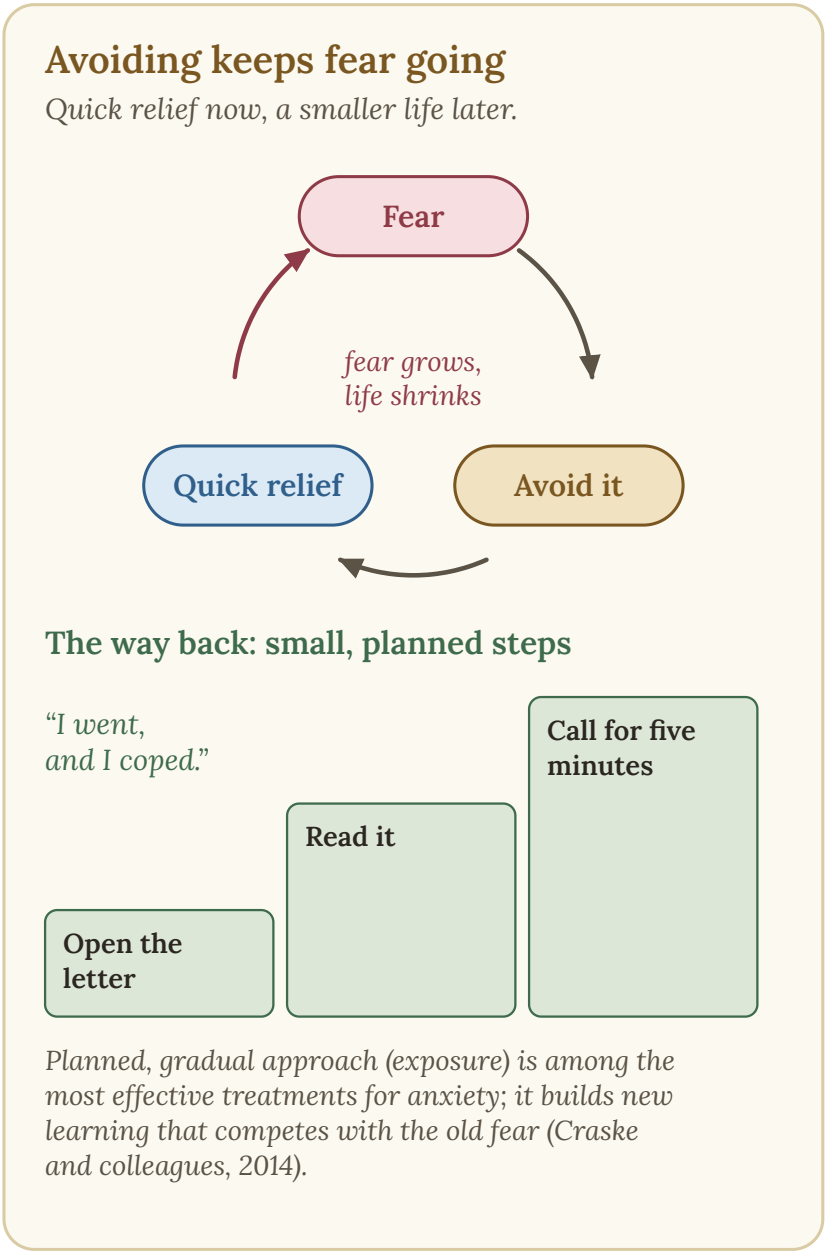



FIGURE 21 Avoiding keeps fear going. Small, planned steps back in help most.

03

## Give worry a time and a place.

Trying hard not to worry rarely works. What helps a lot of people is postponing it. You notice a worry, write it down, and save it for a set "worry time" later in the day. In an early study by Borkovec and colleagues (1983), people who practiced this for four weeks reported worrying less each day. In worry time, go through the list and ask of each one whether there's anything you can do about it. If there is, plan one step. If there isn't, practice letting it go, which is easier said than done, I know.

Desmond looks after his dad and keeps a small red notebook by the kettle. Worries go in it all day. At six, with a cup of tea, he gives the notebook fifteen minutes. By then half the morning's worries look smaller, and a couple have quietly worked themselves out. The one about the water heater has been in there since August, and he has decided to let it stay. When one turns up at the wrong time of day, the trick is to tell it, more or less, "Noted. I'll think about that at six."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 16

**Flip it**

*Tolu, 17, at 1am, three days before an exam*

### Flip it

What's on your mind?

*What if I fail my biology exam on Friday and don't get into the course I want?*

What kind is it?

A complaint about someone | A *worry* | Being hard on myself | Anger

THE FLIP

**The best outcome would be**
[what you hope for]

**The main thing in the way**
I fail my biology exam on Friday and don't get into the course I want

**If that happens, I'll**
[one small thing you could do]

**One step today**
[something that takes ten minutes or less]

This is WOOP, from Gabriele Oettingen's research: Wish, Outcome, Obstacle, Plan. The worry becomes the obstacle you plan for. This is a starting point. Change any words you like.

Tolu's version
*Best outcome: I pass, and I feel I did my best. In the way: I freeze on the long questions. If that happens, I'll do the short questions first and come back. One step today: one long question from a past paper, then bed.*

When the worry comes back at 1am
*It goes on the list for tomorrow's worry time, 5pm, ten minutes.*

*Made-up example. If worry is stopping you sleeping or eating most days, tell someone you trust.*

Fill in your own: Flip it (spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins)

04

## Low mood is common. Depression is more than a bad week.

Everyone has low days, and sadness after a loss or a let-down is normal. Depression is different. It means low mood, or losing interest in things you used to enjoy, for most of the day, nearly every day, for two weeks or more, often with poor sleep, tiredness, appetite changes, feeling worthless or guilty, and finding it hard to think. It can look like sadness. It can also look like irritability, or just running on empty. It is a health problem, and nobody gets it by being weak.

Lionel taught geography for thirty-one years. Lately he has stopped going to the Thursday walking group. He isn't reading. He wakes at four every morning and lies there listening to the water heater come on. Getting old, he tells himself. It was his daughter, up for the weekend, who said it, carefully, while they were doing the dishes. "Dad, I think this might be depression. And that can be treated." He was pretty annoyed with her for about a day.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I've not been myself for a few weeks, and I don't think it's just tiredness."
> "I don't enjoy things I used to. Can I talk to you about it?"

05

## Doing often comes before feeling better.

Low mood tells you to wait until you feel like it. But withdrawing makes life emptier, and that deepens the low. A well-tested approach called behavioral activation turns this around. You plan small, doable things that bring a bit of pleasure or a sense of having done something, and you do them whether you feel like it or not. A review of 26 trials by Ekers and colleagues (2014) found it helped with depression, though many of the studies were small.

After her divorce, living on her own, Lorraine planned three small things a day, a ten-minute walk to the postbox and back, one call or message, and one job she could finish, like wiping the stove. Most days, honestly, they felt pointless. She did them anyway, and over a few weeks the days started to feel less dull, though she couldn't tell you which day it changed.

06

## Sleep, moving and people do a lot of the work.

These sound too simple to matter. The evidence is solid all the same. Improving sleep can lift mood: in a large trial with university students, Freeman and colleagues (2017) found that an online sleep course reduced insomnia, and with it some other mental health difficulties.

Exercise helps depression too. A review of 218 trials by Noetel and colleagues (2024) found walking or jogging, yoga and strength training all helped. Belonging to groups protects as well. Cruwys and colleagues (2013) found that people with depression who joined groups were less likely to relapse.

A new dad, exhausted and low, sat down with his partner and a calendar and between them they blocked out one protected long sleep each on the weekend, a stroller walk every morning around the park whatever the weather, and his old Wednesday five-a-side, which he'd dropped when the baby came and missed more than he'd admitted. He was terrible at five-a-side the first week, and went back anyway. Calm sounds help some people wind down at night, too, and Cool-down corner (spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes) has some.

**People are not an optional extra**

A meta-analysis of 148 studies, with over 300,000 people, found that people with stronger social ties had about 50% better odds of survival over the years they were followed. The studies observe rather than prove cause, but it's hard to read that and call calling a friend a luxury.

**Holt-Lunstad, Smith and Layton (2010)** · *Strong: a large meta-analysis of observational studies; cause not established*

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I need help protecting my sleep for a while." "Would you come for a short walk with me? I find it hard to go on my own."



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Small, steady things help: a walk, a regular bedtime, time with someone kind. Calm sounds can be a soft way to wind down at night.

TOOL **Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes`

07

## Trauma is about what happened, and what it left behind.

Trauma usually means going through, or seeing, something that threatened life or safety, such as violence, abuse, a serious accident, war, or the sudden death of someone close. It is very common. In surveys across 24 countries, Kessler and colleagues (2017) found about 7 in 10 adults had been through at least one.

Most people recover over time. A smaller number develop post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), with memories that come back vividly, avoiding reminders, feeling on high alert, and sleep problems. Ordinary hard times and stress hurt too, even when they aren't trauma in this sense.

Months after a crash at a wet intersection, Shirin still jumps at the sound of brakes and won't drive after dark. Her partner has started saying "It's fine, it's fine" before she's even flinched, which she finds both sweet and maddening. Her alarm learned that cars can mean danger and hasn't unlearned it yet. That is a long way from overreacting. Trauma-focused therapies help many people.

08

## After something frightening: safety, choice and no pressure.

After a frightening event, people need safety, practical help, warmth and choice. They don't need to be made to talk. A review of single-session "debriefing" after trauma by Rose and colleagues (2002) found it did not prevent PTSD, and might make things worse for some. Services that are "trauma-informed" (SAMHSA, 2014) put safety, trust, choice and working together first, and the same ideas help in families, friendships and workplaces.

Someone had been in Grandma's house while she was at the store. They took her purse from the drawer and her late husband's watch. She didn't want to talk about it, and said so, twice. Her grandson didn't push. He fixed the lock on the back door, which took him most of the afternoon and two trips to the hardware shop, and slept on her sofa. "If you ever want to talk about it, I'm here," he said in the morning, and went to work. A week later she called him at nine at night and talked for an hour, mostly about the watch.

09

## Therapy helps many people, and medicines can too.

Cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT) teaches practical ways to notice and change patterns of thinking and doing. It's one of the most studied talk therapies, and a review of over a hundred meta-analyses by Hofmann and colleagues (2012) found the strongest support for anxiety problems and stress, and support for many other problems too.

Guidelines such as NICE (2022) also recommend guided self-help, behavioral activation, exercise groups and, for some people, antidepressants. Medicines work differently for different people, and stopping one suddenly can cause problems of its own.

Zack was too embarrassed to ask anyone about the panic attacks. Then one kept him from getting on the 7:40 for the second week in a row, and he stood on the platform watching it go. His doctor referred him for a short course of CBT, eight sessions. He takes the train to work again now, with a book and a bottle of water for the bad days, and there are still some bad days. Before an appointment, it helps to write three lines, on what you've noticed, how long it has gone on, and what it's stopping you doing.

WORDS TO TRY

"I'd like to talk about my mood. It's been going on for a while." "What are my options, and what do you recommend for someone like me?"

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can learn how your alarm works, keep the basics going, take small steps back toward life, and ask for help when it's more than you can carry. You can't think your way out of depression by trying harder, and you can't fix someone else's. Being kind to yourself, and getting the right help, are part of the work.

MONDAY, 7:30AM

*Last night you wrote the three worries on the back of an envelope from the gas board and told them, out loud, feeling ridiculous, that they could wait till morning. You slept a bit. Now you breathe out long at the kitchen window and text your neighbor. Hospital at ten and I'm a bit scared, cup of coffee after?*

*Three hearts and "course." The appointment is still the appointment. You look at the envelope again, and the weeks of not wanting to see anyone, and add a fourth line at the bottom, smaller than the others. Ask about my mood.*

## If you're a teenager

Exams, friends, group chats and the future can all land at once, usually at about one in the morning. Tolu is seventeen and can't sleep the night before

her biology exam. She writes the worry down for tomorrow's ten-minute worry time, plans one small step (ask Mr. Okafor what kind of questions come up) and puts her phone out on the landing, which she hates. The next day she tells her mom, who says, "Why didn't you wake me?" and it helps more than Tolu expected.

If worry or low mood is stopping you sleeping or going to school most days for a few weeks, tell someone you trust.

YOU COULD SAY

"I keep worrying at night. Can I talk it through?" "I don't need you to fix it. I just need to say it."

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

### Worry, from both sides

Some people worry out loud, talking it round until it shrinks. Others keep it in, and talking about it too soon makes it grow. If you talk it out, the quiet worrier may need a walk side by side more than a conversation. If you keep it in, the talker isn't making a fuss. Saying it is how they get it out of their head.

**Where the fields meet.** Holistic therapies start with the body, which is where worry lives first: slow breathing out, a walk, a regular bedtime. Some of these practices are well studied and some are debated. Aromatherapy adds that the setting matters, a quieter room or softer light. The evidence for particular oils is weak, so the help here is the room, not the bottle.

## In everyday life

Living on your own can make worry louder at night and low mood quieter and easier to miss, so one small contact a day is worth protecting, even a two-minute call (see On your own: when it's lonely, spreadloveandacceptance.

com/on-my-own). With a partner, low mood can look like not caring, and anxiety can look like nagging when it's really a worried mind asking again for reassurance. Describe what's going on instead of leaving the other person to guess: "I'm low today, and I'm not mad at you." Children and teenagers get anxious and low too, and calm, routine and listening help them more than reassurance on a loop. A friend who keeps canceling may be struggling. Keep inviting them, with no pressure to say yes.

Grief and depression overlap without being the same thing, and Chapter 8 (page 116) looks at grief on its own terms. At work, a short honest line to a manager often opens up more support than people expect. If you have ADHD, avoidance often looks like putting things off, so make the first step almost silly ("open the envelope"), set a ten-minute timer, or do it with someone else in the room. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-16-worry-in-depth).

## Common mix-ups

Anxiety doesn't mean something is wrong with you. It's a normal alarm. It only becomes a problem when it rings too loud or too often, or starts shrinking your life. Depression isn't just sadness, and nobody snaps out of it. It affects sleep, energy, thinking and the body as well as mood, and many people recover with the right help. Not everything bad that happens is trauma in the clinical sense, which usually means a threat to life or safety. Other hard things still hurt and still deserve care, and the word doesn't need to fit for help to be fair. Talking about trauma right away doesn't help everyone either. Some people want to and some don't, forcing it can make things worse, and safety and choice come first.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Notice, and ask. "You've seemed a bit low lately. How are you doing, really?" opens the door, and after that it helps to listen more than you talk. Don't argue with the feeling. "Cheer up" and "It could be worse" push people away. "That sounds really hard" keeps them close. Offer something specific, a walk

or a meal or a ride somewhere, because a small practical offer is much easier to accept than a big vague one.

If you're worried someone may be thinking of ending their life, it's okay to ask them plainly, in your own words. Asking doesn't put the idea in their head (a review by Dazzi and colleagues, 2014, found no sign that it does). If they say yes, stay with them, listen, and help them tell someone else they trust. And look after yourself too, because supporting someone who is struggling is tiring (see Chapter 12, page 175).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "I'm not trying to fix it. I just want you to know I'm here." "Would it help if I came with you?"

## Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

**Workpapers** **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11): a plan, made on a calm day, for hard moments.

**Tools** **helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now): steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.
- My weather today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks): a quick daily check-in on stress, sleep and people.

**Reading** **pages to read on the website**

- The calm visualizer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/calm-visualizer) for slow breathing.
- The library: the stress response (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress), the window of tolerance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress#window-of-tolerance), sleep and mood (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress#sleep-and-mood), going over and over things (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), catastrophizing (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking) and loneliness (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection).

## More for your situation

- On your own · Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) · For parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) · New parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent)
- Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers)
- At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- **More in Part Three:** Stress (page 28) · Self-worth and self-compassion (page 102) · Healing (page 161)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

THIS CONNECTS TO


**Part Three · Chapter 2 · Stress and the nervous system** page 28
*The stress ladder and rest*

**Part Three · Chapter 7 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion** page 102
*A kinder inner voice*

**Part Three · Chapter 12 · Helping others well** page 175
*Supporting someone who is struggling*

**Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words** read online
*Checking your weather each day*


PUT IT TO USE

**The Calm-Down Kit**
A plan, made on a calm day, for hard moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11

**Upset right now?**
Steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

# 17

PART THREE · CHAPTER 17

# Fitting in: groups, influence and culture

*Why fitting in pulls so hard, how groups shape what we say and do, how culture and family set the unwritten rules, and how to stay yourself, and disagree kindly, without losing your place, whether the group is a family, a friendship, a team, a faith, a neighborhood or a group chat.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. The pull to fit in is old and strong
2. We go along more than we think
3. Authority can lead people a long way
4. "Us and them" forms fast
5. Norms are the rules nobody wrote down
6. Cultures differ, and so do people inside them
7. Every family is a small culture
8. Online groups pull harder and faster
9. You can belong and still be yourself
10. Disagree kindly, and early
11. If you're a teenager
12. Influence, pressure and manipulation
13. In everyday life
14. If you want to help someone else with this
15. Reading on this site
16. More for your situation


THURSDAY, 9:20PM

*The family group chat is going. Uncle Trevor has posted a joke about your cousin's new partner, and the laughing faces are stacking up underneath it. Six, then seven, and your mom has done one.*

*You don't find it funny. You also don't want to be the one who can't take a joke. Your thumb is already over the little laughing face.*

We all belong to groups, and we need them. Chapter 5 (page 74) looks at belonging, at why we need each other and how trust grows. This chapter

looks at the other side, at how groups pull on us, why we go along, and how to stay true to yourself while staying connected.

A joke in the family chat, quickly. On the surface, a picture and a laughing face. Underneath, the pull not to be the one who spoils it. Underneath that, a norm nobody wrote down. The roots are quiet incentives and ownership and structure. Then slowly, one pull at a time.

01

## The pull to fit in is old and strong.

For most of human history, being in a group meant surviving, and being left out still feels alarming. In studies by Williams and colleagues (2000), people who were simply left out of an online ball-throwing game, by strangers they would never meet, felt worse and less as if they belonged. So we bend to stay in. We laugh at the jokes, keep quiet, go along.

At the warehouse, the new guy gets called "Prof" in his first week, because he wears glasses and once, fatally, used the word "ostensibly." He hates it. He laughs anyway, every time, because more than anything that first month he wants to be one of them. By Christmas he's down as Prof on the schedule, and has mostly stopped minding.

02

## We go along more than we think.

In Solomon Asch's famous experiments (Asch, 1956), people judged which of three lines matched another line. When the actors around them all gave the same wrong answer, people went along with the group on about a third of the answers, even though the right answer was obvious.

Many people never went along at all. Later research, such as a review by Bond and Smith (1996), found the effect is real but varies, smaller in more recent studies and larger in cultures that put the group first.

Everyone in the meeting loved the new schedule. Bukola could see a hole the size of a bus in the Friday cover, and said nothing, because everyone loved the new schedule. Afterward, waiting for the elevator, two colleagues said quietly that they'd had doubts too. All three of them went back to their desks. The schedule started on the Monday and the Friday cover fell over on the

first Friday. Writing your own view down before a group decides, and only then listening, makes it a good deal easier to say it.

**Groupthink**

Irving Janis named the moment a close group's wish to agree crowds out a realistic look at the options. His evidence was case studies of big policy decisions, so it's an idea more than a measurement, but two of his remedies travel well: the person in charge holds back their view at first, and someone is asked to argue the other side.

**Janis (1972)** · *Mixed: an influential idea built on case studies*

## We go along more than we think

*And one other voice changes a lot.*




### Alone against the group




*went along on about 1 in 3 answers*

### With one ally




*going along fell sharply*

*One calm, kind voice saying "I see it differently" often frees others to say so too.*

*Asch (1956). About a quarter of people never went along. Across 133 later studies the effect held but varied by time and culture (Bond and Smith, 1996).*

FIGURE 22 We go along more than we think, and one other voice changes a lot. In Asch's studies, going along fell sharply when one other person gave the right answer.

03

## Authority can lead people a long way.

In Stanley Milgram's experiments (Milgram, 1963), many ordinary people kept giving what they believed were painful electric shocks to a stranger because a man in a lab coat told them to, although no shocks were real. Burger (2009) repeated part of the study safely and found similar results. The studies are also debated. Later researchers, such as Haslam and Reicher (2012), argue that people went along when they believed in the cause, and many people refused.

On a night shift, a senior doctor tells a staff nurse to give a dose that looks wrong to her. It's three in the morning, and he is very senior and very tired. She checks anyway, and then says so, and she's right. Checking was the loyal thing to do. He said thank you, eventually, and sounded as if he meant it.

**Safe to speak up**

In 51 teams at one manufacturing company, Amy Edmondson found that a shared sense that it was safe to take interpersonal risks went with more learning, and learning went with better performance. Most later studies are correlational, but the idea has held up widely.

**Edmondson (1999)** · *Strong: a highly replicated idea, though mostly correlational*

04

## "Us and them" forms fast.

Part of how we see ourselves comes from our groups, whether that's a family, a town, a team, a faith or a job. Tajfel and Turner (1979) called this social identity. It brings pride and loyalty. It also makes us quick to favor "us" and to see "them" as all the same, even when the groups are formed on almost nothing.

Two branches of one family have always sat apart at weddings, and nobody can quite remember why. Something about a christening in 1994. At the most recent one a cousin quietly rearranged the seating plan, and the two sides discovered, over the cheese course, a shared and passionate weakness for terrible music. They were the last ones on the dance floor. They still sit apart at funerals, but it's a start.

05

## Norms are the rules nobody wrote down.

Every group has norms about what you wear, how you speak, what you laugh at and what you never mention, and we often guess them wrong. In studies at one university, Prentice and Miller (1993) found that most students were privately less comfortable with heavy drinking than they thought everyone else was. Each person thought they were the odd one out, so everyone kept going along.

In one office everybody answered emails at midnight, because everybody thought it was expected. Then a manager said, quite casually, in a meeting about something else, that she didn't expect replies after six. You could almost hear the room breathe out. "We have always done it this way" usually means a rule nobody has checked in years, so it's worth asking when anyone last did.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 17

**House rules for us**

*Shona and her son Dexter, 15*

### House rules for us

Person A
*Shona*

Person B
*Dexter*

Date of this list
*October 3, 2026*

### Our rules, and who keeps each one

| Rule | Who keeps it | Why it matters to Shona | Why it matters to Dexter |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Phones charge in the kitchen from 10 on school nights* | *Both (decide together)* | *I sleep better knowing you're not up at 2* | *Fine if it's both our phones, not just mine* |
| *Homework before games, Monday to Thursday* | *Dexter* | *Fewer reminders from me* | *Weekends are mine, then* |

| Rule | Who keeps it | Why it matters to Shona | Why it matters to Dexter |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Say where you're going and when you'll be back* | *Both (decide together)* | *So I don't worry* | *Mom does it too, so it's fair* |
| *Friday tea together, no phones at the table* | *Both (decide together)* | *It's my favorite hour of the week* | *Only if I can pick the food sometimes* |

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

**Rules with someone who keeps them**

4 of 4. Every rule has someone who keeps it.

### Changes to the list

| Date | What changed | Who |
|---|---|---|
| 3 Oct 2026 | *Dexter asked for weekends without phone rules. Agreed for a month, then we look again.* | *Shona and Dexter* |

*Made-up example. The norms nobody wrote down, written down, with room for both of them to change them.*

Fill in your own: House rules for us (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)

06

## Cultures differ, and so do people inside them.

Cultures differ in how much they put the individual or the group first, which researchers call individualism and collectivism (Hofstede, 1980). In some, standing out is admired, and in others fitting in and keeping harmony are signs of maturity. Labels need care, though. A large review by Oyserman and colleagues (2002) found the differences were smaller and less tidy than often claimed, and individuals vary hugely within every culture.

Anjali calls her mom every day, sometimes twice. Her partner Sean, who was raised to "do his own thing" and calls his parents on birthdays, thought this was clingy. She thought he was cold, and said so, once, in the car. Each of them was following rules they'd learned before they could tie their shoes. It came out properly over a Sunday dinner at her mom's, when her mom asked

Sean when he'd last called his own mother, and he genuinely couldn't remember.

07

## Every family is a small culture.

Families have their own norms about how loud people are and how feelings are shown. Some things get talked about and some never do, and there are rules about how you say sorry, if you do. Usually we only notice our family's rules when we live with someone from a different family. Where your lens came from (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-1-then) looks at the rules you grew up with.

Two roommates clashed over the kitchen for most of a semester. In one family you wash up straight after eating. In the other you leave it to soak and do it in the morning. Each thought the other was lazy, or fussy, depending. Neither was. Each was obeying a rule from a kitchen two hundred miles away, and once they'd worked that out they made a third rule, which neither of them likes and both of them keep.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 18

**Kitchen-table check-in: family plan**

*Amaka and Chris, new parents, with Chris's parents*

### Our family plan

A plan for the family, not a list of chores.

Who's in this plan (optional)

*Amaka, Chris, Grandma Joy and Grandpa Pete*

Visits

*Sunday lunch every other week, 12 to 3. Text the day before.*

Advice

*Ask first: "Do you want ideas, or just to talk?"*

The baby's or children's routines

*Nap at 1. Back to sleep on her back, always. Ask us before any new food.*

A regular job for a grandparent or relative
*Grandpa Pete does the Tuesday morning walk with the stroller.*

We'll look at this again on
*The first Sunday of December*

ON THE CARD

One topic at a time. We're on the same side.

*Two family cultures, one plan written on purpose.*
Fill in your own: Kitchen-table check-in: family plan
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins)

08

## Online groups pull harder and faster.

Group chats, forums and social media make group pressure quicker and more public, because likes and replies show the norm instantly. In a study of over half a million posts, Brady and colleagues (2017) found that messages with more moral and emotional words spread further, mostly among people who already agreed. Outrage travels fast. Quiet doubts stay put.

A parents' group chat turned against a teacher after one angry post about a detention, forty messages in an hour. One dad, who knew her a little from the PTA, sent something calm. He said he'd want to hear her side before anyone decided anything. Two other parents agreed with him, and the thread went quiet and stayed quiet. Before you react to a heated post, wait ten minutes. The Chat analyzer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator) can help you read a message calmly first.



TIDBIT

Group chats move fast. Before you send a reply, a helper on the website can read the room with you.

TOOL **Chat analyzer** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

09

## You can belong and still be yourself.

Belonging means being accepted as you are, whereas fitting in means changing in order to be accepted (Chapter 5, page 74, says more). Good groups have room for difference. It helps to know your own values, to have more than one group, and to have at least one ally. In Asch's experiments, when just one other person gave the right answer, going along with the group dropped sharply.

Rory loves chess and his friends tease him about it, relentlessly. He didn't drop chess and he didn't drop his friends. He joined the club that meets in the library on Wednesdays as well, so now he has two groups and neither of them gets to decide who he is. He gets teased, and he's also county under-16 runner-up, which he mentions more often than strictly necessary.

10

## Disagree kindly, and early.

You don't have to choose between going along and starting a war. A kind disagreement is short and calm, it's about the issue, and it leaves room for other people. Speaking early is easier than speaking late, and a private word often works better than speaking up in front of everyone.

Some people keep a sentence ready, for exactly this. "I see it a bit differently. Can I say why?" "I'm not comfortable with that joke." "Can we hear from people who haven't spoken yet?" Pick the one that sounds most like you and say it out loud a few times in the car, so it's there when you need it. Say it so it lands (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-09-say-it-so-it-lands) helps with the words.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Disagreeing early and kindly is easier with the words ready. This workpaper helps you say it so it lands.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can notice the pull to fit in, check what you actually think, choose your groups, and say "I see it differently" kindly.

You can't control what a group does, and you don't have to stay in a group that keeps asking you to hide who you are or go against what's right.

THURSDAY, 9:40PM

*You don't press it, and you message your aunt instead, privately. I know it was meant to be funny but it might hurt if they see it. Could we leave it?*

*Four minutes later the joke vanishes, and then a message comes through to you. It was only a bit of fun. People are so sensitive these days. At ten thirty your cousin messages to say thank you, because she saw it before it went. At Sunday lunch your aunt passes you the gravy without looking at you, and you don't yet know whether that'll pass.*

## If you're a teenager

Group chats are where a lot of friendship happens, and a lot of hurt. Mason is fifteen when he finds a photo of himself from gym class being passed around his class chat with comments under it. He doesn't answer back.

He screenshots it and mutes the chat. Then he tells his sister, and together they tell his homeroom teacher. Then a girl in his class messages him privately to say it wasn't funny and that she's sorry she didn't say anything. Most people in a group chat don't like what's happening, and each of them thinks everyone else does.

YOU COULD SAY

"I'm not okay with this. Please delete it." To a friend, "That wasn't okay. Are you alright?" To an adult, "Something's happening online and I need help with it."

## Influence, pressure and manipulation.

Groups and people shape each other all the time, and most of it is ordinary. You pick up a team's jokes, a family's habits and a friend group's taste in music, and people who care about you will sometimes try to change your mind. That's influence, and it happens in the open. "Manipulative" is a much stronger word.

For something to be manipulation, these are usually all present:

- the person wants something they aren't saying, or gives you information they know is false,
- they use your feelings, such as guilt, fear or love, to get it,
- it's deliberate and it repeats,
- saying no costs you something, such as your place in the group or warmth from them.

Not enough on its own:

- persuading you openly, even hard,
- asking more than once,
- being disappointed or sad when you say no,
- hinting instead of asking, which is a normal style in many families and cultures.

A good test is whether you could say "I see it differently" and still be welcome next week. If something feels off, describe the moment rather than the motive: "When you said the others would be let down if I didn't come, I felt pushed. Can you just ask me straight?"

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

### A group, two ways

Some people pick up a group's unwritten rules in a week without anyone saying them. Others only find a rule out by breaking it. If the rules reach you easily, say them out loud for the people they

don't reach. If they don't reach you, asking "What's the rule here?" is a fair question, not a weakness.

**Where the fields meet.** Politics says every group needs a fair way to decide and a say for everyone. Behavioral science adds that norms are habits the whole group keeps without noticing. The root is quiet incentives, because a group drifts toward whatever it rewards.

## In everyday life

Having no group can be as hard as having a pushy one, and groups built round something you enjoy bring belonging along with the activity. Partners bring two families and two sets of rules, which are worth talking about openly before you make your own. Children and teenagers feel peer pressure strongly, and practicing a "no" that saves face helps them. Old family roles, the peacekeeper or the black sheep, can be hard to step out of. At work, when everyone agrees too fast, it helps if whoever leads shares their view last and asks each person to name one risk before deciding (more in the full chapter, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-17-groups-in-depth). And online, you're allowed to mute, leave, or take a break from groups that leave you feeling worse.

## If you want to help someone else with this

If someone speaks up, back them up, even quietly ("I think that's a fair point"), because one ally makes a huge difference. In any group you lead, invite the quieter people and the different views by asking what nobody has thought of yet. If someone seems to be going along against their wishes, ask gently, away from the group. And keep an eye on who gets left out of the chats and the plans, so you can bring them in.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I noticed you went quiet when they said that. Are you okay?" "I'd like to hear what you think, even if it's different."

## Reading on the website

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- The wiring card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card), to share how you work best so a group can make room for you.
- Leading a group (spreadloveandacceptance.com/groups), a six-session guide with ground rules that make room for difference.
- The library on teams (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/teams), including psychological safety.
- The library: family scripts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life), social comparison (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life#social-comparison), the false consensus effect (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking) and confirmation bias (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking#confirmation-bias).
- How communication works (page 57), on saying hard things so they land.

## More for your situation

- For teens: friends and pressure (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · In-laws (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life#in-laws)
- At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- For teachers (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-teachers)
- **Related chapters:** Belonging and trust (page 74) · How we see each other (page 43) · Values (page 148)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ The pull to fit in is old and strong.
- ✓ Authority can lead people a long way.
- ✓ Norms are the rules nobody wrote down.
- ✓ Online groups pull harder and faster.
- ✓ Disagree kindly, and early.

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part Three · Chapter 3 · How we see each other**
*Bias and the stories we tell* page 43

**Part Three · Chapter 5 · Attachment, trust and belonging**
*Why belonging matters so much* page 74

**Part Three · Chapter 10 · Values, meaning and a good life**
*Holding on to your own values* page 148

**Part Two · Chapter IV · Two kinds of fair**
*Agreeing what fair means in your group* read online

PUT IT TO USE



**The wiring card**
To share how you work best so a group can make room for you
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card



**Leading a group**
A six-session guide with ground rules that make room for difference
spreadloveandacceptance.com/groups

# Workpapers and tools in this book

*Every workpaper and tool this book points to, in two separate lists, with the chapters and pages that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.*

## Workpapers mentioned in this book

*Pages to fill in, on your own or together.*

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02
In: Stress and the nervous system (page **28**), Helping others well (page **175**)

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03
In: Habits and change (page **88**), Helping others well (page **175**), Groups, influence and culture (page **245**)

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09
In: How communication works (page **57**), Groups, influence and culture (page **245**)

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11
In: How feelings work (page **14**), Stress and the nervous system (page **28**), Anger (page **188**), Worry, low mood and trauma (page **231**)

WORKPAPER WP-13 **The 90-second daily check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-13
In: Habits and change (page **88**)

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-15
In: Attachment, trust and belonging (page **74**), Values, meaning and a good life (page **148**), Closeness and love (page **218**)

## Tools mentioned in this book

*Interactive helpers to use on the site.*

TOOL **Chat analyzer** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator
In: How we see each other (page **43**), How communication works (page **57**), Groups, influence and culture (page **245**)

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder
In: How we see each other (page **43**), How communication works (page **57**), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page **102**), Healing after hurt (page **161**)

TOOL **Say no kindly: make your scripts** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/refusals
In: Helping others well (page 175)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: make a pause plan** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw
In: Stress and the nervous system (page 28), Attachment, trust and belonging (page 74), Anger (page 188)

TOOL **Kitchen-table check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins
In: How communication works (page 57), Helping others well (page 175), Groups, influence and culture (page 245)

TOOL **Small wins: Flip it** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins
In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 102), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 231)

TOOL **Stay close: one small idea** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding
In: How feelings work (page 14), Attachment, trust and belonging (page 74), Closeness and love (page 218)

TOOL **How you connect: what feels like care** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages
In: Values, meaning and a good life (page 148), Closeness and love (page 218)

TOOL **How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength
In: Personality, temperament and change (page 203)

TOOL **How you connect: how I like to be spoken to** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card
In: How communication works (page 57), Minds that work differently (page 129), Personality, temperament and change (page 203), Groups, influence and culture (page 245)

TOOL **Old rules, new choices** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up
In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 102), Values, meaning and a good life (page 148)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: Upset right now?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now
In: How feelings work (page 14), Stress and the nervous system (page 28), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 102), Loss, grief and big life changes (page 116), Healing after hurt (page 161), Anger (page 188), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 231)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: soften a tense moment** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/soften-a-tense-moment
In: Anger (page 188)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

In: Stress and the nervous system (page **28**), Loss, grief and big life changes (page **116**), Worry, low mood and trauma (page **231**)

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

In: How feelings work (page **14**)

TOOL **My weather today: the sky (the ladder)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

In: Stress and the nervous system (page **28**), Healing after hurt (page **161**)

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page **102**), Loss, grief and big life changes (page **116**), Healing after hurt (page **161**)

TOOL **Ask Professor Puddles** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page **102**), Values, meaning and a good life (page **148**), Helping others well (page **175**)

TOOL **Read your way** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-you-take-things-in

In: Minds that work differently (page **129**)

TOOL **Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

In: Habits and change (page **88**)

TOOL **Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting

In: How we see each other (page **43**), How communication works (page **57**), Healing after hurt (page **161**)

TOOL **Plan it once: room agreement for roommates** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room

In: How communication works (page **57**), Minds that work differently (page **129**), Personality, temperament and change (page **203**)

TOOL **Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/work

In: Attachment, trust and belonging (page **74**), Habits and change (page **88**), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page **102**), Values, meaning and a good life (page **148**), Helping others well (page **175**), Anger (page **188**), Personality, temperament and change (page **203**), Worry, low mood and trauma (page **231**), Groups, influence and culture (page **245**)

# How the numbers work

*Every number in this book is arithmetic you can do with a pencil. None of them is a test, a diagnosis or a verdict on anyone: they describe a week, a load or a way of sharing work. The weights and cut-offs are this book's own rules of thumb, not research findings, and you are free to disagree with them. The worked examples are the book's own, so you can check them against the chapters.*

Two habits run through all of them. **Scores are rounded to two decimal places before their band is read,** so the number you see and the words you see always agree. And **nobody's score is ever worked out for them:** if someone's own answer is missing, the total waits.

## The stress tank: How much are you carrying?

You score five things from 0 (not at all) to 4 (very true), about the last day or two: sleep debt, workload elsewhere, unresolved conflict, your physical state, and time pressure today.

```
tank = (sleep + workload + conflict + body + time) ÷ 20
```

The answer runs from 0 to 1, and **higher means fuller**. Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 up to 0.60 medium, and 0.60 or more high. (The worksheet splits each band in two for its words: very light under 0.15, light, medium on the lighter side under 0.45, medium on the heavier side, high under 0.80, and very high from 0.80.) Your **battery** is the other side of the same thing, the energy you have left, so a full tank means a low battery. The battery is a picture in words, not a second score.

> WORKED EXAMPLE Rosa, from Part Two, Chapter III (online), scores sleep 3, workload 4, conflict 1, body 2 and time 3.
>
> `3 + 4 + 1 + 2 + 3 = 13; 13 ÷ 20 = 0.65`, which is in the high band.

**Two or more of you:** each person scores only themselves, and the shared figure is the plain average of everyone's own scores. If any one person is at 0.60 or more, treat that as the headline, whatever the average says.

**Coming back after a pause** (the Calm-Down Kit): if you like numbers, take the score again after a calming round. Under 0.50, go back at the time you named. From 0.50 to 0.59, take another round. At 0.60 or more after two rounds, put it off to a named

time. The kit's line sits at 0.50 on purpose: you don't need an empty tank to come back, just one less than half full.

### My weather today: the room in your day

My weather today shows words, not numbers: a sky (clear, gusty or fogged in) and how much room you have today. Behind the words sits a rough tally from 0 to 100, where **higher means a heavier day**. You only see it if you tick "Show the numbers behind this."

| WHAT YOU PICKED | ADDS |
|---|---|
| The sky: clear, gusty, fogged in | 0, 26, 34 |
| The pressure: light, building, heavy (skipped: 6) | 0, 10, 20 |
| Last night's sleep: properly rested, about enough, short night, barely slept (skipped: 6) | 0, 2, 10, 18 |
| People load: barely any, a normal amount, a lot, nonstop (skipped: 4) | 0, 3, 9, 14 |
| Ground conditions (hungry, thirsty, in pain and so on) | 4 each, up to 14 |
| What's blowing in (work, money, health and so on) | 3 each, up to 10 |

Under 45 reads as lots of room today, 45 to 64 as some room, and 65 or more as very little room.

WORKED EXAMPLE Joel, from Part One, Now (online), picks gusty, building pressure, a short night, a lot of people time, one ground condition (hungry) and one thing blowing in (work).

`26 + 10 + 10 + 9 + 4 + 3 = 62`: some room today, with less than usual, so the forecast says to go gently and settle first.

All of these are this book's own ways of putting things into numbers. They have not been tested in research studies, and they shouldn't be quoted as findings. The free calculators on the website do the arithmetic for you, and each one has a "How is this worked out?" note.

# Blank worksheets

*Photocopy or print these pages, as many times as you like, and fill them out by hand. Each one is a blank copy of a worksheet in the book. The free fillable versions on the website do the sums for you, and keep what you type on your own device.*

# How much are you carrying?

Fillable version: spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02.html

Fill this out on your own, about yourself only. Never fill it out for someone else.

Your name _____ Date _____

### The checklist

Score each row based on how the last 24–48 hours have actually gone. Circle one: 0 = Not at all, 4 = Very true. Living with a long-term illness? Your physical row may always be high. That fills the tank; it isn't a mood.

| | Not at all | | | | Very true |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Sleep debt (less rested than usual) | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
| Workload elsewhere (job, school, caregiving) | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
| Recent unresolved conflict (any source) | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
| Physical state (hungry, sick, in pain) | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
| Time pressure today specifically | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |

### How full is your stress tank?

Points (add the five circled numbers): _____ out of 20

Tank: points ÷ 20 = _____ out of 1.00

Higher means a fuller tank (and a lower battery). Under 0.30: light. 0.30 to 0.59: medium. 0.60 or more: high. Put off anything that doesn't need deciding in the next hour.

### Optional

☐ Some of what I'm carrying is caring for someone

**Anything you want to name before talking**

A high score is a way to press pause, not a way out. It means "let's come back to this tomorrow," not "this doesn't need to happen."

# Say it so it lands

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09.html

A self-check each of you uses on your own side of a conversation. Use it on one thing that actually stung.

Your name _____ Date _____

## Before you speak or send: fact, feeling, ask

**Raw reaction (optional, and just for you)**

**What's the fact underneath this? (One sentence, no adjectives.) For example: "The trash went out late on Tuesday."**

**What's the feeling underneath this? (Frustrated, tired, unseen, rushed…) A feeling about you, not a verdict about them.**

**What's the actual ask? (What do you want to happen next, specifically?) Something the other person can say yes to.**

## Before you react: four quick checks

| Check | Circle one |
|---|---|
| Is this about a specific, nameable task or event? | Yes · No |
| Would I read this the same way if I weren't already carrying a lot? | Yes · No · Not sure |
| Is there a neutral interpretation that also fits what was said? | Yes · No |
| Am I responding to their words, or to a pattern from a past conversation? | Their words · A past pattern |

A "No" or "Not sure" on the second check, a "Yes" on the third or "A past pattern" on the fourth are good reasons to pause first. A kind "not right now" and a time to come back keep it honest.

# The Calm-Down Kit

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11.html

A short plan, made ahead of time, for calming your body down enough to have the conversation, or to put it off honestly. Fill in Part A on an ordinary day, not a hard one. Your kit is yours; only the pause plan is made to share.

Whose kit is this? (your name) _____ Date _____

### Part A: What tends to start it

| What tends to start it | How it shows up in my body first |
|---|---|
| | |
| | |
| | |

### Part A: My two defaults

Pick two calming steps now: asymmetric breathing (breathe in for 4, out for 6) · naming the room (5 things you see, 4 you hear, 3 you can touch) · weight and pressure (feet pressed firmly into the floor, or something warm held in both hands) · gating (cutting noise and light: lower the lights, step out) · walking it out · a low, steady sound.

First default _____ Second, if the first isn't available _____

### Part A: My pause line

Say how you are, how long you need, and when you'll be back: "I'm at capacity. I need ten minutes. I'll be back at a quarter after."

_____

### Our pause plan (agree it together, and share it)

Our pause word or signal _____ The shortest break we take _____

How we set the time to come back _____ The first sentence when we come back _____

**Part B, in the moment:** say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step.

### Part C: Coming back

Still hot? Another round. Twice? Name a new time. Settled enough to listen? Go back at the time you named. (For number fans: your stress tank score, 0 to 1. Under 0.50, go back. From 0.50 to 0.59, take another round. At 0.60 or above after two rounds, put it off.)

| Time | What I did | How I feel now (Still hot / Settled enough) | Stress tank before (0–1) | Stress tank after (0–1) |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | |
| | | | | |
| | | | | |

Next small action _____ If you put the conversation off: when you'll pick it back up _____

### Where I've landed

☐ I'm going with this

Look at this again on (optional) _____

Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

# Words used in this book

*The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. More at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.*

### Alexithymia

Finding it hard to notice, name or describe your own feelings. It is a trait on a scale, not an illness, and it is more common in some autistic people. Naming body signals first can help.

### A bid

A bid is any small reach for attention or connection, like "look at this," a sigh or a joke.

*For example: They show you a photo of a dog. Looking and smiling back is turning toward it.*

### Check-in

A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

*For example: "Load today: heavy. Thank you for the dishes. One small thing: the car. My ask: could you fill it up?"*

### Complacency

Complacency is what happens when something has worked for a long time and you stop checking on it. It isn't laziness or a lack of love. It's a setup nobody has looked at lately.

*For example: "How was your day?" "Fine." Months go by and nobody has asked a real question.*

### Double empathy

The idea, from the autistic researcher Damian Milton, that misunderstandings between autistic and non-autistic people run both ways: each finds the other hard to read, so neither side is simply "missing" something.

### Drift

Drift is how two people slowly fall out of step when nobody checks in, even when nothing is wrong.

*For example: Three busy weeks, no real talk, and small things start to feel big.*

### Flooded

Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.

*For example: "I need twenty minutes. Can we talk again at eight?"*

### Groupthink

When a close group wants agreement so much that doubts go unsaid and a poor decision goes ahead. Irving Janis named it in 1972.

### If-then plan

A small plan written as "If this happens, then I will do that," which makes a new habit easier to start (Peter Gollwitzer).

### A kind no

A kind no says what you can and can't do right now, without blaming anyone.

*For example: "I can't take that on this week. I could help on Saturday."*

### Kinship care

When a grandparent, aunt, older sibling or family friend raises a child whose parents can't.

### The ladder

Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. My weather today calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

### The load

The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

*For example: Buying the gift is one job. Remembering the birthday, picking the gift and wrapping it are three more.*

### Masking

Masking is hiding the way you're wired to fit in, which can be very tiring over time.

*For example: Forcing eye contact and rehearsing small talk all day, then needing the evening to recover.*

### Monotropism

A theory of autistic attention: attention gathers deeply on a few things at a time, rather than spreading thinly across many. Switching away can take real effort.

### My weather today

My weather today is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

*For example: Short night, busy day: the forecast says to keep big talks for tomorrow.*

### Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

*For example: Sam owns the recycling: noticing it's full, taking it out and buying the bags.*

### Pressure

Pressure, in My weather today, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

*For example: A pressure of 40 leaves room in the day; 75 means go gently and leave big things for later.*

### Prolonged grief

Grief that stays intense and gets in the way of daily life for a long time after a death (6 to 12 months or more, depending on the guideline). It is treatable.

### Psychological safety

A shared sense in a group or team that you can speak up, ask a question or admit a mistake without being punished or embarrassed (Amy Edmondson).

### Repair

A repair is anything that stops a tense moment from getting worse, like a joke, a softer tone or "Can we start over?"

*For example: "I said that badly. What I meant was..."*

### Rumination

Going over the same worry or regret again and again without getting closer to an answer.

### Second arrow

The extra pain we add on top of a hard moment, such as being angry at ourselves for being sad. The first arrow is the event; the second is what we tell ourselves about it (a Buddhist image).

### Setup score

The one number from Is the setup working for everyone?: balance, ownership and stress added up with weights (0.40, 0.35 and 0.25), from 0 to 1. 0.70 and up is working well, 0.40 to 0.69 needs a look, under 0.40 needs a rethink, together. It judges the setup, never a person.

### Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?, scored from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 to 0.59 medium, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

### Turning toward

Turning toward means answering someone's small bids for attention, even briefly, instead of missing or brushing them off.

*For example: "Oh, that's a funny one!" instead of scrolling on.*

### Wave Code

Four letters from the style quiz in How you connect, one for each of four preferences about how you take in and send words. Each letter shows where you lean on a dial today: a shorthand for preferences, not a personality type.

### Window of tolerance

The range in which you can feel strong feelings and still think and talk. Above it you are flooded or revved up; below it you shut down. A phrase from the psychiatrist Dan Siegel.

### Wired differently

Being wired differently means your brain works in a less common way, such as being autistic, ADHD, dyslexic or highly sensitive, which changes how words land.

*For example: A hint like "the trash are full" may be heard as a plain fact, not a request.*

### Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

*For example: Some people need a plan in writing. Others think best out loud.*

### Workpaper

A page you fill in, on your own or with someone, about your own week or your own side. Every workpaper is free to print or to fill out on the website.

*For example: "Who did what" is a week's log of who did what.*

### Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

*For example: "Rest is earned" can feel like plain fact, until you notice it was your family's rule.*

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# Research notes

*The 332 studies and books the chapters mention, chapter by chapter, each with what it found in plain words and where to read it. Each entry was looked up and checked: most against the paper itself or its abstract, some (mostly older books) against a publisher's or library's record. Unchecked works are left out. The full list, with notes on how strong each finding is, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.*

## Reading research: a few words in plain English

The chapters often say how sure the research is: "a small study," "linked with," "didn't replicate." Here is what those words mean, so every note in the book is something you can weigh for yourself.

**Correlational ("linked with")**
Two things tend to go together: people who sleep less tend to argue more. It doesn't show which causes which, or whether a third thing, like a new baby, causes both.

**Experiment**
Researchers change one thing on purpose, ideally deciding by chance who gets it, and compare. Better at showing cause, though often in a lab, for a short time, with a small group.

**Meta-analysis**
A study of studies: it pools many studies of the same question. Usually more trustworthy than any one study, but only as good as the studies in it.

**Replication**
Doing a study again to see if the result holds. When a large team re-ran 100 published psychology studies in 2015, only about a third gave a clear result again, and the effects were on average about half as big. So one study is a start, not the end.

**Effect size**
How big a difference is, not just whether there is one. A result can be real ("significant") and still tiny. The book says "small" or "modest" when that is the case.

**Who was studied**
Much of psychology studies students in Western, educated, well-off countries. A finding may not fit every age, culture or kind of family, and many studies of couples looked only at a mother and a father.

**Self-report**
People answered questions about themselves. That is often the only way to ask about feelings, but memory and wanting to look good both creep in.

**How the book labels things:** a *Research note* describes published findings in plain words and says where the evidence is thin. *This site's idea* marks the book's own ways of putting things into practice, such as the worksheets and the setup score, which have not been tested in studies. The full list at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research also says how strong each finding is: strong, moderate or early.

PART THREE · CHAPTER 1

## How feelings work


**Barrett, L. F. (2017).** *The theory of constructed emotion: an active inference account of interoception and categorization.* Social Cognitive and Affective Neuroscience, 12(1), 1–23. Sets out the theory that the brain constantly predicts the body's needs and constructs emotions by making sense of body sensations using learned concepts.
doi.org/10.1093/scan/nsw154

**Barrett, L. F., Adolphs, R., Marsella, S., Martinez, A. M., & Pollak, S. D. (2019).** *Emotional expressions reconsidered: Challenges to inferring emotion from human facial movements.* Psychological Science in the Public Interest, 20(1), 1–68. Concluded that facial movements are not reliable enough to infer a person's specific emotion across situations and cultures.
doi.org/10.1177/1529100619832930

**Bird, G., & Cook, R. (2013).** *Mixed emotions: The contribution of alexithymia to the emotional symptoms of autism.* Translational Psychiatry, 3(7), e285. Argued that emotional difficulties seen in some autistic people are better explained by co-occurring alexithymia than by autism itself.
doi.org/10.1038/tp.2013.61

**Bushman, B. J. (2002).** *Does venting anger feed or extinguish the flame? Catharsis, rumination, distraction, anger, and aggressive responding.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 28(6), 724–731. Angered people who hit a punching bag while thinking about the person who provoked them felt angrier afterward than people who were distracted or did nothing.
doi.org/10.1177/0146167202289002

**Cacioppo, J. T., & Patrick, W. (2008).** *Loneliness: Human Nature and the Need for Social Connection.* W. W. Norton (New York). A book arguing that loneliness is a biological signal, like hunger, that we need connection, and that chronic loneliness can trap people in isolation and harm health.
wellcomecollection.org/works/wp45vzsp

**Craig, A. D. (2002).** *How do you feel? Interoception: the sense of the physiological condition of the body.* Nature Reviews Neuroscience, 3(8), 655–666. Described a pathway that carries signals about the body's internal state to the brain (including the insula), and proposed it underlies subjective feelings, emotion and self-awareness.
doi.org/10.1038/nrn894

**Dutton, D. G., & Aron, A. P. (1974).** *Some evidence for heightened sexual attraction under conditions of high anxiety.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 30(4), 510–517. In a field study, men approached by an attractive female interviewer on a high, swaying suspension bridge were more likely to call her afterward than men approached on a low, sturdy bridge; the authors read this as arousal from fear being mislabelled as attraction.
doi.org/10.1037/h0037031

**Ekman, P., & Friesen, W. V. (1971).** *Constants across cultures in the face and emotion.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 17(2), 124–129. In the Fore people of Papua New Guinea, who had seen little Western media, adults and children mostly matched short emotion stories to the same facial expressions that Western people chose. This was taken as evidence that a few facial expressions of emotion are shared across cultures.
doi.org/10.1037/h0030377

**Gross, J. J., & John, O. P. (2003).** *Individual differences in two emotion regulation processes: Implications for affect, relationships, and well-being.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 85(2), 348–362. Across five studies, people who habitually reappraised had better emotional experience, relationships and well-being; habitual suppression was linked to worse outcomes.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.85.2.348

**Hatfield, E., Cacioppo, J. T., & Rapson, R. L. (1994).** *Emotional contagion.* Cambridge University Press (Studies in Emotion and Social Interaction). Describes emotional contagion: people tend to mimic each other's faces, voices and postures, and that mimicry can shift their own feelings.
catalogue.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/cb37435416b

**James, W. (1884).** *What is an emotion?* Mind, os-IX(34), 188–205. James argued that bodily changes follow directly from perceiving something exciting, and that our feeling of those bodily changes is the emotion.
doi.org/10.1093/mind/os-IX.34.188

**Kashdan, T. B., Barrett, L. F., & McKnight, P. E. (2015).** *Unpacking emotion differentiation: Transforming unpleasant experience by perceiving distinctions in negativity.* Current Directions in Psychological Science, 24(1), 10–16. Reviewed research on emotion differentiation (emotional granularity): people who describe negative feelings in fine-grained ways tend to rely less on unhelpful coping such as binge drinking or aggression.
doi.org/10.1177/0963721414550708

**Kircanski, K., Lieberman, M. D., & Craske, M. G. (2012).** *Feelings into words: Contributions of language to exposure therapy.* Psychological Science, 23(10), 1086–1091. Spider-fearful people who described their feelings in words while near a live spider showed lower skin-conductance arousal a week later than people who reappraised, distracted themselves or had exposure alone; self-reported fear did not differ between groups.
doi.org/10.1177/0956797612443830

**Levant, R. F., Hall, R. J., Williams, C. M., & Hasan, N. T. (2009).** *Gender differences in alexithymia.* Psychology of Men & Masculinity, 10(3), 190–203. A meta-analysis of 41 samples found that men scored slightly higher than women on alexithymia (difficulty identifying and describing feelings), but the difference was small.
doi.org/10.1037/a0015652

**Lieberman, M. D., Eisenberger, N. I., Crockett, M. J., Tom, S. M., Pfeifer, J. H., & Way, B. M. (2007).** *Putting feelings into words: Affect labeling disrupts amygdala activity in response to affective stimuli.* Psychological Science, 18(5), 421–428. In a brain-imaging study, labeling the emotion in a picture reduced amygdala and other limbic responses compared with other ways of processing the image.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2007.01916.x

**Marlatt, G. A., & Gordon, J. R. (Eds.) (1985).** *Relapse prevention: Maintenance strategies in the treatment of addictive behaviors.* Guilford Press. An edited volume setting out the cognitive-behavioral relapse prevention model, including the "abstinence violation effect": after one slip, guilt and a sense of total failure can make a full relapse more likely.
krimdok.uni-tuebingen.de/Record/27251005X

**Matsumoto, D., Yoo, S. H., & Nakagawa, S. (2008).** *Culture, emotion regulation, and adjustment.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 94(6), 925–937. Across 23 countries, cultures that placed more value on social order and hierarchy tended to report more suppression of emotions; cultures valuing individual autonomy and egalitarianism reported less.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.94.6.925

**Milton, D. E. M. (2012).** *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

**Pennebaker, J. W., & Beall, S. K. (1986).** *Confronting a traumatic event: Toward an understanding of inhibition and disease.* Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 95(3), 274–281. An early expressive-writing experiment in which students wrote about traumatic experiences over several days; it launched decades of research on whether writing about difficult experiences helps health and well-being.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-843X.95.3.274

**Schachter, S., & Singer, J. (1962).** *Cognitive, social, and physiological determinants of emotional state.* Psychological Review, 69(5), 379–399. Proposed the two-factor theory: an emotion is physical arousal plus a label we give it from the situation.
doi.org/10.1037/h0046234

**Schwarz, N., & Clore, G. L. (1983).** *Mood, misattribution, and judgments of well-being: Informative and directive functions of affective states.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 45(3), 513–523. People in a good mood (including people phoned on sunny days) rated their happiness and life satisfaction higher. A bad mood stopped lowering their ratings once their attention was drawn to an outside cause, such as the weather.
worlddatabaseofhappiness.eur.nl

**Singer, T., & Klimecki, O. M. (2014).** *Empathy and compassion.* Current Biology, 24(18), R875–R878. Distinguished empathic distress (sharing someone's pain, which can overwhelm) from compassion (warm concern), which engage different brain networks; brief compassion training increased positive feelings.
doi.org/10.1016/j.cub.2014.06.054

**Torre, J. B., & Lieberman, M. D. (2018).** *Putting feelings into words: Affect labeling as implicit emotion regulation.* Emotion Review, 10(2), 116–124. Reviewed evidence that naming a feeling can reduce its intensity even though it does not feel like regulating it at the time.
doi.org/10.1177/1754073917742706

**Verduyn, P., & Lavrijsen, S. (2015).** *Which emotions last longest and why: The role of event importance and rumination.* Motivation and Emotion, 39(1), 119–127. Of 27 emotions studied, sadness lasted longest, while shame, surprise, fear and disgust were among the shortest; long-lasting emotions tended to follow important events and involve rumination.
ppw.kuleuven.be/okp/_pdf/Verduyn2015WELLA.pdf

**Wegner, D. M., Schneider, D. J., Carter, S. R., & White, T. L. (1987).** *Paradoxical effects of thought suppression.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 53(1), 5–13. People asked not to think of a white bear kept thinking of it, suggesting that trying to suppress a thought can backfire.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.53.1.5

PART THREE · CHAPTER 2

## Stress and the nervous system

**Arnsten, A. F. T. (2009).** *Stress signalling pathways that impair prefrontal cortex structure and function.* Nature Reviews Neuroscience, 10(6), 410–422. Reviewed evidence that stress chemicals rapidly weaken the prefrontal cortex, which supports planning and flexible thinking, while strengthening more habitual responses.
doi.org/10.1038/nrn2648

**Bakker, A. B., & Demerouti, E. (2007).** *The job demands-resources model: State of the art.* Journal of Managerial Psychology, 22(3), 309–328. A review of the job demands-resources model: high job demands drive strain and burnout, while job resources such as support, control and feedback drive motivation and help buffer demands.
doi.org/10.1108/02683940710733115

**Balban, M. Y., Neri, E., Kogon, M. M., Weed, L., Nouriani, B., Jo, B., Holl, G., Zeitzer, J. M., Spiegel, D., & Huberman, A. D. (2023).** *Brief structured respiration practices enhance mood and reduce physiological arousal.* Cell Reports Medicine, 4(1), 100895. In a month-long randomized trial of five minutes a day, breathing exercises improved mood more than mindfulness meditation, with cyclic sighing (long out-breaths) showing the largest benefits.
doi.org/10.1016/j.xcrm.2022.100895

**Ben Simon, E., & Walker, M. P. (2018).** *Sleep loss causes social withdrawal and loneliness.* Nature Communications. After a night without sleep, young adults kept an approaching person at a greater distance and felt lonelier, with brain changes linked to social avoidance; rested people who briefly watched them felt lonelier too.
doi.org/10.1038/s41467-018-05377-0

**Bolger, N., Zuckerman, A., & Kessler, R. C. (2000).** *Invisible support and adjustment to stress.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 79(6), 953–961. In couples where one partner faced a stressful exam, support the recipient did not notice (reported by the giver but not the receiver) was linked with better adjustment, while noticed (visible) support was not.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.79.6.953

**Coan, J. A., Schaefer, H. S., & Davidson, R. J. (2006).** *Lending a hand: Social regulation of the neural response to threat.* Psychological Science, 17(12), 1032–1039. In an fMRI study, married women facing the threat of a mild shock showed less threat-related brain activity while holding their husband's hand than when alone.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2006.01832.x

**Gordon, A. M., & Chen, S. (2014).** *The role of sleep in interpersonal conflict: Do sleepless nights mean worse fights?* Social Psychological and Personality Science, 5(2), 168–175. In a 14-day daily study, people reported more conflict with their partner after poor nights of sleep, and conflicts were resolved best when both partners were well rested.
doi.org/10.1177/1948550613488952

**Hull, L., Petrides, K. V., Allison, C., Smith, P., Baron-Cohen, S., Lai, M.-C., & Mandy, W. (2017).** *"Putting on my best normal": Social camouflaging in adults with autism spectrum conditions.* Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders, 47(8), 2519–2534. Interviews with 92 autistic adults described camouflaging as motivated by wanting to fit in and connect, done through masking and compensating techniques, and often followed by exhaustion and threats to self-perception.
doi.org/10.1007/s10803-017-3166-5

**Jamieson, J. P., Nock, M. K., & Mendes, W. B. (2012).** *Mind over matter: Reappraising arousal improves cardiovascular and cognitive responses to stress.* Journal of Experimental Psychology: General, 141(3), 417–422. People told to see their stress arousal as helpful showed healthier cardiovascular responses and less attention to negative information than control groups.
doi.org/10.1037/a0025719

**Kanner, A. D., Coyne, J. C., Schaefer, C., & Lazarus, R. S. (1981).** *Comparison of two modes of stress measurement: Daily hassles and uplifts versus major life events.* Journal of Behavioral Medicine, 4(1), 1–39. Everyday hassles predicted psychological symptoms better than major life events did, and still did after life events were taken into account.
doi.org/10.1007/BF00844845

**Kaplan, S. (1995).** *The restorative benefits of nature: Toward an integrative framework.* Journal of Environmental Psychology, 15(3), 169–182. Set out attention restoration theory: effortful, directed attention gets fatigued, and environments such as nature, which hold attention effortlessly, help it recover; the paper links this with stress recovery.
doi.org/10.1016/0272-4944(95)90001-2

**Lazarus, R. S., & Folkman, S. (1984).** *Stress, appraisal, and coping.* Springer Publishing, New York. Set out the appraisal model: stress depends on judging whether something threatens you and whether you can cope; it also distinguished problem-focused from emotion-focused coping.
wellcomecollection.org/works/b5zr7tvm

**Leikas, S., & Ilmarinen, V.-J. (2017).** *Happy now, tired later? Extraverted and conscientious behavior are related to immediate mood gains, but to later fatigue.* Journal of Personality, 85(5), 603–615. In a 12-day experience-sampling study, acting extraverted went with better mood at the time but more fatigue about three hours later, for introverts and extraverts alike.
doi.org/10.1111/jopy.12264

**McEwen, B. S., & Stellar, E. (1993).** *Stress and the individual: Mechanisms leading to disease.* Archives of Internal Medicine, 153(18), 2093–2101. Introduced "allostatic load": the cumulative wear and tear on the body from repeated or chronic stress responses.
pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/8379800

**Miserandino, C. (2003).** *The spoon theory.* ButYouDontLookSick.com (essay). A personal essay in which Christine Miserandino, who has lupus, used a handful of spoons to show a friend that each daily task costs some of a limited supply of energy.
butyoudontlooksick.com/articles/written-by-christine/the-spoon-theory

**Murray, D., Lesser, M., & Lawson, W. (2005).** *Attention, monotropism and the diagnostic criteria for autism.* Autism, 9(2), 139–156. Proposed "monotropism": autistic attention tends to be pulled strongly into a few interests at a time, and the authors argued this can explain the other diagnostic features of autism.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361305051398

**Raymaker, D. M., Teo, A. R., Steckler, N. A., et al. (2020).** *"Having all of your internal resources exhausted beyond measure and being left with no clean-up crew": Defining autistic burnout.* Autism in Adulthood, 2(2), 132–143. From 19 interviews and 19 public online accounts, analyzed with autistic co-researchers, autistic burnout was defined as long-term exhaustion, loss of function and reduced tolerance to stimulus, arising from chronic life stress and a mismatch between expectations and abilities without enough support.
doi.org/10.1089/aut.2019.0079

**Repetti, R. L. (1989).** *Effects of daily workload on subsequent behavior during marital interaction: The roles of social withdrawal and spouse support.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 57(4), 651–659. In a daily study of air traffic controllers, after high-workload days they were more socially withdrawn and less emotionally expressive with their spouses that evening.
psych.ucla.edu/wp-content/uploads/Repetti-JPSP-1989.pdf

**Shaw, P., Stringaris, A., Nigg, J., & Leibenluft, E. (2014).** *Emotion dysregulation in attention deficit hyperactivity disorder.* American Journal of Psychiatry, 171(3), 276-293. A literature review found that trouble regulating emotions (quick, strong feelings that are hard to bring back down) is common in ADHD across the lifespan, with clinic studies of young people putting it at roughly a quarter to a half, and that it adds a lot to the day-to-day difficulty ADHD brings.
doi.org/10.1176/appi.ajp.2013.13070966

**Siegel, D. J. (1999).** *The developing mind: Toward a neurobiology of interpersonal experience.* Guilford Press. A book linking attachment, memory and brain development; it introduced the "window of tolerance", the range of arousal in which a person can feel strong emotion and still think and respond flexibly.
catalog.library.nashville.org/Record/CARL0000114962

**Sonnentag, S., & Fritz, C. (2007).** *The Recovery Experience Questionnaire: Development and validation of a measure for assessing recuperation and unwinding from work.* Journal of Occupational Health Psychology, 12(3), 204–221. Identified four separate recovery experiences outside work: psychological detachment, relaxation, mastery and control.
doi.org/10.1037/1076-8998.12.3.204

**Taylor, S. E., Klein, L. C., Lewis, B. P., Gruenewald, T. L., Gurung, R. A. R., & Updegraff, J. A. (2000).** *Biobehavioral responses to stress in females: Tend-and-befriend, not fight-or-flight.* Psychological Review, 107(3), 411–429. Proposed that under stress people, perhaps especially women, often respond by protecting others and seeking social connection ("tend and befriend"), not only fight or flight.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-295X.107.3.411

**Tronick, E., Als, H., Adamson, L., Wise, S., & Brazelton, T. B. (1978).** *The infant's response to entrapment between contradictory messages in face-to-face interaction.* Journal of the American Academy of Child Psychiatry, 17(1), 1–13. The first "still face" study: when a mother kept a blank, unresponsive face, infants tried hard to re-engage her, then grew upset and withdrew; they recovered when she responded again.
doi.org/10.1016/S0002-7138(09)62273-1

**Yerkes, R. M., & Dodson, J. D. (1908).** *The relation of strength of stimulus to rapidity of habit-formation.* Journal of Comparative Neurology and Psychology, 18(5), 459–482. Studied how the strength of an electric shock affected how quickly dancing mice learned to avoid a black passage; later writers turned it into a general "inverted U" for arousal and performance.
doi.org/10.1002/cne.920180503

**Yoo, S.-S., Gujar, N., Hu, P., Jolesz, F. A., & Walker, M. P. (2007).** *The human emotional brain without sleep—a prefrontal amygdala disconnect.* Current Biology, 17(20), R877–R878. After a night without sleep, the amygdala reacted more strongly to negative pictures and was less connected to the prefrontal cortex.
doi.org/10.1016/j.cub.2007.08.007

**Zaccaro, A., Piarulli, A., Laurino, M., Garbella, E., Menicucci, D., Neri, B., & Gemignani, A. (2018).** *How breath-control can change your life: A systematic review on psycho-physiological correlates of slow breathing.* Frontiers in Human Neuroscience, 12, 353. Slow breathing was linked with changes in heart-rate variability and with more comfort, relaxation and alertness and less arousal and anxiety.
doi.org/10.3389/fnhum.2018.00353

PART THREE · CHAPTER 3

## How we see each other

**Baumeister, R. F., Bratslavsky, E., Finkenauer, C., & Vohs, K. D. (2001).** *Bad is stronger than good.* Review of General Psychology, 5(4), 323–370. A wide review concluding that bad events, feedback, emotions and relationship behaviors usually have a bigger and longer-lasting effect than equally good ones.
doi.org/10.1037/1089-2680.5.4.323

**Crompton, C. J., Ropar, D., Evans-Williams, C. V. M., Flynn, E. G., & Fletcher-Watson, S. (2020).** *Autistic peer-to-peer information transfer is highly effective.* Autism, 24(7), 1704–1712. In "diffusion chains" where a story was passed along eight people (72 adults), all-autistic chains passed on as much detail as all-non-autistic chains, while mixed chains lost detail faster and reported lower rapport.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361320919286

**Epley, N. (2014).** *Mindwise: How We Understand What Others Think, Believe, Feel, and Want.* Alfred A. Knopf (New York). A book reviewing research on how people infer others' thoughts and feelings, and why this 'sixth sense' is more error-prone than we believe.
wellcomecollection.org/works/zh83qear

**Eyal, T., Steffel, M., & Epley, N. (2018).** *Perspective mistaking: Accurately understanding the mind of another requires getting perspective, not taking perspective.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 114(4), 547–571. As the title states, a series of experiments found that imagining another person's perspective did not make people more accurate about what that person thought or felt, whereas getting their perspective directly (by asking) did.
doi.org/10.1037/pspa0000115

**Hastorf, A. H., & Cantril, H. (1954).** *They saw a game: A case study.* Journal of Abnormal and Social Psychology, 49(1), 129–134. Students from Princeton and Dartmouth watched the same rough football game and saw it very differently, for example in how many infractions each team committed.
doi.org/10.1037/h0057880

**Jones, E. E., & Harris, V. A. (1967).** *The attribution of attitudes.* Journal of Experimental Social Psychology, 3(1), 1–24. In three experiments, people judged a speaker's true attitude from a speech; they tended to attribute the stated position to the speaker even when told the speaker had been assigned it.
doi.org/10.1016/0022-1031(67)90034-0

**Jones, E. E., & Nisbett, R. E. (1971).** *The actor and the observer: Divergent perceptions of the causes of behavior.* General Learning Press (short monograph). Proposed the actor-observer hypothesis: people tend to explain their own actions by the situation and others' actions by their dispositions.
krimdok.uni-tuebingen.de/Record/1098932900

**Malle, B. F. (2006).** *The actor-observer asymmetry in attribution: A (surprising) meta-analysis.* Psychological Bulletin, 132(6), 895–919. A meta-analysis of 173 studies found average actor-observer effects near zero; the asymmetry appeared only in some conditions (for example when actor and observer were intimates, or for negative events), with a reverse pattern for positive events.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.132.6.895

**Milton, D. E. M. (2012).** *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

**Murray, D., Lesser, M., & Lawson, W. (2005).** *Attention, monotropism and the diagnostic criteria for autism.* Autism, 9(2), 139–156. Proposed "monotropism": autistic attention tends to be pulled strongly into a few interests at a time, and the authors argued this can explain the other diagnostic features of autism.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361305051398

**Pronin, E., Lin, D. Y., & Ross, L. (2002).** *The bias blind spot: Perceptions of bias in self versus others.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 28(3), 369–381. People, from students to airport travelers, readily saw common biases in others but rated themselves as less biased than their peers (the bias blind spot).
doi.org/10.1177/0146167202286008

**Ross, L. (1977).** *The intuitive psychologist and his shortcomings: Distortions in the attribution process.* Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 10, 173–220. Reviewed the biases of the lay 'intuitive psychologist' and named the fundamental attribution error: underestimating situational causes and overestimating personal dispositions when explaining others' behavior.
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(08)60357-3

**Ross, L., & Ward, A. (1996).** *Naive realism in everyday life: Implications for social conflict and misunderstanding.* In E. S. Reed, E. Turiel, & T. Brown (Eds.), Values and Knowledge (pp. 103–135). Lawrence Erlbaum / Psychology Press. Described naive realism: people assume they see the world objectively, so those who disagree must be uninformed, irrational or biased — a dynamic that fuels conflict and misunderstanding.
doi.org/10.4324/9780203773772-6

**Sasson, N. J., Faso, D. J., Nugent, J., Lovell, S., Kennedy, D. P., & Grossman, R. B. (2017).** *Neurotypical peers are less willing to interact with those with autism based on thin slice judgments.* Scientific Reports, 7, 40700. Across three studies, non-autistic observers formed less favorable first impressions of autistic children and adults from a few seconds of video, and were less willing to interact with them; the bias disappeared when they judged only transcripts of what was said.
doi.org/10.1038/srep40700

**Tversky, A., & Kahneman, D. (1973).** *Availability: A heuristic for judging frequency and probability.* Cognitive Psychology, 5(2), 207–232. People judge how common something is by how easily examples come to mind. That usually works, but vivid or recent examples make some things seem more common than they are.
apps.dtic.mil/sti/pdfs/ADA045770.pdf

## How communication works

**Carrère, S., & Gottman, J. M. (1999).** *Predicting divorce among newlyweds from the first three minutes of a marital conflict discussion.* Family Process, 38(3), 293–301. In 124 newlywed couples, how the first three minutes of a conflict discussion went (more negative and less positive emotion) predicted which couples divorced over the next six years.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1545-5300.1999.00293.x

**Crompton, C. J., Ropar, D., Evans-Williams, C. V. M., Flynn, E. G., & Fletcher-Watson, S. (2020).** *Autistic peer-to-peer information transfer is highly effective.* Autism, 24(7), 1704–1712. In "diffusion chains" where a story was passed along eight people (72 adults), all-autistic chains passed on as much detail as all-non-autistic chains, while mixed chains lost detail faster and reported lower rapport.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361320919286

**Daft, R. L., & Lengel, R. H. (1986).** *Organizational information requirements, media richness and structural design.* Management Science, 32(5), 554–571. Proposed media richness theory: richer channels (face to face, then phone, then written) are better suited to ambiguous, equivocal messages.
doi.org/10.1287/mnsc.32.5.554

**Epley, N., & Schroeder, J. (2014).** *Mistakenly seeking solitude.* Journal of Experimental Psychology: General, 143(5), 1980–1999. Commuters asked to talk with a stranger on their train or bus reported a more positive journey than those told to sit in solitude, even though people predicted the opposite; misjudging how pleasant such talk would be keeps people apart.
doi.org/10.1037/a0037323

**Gilovich, T., Savitsky, K., & Medvec, V. H. (1998).** *The illusion of transparency: Biased assessments of others' ability to read one's emotional states.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 75(2), 332–346. In several sets of studies, people overestimated how well others could read their internal states (for example, liars overestimated how detectable their lies were, and people thought their disgust showed more than it did).
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.75.2.332

**Gordon, T. (1970).** *P.E.T.: Parent Effectiveness Training.* New York: P. H. Wyden (book; revised 2000). A parenting book and course that popularized "I-messages": describing your own feelings and the effect of a behavior rather than blaming the other person.
search.worldcat.org/title/670595

**Gottman, J. M. (1994).** *What predicts divorce? The relationship between marital processes and marital outcomes.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ); reissued by Routledge. Gottman's report of his long-term studies of couples, including "flooding": feeling so physically overwhelmed in a conflict that listening and thinking become very hard.
routledge.com

**Gottman, J. M., Coan, J., Carrère, S., & Swanson, C. (1998).** *Predicting marital happiness and stability from newlywed interactions.* Journal of Marriage and the Family, 60(1), 5–22. In a six-year study of newlyweds, husbands who accepted influence from their wives were more likely to have stable, happy marriages, while active-listening style paraphrasing during conflict was rare and did not predict outcomes.
jstor.org/stable/353438

**Gunraj, D. N., Drumm-Hewitt, A. M., Dashow, E. M., Upadhyay, S. S. N., & Klin, C. M. (2016).** *Texting insincerely: The role of the period in text messaging.* Computers in Human Behavior, 55, 1067–1075. Short text-message replies ending in a period were rated as less sincere than the same replies without one; the effect did not appear for handwritten notes.
doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2015.11.003

**Kruger, J., Epley, N., Parker, J., & Ng, Z.-W. (2005).** *Egocentrism over e-mail: Can we communicate as well as we think?* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 89(6), 925–936. Across five experiments, people overestimated how well email recipients would detect their tone (such as sarcasm or seriousness), partly because they found it hard to step outside their own perspective.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.89.6.925

**Malinowski, B. (1923).** *The problem of meaning in primitive languages.* Supplement I (pp. 451–510 in later printings) in C. K. Ogden & I. A. Richards, The Meaning of Meaning. London: Kegan Paul; New York: Harcourt, Brace. Named "phatic communion": small talk whose job is not to pass on information but to create and keep up a bond ("ties of union are created by mere exchange of words").
archive.org/details/meaningofmeaning00ogde

**Milton, D. E. M. (2012).** *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

**Rosenberg, M. B. (1999).** *Nonviolent Communication: A Language of Compassion (later editions: A Language of Life).* PuddleDancer Press (Encinitas, CA); 2nd ed. 2003, 3rd ed. 2015. Describes Nonviolent Communication: expressing observations, feelings, needs and requests, and listening for the same in others.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/562413

**Sandstrom, G. M., & Dunn, E. W. (2014).** *Is efficiency overrated? Minimal social interactions lead to belonging and positive affect.* Social Psychological and Personality Science, 5(4), 437–442. People who had a brief, friendly social exchange with a coffee-shop barista reported more belonging and positive mood than those who kept the exchange purely efficient.
doi.org/10.1177/1948550613502990

**Savitsky, K., Keysar, B., Epley, N., Carter, T., & Swanson, A. (2011).** *The closeness-communication bias: Increased egocentrism among friends versus strangers.* Journal of Experimental Social Psychology, 47(1), 269–273. In three experiments, people overestimated how well they communicated with friends and spouses, more than with strangers, and made more egocentric errors following a friend's directions; closeness seemed to relax the checking people do with strangers.
sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0022103110002118

**Schegloff, E. A., Jefferson, G., & Sacks, H. (1977).** *The preference for self-correction in the organization of repair in conversation.* Language, 53(2), 361–382. Analyses of everyday conversation showed that 'repair' of trouble in speaking, hearing and understanding is a built-in, organized part of talk, and that people strongly prefer to correct themselves rather than be corrected.
doi.org/10.1353/lan.1977.0041

**Tronick, E., Als, H., Adamson, L., Wise, S., & Brazelton, T. B. (1978).** *The infant's response to entrapment between contradictory messages in face-to-face interaction.* Journal of the American Academy of Child Psychiatry, 17(1), 1–13. The first "still face" study: when a mother kept a blank, unresponsive face, infants tried hard to re-engage her, then grew upset and withdrew; they recovered when she responded again.
doi.org/10.1016/S0002-7138(09)62273-1

**Watzlawick, P., Beavin [Bavelas], J. H., & Jackson, D. D. (1967).** *Pragmatics of Human Communication: A Study of Interactional Patterns, Pathologies, and Paradoxes.* New York: W. W. Norton (book). Set out a few "axioms" of communication, including that every message has a content level (what is said) and a relationship level (what it says about us), and that the relationship level often decides how the content is heard.
ci.nii.ac.jp/ncid/BA01493188

**Weger, H., Jr., Castle Bell, G., Minei, E. M., & Robinson, M. C. (2014).** *The relative effectiveness of active listening in initial interactions.* International Journal of Listening, 28(1), 13–31. People who talked with a listener using active-listening responses felt more understood than those who received advice or simple acknowledgements; differences in satisfaction and liking were small.
doi.org/10.1080/10904018.2013.813234

## Attachment, trust and belonging

**Ainsworth, M. D. S., Blehar, M. C., Waters, E., & Wall, S. (1978).** *Patterns of Attachment: A Psychological Study of the Strange Situation.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ). Reported the Strange Situation studies of infants and mothers and described secure and insecure attachment patterns.
search.worldcat.org/title/4194069

**Baumeister, R. F., & Leary, M. R. (1995).** *The need to belong: Desire for interpersonal attachments as a fundamental human motivation.* Psychological Bulletin, 117(3), 497–529. A major review arguing that the need to belong is a fundamental human motivation: people need frequent, pleasant contact within a few stable, caring relationships, and unmet belonging has wide emotional and cognitive costs.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.117.3.497

**Bowlby, J. (1969).** *Attachment and Loss, Vol. 1: Attachment.* Hogarth Press and the Institute of Psycho-Analysis (London) / Basic Books (New York). The first volume of Bowlby's trilogy, setting out attachment theory: children's bond with caregivers is an evolved system for seeking safety and comfort.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/194760

**Brennan, K. A., Clark, C. L., & Shaver, P. R. (1998).** *Self-report measurement of adult attachment: An integrative overview.* In J. A. Simpson & W. S. Rholes (Eds.), Attachment Theory and Close Relationships (pp. 46–76). Guilford. A large factor-analytic study of all known self-report adult attachment measures found that they reduce to two broad dimensions: attachment anxiety and avoidance.
labs.psychology.illinois.edu/~rcfraley/measures/brennan.html

**Cacioppo, J. T., & Patrick, W. (2008).** *Loneliness: Human Nature and the Need for Social Connection.* W. W. Norton (New York). A book arguing that loneliness is a biological signal, like hunger, that we need connection, and that chronic loneliness can trap people in isolation and harm health.
wellcomecollection.org/works/wp45vzsp

**Coan, J. A., & Sbarra, D. A. (2015).** *Social baseline theory: The social regulation of risk and effort.* Current Opinion in Psychology, 1, 87–91. Proposes that the brain expects to have supportive people around, which lowers perceived risk and effort; without them, coping takes more effort.
doi.org/10.1016/j.copsyc.2014.12.021

**Coan, J. A., Schaefer, H. S., & Davidson, R. J. (2006).** *Lending a hand: Social regulation of the neural response to threat.* Psychological Science, 17(12), 1032–1039. In an fMRI study, married women facing the threat of a mild shock showed less threat-related brain activity while holding their husband's hand than when alone.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2006.01832.x

**Crompton, C. J., Ropar, D., Evans-Williams, C. V. M., Flynn, E. G., & Fletcher-Watson, S. (2020).** *Autistic peer-to-peer information transfer is highly effective.* Autism, 24(7), 1704–1712. In "diffusion chains" where a story was passed along eight people (72 adults), all-autistic chains passed on as much detail as all-non-autistic chains, while mixed chains lost detail faster and reported lower rapport.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361320919286

**Edmondson, A. (1999).** *Psychological safety and learning behavior in work teams.* Administrative Science Quarterly, 44(2), 350–383. In 51 teams at a manufacturing company, a shared belief that it was safe to take interpersonal risks (psychological safety) was linked with more team learning behavior, which in turn was linked with performance.
doi.org/10.2307/2666999

**Eisenberger, N. I., Lieberman, M. D., & Williams, K. D. (2003).** *Does rejection hurt? An fMRI study of social exclusion.* Science, 302(5643), 290–292. Being left out of a virtual ball-tossing game increased activity in the anterior cingulate cortex, a region also involved in physical pain distress, in proportion to how upset people felt.
doi.org/10.1126/science.1089134

**Epley, N., & Schroeder, J. (2014).** *Mistakenly seeking solitude.* Journal of Experimental Psychology: General, 143(5), 1980–1999. Commuters asked to talk with a stranger on their train or bus reported a more positive journey than those told to sit in solitude, even though people predicted the opposite; misjudging how pleasant such talk would be keeps people apart.
doi.org/10.1037/a0037323

**Fraley, R. C., Hudson, N. W., Heffernan, M. E., & Segal, N. (2015).** *Are adult attachment styles categorical or dimensional? A taxometric analysis of general and relationship-specific attachment orientations.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 109(2), 354–368. Taxometric analyses suggested that adult attachment differences are dimensional (degrees of anxiety and avoidance) rather than distinct types.
doi.org/10.1037/pspp0000027

**Hall, J. A. (2019).** *How many hours does it take to make a friend?* Journal of Social and Personal Relationships, 36(4), 1278–1296 (online first 2018). Studies of adults who had recently moved and of students found that more hours spent together, especially in leisure, went with moving from acquaintance to closer friendship.
doi.org/10.1177/0265407518761225

**Hazan, C., & Shaver, P. (1987).** *Romantic love conceptualized as an attachment process.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 52(3), 511–524. Two questionnaire studies proposed that adult romantic love is an attachment process: the share of adults in each of three attachment styles roughly matched infant figures, and the styles differed in how people experienced love, their views of self and others, and recalled relationships with parents.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.52.3.511

**Holt-Lunstad, J., Smith, T. B., & Layton, J. B. (2010).** *Social relationships and mortality risk: A meta-analytic review.* PLoS Medicine, 7(7), e1000316. A meta-analysis of 148 studies (308,849 participants) found people with stronger social relationships had about 50% greater odds of survival over the study periods, consistently across age, sex and health status.
doi.org/10.1371/journal.pmed.1000316

**Hull, L., Petrides, K. V., Allison, C., Smith, P., Baron-Cohen, S., Lai, M.-C., & Mandy, W. (2017).** *"Putting on my best normal": Social camouflaging in adults with autism spectrum conditions.* Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders, 47(8), 2519–2534. Interviews with 92 autistic adults described camouflaging as motivated by wanting to fit in and connect, done through masking and compensating techniques, and often followed by exhaustion and threats to self-perception.
doi.org/10.1007/s10803-017-3166-5

**Lewicki, R. J., Polin, B., & Lount, R. B., Jr. (2016).** *An exploration of the structure of effective apologies.* Negotiation and Conflict Management Research, 9(2), 177–196. Testing six apology components with 755 participants, acknowledging responsibility was rated most important, then an offer of repair; a request for forgiveness mattered least. Apologies with more components were rated better.
doi.org/10.1111/ncmr.12073

**Main, M., & Solomon, J. (1990).** *Procedures for identifying infants as disorganized/disoriented during the Ainsworth Strange Situation.* In M. T. Greenberg, D. Cicchetti & E. M. Cummings (Eds.), Attachment in the Preschool Years (pp. 121–160). University of Chicago Press. Added a fourth attachment pattern, disorganized/disoriented, for infants who seemed frightened or confused by the caregiver in the Strange Situation, with indices for coding it.
chicagoreference.com/ucp/books/book/chicago/A/bo3774473.html

**Rempel, J. K., Holmes, J. G., & Zanna, M. P. (1985).** *Trust in close relationships.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 49(1), 95–112. Described trust in close relationships as having three components, predictability, dependability and faith, and developed a self-report Trust Scale to measure them.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.49.1.95

**Rutgers, A. H., Bakermans-Kranenburg, M. J., van IJzendoorn, M. H., & van Berckelaer-Onnes, I. A. (2004).** *Autism and attachment: A meta-analytic review.* Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry, 45(6), 1123–1134. Across 16 studies, about half of autistic children in Strange Situation studies were securely attached; autistic children were less often secure on average, but the difference disappeared in samples of children with higher mental development.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1469-7610.2004.t01-1-00305.x

**Sandstrom, G. M., & Dunn, E. W. (2014).** *Is efficiency overrated? Minimal social interactions lead to belonging and positive affect.* Social Psychological and Personality Science, 5(4), 437–442. People who had a brief, friendly social exchange with a coffee-shop barista reported more belonging and positive mood than those who kept the exchange purely efficient.
doi.org/10.1177/1948550613502990

**Tajfel, H., & Turner, J. C. (1979).** *An integrative theory of intergroup conflict.* In W. G. Austin & S. Worchel (Eds.), The Social Psychology of Intergroup Relations (pp. 33–47). Brooks/Cole. Sets out social identity theory: part of our self-image comes from the groups we belong to, and we are motivated to see our groups positively, often by favoring them over others, even when groups are formed on trivial grounds.
alnap.org

**Williams, K. D., Cheung, C. K. T., & Choi, W. (2000).** *Cyberostracism: Effects of being ignored over the Internet.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 79(5), 748–762. In an online ball-tossing game (1,486 people from 62 countries in the first study), being left out by computer-controlled "players" made people feel worse and lowered their sense of belonging.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.79.5.748

PART THREE · CHAPTER 6

## Habits and change

**Baumeister, R. F., Bratslavsky, E., Muraven, M., & Tice, D. M. (1998).** *Ego depletion: Is the active self a limited resource?* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 74(5), 1252–1265. In four experiments, an earlier act of self-control (such as resisting chocolate and eating radishes) was followed by giving up sooner on a later task, which the authors took as evidence that self-control draws on a limited resource.
researchconnect.suny.edu

**Bem, D. J. (1972).** *Self-perception theory.* Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 6, 1–62. Proposed that people come to know their own attitudes and feelings partly by observing their own behavior, much as an outside observer would.
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(08)60024-6

**Bolger, N., Zuckerman, A., & Kessler, R. C. (2000).** *Invisible support and adjustment to stress.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 79(6), 953–961. In couples where one partner faced a stressful exam, support the recipient did not notice (reported by the giver but not the receiver) was linked with better adjustment, while noticed (visible) support was not.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.79.6.953

**Breines, J. G., & Chen, S. (2012).** *Self-compassion increases self-improvement motivation.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 38(9), 1133–1143. In four experiments, people encouraged to be self-compassionate about a failure or moral mistake were more motivated to improve (for example, studying longer for a retest) than people encouraged to boost their self-esteem.
doi.org/10.1177/0146167212445599

**Bryan, C. J., Walton, G. M., Rogers, T., & Dweck, C. S. (2011).** *Motivating voter turnout by invoking the self.* PNAS, 108(31), 12653–12656. Asking people about "being a voter" rather than "voting" increased interest in registering and, in two US statewide elections, increased turnout measured in official records.
doi.org/10.1073/pnas.1103343108

**Christensen, A., & Heavey, C. L. (1990).** *Gender and social structure in the demand/withdraw pattern of marital conflict.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 59(1), 73–81. Wife-demand/husband-withdraw was more common overall, but who demanded depended partly on whose issue was being discussed; the authors linked the pattern to social structure (who wants change) as well as gender.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.59.1.73

**Christensen, A., Atkins, D. C., Berns, S., Wheeler, J., Baucom, D. H., & Simpson, L. E. (2004).** *Traditional versus integrative behavioral couple therapy for significantly and chronically distressed married couples.* Journal of Consulting and Clinical Psychology, 72(2), 176–191. In a randomized trial with 134 seriously distressed couples, both integrative (acceptance-based) and traditional behavioral couple therapy produced similar rates of clinically significant improvement, with different patterns of change during treatment.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-006X.72.2.176

**Drigotas, S. M., Rusbult, C. E., Wieselquist, J., & Whitton, S. W. (1999).** *Close partner as sculptor of the ideal self: Behavioral affirmation and the Michelangelo phenomenon.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 77(2), 293–323. Across four studies, people whose partners saw and treated them in line with their ideal self moved closer to that ideal over time, and this affirmation was linked with better couple functioning and more stable relationships.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.77.2.293

**Gollwitzer, P. M. (1999).** *Implementation intentions: Strong effects of simple plans.* American Psychologist, 54(7), 493–503. Reviewed research showing that if-then plans ("when situation X arises, I will do Y") hand control of action to the planned cue and help people act on their goals.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.54.7.493

**Gollwitzer, P. M., & Sheeran, P. (2006).** *Implementation intentions and goal achievement: A meta-analysis of effects and processes.* Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 38, 69–119. A meta-analysis of 94 independent tests found that forming if-then plans had a medium-to-large effect on reaching goals (d = .65).
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(06)38002-1

**Hagger, M. S., Chatzisarantis, N. L. D., Alberts, H., et al. (2016).** *A multilab preregistered replication of the ego-depletion effect.* Perspectives on Psychological Science, 11(4), 546–573. A preregistered replication across 23 labs (2,141 participants) found an ego-depletion effect close to zero (d = 0.04, confidence interval including zero).
doi.org/10.1177/1745691616652873

**Hofmann, W., Baumeister, R. F., Förster, G., & Vohs, K. D. (2012).** *Everyday temptations: An experience sampling study of desire, conflict, and self-control.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 102(6), 1318–1335. Tracking people's desires through the day by smartphone, the researchers found that people high in trait self-control reported fewer temptations and conflicts, rather than resisting more often.
doi.org/10.1037/a0026545

**Kahneman, D., & Tversky, A. (1979).** *Prospect theory: An analysis of decision under risk.* Econometrica, 47(2), 263–291. People weigh choices as gains and losses from where they stand now, and a loss feels bigger than a gain of the same size ("loss aversion"), which helps explain why change can feel risky even when it would help.
jstor.org/stable/1914185

**Lally, P., van Jaarsveld, C. H. M., Potts, H. W. W., & Wardle, J. (2010).** *How are habits formed: Modelling habit formation in the real world.* European Journal of Social Psychology, 40(6), 998–1009. Following 96 volunteers who repeated a daily behavior in the same context for 12 weeks, automaticity rose along a curve that leveled off; reaching 95% of each person's plateau took between 18 and 254 days, and missing a single day did not meaningfully set progress back.
doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.674

**Marlatt, G. A., & Gordon, J. R. (Eds.) (1985).** *Relapse prevention: Maintenance strategies in the treatment of addictive behaviors.* Guilford Press. An edited volume setting out the cognitive-behavioral relapse prevention model, including the "abstinence violation effect": after one slip, guilt and a sense of total failure can make a full relapse more likely.
krimdok.uni-tuebingen.de/Record/27251005X

**Miller, W. R., & Rollnick, S. (1991).** *Motivational interviewing: Preparing people to change addictive behavior.* Guilford Press. The first full presentation of motivational interviewing: a way of talking about change that treats mixed feelings as normal and draws out the person's own reasons for change.
motivationalinterviewing.org

**Murray, D., Lesser, M., & Lawson, W. (2005).** *Attention, monotropism and the diagnostic criteria for autism.* Autism, 9(2), 139–156. Proposed "monotropism": autistic attention tends to be pulled strongly into a few interests at a time, and the authors argued this can explain the other diagnostic features of autism.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361305051398

**Neal, D. T., Wood, W., Wu, M., & Kurlander, D. (2011).** *The pull of the past: When do habits persist despite conflict with motives?* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 37(11), 1428–1437. In field experiments on habitual eating, people with a strong movie-popcorn habit ate stale popcorn about as much as fresh popcorn in a movie theater, but not in a different setting: context cues drove the habit more than taste or intentions.
doi.org/10.1177/0146167211419863

**Prochaska, J. O., & DiClemente, C. C. (1983).** *Stages and processes of self-change of smoking: Toward an integrative model of change.* Journal of Consulting and Clinical Psychology, 51(3), 390–395. Applied an integrative "stages of change" model to 872 people quitting smoking on their own, describing movement through stages such as contemplation, action and maintenance.
digitalcommons.uri.edu/psy_facpubs/572

**Raymaker, D. M., Teo, A. R., Steckler, N. A., et al. (2020).** *"Having all of your internal resources exhausted beyond measure and being left with no clean-up crew": Defining autistic burnout.* Autism in Adulthood, 2(2), 132–143. From 19 interviews and 19 public online accounts, analyzed with autistic co-researchers, autistic burnout was defined as long-term exhaustion, loss of function and reduced tolerance to stimulus, arising from chronic life stress and a mismatch between expectations and abilities without enough support.
doi.org/10.1089/aut.2019.0079

**Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2000).** *Self-determination theory and the facilitation of intrinsic motivation, social development, and well-being.* American Psychologist, 55(1), 68–78. Summarized self-determination theory: people are most motivated and well when three basic needs are met: autonomy, competence and relatedness.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.55.1.68

**Samuelson, W., & Zeckhauser, R. (1988).** *Status quo bias in decision making.* Journal of Risk and Uncertainty, 1, 7–59. In decision experiments and in real choices of health plans and retirement programs, people disproportionately stuck with the current option (status quo bias).
jstor.org/stable/41760530

**Thaler, R. H., & Sunstein, C. R. (2008).** *Nudge: Improving decisions about health, wealth, and happiness.* Yale University Press. Argues that small changes in how choices are presented (defaults, order, ease) can steer people toward better decisions without removing their freedom to choose.
identity.wellcomecollection.org/works/usu4u2um

**Wood, W., Quinn, J. M., & Kashy, D. A. (2002).** *Habits in everyday life: Thought, emotion, and action.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 83(6), 1281–1297. In two diary studies with hourly reports, a large share of everyday behavior was habitual (repeated in the same place, often while thinking about something else), and habits came with less stress than non-habitual actions.
dornsife.usc.edu

## Self-worth, shame and self-compassion

**Baumeister, R. F., Campbell, J. D., Krueger, J. I., & Vohs, K. D. (2003).** *Does high self-esteem cause better performance, interpersonal success, happiness, or healthier lifestyles?* Psychological Science in the Public Interest, 4(1), 1–44. A major review concluded that high self-esteem does not reliably cause better performance or relationships; for example, good school performance partly produces high self-esteem rather than the reverse.
doi.org/10.1111/1529-1006.01431

**Breines, J. G., & Chen, S. (2012).** *Self-compassion increases self-improvement motivation.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 38(9), 1133–1143. In four experiments, people encouraged to be self-compassionate about a failure or moral mistake were more motivated to improve (for example, studying longer for a retest) than people encouraged to boost their self-esteem.
doi.org/10.1177/0146167212445599

**Curran, T., & Hill, A. P. (2019).** *Perfectionism is increasing over time: A meta-analysis of birth cohort differences from 1989 to 2016.* Psychological Bulletin, 145(4), 410–429. A meta-analysis of college students' perfectionism scores found perfectionism rose between 1989 and 2016, with the largest rise in the sense that others expect perfection.
doi.org/10.1037/bul0000138

**Festinger, L. (1954).** *A theory of social comparison processes.* Human Relations, 7(2), 117–140. Proposed that people judge their own opinions and abilities by comparing themselves with others, especially when there is no objective standard.
doi.org/10.1177/001872675400700202

**Hewitt, P. L., & Flett, G. L. (1991).** *Perfectionism in the self and social contexts: Conceptualization, assessment, and association with psychopathology.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 60(3), 456–470. Introduced a multidimensional model of perfectionism, distinguishing self-oriented, other-oriented and socially prescribed perfectionism, and linked these to psychological difficulties.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.60.3.456

**Lewis, H. B. (1971).** *Shame and guilt in neurosis.* International Universities Press, New York. Drawing on therapy sessions, Lewis distinguished shame, which centers on the whole self, from guilt, which centers on a specific act.
find.library.upenn.edu/catalog/99549673503681

**Mueller, C. M., & Dweck, C. S. (1998).** *Praise for intelligence can undermine children's motivation and performance.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 75(1), 33–52. In six studies, children praised for intelligence cared more about looking good than learning, and after failure persisted less and performed worse than children praised for effort.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.75.1.33

**Neff, K. D. (2003).** *Self-compassion: An alternative conceptualization of a healthy attitude toward oneself.* Self and Identity, 2(2), 85–101. Defined self-compassion as three parts: self-kindness instead of harsh judgment, common humanity instead of isolation, and mindfulness instead of over-identifying with painful feelings.
doi.org/10.1080/15298860309032

**Nolen-Hoeksema, S. (1991).** *Responses to depression and their effects on the duration of depressive episodes.* Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 100(4), 569–582. Proposed the response styles theory: people who ruminate on their low mood tend to have longer depressions than people who distract themselves.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-843X.100.4.569

**Tangney, J. P., & Dearing, R. L. (2002).** *Shame and guilt.* Guilford Press. Summarizes years of research distinguishing shame (about the self) from guilt (about the act): guilt-proneness goes with empathy and repair, shame-proneness with hiding, blame and anger.
guilford.com/books/Shame-and-Guilt/Tangney-Dearing/9781572309876

## Loss, grief and big life changes

**Bonanno, G. A. (2004).** *Loss, trauma, and human resilience: Have we underestimated the human capacity to thrive after extremely aversive events?* American Psychologist, 59(1), 20–28. Argued that resilience after loss or trauma is distinct from recovery, is more common than many theorists assumed, and can come about in several ways.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.59.1.20

**Bonanno, G. A. (2009).** *The other side of sadness: What the new science of bereavement tells us about life after loss.* Basic Books. A book summarizing bereavement research: most people are resilient after a loss, grief tends to come and go rather than follow fixed stages, and only a minority develop long-lasting, severe grief.
hachettebookgroup.com

**Boss, P. (1999).** *Ambiguous loss: Learning to live with unresolved grief.* Harvard University Press. Named "ambiguous loss": losses without clear closure, such as someone physically absent but psychologically present, or present but psychologically changed (as in dementia), and suggested ways to cope.
bookshare.org/browse/book/2050897

**Bowlby, J. (1969).** *Attachment and Loss, Vol. 1: Attachment.* Hogarth Press and the Institute of Psycho-Analysis (London) / Basic Books (New York). The first volume of Bowlby's trilogy, setting out attachment theory: children's bond with caregivers is an evolved system for seeking safety and comfort.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/194760

**Bridges, W. (1980).** *Transitions: Making sense of life's changes.* Addison-Wesley. Distinguished outer change from inner transition and described three phases: endings, a "neutral zone", and new beginnings.
narrativestudies.lib.unb.ca/bibcite/reference/16554

**Doka, K. J. (Ed.) (1989).** *Disenfranchised grief: Recognizing hidden sorrow.* Lexington Books. Coined "disenfranchised grief": grief that is not openly acknowledged, publicly mourned or socially supported.
openlibrary.org/books/OL354418M

**Holmes, T. H., & Rahe, R. H. (1967).** *The Social Readjustment Rating Scale.* Journal of Psychosomatic Research, 11(2), 213–218. Created the Social Readjustment Rating Scale, a list of 43 life events (such as divorce, job loss, moving and bereavement) rated by how much readjustment they demand.
doi.org/10.1016/0022-3999(67)90010-4

**Klass, D., Silverman, P. R., & Nickman, S. L. (Eds.) (1996).** *Continuing bonds: New understandings of grief.* Taylor & Francis. Challenged the idea that healthy mourning means cutting ties with the dead, showing across many groups that ongoing inner bonds with the deceased are common and often healthy.
routledge.com

**Kübler-Ross, E. (1969).** *On death and dying.* Macmillan. Described five stages (denial, anger, bargaining, depression, acceptance) from work with dying patients.
search.worldcat.org/title/4238

**Martin, T. L., & Doka, K. J. (2000).** *Men don't cry... women do: Transcending gender stereotypes of grief.* Brunner/Mazel. Described intuitive (feeling-focused) and instrumental (thinking- and doing-focused) grieving patterns, plus blended ones, arguing that they are related to gender but not determined by it.
opac.tangaza.ac.ke/bib/168348

**O'Connor, M.-F. (2022).** *The grieving brain: The surprising science of how we learn from love and loss.* HarperOne. A neuroscientist's account of grief as partly a learning problem: the brain must slowly update a map of the world in which the lost person is always there.
newbooksnetwork.com/the-grieving-brain

**Pennebaker, J. W., & Beall, S. K. (1986).** *Confronting a traumatic event: Toward an understanding of inhibition and disease.* Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 95(3), 274–281. An early expressive-writing experiment in which students wrote about traumatic experiences over several days; it launched decades of research on whether writing about difficult experiences helps health and well-being.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-843X.95.3.274

**Stroebe, M., & Schut, H. (1999).** *The dual process model of coping with bereavement: Rationale and description.* Death Studies, 23(3), 197–224. Proposed the dual process model: healthy grieving moves back and forth (oscillates) between loss-oriented and restoration-oriented coping, including taking breaks from grief.
research-portal.uu.nl

PART THREE · CHAPTER 9

## Minds that work differently

**American Speech-Language-Hearing Association (ASHA) (2018).** *Facilitated communication [Position statement].* ASHA policy PS2018-00352. States that facilitated communication, where a helper supports the person's hand or arm while they type or point, is discredited: research has found the messages come from the facilitator, and it should not be used.
asha.org/policy/ps2018-00352

**Aron, E. N., & Aron, A. (1997).** *Sensory-processing sensitivity and its relation to introversion and emotionality.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 73(2), 345–368. Across seven studies, the authors identified a single core trait of sensory-processing sensitivity, partly independent of introversion and emotionality, and developed the 27-item Highly Sensitive Person Scale.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.73.2.345

**Au-Yeung, S. K., Freeth, M., & Thompson, A. R. (2025).** *'Am I gonna regret this?': The experiences of diagnostic disclosure in autistic adults.* Autism, 29(8), 2181–2192. In interviews with 12 adults diagnosed as autistic in adulthood, telling others helped some reach support, be more themselves and help others, but many had not been believed, which made them more cautious about telling.
doi.org/10.1177/13623613251337504

**Barkley, R. A. (1997).** *Behavioral inhibition, sustained attention, and executive functions: Constructing a unifying theory of ADHD.* Psychological Bulletin, 121(1), 65–94. A theoretical review proposing that ADHD centers on a difficulty with behavioral inhibition, which in turn affects executive functions such as working memory, self-regulation of emotion and motivation, and the sense of time.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.121.1.65

**Bird, G., & Cook, R. (2013).** *Mixed emotions: The contribution of alexithymia to the emotional symptoms of autism.* Translational Psychiatry, 3(7), e285. Argued that emotional difficulties seen in some autistic people are better explained by co-occurring alexithymia than by autism itself.
doi.org/10.1038/tp.2013.61

**Blackwell, A. G. (2017).** *The curb-cut effect.* Stanford Social Innovation Review, 15(1), Winter 2017. An essay arguing that laws and programs designed for disadvantaged groups, like curb cuts made for wheelchair users, often end up benefiting everyone.
ssir.org/issue/winter-2017

**Botha, M., & Frost, D. M. (2020).** *Extending the minority stress model to understand mental health problems experienced by the autistic population.* Society and Mental Health, 10(1), 20–34. In 111 autistic adults, everyday discrimination, internalized stigma and concealing being autistic predicted poorer mental health even after accounting for general stress, suggesting minority stress plays a part.
doi.org/10.1177/2156869318804297

**Cooper, K., Smith, L. G. E., & Russell, A. (2017).** *Social identity, self-esteem, and mental health in autism.* European Journal of Social Psychology, 47(7), 844–854. In 272 autistic and 267 non-autistic participants, autistic people who identified more strongly with other autistic people had higher self-esteem, which was in turn linked to lower anxiety and depression.
doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.2297

**Crompton, C. J., Ropar, D., Evans-Williams, C. V. M., Flynn, E. G., & Fletcher-Watson, S. (2020).** *Autistic peer-to-peer information transfer is highly effective.* Autism, 24(7), 1704–1712. In "diffusion chains" where a story was passed along eight people (72 adults), all-autistic chains passed on as much detail as all-non-autistic chains, while mixed chains lost detail faster and reported lower rapport.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361320919286

**Demetriou, E. A., Lampit, A., Quintana, D. S., et al. (2018).** *Autism spectrum disorders: A meta-analysis of executive function.* Molecular Psychiatry, 23, 1198–1204. Pooling 235 studies with over 14,000 participants, found that autistic people on average scored lower than non-autistic people across executive function tasks, with wide variation and mixed findings across ages.
doi.org/10.1038/mp.2017.75

**Donnellan, A. M. (1984).** *The criterion of the least dangerous assumption.* Behavioral Disorders, 9(2), 141–150. Proposed that when we lack evidence about what someone can understand or do, we should act on the assumption that would do the least harm if wrong, which usually means presuming competence.
scholar.google.com

**Dunn, W. (1997).** *The impact of sensory processing abilities on the daily lives of young children and their families: A conceptual model.* Infants & Young Children, 9(4), 23–35. Proposed a model of sensory processing in which people differ in their neurological thresholds (high or low) and in how they respond (going along with them or acting against them), giving four patterns that affect daily life.
doi.org/10.1097/00001163-199704000-00005

**Grove, R., Hoekstra, R. A., Wierda, M., & Begeer, S. (2018).** *Special interests and subjective wellbeing in autistic adults.* Autism Research, 11(5), 766–775. In a survey of autistic adults in the Netherlands Autism Register, about two-thirds reported a special interest; greater motivation for the interest was linked to higher wellbeing, while very high intensity of engagement was linked to lower wellbeing.
research.vu.nl

**Hull, L., Petrides, K. V., Allison, C., Smith, P., Baron-Cohen, S., Lai, M.-C., & Mandy, W. (2017).** *"Putting on my best normal": Social camouflaging in adults with autism spectrum conditions.* Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders, 47(8), 2519–2534. Interviews with 92 autistic adults described camouflaging as motivated by wanting to fit in and connect, done through masking and compensating techniques, and often followed by exhaustion and threats to self-perception.
doi.org/10.1007/s10803-017-3166-5

**Kapp, S. K., Steward, R., Crane, L., Elliott, D., Elphick, C., Pellicano, E., & Russell, G. (2019).** *"People should be allowed to do what they like": Autistic adults' views and experiences of stimming.* Autism, 23(7), 1782–1792. Interviews with 32 autistic adults described stimming as a way to regulate overwhelming emotions and sensations, and as something that becomes accepted through understanding; participants objected to efforts to stop harmless stimming.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361319829628

**Kenny, L., Hattersley, C., Molins, B., Buckley, C., Povey, C., & Pellicano, E. (2016).** *Which terms should be used to describe autism? Perspectives from the UK autism community.* Autism, 20(4), 442–462. A survey of 3,470 people in the UK autism community found no single preferred term: "autism" and "on the autism spectrum" were widely endorsed, and "autistic" was favored by many autistic adults and families but much less by professionals.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361315588200

**Kildahl, A. N., Helverschou, S. B., Rysstad, A. L., Wigaard, E., Hellerud, J. M., Ludvigsen, L. B., & Howlin, P. (2021).** *Pathological demand avoidance in children and adolescents: A systematic review.* Autism, 25(8), 2162–2176. Reviewing 13 studies, found they nearly all relied on Newson's original descriptions and mostly on parent reports, seldom considered other explanations such as anxiety, and none asked people with the profile about their own experience.
doi.org/10.1177/13623613211034382

**Leedham, A., Thompson, A. R., Smith, R., & Freeth, M. (2020).** *'I was exhausted trying to figure it out': The experiences of females receiving an autism diagnosis in middle to late adulthood.* Autism, 24(1), 135–146. Interviews with eleven autistic women diagnosed at 40 or older explored how they made sense of a lifetime of feeling different and how the diagnosis changed their understanding of themselves.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361319853442

**Millar, D. C., Light, J. C., & Schlosser, R. W. (2006).** *The impact of augmentative and alternative communication intervention on the speech production of individuals with developmental disabilities: A research review.* Journal of Speech, Language, and Hearing Research, 49(2), 248–264. Across 23 studies (67 people aged 2 to 60), AAC did not hold back speech, and in many cases speech increased, though most studies lacked strong experimental control.
doi.org/10.1044/1092-4388(2006/021)

**Milton, D. E. M. (2012).** *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

**Miserandino, C. (2003).** *The spoon theory.* ButYouDontLookSick.com (essay). A personal essay in which Christine Miserandino, who has lupus, used a handful of spoons to show a friend that each daily task costs some of a limited supply of energy.
butyoudontlooksick.com/articles/written-by-christine/the-spoon-theory

**Murray, D., Lesser, M., & Lawson, W. (2005).** *Attention, monotropism and the diagnostic criteria for autism.* Autism, 9(2), 139–156. Proposed "monotropism": autistic attention tends to be pulled strongly into a few interests at a time, and the authors argued this can explain the other diagnostic features of autism.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361305051398

**Newson, E., Le Maréchal, K., & David, C. (2003).** *Pathological demand avoidance syndrome: A necessary distinction within the pervasive developmental disorders.* Archives of Disease in Childhood, 88(7), 595–600. Proposed recognizing "pathological demand avoidance" as a separate profile within the autism spectrum, based on 150 cases with an equal sex ratio, describing strong avoidance of everyday demands.
doi.org/10.1136/adc.88.7.595

**Phung, J., Penner, M., Pirlot, C., & Welch, C. (2021).** *What I wish you knew: Insights on burnout, inertia, meltdown, and shutdown from autistic youth.* Frontiers in Psychology, 12, 741421. Interviews with eight autistic children and young people explored burnout, inertia, meltdown and shutdown as separate experiences, what they feel like, and what others do that helps or makes them worse.
doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2021.741421

**Raymaker, D. M., Teo, A. R., Steckler, N. A., et al. (2020).** *"Having all of your internal resources exhausted beyond measure and being left with no clean-up crew": Defining autistic burnout.* Autism in Adulthood, 2(2), 132–143. From 19 interviews and 19 public online accounts, analyzed with autistic co-researchers, autistic burnout was defined as long-term exhaustion, loss of function and reduced tolerance to stimulus, arising from chronic life stress and a mismatch between expectations and abilities without enough support.
doi.org/10.1089/aut.2019.0079

**Sasson, N. J., & Morrison, K. E. (2019).** *First impressions of adults with autism improve with diagnostic disclosure and increased autism knowledge of peers.* Autism, 23(1), 50–59. 215 observers formed more favorable first impressions of autistic adults when told they were autistic, and observers who knew more about autism rated them more favorably.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361317729526

**Sasson, N. J., Faso, D. J., Nugent, J., Lovell, S., Kennedy, D. P., & Grossman, R. B. (2017).** *Neurotypical peers are less willing to interact with those with autism based on thin slice judgments.* Scientific Reports, 7, 40700. Across three studies, non-autistic observers formed less favorable first impressions of autistic children and adults from a few seconds of video, and were less willing to interact with them; the bias disappeared when they judged only transcripts of what was said.
doi.org/10.1038/srep40700

**Weigelt, S., Koldewyn, K., & Kanwisher, N. (2012).** *Face identity recognition in autism spectrum disorders: A review of behavioral studies.* Neuroscience & Biobehavioral Reviews, 36(3), 1060–1084. Found that autistic people were, on average, less accurate at recognizing and remembering face identity, especially when memory was involved, while processing faces in broadly the same way; whether the difficulty is specific to faces was unclear.
doi.org/10.1016/j.neubiorev.2011.12.008

PART THREE · CHAPTER 10

## Values, meaning and a good life

**Baumeister, R. F., Vohs, K. D., Aaker, J. L., & Garbinsky, E. N. (2013).** *Some key differences between a happy life and a meaningful life.* Journal of Positive Psychology, 8(6), 505–516. In surveys of about 400 adults, happiness and meaningfulness overlapped but differed: good health and an easy life went with happiness but not meaning, while thinking more about the past and future went with more meaning but less happiness.
doi.org/10.1080/17439760.2013.830764

**Curry, O. S., Rowland, L. A., Van Lissa, C. J., Zlotowitz, S., McAlaney, J., & Whitehouse, H. (2018).** *Happy to help? A systematic review and meta-analysis of the effects of performing acts of kindness on the well-being of the actor.* Journal of Experimental Social Psychology, 76, 320–329. A meta-analysis of 27 experiments found that performing acts of kindness had a small-to-medium positive effect on the giver's well-being ($\delta = 0.28$).
doi.org/10.1016/j.jesp.2018.02.014

**Gollwitzer, P. M. (1999).** *Implementation intentions: Strong effects of simple plans.* American Psychologist, 54(7), 493–503. Reviewed research showing that if-then plans ("when situation X arises, I will do Y") hand control of action to the planned cue and help people act on their goals.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.54.7.493

**Hayes, S. C., Strosahl, K. D., & Wilson, K. G. (1999).** *Acceptance and commitment therapy: An experiential approach to behavior change.* Guilford Press. The first main book on acceptance and commitment therapy (ACT), which puts chosen values at the center and teaches making room for difficult feelings while acting on what matters.
contextualscience.org/publications/hayes_strosahl_wilson_1999

**Lally, P., van Jaarsveld, C. H. M., Potts, H. W. W., & Wardle, J. (2010).** *How are habits formed: Modelling habit formation in the real world.* European Journal of Social Psychology, 40(6), 998–1009. Following 96 volunteers who repeated a daily behavior in the same context for 12 weeks, automaticity rose along a curve that leveled off; reaching 95% of each person's plateau took between 18 and 254 days, and missing a single day did not meaningfully set progress back.
doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.674

**Lazarus, R. S., & Folkman, S. (1984).** *Stress, appraisal, and coping.* Springer Publishing, New York. Set out the appraisal model: stress depends on judging whether something threatens you and whether you can cope; it also distinguished problem-focused from emotion-focused coping.
wellcomecollection.org/works/b5zr7tvm

**Markus, H. R., & Kitayama, S. (1991).** *Culture and the self: Implications for cognition, emotion, and motivation.* Psychological Review, 98(2), 224–253. Argued that cultures differ in how they construe the self, as independent or interdependent with others, and that this shapes cognition, emotion and motivation.
sites.duke.edu

**Martela, F., & Steger, M. F. (2016).** *The three meanings of meaning in life: Distinguishing coherence, purpose, and significance.* Journal of Positive Psychology, 11(5), 531–545. Proposed that meaning in life has three parts: coherence (life makes sense), purpose (having core goals and direction) and significance (feeling that one's life has value).
research.aalto.fi

**Milton, D. E. M. (2012).** *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

**Murray, D., Lesser, M., & Lawson, W. (2005).** *Attention, monotropism and the diagnostic criteria for autism.* Autism, 9(2), 139–156. Proposed "monotropism": autistic attention tends to be pulled strongly into a few interests at a time, and the authors argued this can explain the other diagnostic features of autism.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361305051398

**Ross, L., & Ward, A. (1996).** *Naive realism in everyday life: Implications for social conflict and misunderstanding.* In E. S. Reed, E. Turiel, & T. Brown (Eds.), Values and Knowledge (pp. 103–135). Lawrence Erlbaum / Psychology Press. Described naive realism: people assume they see the world objectively, so those who disagree must be uninformed, irrational or biased — a dynamic that fuels conflict and misunderstanding.
doi.org/10.4324/9780203773772-6

**Rotter, J. B. (1966).** *Generalized expectancies for internal versus external control of reinforcement.* Psychological Monographs: General and Applied, 80(1), 1–28. Described individual differences in "locus of control", how far people believe outcomes depend on their own actions rather than outside forces, and introduced a scale to measure it.
doi.org/10.1037/h0092976

**Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2000).** *Self-determination theory and the facilitation of intrinsic motivation, social development, and well-being.* American Psychologist, 55(1), 68–78. Summarized self-determination theory: people are most motivated and well when three basic needs are met: autonomy, competence and relatedness.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.55.1.68

**Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2001).** *On happiness and human potentials: A review of research on hedonic and eudaimonic well-being.* Annual Review of Psychology, 52, 141–166. Reviewed two traditions of well-being research: hedonic (pleasure and the absence of pain) and eudaimonic (meaning, self-realization and full functioning), and how they diverge and complement each other.
doi.org/10.1146/annurev.psych.52.1.141

**Ryff, C. D. (1989).** *Happiness is everything, or is it? Explorations on the meaning of psychological well-being.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 57(6), 1069–1081. Proposed six dimensions of psychological well-being (self-acceptance, positive relations, autonomy, environmental mastery, purpose in life and personal growth) and tested them with 321 adults, finding that several were not captured by earlier happiness measures.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.57.6.1069

**Schwartz, S. H. (1992).** *Universals in the content and structure of values: Theoretical advances and empirical tests in 20 countries.* Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 25, 1–65. Using data from 20 countries, found that the meaning of a set of basic value types was broadly similar across most groups, and that values are organized by two dimensions into a circle of compatible and conflicting motivations.
cris.huji.ac.il

**Steger, M. F., Frazier, P., Oishi, S., & Kaler, M. (2006).** *The Meaning in Life Questionnaire: Assessing the presence of and search for meaning in life.* Journal of Counseling Psychology, 53(1), 80–93. Developed the 10-item Meaning in Life Questionnaire, which separately measures the presence of meaning and the search for meaning, and tested its reliability and validity across three studies.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-0167.53.1.80

## Healing after hurt

**Baumeister, R. F., Stillwell, A., & Wotman, S. R. (1990).** *Victim and perpetrator accounts of interpersonal conflict: Autobiographical narratives about anger.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 59(5), 994–1005. People wrote stories about a time they angered someone and a time someone angered them; perpetrators and victims described the same kinds of event very differently, for example in how serious, understandable and finished the harm was.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.59.5.994

**Bonanno, G. A. (2004).** *Loss, trauma, and human resilience: Have we underestimated the human capacity to thrive after extremely aversive events?* American Psychologist, 59(1), 20–28. Argued that resilience after loss or trauma is distinct from recovery, is more common than many theorists assumed, and can come about in several ways.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.59.1.20

**Carrère, S., & Gottman, J. M. (1999).** *Predicting divorce among newlyweds from the first three minutes of a marital conflict discussion.* Family Process, 38(3), 293–301. In 124 newlywed couples, how the first three minutes of a conflict discussion went (more negative and less positive emotion) predicted which couples divorced over the next six years.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1545-5300.1999.00293.x

**Cohen, S., & Wills, T. A. (1985).** *Stress, social support, and the buffering hypothesis.* Psychological Bulletin, 98(2), 310–357. A review arguing that social support protects (buffers) people from the harmful effects of stress, especially perceived availability of support, alongside general main effects of being socially integrated.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.98.2.310

**Eisenberger, N. I., Lieberman, M. D., & Williams, K. D. (2003).** *Does rejection hurt? An fMRI study of social exclusion.* Science, 302(5643), 290–292. Being left out of a virtual ball-tossing game increased activity in the anterior cingulate cortex, a region also involved in physical pain distress, in proportion to how upset people felt.
doi.org/10.1126/science.1089134

**Eubanks, C. F., Muran, J. C., & Safran, J. D. (2018).** *Alliance rupture repair: A meta-analysis.* Psychotherapy, 55(4), 508–519. Across 11 studies (1,314 patients), repairing ruptures in the therapist-client relationship was moderately associated with better outcomes; training therapists in rupture repair did not show a significant effect on outcomes in 6 studies.
doi.org/10.1037/pst0000185

**Frattaroli, J. (2006).** *Experimental disclosure and its moderators: A meta-analysis.* Psychological Bulletin, 132(6), 823–865. Pooling 146 randomized studies, experimental disclosure (such as expressive writing) had a small but significant positive average effect.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.132.6.823

**Frazier, P., Tennen, H., Gavian, M., Park, C., Tomich, P., & Tashiro, T. (2009).** *Does self-reported posttraumatic growth reflect genuine positive change?* Psychological Science, 20(7), 912–919. Measuring 122 students before and after a trauma, the researchers found that self-reported growth was largely unrelated to actual measured change, and perceived growth went with more distress while actual growth went with less.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2009.02381.x

**Gordon, K. C., Baucom, D. H., & Snyder, D. K. (2004).** *An integrative intervention for promoting recovery from extramarital affairs.* Journal of Marital and Family Therapy, 30(2), 213-231. In a small study of six couples who had a structured couples therapy after an affair, most were less distressed by the end, and the hurt partners reported more forgiveness. The therapy moved in stages: dealing with the shock, understanding how the affair came about, and then deciding how to move on.
pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/15114949

**Gottman, J. M. (2011).** *The Science of Trust: Emotional Attunement for Couples.* W. W. Norton (New York). A book drawing on Gottman's lab research and game theory to argue that trust is built through emotional attunement in everyday moments, and describing how couples can repair it.
wwnorton.co.uk/books/9780393705959-the-science-of-trust

**Kim, P. H., Ferrin, D. L., Cooper, C. D., & Dirks, K. T. (2004).** *Removing the shadow of suspicion: The effects of apology versus denial for repairing competence- versus integrity-based trust violations.* Journal of Applied Psychology, 89(1), 104–118. Trust was repaired more successfully when people apologized for competence-based violations but denied culpability for integrity-based violations, depending also on later evidence of guilt or innocence.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.89.1.104

**Leary, M. R., Springer, C., Negel, L., Ansell, E., & Evans, K. (1998).** *The causes, phenomenology, and consequences of hurt feelings.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 74(5), 1225–1237. Hurt feelings were triggered by events that signaled relational devaluation (feeling less valued by someone), usually by people the person knew well.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.74.5.1225

**Leary, M. R., Tate, E. B., Adams, C. E., Allen, A. B., & Hancock, J. (2007).** *Self-compassion and reactions to unpleasant self-relevant events: The implications of treating oneself kindly.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 92(5), 887–904. In five studies, self-compassion softened people's reactions to unpleasant events in ways distinct from, and sometimes more helpful than, self-esteem.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.92.5.887

**Lewicki, R. J., Polin, B., & Lount, R. B., Jr. (2016).** *An exploration of the structure of effective apologies.* Negotiation and Conflict Management Research, 9(2), 177–196. Testing six apology components with 755 participants, acknowledging responsibility was rated most important, then an offer of repair; a request for forgiveness mattered least. Apologies with more components were rated better.
doi.org/10.1111/ncmr.12073

**McNulty, J. K. (2008).** *Forgiveness in marriage: Putting the benefits into context.* Journal of Family Psychology, 22(1), 171–175. Looked at newly married couples and argued, as the title says, that the benefits of forgiving depend on the context, such as how often a partner behaves badly.
doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.22.1.171

**McNulty, J. K. (2011).** *The dark side of forgiveness: The tendency to forgive predicts continued psychological and physical aggression in marriage.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 37(6), 770–783. In newlywed couples over four years, partners' aggression stayed stable toward more forgiving spouses but declined toward less forgiving ones, suggesting forgiveness can remove consequences that would discourage repeat offending.
doi.org/10.1177/0146167211407077

**Milton, D. E. M. (2012).** *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

**Neff, K. D. (2003).** *Self-compassion: An alternative conceptualization of a healthy attitude toward oneself.* Self and Identity, 2(2), 85–101. Defined self-compassion as three parts: self-kindness instead of harsh judgment, common humanity instead of isolation, and mindfulness instead of over-identifying with painful feelings.
doi.org/10.1080/15298860309032

**Nolen-Hoeksema, S. (1991).** *Responses to depression and their effects on the duration of depressive episodes.* Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 100(4), 569–582. Proposed the response styles theory: people who ruminate on their low mood tend to have longer depressions than people who distract themselves.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-843X.100.4.569

**Pennebaker, J. W., & Beall, S. K. (1986).** *Confronting a traumatic event: Toward an understanding of inhibition and disease.* Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 95(3), 274–281. An early expressive-writing experiment in which students wrote about traumatic experiences over several days; it launched decades of research on whether writing about difficult experiences helps health and well-being.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-843X.95.3.274

**Pillemer, K. (2020).** *Fault Lines: Fractured Families and How to Mend Them.* Avery (Penguin Random House). Draws on the Cornell Reconciliation Project, including a national survey on estrangement and interviews, to show family estrangement is more common than people assume and that some people reconcile.
search.worldcat.org/oclc/1145305518

**Raymaker, D. M., Teo, A. R., Steckler, N. A., et al. (2020).** *"Having all of your internal resources exhausted beyond measure and being left with no clean-up crew": Defining autistic burnout.* Autism in Adulthood, 2(2), 132–143. From 19 interviews and 19 public online accounts, analyzed with autistic co-researchers, autistic burnout was defined as long-term exhaustion, loss of function and reduced tolerance to stimulus, arising from chronic life stress and a mismatch between expectations and abilities without enough support.
doi.org/10.1089/aut.2019.0079

**Rempel, J. K., Holmes, J. G., & Zanna, M. P. (1985).** *Trust in close relationships.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 49(1), 95–112. Described trust in close relationships as having three components, predictability, dependability and faith, and developed a self-report Trust Scale to measure them.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.49.1.95

**Rosenberg, M. B. (1999).** *Nonviolent Communication: A Language of Compassion (later editions: A Language of Life).* PuddleDancer Press (Encinitas, CA); 2nd ed. 2003, 3rd ed. 2015. Describes Nonviolent Communication: expressing observations, feelings, needs and requests, and listening for the same in others.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/562413

**Tedeschi, R. G., & Calhoun, L. G. (1996).** *The Posttraumatic Growth Inventory: Measuring the positive legacy of trauma.* Journal of Traumatic Stress, 9(3), 455–471. Developed the 21-item Posttraumatic Growth Inventory with five areas of reported growth: new possibilities, relating to others, personal strength, spiritual change and appreciation of life.
doi.org/10.1007/BF02103658

**Tronick, E., Als, H., Adamson, L., Wise, S., & Brazelton, T. B. (1978).** *The infant's response to entrapment between contradictory messages in face-to-face interaction.* Journal of the American Academy of Child Psychiatry, 17(1), 1–13. The first "still face" study: when a mother kept a blank, unresponsive face, infants tried hard to re-engage her, then grew upset and withdrew; they recovered when she responded again.
doi.org/10.1016/S0002-7138(09)62273-1

**Wade, N. G., Hoyt, W. T., Kidwell, J. E. M., & Worthington, E. L., Jr. (2014).** *Efficacy of psychotherapeutic interventions to promote forgiveness: A meta-analysis.* Journal of Consulting and Clinical Psychology, 82(1), 154–170. Across 54 reports, people in explicit forgiveness interventions reported more forgiveness than untreated controls and than those in other treatments, along with larger improvements in depression, anxiety and hope than no treatment.
doi.org/10.1037/a0035268

PART THREE · CHAPTER 12

## Helping others well

**Bloom, P. (2016).** *Against empathy: The case for rational compassion.* Ecco. A book arguing that empathy, feeling what others feel, is biased toward people like us and can cloud judgment, and that reasoned compassion is a better guide to helping.
wellcomecollection.org/works/c5q8eupq

**Bolger, N., Zuckerman, A., & Kessler, R. C. (2000).** *Invisible support and adjustment to stress.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 79(6), 953–961. In couples where one partner faced a stressful exam, support the recipient did not notice (reported by the giver but not the receiver) was linked with better adjustment, while noticed (visible) support was not.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.79.6.953

**Brown, S. L., Nesse, R. M., Vinokur, A. D., & Smith, D. M. (2003).** *Providing social support may be more beneficial than receiving it: Results from a prospective study of mortality.* Psychological Science, 14(4), 320–327. In a five-year study of older married adults, those who reported giving practical help to others or emotional support to their spouse had lower mortality, while receiving support was not linked to mortality once giving was accounted for.
researchconnect.stonybrook.edu

**Cutrona, C. E., & Russell, D. W. (1990).** *Type of social support and specific stress: Toward a theory of optimal matching.* In B. R. Sarason, I. G. Sarason & G. R. Pierce (Eds.), Social Support: An Interactional View (pp. 319–366). New York: Wiley. Proposed the "optimal matching" idea: support helps most when its type fits the problem, for example practical help for things you can change and comfort for things you can't.
search.worldcat.org

**Darley, J. M., & Latané, B. (1968).** *Bystander intervention in emergencies: Diffusion of responsibility.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 8(4), 377–383. Participants who believed others could also hear a person having a seizure were slower and less likely to help; the presence of others reduced each person's sense of responsibility.
doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

**Dazzi, T., Gribble, R., Wessely, S., & Fear, N. T. (2014).** *Does asking about suicide and related behaviours induce suicidal ideation? What is the evidence?* Psychological Medicine, 44(16), 3361–3363. A review of published studies in adults and adolescents, in the general population and in groups at higher risk. None found a significant rise in suicidal thoughts after people were asked about suicide; talking about it may even lower them.
pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/24998511

**Dunn, E. W., Aknin, L. B., & Norton, M. I. (2008).** *Spending money on others promotes happiness.* Science, 319(5870), 1687–1688. Spending more of one's income on others predicted greater happiness in a nationally representative survey and in a field study of windfall spending, and people randomly assigned to spend money on others were happier than those assigned to spend it on themselves.
doi.org/10.1126/science.1150952

**Figley, C. R. (Ed.) (1995).** *Compassion fatigue: Coping with secondary traumatic stress disorder in those who treat the traumatized.* Brunner/Mazel, New York. An edited volume introducing "compassion fatigue" as a cost of helping traumatized people, distinguished from burnout and PTSD, with ideas for prevention.
routledge.com

**Fischer, P., Krueger, J. I., Greitemeyer, T., Vogrincic, C., Kastenmüller, A., Frey, D., Heene, M., Wicher, M., & Kainbacher, M. (2011).** *The bystander-effect: A meta-analytic review on bystander intervention in dangerous and non-dangerous emergencies.* Psychological Bulletin, 137(4), 517–537. Across 105 effect sizes and over 7,700 participants, the bystander effect was reliable but weaker when situations were clearly dangerous.
doi.org/10.1037/a0023304

**Flynn, F. J., & Lake, V. K. B. (Bohns) (2008).** *"If you need help, just ask": Underestimating compliance with direct requests for help.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 95(1), 128–143. In five studies, people asking for help underestimated how many others would agree to a direct request, by as much as 50%, partly because they overlooked how awkward it feels to say no.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.95.1.128

**Helgeson, V. S., & Fritz, H. L. (1998).** *A theory of unmitigated communion.* Personality and Social Psychology Review, 2(3), 173–183. Proposed "unmitigated communion", focusing on others to the exclusion of oneself, and distinguished it from healthy caring; unmitigated communion, not communion, was linked to psychological distress.
doi.org/10.1207/s15327957pspr0203_2

**Hobfoll, S. E. (1989).** *Conservation of resources: A new attempt at conceptualizing stress.* American Psychologist, 44(3), 513–524. Proposed conservation of resources theory: stress arises when people's valued resources are threatened or lost, or when investing resources does not pay off, and people strive to protect what they have.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.44.3.513

**House, J. S. (1981).** *Work Stress and Social Support.* Addison-Wesley (Reading, MA). A book on social support at work that distinguished emotional, instrumental, informational and appraisal support.
libcat.library.tamu.edu/Record/in00000649568

**Maslach, C., & Jackson, S. E. (1981).** *The measurement of experienced burnout.* Journal of Occupational Behaviour (now Journal of Organizational Behavior), 2(2), 99–113. Developed the Maslach Burnout Inventory, with three subscales: emotional exhaustion, depersonalization, and reduced personal accomplishment.
scienceopen.com/document/vid/19d4ed76-9f31-47eb-93e2-81f08d26f4d4

**Miller, W. R., & Rollnick, S. (1991).** *Motivational interviewing: Preparing people to change addictive behavior.* Guilford Press. The first full presentation of motivational interviewing: a way of talking about change that treats mixed feelings as normal and draws out the person's own reasons for change.
motivationalinterviewing.org

**Miserandino, C. (2003).** *The spoon theory.* ButYouDontLookSick.com (essay). A personal essay in which Christine Miserandino, who has lupus, used a handful of spoons to show a friend that each daily task costs some of a limited supply of energy.
butyoudontlooksick.com/articles/written-by-christine/the-spoon-theory

**Philpot, R., Liebst, L. S., Levine, M., Bernasco, W., & Lindegaard, M. R. (2020).** *Would I be helped? Cross-national CCTV footage shows that intervention is the norm in public conflicts.* American Psychologist, 75(1), 66–75. Analyzing CCTV footage of real public conflicts in three countries, the researchers found that at least one bystander intervened in most incidents, at similar rates across countries, and that more bystanders made intervention more likely.
doi.org/10.1037/amp0000469

**Pinquart, M., & Sörensen, S. (2003).** *Differences between caregivers and noncaregivers in psychological health and physical health: A meta-analysis.* Psychology and Aging, 18(2), 250–267. Across 84 studies, caregivers reported more stress and depression and lower wellbeing and self-efficacy than non-caregivers, with smaller differences in physical health; gaps were larger for dementia caregivers.
doi.org/10.1037/0882-7974.18.2.250

**Raymaker, D. M., Teo, A. R., Steckler, N. A., et al. (2020).** *"Having all of your internal resources exhausted beyond measure and being left with no clean-up crew": Defining autistic burnout.* Autism in Adulthood, 2(2), 132–143. From 19 interviews and 19 public online accounts, analyzed with autistic co-researchers, autistic burnout was defined as long-term exhaustion, loss of function and reduced tolerance to stimulus, arising from chronic life stress and a mismatch between expectations and abilities without enough support.
doi.org/10.1089/aut.2019.0079

**Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2000).** *Self-determination theory and the facilitation of intrinsic motivation, social development, and well-being.* American Psychologist, 55(1), 68–78. Summarized self-determination theory: people are most motivated and well when three basic needs are met: autonomy, competence and relatedness.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.55.1.68

**Singer, T., & Klimecki, O. M. (2014).** *Empathy and compassion.* Current Biology, 24(18), R875–R878. Distinguished empathic distress (sharing someone's pain, which can overwhelm) from compassion (warm concern), which engage different brain networks; brief compassion training increased positive feelings.
doi.org/10.1016/j.cub.2014.06.054

**World Health Organization (2019).** *Burn-out an "occupational phenomenon": International Classification of Diseases.* WHO news item, 28 May 2019. ICD-11 includes burn-out as an occupational phenomenon, not a medical condition: a syndrome from chronic workplace stress that has not been successfully managed, with exhaustion, mental distance or cynicism about one's job, and reduced professional efficacy. WHO says the term should not be used for other areas of life.
who.int

## Anger

**Baumeister, R. F., Stillwell, A., & Wotman, S. R. (1990).** *Victim and perpetrator accounts of interpersonal conflict: Autobiographical narratives about anger.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 59(5), 994–1005. People wrote stories about a time they angered someone and a time someone angered them; perpetrators and victims described the same kinds of event very differently, for example in how serious, understandable and finished the harm was.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.59.5.994

**Bushman, B. J. (2002).** *Does venting anger feed or extinguish the flame? Catharsis, rumination, distraction, anger, and aggressive responding.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 28(6), 724–731. Angered people who hit a punching bag while thinking about the person who provoked them felt angrier afterward than people who were distracted or did nothing.
doi.org/10.1177/0146167202289002

**Bushman, B. J., Bonacci, A. M., Pedersen, W. C., Vasquez, E. A., & Miller, N. (2005).** *Chewing on it can chew you up: Effects of rumination on triggered displaced aggression.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 88(6), 969–983. In three experiments, people who ruminated about a provocation, even for eight hours, were later more aggressive toward someone who only mildly annoyed them than people who were distracted.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.88.6.969

**Carver, C. S., & Harmon-Jones, E. (2009).** *Anger is an approach-related affect: Evidence and implications.* Psychological Bulletin, 135, 183–204. A review of evidence that anger is usually an "approach" emotion: like eagerness, it moves people toward a goal or obstacle rather than away from it.
doi.org/10.1037/a0013965

**Chida, Y., & Steptoe, A. (2009).** *The association of anger and hostility with future coronary heart disease: A meta-analytic review of prospective evidence.* Journal of the American College of Cardiology, 53(11), 936–946. Anger and hostility were linked with a modestly higher risk of later coronary heart disease events, in both initially healthy people and people with heart disease; the link was no longer significant in studies that controlled for behaviors such as smoking.
doi.org/10.1016/j.jacc.2008.11.044

**Crompton, C. J., Ropar, D., Evans-Williams, C. V. M., Flynn, E. G., & Fletcher-Watson, S. (2020).** *Autistic peer-to-peer information transfer is highly effective.* Autism, 24(7), 1704–1712. In "diffusion chains" where a story was passed along eight people (72 adults), all-autistic chains passed on as much detail as all-non-autistic chains, while mixed chains lost detail faster and reported lower rapport.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361320919286

**Del Vecchio, T., & O'Leary, K. D. (2004).** *Effectiveness of anger treatments for specific anger problems: A meta-analytic review.* Clinical Psychology Review, 24(1), 15–34. Across 23 controlled studies of adults with anger problems, anger treatments produced medium to large effects; cognitive approaches did well for long-standing (trait) anger, anger suppression and driving anger, and relaxation for in-the-moment anger.
doi.org/10.1016/j.cpr.2003.09.006

**Gordon, A. M., & Chen, S. (2014).** *The role of sleep in interpersonal conflict: Do sleepless nights mean worse fights?* Social Psychological and Personality Science, 5(2), 168–175. In a 14-day daily study, people reported more conflict with their partner after poor nights of sleep, and conflicts were resolved best when both partners were well rested.
doi.org/10.1177/1948550613488952

**Gordon, T. (1970).** *P.E.T.: Parent Effectiveness Training.* New York: P. H. Wyden (book; revised 2000). A parenting book and course that popularized "I-messages": describing your own feelings and the effect of a behavior rather than blaming the other person.
search.worldcat.org/title/670595

**Gross, J. J. (1998).** *The emerging field of emotion regulation: An integrative review.* Review of General Psychology, 2(3), 271–299. Set out the process model of emotion regulation, with five points where emotion can be shaped: situation selection, situation modification, attention, cognitive change (reappraisal) and response modulation.
doi.org/10.1037/1089-2680.2.3.271

**Gross, J. J., & John, O. P. (2003).** *Individual differences in two emotion regulation processes: Implications for affect, relationships, and well-being.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 85(2), 348–362. Across five studies, people who habitually reappraised had better emotional experience, relationships and well-being; habitual suppression was linked to worse outcomes.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.85.2.348

**James, W. (1884).** *What is an emotion?* Mind, os-IX(34), 188–205. James argued that bodily changes follow directly from perceiving something exciting, and that our feeling of those bodily changes is the emotion.
doi.org/10.1093/mind/os-IX.34.188

**Kapp, S. K., Steward, R., Crane, L., Elliott, D., Elphick, C., Pellicano, E., & Russell, G. (2019).** *"People should be allowed to do what they like": Autistic adults' views and experiences of stimming.* Autism, 23(7), 1782–1792. Interviews and focus groups with 32 autistic adults described stimming as a way to regulate overwhelming emotions and sensations, and as something that becomes accepted through understanding; participants objected to efforts to stop harmless stimming.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361319829628

**Kinnaird, E., Stewart, C., & Tchanturia, K. (2019).** *Investigating alexithymia in autism: A systematic review and meta-analysis.* European Psychiatry, 55, 80–89. Across 15 studies, about half of autistic participants (around 50%) had high alexithymia compared with about 5% of comparison participants; alexithymia is common in autism but not universal.
doi.org/10.1016/j.eurpsy.2018.09.004

**Kjærvik, S. L., & Bushman, B. J. (2024).** *A meta-analytic review of anger management activities that increase or decrease arousal: What fuels or douses rage?* Clinical Psychology Review (April 2024). Across 154 studies, activities that calm the body (such as slow breathing, relaxation and mindfulness) reduced anger and aggression, while arousal-increasing activities showed little or no benefit.
news.osu.edu

**Kross, E., Ayduk, O., & Mischel, W. (2005).** *When asking "why" does not hurt: Distinguishing rumination from reflective processing of negative emotions.* Psychological Science, 16(9), 709–715. After recalling an anger-provoking experience, people who asked why they felt as they did from a self-distanced perspective showed less emotional reactivity than those who relived it through their own eyes.
rascl.studentorg.berkeley.edu/assets/files/kross_etal_2005_ps.pdf

**Mischkowski, D., Kross, E., & Bushman, B. J. (2012).** *Flies on the wall are less aggressive: Self-distancing "in the heat of the moment" reduces aggressive thoughts, angry feelings and aggressive behavior.* Journal of Experimental Social Psychology. After being provoked, people who reflected on the moment from a distanced, "fly on the wall" view felt less angry and behaved less aggressively than people who relived it from their own point of view.
doi.org/10.1016/j.jesp.2012.03.012

**Mostofsky, E., Penner, E. A., & Mittleman, M. A. (2014).** *Outbursts of anger as a trigger of acute cardiovascular events: A systematic review and meta-analysis.* European Heart Journal, 35(21), 1404–1410. Across nine case-crossover studies, the rate of heart attacks, strokes and arrhythmias was higher in the two hours after an outburst of anger than at other times, especially for people already at high risk.
doi.org/10.1093/eurheartj/ehu033

**Rosenberg, M. B. (1999).** *Nonviolent Communication: A Language of Compassion (later editions: A Language of Life).* PuddleDancer Press (Encinitas, CA); 2nd ed. 2003, 3rd ed. 2015. Describes Nonviolent Communication: expressing observations, feelings, needs and requests, and listening for the same in others.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/562413

**Saini, M. (2009).** *A meta-analysis of the psychological treatment of anger: Developing guidelines for evidence-based practice.* Journal of the American Academy of Psychiatry and the Law, 37(4), 473–488. Across 96 studies and 139 treatment effects, psychological treatments for anger (such as CBT, skills training and relaxation) were generally effective, with considerable variation between treatments and studies.
pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/20018996

**Shaw, P., Stringaris, A., Nigg, J., & Leibenluft, E. (2014).** *Emotion dysregulation in attention deficit hyperactivity disorder.* American Journal of Psychiatry, 171(3), 276–293. A literature review found that trouble regulating emotions (quick, strong feelings that are hard to bring back down) is common in ADHD across the lifespan, with clinic studies of young people putting it at roughly a quarter to a half, and that it adds a lot to the day-to-day difficulty ADHD brings.
doi.org/10.1176/appi.ajp.2013.13070966

PART THREE · CHAPTER 14

## Personality, temperament and change

**Aron, E. N., & Aron, A. (1997).** *Sensory-processing sensitivity and its relation to introversion and emotionality.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 73(2), 345–368. Across seven studies, the authors identified a single core trait of sensory-processing sensitivity, partly independent of introversion and emotionality, and developed the 27-item Highly Sensitive Person Scale.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.73.2.345

**Bleidorn, W., Schwaba, T., Zheng, A., Hopwood, C. J., Sosa, S. S., Roberts, B. W., & Briley, D. A. (2022).** *Personality stability and change: A meta-analysis of longitudinal studies.* Psychological Bulletin, 148(7–8), 588–619. Who is more or less of a trait compared with others becomes steadier through childhood and levels off by about 25, while average levels keep shifting gently across life, with emotional stability rising most.
doi.org/10.1037/bul0000365

**Grove, R., Hoekstra, R. A., Wierda, M., & Begeer, S. (2018).** *Special interests and subjective wellbeing in autistic adults.* Autism Research, 11(5), 766–775. In a survey of autistic adults in the Netherlands Autism Register, about two-thirds reported a special interest; greater motivation for the interest was linked to higher wellbeing, while very high intensity of engagement was linked to lower wellbeing.
research.vu.nl

**Hudson, N. W., & Fraley, R. C. (2015).** *Volitional personality trait change: Can people choose to change their personality traits?* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 109(3), 490–507. In two 16-week studies, people who wanted to change a trait tended to shift a little in that direction, especially when they set concrete plans to act differently.
doi.org/10.1037/pspp0000021

**Hull, L., Petrides, K. V., Allison, C., Smith, P., Baron-Cohen, S., Lai, M.-C., & Mandy, W. (2017).** *"Putting on my best normal": Social camouflaging in adults with autism spectrum conditions.* Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders, 47(8), 2519–2534. Interviews with 92 autistic adults described camouflaging as motivated by wanting to fit in and connect, done through masking and compensating techniques, and often followed by exhaustion and threats to self-perception.
doi.org/10.1007/s10803-017-3166-5

**Leedham, A., Thompson, A. R., Smith, R., & Freeth, M. (2020).** *'I was exhausted trying to figure it out': The experiences of females receiving an autism diagnosis in middle to late adulthood.* Autism, 24(1), 135–146. Interviews with eleven autistic women diagnosed at 40 or older explored how they made sense of a lifetime of feeling different and how the diagnosis changed their understanding of themselves.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361319853442

**Leikas, S., & Ilmarinen, V.-J. (2017).** *Happy now, tired later? Extraverted and conscientious behavior are related to immediate mood gains, but to later fatigue.* Journal of Personality, 85(5), 603–615. In a 12-day experience-sampling study, acting extraverted went with better mood at the time but more fatigue about three hours later, for introverts and extraverts alike.
doi.org/10.1111/jopy.12264

**McCrae, R. R., & Costa, P. T., Jr. (1987).** *Validation of the five-factor model of personality across instruments and observers.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 52(1), 81–90. Ratings of 275 adults by their peers showed the same five broad trait factors found in self-reports, and peers and the people themselves agreed moderately well. This helped establish the "Big Five" as a common map of personality.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.52.1.81

**Roberts, B. W., Luo, J., Briley, D. A., Chow, P. I., Su, R., & Hill, P. L. (2017).** *A systematic review of personality trait change through intervention.* Psychological Bulletin, 143(2), 117–141. Across 207 studies, personality trait scores changed noticeably during therapy and other interventions over about six months, mostly toward more emotional stability, and the changes lasted in follow-ups.
doi.org/10.1037/bul0000088

**Roberts, B. W., Walton, K. E., & Viechtbauer, W. (2006).** *Patterns of mean-level change in personality traits across the life course: A meta-analysis of longitudinal studies.* Psychological Bulletin, 132(1), 1–25. Pooling 92 long-term studies, people on average became more confident in social settings, more conscientious and more emotionally stable, especially between about 20 and 40, and traits kept changing in middle and old age.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.132.1.1

**Thomas, A., & Chess, S. (1977).** *Temperament and Development.* New York: Brunner/Mazel. From the New York Longitudinal Study, which followed children from infancy, the authors described inborn differences in temperament, such as activity, regularity, adaptability and mood, and argued that how well a child's temperament fits their surroundings matters ("goodness of fit").
wellcomecollection.org/works/epddh966

PART THREE · CHAPTER 15

## Closeness and love

**Acevedo, B. P., & Aron, A. (2009).** *Does a long-term relationship kill romantic love?* Review of General Psychology, 13(1), 59–65. Reviewing studies of short- and long-term relationships, the authors concluded that romantic love without obsession can last in long-term relationships and is linked with greater satisfaction and well-being.
doi.org/10.1037/a0014226

**Algoe, S. B., Gable, S. L., & Maisel, N. C. (2010).** *It's the little things: Everyday gratitude as a booster shot for romantic relationships.* Personal Relationships, 17(2), 217–233. In a daily-diary study of cohabiting couples, feeling gratitude after a partner's thoughtful act predicted greater relationship connection and satisfaction the next day, for both partners.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1475-6811.2010.01273.x

**Aron, A., & Aron, E. N. (1986).** *Love and the Expansion of Self: Understanding Attraction and Satisfaction.* Hemisphere Publishing (Washington, DC). Introduced the self-expansion model: people are motivated to grow by including a partner's perspectives, resources and identity in their sense of self.
libcat.library.tamu.edu/Record/in00000408876

**Aron, A., Melinat, E., Aron, E. N., Vallone, R. D., & Bator, R. J. (1997).** *The experimental generation of interpersonal closeness: A procedure and some preliminary findings.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 23(4), 363–377. Pairs of strangers who spent about 45 minutes on gradually deepening self-disclosure tasks (the "36 questions") felt closer afterward than pairs given small-talk tasks; matching on attitudes or expecting to like each other made no significant difference.
ggia.berkeley.edu/practice/36_questions_for_increasing_closeness

**Aron, A., Norman, C. C., Aron, E. N., McKenna, C., & Heyman, R. E. (2000).** *Couples' shared participation in novel and arousing activities and experienced relationship quality.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 78(2), 273–284. Couples who took part together in a novel, mildly challenging activity reported higher relationship quality afterward than couples who did a mundane task.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.78.2.273

**Baumeister, R. F., & Leary, M. R. (1995).** *The need to belong: Desire for interpersonal attachments as a fundamental human motivation.* Psychological Bulletin, 117(3), 497–529. A major review arguing that the need to belong is a fundamental human motivation: people need frequent, pleasant contact within a few stable, caring relationships, and unmet belonging has wide emotional and cognitive costs.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.117.3.497

**Carstensen, L. L., Isaacowitz, D. M., & Charles, S. T. (1999).** *Taking time seriously: A theory of socioemotional selectivity.* American Psychologist, 54(3), 165–181. Proposes that perceived time left shapes social goals: when time feels open-ended people seek new information and contacts; when it feels limited they focus on fewer, emotionally meaningful relationships.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.54.3.165

**Driver, J. L., & Gottman, J. M. (2004).** *Daily marital interactions and positive affect during marital conflict among newlywed couples.* Family Process, 43(3), 301–314. Observing 49 newlywed couples over dinner and in a conflict discussion, the authors linked turning toward each other's everyday bids with more positive emotion (such as humor and affection) during later conflict.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1545-5300.2004.00024.x

**Fraley, R. C., Hudson, N. W., Heffernan, M. E., & Segal, N. (2015).** *Are adult attachment styles categorical or dimensional? A taxometric analysis of general and relationship-specific attachment orientations.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 109(2), 354–368. Taxometric analyses suggested that adult attachment differences are dimensional (degrees of anxiety and avoidance) rather than distinct types.
doi.org/10.1037/pspp0000027

**Gable, S. L., Reis, H. T., Impett, E. A., & Asher, E. R. (2004).** *What do you do when things go right? The intrapersonal and interpersonal benefits of sharing positive events.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 87(2), 228–245. Across four studies, telling others about good news was linked with higher daily positive mood and well-being beyond the event itself, especially when the listener responded actively and constructively; couples whose partners usually responded enthusiastically reported more intimacy and satisfaction.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.87.2.228

**Hazan, C., & Shaver, P. (1987).** *Romantic love conceptualized as an attachment process.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 52(3), 511–524. Two questionnaire studies proposed that adult romantic love is an attachment process: the share of adults in each of three attachment styles roughly matched infant figures, and the styles differed in how people experienced love, their views of self and others, and recalled relationships with parents.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.52.3.511

**Laurenceau, J.-P., Barrett, L. F., & Pietromonaco, P. R. (1998).** *Intimacy as an interpersonal process: The importance of self-disclosure, partner disclosure, and perceived partner responsiveness in interpersonal exchanges.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 74(5), 1238–1251. Diary studies of everyday social interactions supported Reis and Shaver's model: disclosing feelings, and feeling that the other person responded with understanding, both contributed to how intimate an interaction felt.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.74.5.1238

**Reis, H. T., & Shaver, P. (1988).** *Intimacy as an interpersonal process.* In S. Duck (Ed.), Handbook of Personal Relationships (pp. 367–389). Chichester: Wiley. Described intimacy as a back-and-forth process: one person shares something, the other responds with understanding, validation and care, and the first feels known.
search.worldcat.org

PART THREE · CHAPTER 16

## Worry, low mood and trauma

**Bonanno, G. A. (2004).** *Loss, trauma, and human resilience: Have we underestimated the human capacity to thrive after extremely aversive events?* American Psychologist, 59(1), 20–28. Argued that resilience after loss or trauma is distinct from recovery, is more common than many theorists assumed, and can come about in several ways.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.59.1.20

**Borkovec, T. D., Wilkinson, L., Folensbee, R., & Lerman, C. (1983).** *Stimulus control applications to the treatment of worry.* Behaviour Research and Therapy, 21(3), 247–251. People who described themselves as worriers and were taught to postpone worry to a set time and place each day reported less daily worry after four weeks than people given no treatment.
doi.org/10.1016/0005-7967(83)90206-1

**Carleton, R. N. (2016).** *Fear of the unknown: One fear to rule them all?* Journal of Anxiety Disorders, 41, 5–21. A review arguing that fear of the unknown, closely related to intolerance of uncertainty, may be a fundamental fear underlying anxiety and neuroticism.
doi.org/10.1016/j.janxdis.2016.03.011

**Craske, M. G., Treanor, M., Conway, C. C., Zbozinek, T., & Vervliet, B. (2014).** *Maximizing exposure therapy: An inhibitory learning approach.* Behaviour Research and Therapy, 58, 10–23. Describes exposure therapy for anxiety as building new learning that competes with old fear, and sets out ways to strengthen it, such as testing specific expectations, dropping safety behaviors and practicing in varied settings.
doi.org/10.1016/j.brat.2014.04.006

**Cruwys, T., Dingle, G. A., Haslam, C., Haslam, S. A., Jetten, J., & Morton, T. A. (2013).** *Social group memberships protect against future depression, alleviate depression symptoms and prevent depression relapse.* Social Science & Medicine, 98, 179–186. In population data on adults aged 50 and over followed for two to four years, belonging to fewer groups predicted more depression later; among people already depressed, joining one group was linked to a 24% lower risk of relapse and joining three to a 63% lower risk.
doi.org/10.1016/j.socscimed.2013.09.013

**Dazzi, T., Gribble, R., Wessely, S., & Fear, N. T. (2014).** *Does asking about suicide and related behaviours induce suicidal ideation? What is the evidence?* Psychological Medicine, 44(16), 3361–3363. A review of published studies in adults and adolescents, in the general population and in groups at higher risk. None found a significant rise in suicidal thoughts after people were asked about suicide; talking about it may even lower them.
pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/24998511

**Ekers, D., Webster, L., Van Straten, A., Cuijpers, P., Richards, D., & Gilbody, S. (2014).** *Behavioural activation for depression; an update of meta-analysis of effectiveness and sub group analysis.* PLoS ONE, 9(6), e100100. Across 26 randomized trials (1,524 people), behavioral activation, planning and doing small valued activities, reduced depression more than control conditions, and at least as much as medication in the four trials that compared them.
doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0100100

**Felitti, V. J., Anda, R. F., Nordenberg, D., et al. (1998).** *Relationship of childhood abuse and household dysfunction to many of the leading causes of death in adults: The Adverse Childhood Experiences (ACE) Study.* American Journal of Preventive Medicine, 14(4), 245–258. Of 13,494 adults at a large health plan sent a questionnaire, 9,508 responded; the more categories of childhood adversity people reported, the higher their risk of many adult health problems, in a graded relationship.
doi.org/10.1016/S0749-3797(98)00017-8

**Freeman, D., Sheaves, B., et al. (2017).** *The effects of improving sleep on mental health (OASIS): A randomised controlled trial with mediation analysis.* The Lancet Psychiatry, 4(10), 749–758. In 3,755 university students with insomnia, an online CBT course for sleep greatly reduced insomnia and also reduced paranoid thoughts and hallucinatory experiences compared with usual care, with better sleep explaining much of the change.
doi.org/10.1016/S2215-0366(17)30328-0

**Hofmann, S. G., Asnaani, A., Vonk, I. J. J., Sawyer, A. T., & Fang, A. (2012).** *The efficacy of cognitive behavioral therapy: A review of meta-analyses.* Cognitive Therapy and Research, 36(5), 427–440. Reviewing 106 meta-analyses of cognitive behavioral therapy, found the strongest support for anxiety problems, bulimia, anger and general stress, with support across many other problems; few studies looked at groups such as ethnic minorities or people on low incomes.
doi.org/10.1007/s10608-012-9476-1

**Hollocks, M. J., Lerh, J. W., Magiati, I., Meiser-Stedman, R., & Brugha, T. S. (2019).** *Anxiety and depression in adults with autism spectrum disorder: A systematic review and meta-analysis.* Psychological Medicine, 49(4), 559–572. Pooling 35 studies, estimated that about 27% of autistic adults had an anxiety disorder at the time (42% over their lifetime) and about 23% had depression (37% lifetime), with wide variation between studies.
doi.org/10.1017/S0033291718002283

**Holt-Lunstad, J., Smith, T. B., & Layton, J. B. (2010).** *Social relationships and mortality risk: A meta-analytic review.* PLoS Medicine, 7(7), e1000316. A meta-analysis of 148 studies (308,849 participants) found people with stronger social relationships had about 50% greater odds of survival over the study periods, consistently across age, sex and health status.
doi.org/10.1371/journal.pmed.1000316

**Kessler, R. C., et al. (2017).** *Trauma and PTSD in the WHO World Mental Health Surveys.* European Journal of Psychotraumatology, 8(sup5), 1353383. In surveys of 68,894 adults in 24 countries, about 70% reported at least one traumatic event in their lives (3.2 on average); events involving interpersonal violence, such as sexual assault, carried the highest risk of PTSD.
doi.org/10.1080/20008198.2017.1353383

**Koenen, K. C., et al. (2017).** *Posttraumatic stress disorder in the World Mental Health Surveys.* Psychological Medicine, 47(13), 2260–2274. Across 26 surveys with 71,083 adults, lifetime PTSD was found in 3.9% of everyone and 5.6% of people exposed to trauma; about half of those with PTSD had lasting symptoms, and treatment-seeking was much lower in poorer countries.
doi.org/10.1017/S0033291717000708

**McEwen, B. S. (1998).** *Protective and damaging effects of stress mediators.* New England Journal of Medicine, 338(3), 171–179. Explained how the same stress hormones that protect us in the short term cause wear and tear (allostatic load) when stress systems are chronically over- or under-active.
doi.org/10.1056/NEJM199801153380307

**National Institute for Health and Care Excellence (NICE) (2022).** *Depression in adults: treatment and management (NG222).* NICE guideline NG222, London. The NHS guideline for England on depression: recommends a choice of treatments made together with the person, including guided self-help, group or individual CBT and behavioral activation, group exercise, other talk therapies and antidepressants.
nice.org.uk/guidance/ng222

**Noetel, M., et al. (2024).** *Effect of exercise for depression: systematic review and network meta-analysis of randomised controlled trials.* BMJ, 384, e075847. Across 218 trials (about 14,000 people), exercise helped depression. Walking or jogging, yoga and strength training did best, especially at higher intensity, and yoga and strength training were well tolerated.
jyx.jyu.fi/handle/123456789/93572

**Rose, S., Bisson, J., Churchill, R., & Wessely, S. (2002).** *Psychological debriefing for preventing post traumatic stress disorder (PTSD).* Cochrane Database of Systematic Reviews, CD000560. Found no evidence that a single session of psychological debriefing after trauma prevented PTSD, and some evidence it may increase the risk for some people; the authors advised that compulsory debriefing should stop.
doi.org/10.1002/14651858.CD000560

**SAMHSA (2014).** SAMHSA's *concept of trauma and guidance for a trauma-informed approach.* HHS Publication No. (SMA) 14-4884, Rockville, MD. Sets out a working definition of trauma and six principles for trauma-informed services: safety; trustworthiness and transparency; peer support; collaboration; empowerment, voice and choice; and cultural, historical and gender issues.
ncsacw.acf.hhs.gov/userfiles/files/SAMHSA_Trauma.pdf

PART THREE · CHAPTER 17

## Groups, influence and culture

**Asch, S. E. (1956).** *Studies of independence and conformity: I. A minority of one against a unanimous majority.* Psychological Monographs: General and Applied, 70(9, Whole No. 416), 1–70. When a group of actors all gave the same obviously wrong answer about line lengths, participants went along on about a third of answers; about a quarter never went along, and conformity fell sharply when one other person gave the right answer.
doi.org/10.1037/h0093718

**Baumeister, R. F., & Leary, M. R. (1995).** *The need to belong: Desire for interpersonal attachments as a fundamental human motivation.* Psychological Bulletin, 117(3), 497–529. A major review arguing that the need to belong is a fundamental human motivation: people need frequent, pleasant contact within a few stable, caring relationships, and unmet belonging has wide emotional and cognitive costs.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.117.3.497

**Bond, R., & Smith, P. B. (1996).** *Culture and conformity: A meta-analysis of studies using Asch's (1952b, 1956) line judgment task.* Psychological Bulletin, 119(1), 111–137. Across 133 studies in 17 countries using Asch's task, conformity was a reliable effect but varied: it had declined in the United States since the 1950s and was higher in more collectivist cultures.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.119.1.111

**Brady, W. J., Wills, J. A., Jost, J. T., Tucker, J. A., & Van Bavel, J. J. (2017).** *Emotion shapes the diffusion of moralized content in social networks.* Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences, 114(28), 7313–7318. In 563,312 social media posts about divisive political issues, each additional moral-emotional word was linked to about 20% more spread, mostly within like-minded networks rather than across them.
csmapnyu.org

**Burger, J. M. (2009).** *Replicating Milgram: Would people still obey today?* American Psychologist, 64(1), 1–11. A safer partial replication with 70 adults, stopping at the learner's first protest, found obedience rates only slightly lower than Milgram's 45 years earlier; seeing another person refuse did not reduce obedience.
doi.org/10.1037/a0010932

**Cooper, K., Smith, L. G. E., & Russell, A. (2017).** *Social identity, self-esteem, and mental health in autism.* European Journal of Social Psychology, 47(7), 844–854. In 272 autistic and 267 non-autistic participants, autistic people who identified more strongly with other autistic people had higher self-esteem, which was in turn linked to lower anxiety and depression.
doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.2297

**Cruwys, T., Dingle, G. A., Haslam, C., Haslam, S. A., Jetten, J., & Morton, T. A. (2013).** *Social group memberships protect against future depression, alleviate depression symptoms and prevent depression relapse.* Social Science & Medicine, 98, 179–186. In population data on adults aged 50 and over followed for two to four years, belonging to fewer groups predicted more depression later; among people already depressed, joining one group was linked to a 24% lower risk of relapse and joining three to a 63% lower risk.
doi.org/10.1016/j.socscimed.2013.09.013

**Edmondson, A. (1999).** *Psychological safety and learning behavior in work teams.* Administrative Science Quarterly, 44(2), 350–383. In 51 teams at a manufacturing company, a shared belief that it was safe to take interpersonal risks (psychological safety) was linked with more team learning behavior, which in turn was linked with performance.
doi.org/10.2307/2666999

**Haslam, S. A., & Reicher, S. D. (2012).** *Contesting the "nature" of conformity: What Milgram and Zimbardo's studies really show.* PLoS Biology, 10(11), e1001426. Argues that the Milgram and Stanford prison studies do not show blind obedience: people went along when they identified with the authority and believed the cause was right, a pattern the authors call engaged followership.
doi.org/10.1371/journal.pbio.1001426

**Henrich, J., Heine, S. J., & Norenzayan, A. (2010).** *The weirdest people in the world?* Behavioral and Brain Sciences, 33(2–3), 61–83. Showed that most psychology research uses people from Western, educated, industrialised, rich and democratic societies, who are unusual compared with the rest of humanity on many measures, so findings may not generalize.
doi.org/10.1017/S0140525X0999152X

**Hofstede, G. (1980).** *Culture's Consequences: International Differences in Work-Related Values.* Sage Publications (Beverly Hills). From surveys of employees of one multinational company in about 40 countries, described national differences on dimensions including individualism versus collectivism and power distance.
find.library.upenn.edu/catalog/994278913503681

**Janis, I. L. (1972).** *Victims of Groupthink:* A *Psychological Study of Foreign-Policy Decisions and Fiascoes.* Boston: Houghton Mifflin (book). Named "groupthink": in a close-knit group, the wish to agree can crowd out a realistic look at the options. Janis drew on case studies of policy decisions such as the Bay of Pigs invasion, and suggested remedies such as leaders holding back their own view at first and someone being asked to argue the other side.
search.worldcat.org/search?q=Victims+of+groupthink+Janis+1972

**Markus, H. R., & Kitayama, S. (1991).** *Culture and the self: Implications for cognition, emotion, and motivation.* Psychological Review, 98(2), 224–253. Argued that cultures differ in how they construe the self, as independent or interdependent with others, and that this shapes cognition, emotion and motivation.
sites.duke.edu

**Milgram, S. (1963).** *Behavioral study of obedience.* Journal of Abnormal and Social Psychology, 67(4), 371–378. Told by an experimenter to keep giving stronger electric shocks to a protesting learner (an actor; no shocks were real), 26 of 40 men continued to the highest level, many showing great distress.
doi.org/10.1037/h0040525

**Oyserman, D., Coon, H. M., & Kemmelmeier, M. (2002).** *Rethinking individualism and collectivism: Evaluation of theoretical assumptions and meta-analyses.* Psychological Bulletin, 128(1), 3–72. Pooling many studies, found individualism–collectivism differences were often smaller and less consistent than assumed: European Americans were not more individualistic than African or Latino Americans, nor less collectivistic than Japanese or Korean participants.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.128.1.3

**Perry, G. (2013).** *Behind the Shock Machine: The Untold Story of the Notorious Milgram Psychology Experiments.* Scribe (Melbourne, 2012); revised edition The New Press (New York, 2013). Drawing on Milgram's archives and interviews with participants, argues that the procedure varied more than reported and that many participants doubted the shocks were real, which calls the famous 65% figure into question.
sciencenews.org/article/behind-shock-machine

**Prentice, D. A., & Miller, D. T. (1993).** *Pluralistic ignorance and alcohol use on campus: Some consequences of misperceiving the social norm.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 64(2), 243–256. Students believed they were less comfortable with campus drinking than the average student; over time some men shifted their attitudes toward the imagined norm, and feeling out of step went with feeling alienated.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.64.2.243

**Tajfel, H., & Turner, J. C. (1979).** *An integrative theory of intergroup conflict.* In W. G. Austin & S. Worchel (Eds.), The Social Psychology of Intergroup Relations (pp. 33–47). Brooks/Cole. Sets out social identity theory: part of our self-image comes from the groups we belong to, and we are motivated to see our groups positively, often by favoring them over others, even when groups are formed on trivial grounds.
alnap.org

**Williams, K. D., Cheung, C. K. T., & Choi, W. (2000).** *Cyberostracism: Effects of being ignored over the Internet.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 79(5), 748–762. In an online ball-tossing game (1,486 people from 62 countries in the first study), being left out by computer-controlled "players" made people feel worse and lowered their sense of belonging.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.79.5.748

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